THE ABRAHAM ACCORDS

THE ABRAHAM ACCORDS

THE GULF STATES, ISRAEL, AND THE LIMITS OF NORMALIZATION

ELHAM FAKHRO

Columbia University Press *New York*



Columbia University Press
Publishers Since 1893
New York Chichester, West Sussex
cup.columbia.edu

Copyright © 2024 Columbia University Press
All rights reserved

Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data
Names: Fakhro, Elham, 1986- author.
Title: The Abraham Accords : the Gulf states, Israel, and the limits of normalization / Elham Fakhro.
Description: New York : Columbia University Press, 2024. | Includes bibliographical references and index.
Identifiers: LCCN 2024008947 (print) | LCCN 2024008948 (ebook) | ISBN 9780231212380 (hardback) | ISBN 9780231559355 (ebook)
Subjects: LCSH: Abraham Accords (2020 September 15) | Israel—Foreign relations—Law and legislation. | National security—Law and legislation—Israel. | Israel—Foreign relations—United Arab Emirates. | United Arab Emirates—Foreign relations—Israel. | Israel—Foreign relations—Bahrain. | Bahrain—Foreign relations—Israel. | Peace treaties.
Classification: LCC KZ5765.2202 .F35 2024 (print) | LCC KZ5765.2202 (ebook) | DDC 341.26095694—dc23/eng/20240310
LC record available at https://lccn.loc.gov/2024008947
LC ebook record available at https://lccn.loc.gov/2024008948

Printed in the United States of America

Cover design: Noah Arlow
Cover image: Getty Images

CONTENTS

Preface vii

Introduction 1

1. A Promised Land 11
2. A New Generation of Gulf Leaders 43
3. The Trump Administration 71
4. A New Relationship 111
5. Tolerance-Washing 149
6. Peace and Its Discontents 185

Conclusion 211

Notes 229
Bibliography 301
Index 327

PREFACE

On a late August afternoon in 2020, President Donald Trump took to social media to make an unexpected announcement. "HUGE breakthrough today! Historic Peace Agreement between our two GREAT friends, Israel and the United Arab Emirates!" he wrote, before sending his message into cyberspace.[1] The announcement made headlines globally: the first normalization agreement between Israel and an Arab state in more than twenty-five years had been brokered in secrecy, at a time when international negotiations remained paralyzed with the outbreak of the COVID-19 pandemic.

A broader shift appeared to be in motion when the president made a second announcement, telling reporters that Bahrain was following in the UAE's footsteps and establishing relations with Israel. Days afterward, foreign ministers from both Gulf states came together with President Trump and Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu of Israel at the White House to sign the Abraham Accords, a treaty formalizing their commitments. Trump then addressed the significance of the occasion: "We are here this afternoon to change the course of history. After decades of division and conflict, we mark the dawn of a new Middle East," he declared. Morocco and Sudan would become

the third and fourth Arab signatories to the Abraham Accords, tripling the number of Arab states with which Israel held ties, and effectively ending its regional isolation.

At the time of the announcements, I was living in the UAE, an hour's flight from my home country of Bahrain. There, I had been covering the six Arab Gulf states as senior analyst with the International Crisis Group and lecturing at the New York University campus in Abu Dhabi, until the outbreak of the pandemic pushed both activities online. Caught in the monotony of a new virtual existence, I struggled to make sense of what I was hearing on the news. There had been little indication that either Gulf state was planning to take the bold step of establishing relations with Israel. I was also receiving a barrage of media calls asking the same questions: "Why did the UAE and Bahrain make peace with Israel?" "Who will be next in line?" Oman, Saudi Arabia, and even Qatar were all touted as candidates that might get on board. The intense speculation around what might come next reflected how quickly the region's strategic configuration appeared to have changed. But officials from the UAE and Bahrain avoided mentioning the political calculations driving their decision and framed their move as intended to advance peace and prosperity. Were these really the reasons at play?

Using the contacts that I had at foreign ministries, embassies, security agencies, and policy institutions, and among journalists, I devoted the next weeks to understanding the new agreements and the calculations leading to their enactment. I also spoke to civic activists across the involved states, to document how these developments were being seen. What began as a stint of fieldwork grew into a body of research that further explored the covert ties between the Gulf states and Israel in the years leading up to the accords, and what the new relationship means for the party left out of the agreements: the Palestinians.

This book is the first to explain the drivers of normalization in the UAE and Bahrain, and the evolution of their economic, political, and defense ties with Israel, until 2024. It is based on more than two years of research and interviews with actors from across the Gulf states, Israel, the Palestinian territories, and the United States. With the 2023 Gaza War entering its ninth month at the time of writing, it also covers how these developments have affected the trajectory of normalization in the UAE and Bahrain and prospects for its expansion toward Saudi Arabia. I am grateful to those who offered their time and perspectives, and it is my intent to have conveyed their views as clearly as possible.

Many people contributed to making the book a reality. Thanks go first to my editor at Columbia University Press, Caelyn Cobb, for seeing it through from concept to publication, and to my copy editor, Anita O'Brien, and production editor, Marisa Lastres. For valuable feedback on the draft manuscript, I thank Clive Jones, Marc Lynch, Vali Nasr, Marc Jones, and Bader al-Saif. I am also immensely grateful to the colleagues and experts who offered their insights on the topic covered in this book. Our conversations enriched my work. Thanks especially to Daniel Levy, Tareq Baconi, Ilan Pappe, Rashid Khalidi, Ziad Daoud, Abbas Allawati, Abdullah Baabood, Peter Salisbury, Sanam Vakil, Bilal Saab, Stephen Kalin, Efraim Halevy, Mohammed Baharoon, Paul Salem, Randa Slim, Kristin Diwan, Ahmed al-Omran, Zainab Fattah, and Simeon Kerr. I am indebted to Marc Valeri, Emile Hokayem, Sultan al-Qassimi, Chibli Mallat, and Matteo LeGrenzi for their support at various career junctures.

I'd also like to thank Avi Shlaim for being a mentor since my days as a doctoral student at St. Antony's College, Oxford University. Sincere thanks are also owed to the Centre for Gulf Studies at the Institute of Arab and Islamic Studies at Exeter University and the Chatham

House MENA Program for having me as a research fellow at the time of writing.

Finally, I am grateful to my wonderful family and friends for their support throughout this process, especially Ali, Suhyla, Samah, and Tariq. While I am indebted to the people listed here, the views articulated in this book, and any flaws there may be in it, are my responsibility alone.

THE ABRAHAM ACCORDS

INTRODUCTION

In the year 2000 the Egyptian pop singer Shaban Abdelrahim shot to fame across the Arab world after releasing a hit single with a catchy chorus that repeated: "Ana bakrah Israel," or "I hate Israel." To the tune of a blaring dance beat, Abdelrahim crooned: "I hate Israel, and I'll say it if they ask me. . . . I don't care if you arrest me. I hate Israel and I hate [its] devastation." While dominating the airwaves that summer, the track elicited objections from Israel's embassy in Cairo, which denounced Abdelrahim as a "third-rate performer" who had ridden a "wave of hatred."[1] But in an obituary of the singer's death published nearly two decades later in 2019, a Dubai-based newspaper lauded his single for securing him a place in the hearts of millions of Arabs.[2]

This sort of civic animosity toward Israel mirrored a state consensus across the Arab region, one set out decades earlier. In the aftermath of the 1967 war, Arab leaders from the Levant, North Africa, and Gulf regions came together in Khartoum, collectively agreeing not to deal with Israel, in protest of its capture of swathes of Arab lands during the war. The territories in question included the Golan Heights, which Israel had taken from Syria; the West Bank, which it seized from Jordan; and the Sinai Peninsula and Gaza Strip, which had been controlled by Egypt. Weeks after their meeting, the United

Nations Security Council passed Resolution 242, establishing the international legal and diplomatic framework for resolving the conflict, based on the principle of "land for peace." When the United States brokered a bilateral peace treaty between Egypt and Israel in 1979, it followed the same formula: the return of occupied territory from Israel and the settlement of border disputes, in exchange for diplomatic recognition.

While the agreement resolved the territorial dispute between the two states, relations between them remained cold, the product of calculated pragmatism by Egypt's leaders, and reluctantly tolerated by the masses who continued to voice solidarity for the Palestinians still living under occupation in the West Bank and Gaza. Nor would the agreement affect the sentiments of Israelis, who continued to see themselves as under perpetual threat, in a neighborhood surrounded by hostile actors. The Arab countries not directly involved in the conflict—including the six Gulf Arab States of Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Qatar, Bahrain, Kuwait, and Oman—maintained a boycott of Israel, in support of the frontline states and the Palestinians.

The 1990s witnessed a growing momentum in U.S.-led efforts to resolve the Arab-Israeli conflict and establish a Palestinian state. The Madrid Peace Conference in 1991, co-organized by the United States and the Soviet Union, kicked off a protracted multitrack diplomatic process between Israel and several Arab states, leading to the establishment of a peace treaty between Israel and Jordan in 1994. Anticipating a similar breakthrough for the Palestinians under the Oslo peace process, Oman and Qatar began opening economic and diplomatic channels with Israel, as the UAE engaged in back-channel conversations with Israeli officials. But the collapse of the peace process gave way to the second Intifada in 2000, a mass Palestinian resistance movement. It also brought an end to the "first-wave" Gulf normalization initiatives, as Oman and Qatar rolled back plans to host

Israeli trade offices and reiterated their commitment to Palestinian liberation.

With American progress derailed, Saudi Arabia stepped in with its Arab Peace Initiative, a proposal offering Israel diplomatic relations with all twenty-two members of the Arab League in exchange for the creation of a Palestinian state and a "fair solution" for nearly one million Palestinian refugees and their descendants, a nod to enabling some to return to their homeland, and others likely gaining a more permanent status in neighboring states where they remained in legal limbo. Israel's leaders rejected the proposal, citing the provision on the return of refugees as among the main sticking points.

Between 2009 and 2019 Israeli prime minister Benjamin Netanyahu presided over the doubling of the West Bank settler population, making prospects for a two-state solution increasingly unviable. Meanwhile, the election of Hamas to power in Gaza in 2006 prompted Israel to blockade the territory, crippling its economy. Arab public opinion remained on the side of the Palestinians. Polling data in 2020 affirmed that just 20 percent of Emirati respondents supported allowing business or sports contacts with Israel absent a resolution for the Palestinians, placing their views in line with public opinion in the rest of the Arab world, where support for normalization was as low as 8 percent.[3]

Why, then, did the UAE and Bahrain kick off a process of normalization through the Abraham Accords that broke with the norms of regional diplomacy, did little for the Palestinians, and went against the grain of popular opinion? The outbreak of Iran's nuclear program in 2006, the Arab Spring of 2011, and the enactment of the Iran Nuclear Deal (JCPOA) in 2015 were seismic events that shifted the calculations of leaders in Riyadh, Abu Dhabi, and Manama, bringing the three Gulf states (the trilateral Gulf states) into growing strategic alignment with Israel around a shared threat perception. While

the two sides agreed on the need to weaken the emboldened Sunni Islamist and democratic currents emerging out of the Arab Spring, it would be Iran's nuclear program and the U.S. response to it that most profoundly accelerated their rapprochement. With the signing of the Iran Nuclear Deal in 2015, they agreed that their main security guarantor had gambled away the interests of its closest regional partners for an agreement with a hostile regime, a move that jeopardized their interests. To Gulf leaders, Israel was no longer a distant enemy but a powerful actor that understood their concerns and held the kind of influence in Washington that would elevate their views to any sitting U.S. administration.

The rise of a new generation of statesmen in the early 2000s played another, more personal role in the Gulf's turn to Israel. Less committed to ideals of Arab nationalism than their predecessors, leaders in the UAE and Bahrain began weighing whether the rewards of closer ties with Israel had come to outweigh their costs. Solidarity with the Palestinians had long enabled Arab regimes to signal their moral righteousness and provide their citizens with rare space for political expression. Many rulers also believed in the importance of Palestinian self-determination. But a younger generation of leaders adopted what they viewed as more pragmatic leanings, believing that developing ties with the region's strongest military power were more important than the Palestinian cause, which they saw as largely passé, unsolvable, and undeserving of much political capital. Some also adopted the view, common in mainstream Israeli society, that the Palestinian leadership held most of the blame.

With the signing of the Abraham Accords, the UAE and Bahrain moved beyond diplomatic recognition of Israel, toward a warm peace that embraced its cultural and religious presence and accepted the legitimacy of its Zionist ideology.[4] Cognizant that the plight of the Palestinians continued to shape public opinion across the Arab world, Emirati and Bahraini leaders adopted a delicate narrative:

framing the new relationship as intended to advance regional peace and Palestinian territorial and political rights. But as it became apparent that the accords would not benefit the Palestinians, state officials turned to cultural and economic justifications: linking normalization to prosperity and the development of a new era of tolerance between Muslims and Jews. For the UAE, this narrative fit comfortably with its soft-power efforts to push back against Islamist movements. In Bahrain, the new relationship aided Manama's efforts to reframe its image as moderate and divert attention from its human rights record, a source of sustained criticism from U.S. lawmakers. Trade figures would reveal the economic benefits of the new relationship, with the UAE pouring billions into Israel's most strategic sectors, and the two Gulf states together purchasing over $850 million in Israeli arms in 2021 alone.

The Abraham Accords would likely not have happened without President Donald Trump in office. Surrounded by several advisors with ideological commitments to Israel, he abandoned what they told him was the futile task of making peace between Israel and the Palestinians in favor of an easier alternative: bridging between Israel and the Sunni Arab states that shared his aim of weakening Iran. Seen by Democrats and Republicans alike as a success story in American diplomacy, the accords affected Washington's approach to the Middle East, catalyzing bipartisan efforts to broaden and deepen the agreements and bringing U.S. Arab partners—including those not party to the accords—into closer, triangular security coordination with Israel, especially in areas of air and missile defense. Advancements in these areas would extend the regional impact of the agreements beyond the borders of the normalizing states and set the stage for a new security architecture that elevated Israel and its Arab partners as joint executors and guardians of Washington's regional interests, as it looked to divert its attention to what it considered more pressing issues outside the region, like rising competition from China.

In Israel, the accords were a gift to Prime Minister Netanyahu, who built his career around avoiding talks with the Palestinian Authority and preventing the possibility of a two-state solution. Netanyahu's line of thinking—long ridiculed within Israel—posited that the country did not have to choose between peace with the Arabs and the return of any territory to the Palestinians. The Abraham Accords marked the surprising vindication of this approach, at last decoupling Arab normalization from the Palestinians and putting to rest any lingering rationale for ending the occupation among an Israeli political class that had increasingly lurched further to the right in the preceding decades.

The election of President Joe Biden in 2020 initially brought a sense of relief to the Palestinians, who hoped for a more balanced approach from Washington. But the president continued prioritizing the expansion of Arab normalization with Israel ahead of the resolution of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict. By 2022, he began aggressively courting Saudi Arabia to join the accords, believing that an agreement would lure the kingdom away from developing closer ties with China. Conscious of Biden's fixation on a deal, Saudi Arabia asked for plenty in return: nuclear know-how and a security agreement that would commit the United States to defending it in the event of an attack. Reflecting its past leadership on the issue, Riyadh remained overtly committed to a two-state solution for the Palestinians.

As talks with Saudi Arabia progressed, the United States deepened its role as the broker of Israel's regional integration, bargaining the provision of security commitments and technology to the Arab world's unelected leaders, in exchange for their recognition of Israel, under its most extremist government in recent memory. In Washington, the goal of expanding the accords—and Arab membership in a rising security alliance—would effectively replace the resolution of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict in the hierarchy of Middle East policy. This shift would come at profound costs: weakening U.S.

diplomatic pressure on Israel to alter its status as a permanent occupying power, diminishing prospects for a political solution to enable the Palestinians to live in dignity, and accelerating the proliferation of cyber and military tools to the Gulf states. The neglect of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict at the mantle of normalization would also entrench the paralyzing conditions that would give rise to Hamas's deadly attacks in October 2023, and Israel's devastating reprisal on Gaza. While posing the most significant challenge to the Abraham Accords yet, these events would reinforce what the UAE and Bahrain had signaled all along: that their ties with Israel transcended the plight of the Palestinians, or populist concerns for their fate.

This book's six chapters explore the road to the Abraham Accords in 2020 and their effect in the region ever since. Chapter 1 provides an overview of central developments in the Arab-Israeli conflict since 1948 and the role of Gulf leaders in lending diplomatic and financial support to the Palestinians across key junctures. It also examines the impact of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict on social dynamics in the Gulf, including in driving a Jewish exodus out of Bahrain—the only Gulf state with a sizable Jewish minority. The chapter details the emergence of a "first wave" of Gulf-Israeli normalization around the Oslo process in the 1990s and shows how these ties remained tethered to diplomatic progress on Palestinian statehood, reflecting a commitment by a generation of Gulf leaders to the cause.

Chapter 2 examines how the rise of pro-American leaders in the UAE and Bahrain transformed the approaches of both states toward Israel. It identifies 2006 as a turning point when the UAE and Bahrain began decoupling their relations with Israel from the Palestinians, amid growing fears in Gulf capitals of the implications of Hezbollah's victory over Israel in Lebanon and the rise of Iran as a regional and nuclear power. Other developments—the Arab Spring and the strengthening of Sunni Islamist movements—would bring Israel and the Gulf states even closer together, driving momentum

for their covert ties to spill into the open. The chapter challenges predominant narratives on Gulf-Israeli relations that characterize their ties as having existed independently from the Palestinians, or not at all.

Chapter 3 tells the story of how the Abraham Accords happened. It details how Trump's advisors set out to establish a framework for peace between Israel and the Palestinians, relying on the Gulf states as intermediaries in the diplomatic process. Over time, the close relationships among his advisors, UAE officials like Ambassador Yousef al-Otaiba, and Prime Minister Netanyahu gave rise to a different agreement: one that offered Netanyahu normalization from the UAE in exchange for his promises to forgo plans to annex Palestinian lands in the West Bank. Despite Netanyahu walking back his promises on the day of the announcement, the UAE remained committed to the agreement, with Bahrain joining weeks later.

Chapter 4 explores the economic, political, and military ties developed between the normalizing Gulf states and Israel after the accords, and the regional impact of the agreements. It details how the UAE moved to deepen the new relationship through massive investments in Israel's technology sector and by opening its doors to trade with illegal settlements, despite rising mistrust of Netanyahu among its leadership. The new relationship would affect the economic unity of the Gulf Cooperation Council, with Oman and Kuwait passing new laws to limit the entry of Israeli goods into their territories through the Gulf common market. While affecting these regional ties, the accords enabled the United States to pursue a different kind of unity, by integrating its Arab partners and Israel into a new regional security architecture.

Chapter 5 examines the instrumentalization of the accords by the UAE and Bahrain, as a tool to "tolerance-wash" their reputations in Western capitals. In Bahrain, the conflation of normalization with outreach to the Jewish people would facilitate the government's efforts

to deflect attention away from accusations made by U.S. lawmakers that it was targeting its Shi'a population, which it has been battling since the outbreak of Arab Spring protests in 2011. While facing less criticism for its human rights record, the UAE also used the accords to reinforce its image as liberal and to continue tainting its critics as religious extremists. In Dubai, the UAE's determination to showcase its commitment to tolerance would create new opportunities for an entrepreneurial rabbi.

Chapter 6 details civic responses to the accords. It documents the protests and petitions opposing their enactment in Bahrain and in other Gulf states, and opposition to the agreements among Palestinians and some left-wing Israelis. It also looks at support for the agreements in the Gulf, mostly from business figures and a younger generation of Westernized elites.

The concluding chapter discusses President Biden's efforts to bring Saudi Arabia into the accords, and the disruption to these efforts triggered by the outbreak of the 2023 Gaza War. On October 7, 2023, Israel endured its worst calamity to date, as Hamas killed an estimated 1,200 people and abducted 250 others.[5] Israel responded with massive force in a monthslong military campaign in Gaza, decimating over 70 percent of its civilian infrastructure and killing at least 37,000 people by July 2024.[6] Faced with a spiraling crisis, Biden lent Netanyahu his support by approving new rounds of military aid and vetoing ceasefire resolutions tabled at the UN Security Council. Although Biden eventually voiced support for a ceasefire, he weakened any incentive for Netanyahu to accept a settlement by affirming his continued and unconditional military and political support for Israel. Biden's administration also continued championing a Saudi-Israel deal throughout the war, linking it to a broader peace process despite a refusal by Israeli leaders to accept a Palestinian state, and in the context of visible evidence that expanding normalization would do little to resolve the conflict at hand.

What of the Abraham Accords, in the wake of the war? The conflict posed the most serious test to the agreements since their enactment, and to what remained of Arab support for the Palestinians. Collectively, the Arab states did not go far beyond rhetorical condemnations of Israel's actions, a stance reflecting their deepening internal divisions, and a commitment by the normalizing states to their relationship with Israel even in the face of its unprecedented reprisal on the Palestinians. Yet the most influential Gulf states would also limit their involvement in actions deemed inflammatory to Tehran and its allies, suggesting that any warming in their ties with Israel would be carefully balanced alongside a network of other interests they looked to maintain.

With no indication that it would reverse the course of Arab-Israeli normalization, the war in Gaza instead appeared to briefly slow the pace of its expansion. Saudi Arabia took the clearest steps, by suspending its talks around normalization and making it known in private that the cost of establishing diplomatic relations with Israel had increased. The war had handed Saudi Arabia increased leverage in steering the trajectory of discussions, in view of the Biden administration's drive for a grand bargain that would tie Saudi normalization to a so-called pathway to a Palestinian state. While the Abraham Accords would endure, and likely continue toward a path of expansion, they also serve as a reminder of the limits of normalization in resolving the region's most pressing conflict between Israel and the Palestinians, or contributing to the kind of security architecture capable of delivering a sustained peace.

1

A PROMISED LAND

The establishment of the state of Israel in 1948 triggered multiple, protracted wars with its Arab neighbors. Gulf leaders maintained a unified stance by adopting a boycott of Israel, offering aid to the Arab parties at the forefront of the conflict, and—in the case of Saudi Arabia—leading regional diplomatic efforts aimed at a resolution. Rising regional international optimism toward U.S.-led meditation efforts in the 1990s triggered a first wave of Gulf-Israeli normalization, which collapsed with the failure of peace talks. With diplomacy derailed, several Gulf states would find themselves locked into a growing strategic convergence with Israel, setting the stage for a rise in covert relations between them.

BALFOUR'S PROMISE

The Israeli-Palestinian conflict is often described as the Middle East's most protracted crisis. Yet it emerged out of distinctly European dynamics. During the late nineteenth century, a rising tide of anti-semitism swept across the European continent, driving a nascent Zionist movement to seek out independent, Jewish statehood.[1] Paradoxically, the objectives of the Zionist movement proved congruent

with the aims of Europe's far-right leaders, who wanted to see the continent free of Jewish influence. On November 2, 1917, Britain became the first state to endorse the Zionist proposal for statehood when Arthur Balfour, secretary of state for foreign affairs, penned a letter to Lord Rothschild, a figurehead of Britain's Jewish community, noting: "His Majesty's Government view with favour the establishment in Palestine of a national home for the Jewish people, and will use their best endeavors to facilitate the achievement of this object, it being clearly understood that nothing shall be done which may prejudice the civil and religious rights of existing non-Jewish communities in Palestine, or the rights and political status enjoyed by Jews in any other country."[2]

The Balfour Declaration handed the Zionist movement its first political victory: the promise of a Jewish state in Palestine. Britain's decision emerged out of strategic wartime considerations, including a belief among its political establishment that eliciting the support of the world's Jews may tilt the balance in their favor and convince the United States to enter the war.[3] For Christian Zionists in the British government like Prime Minister Lloyd George, the creation a Jewish state held theological appeal as the beginning of the fulfillment of a biblical prophecy tied to the return of Christ.[4]

FROM PALESTINE TO THE GULF

The allied wartime victory of 1918 set in motion British and French plans to carve out new territorial frontiers from the ashes of the Ottoman Empire. By 1920 Britain secured a League of Nations mandate over the territories of Palestine and Transjordan, covering an area bordering Iraq to the east, the Mediterranean to the west, and modern-day Saudi Arabia to the south. Britain's mandate was temporary by

nature, intended to prepare the inhabitants of Palestine for independent statehood.

At the start of the mandate, Palestine's Jewish population was made up of 56,000 inhabitants, and its indigenous Arab population, 600,000.[5] Britain presided over several waves of Jewish immigration to the territory, a trend accelerated by growing land acquisitions by Zionist institutions in Palestine, as well as Hitler's rise to power, and the concurrent exodus of Jews from Europe. The establishment of the Jewish Agency for Palestine by leading Zionist figures in 1929 facilitated global Jewish settlement in the territory. Between 1931 and 1936, Palestine's Jewish population grew from 16 percent to over 28 percent, alarming the Arab Palestinians who feared their displacement by the new arrivals.[6] In 1936 the Arab Higher Committee—the main political body of the Palestinians—began organizing a series of strikes to pressurize the British government to curb immigration. The strikes escalated into the Arab Revolt, a rebellion against British rule that lasted until 1939.

As the Palestinians began mobilizing against British rule, most of the Arab world remained under imperial control. As far back as 1820, tribal rulers in modern-day Kuwait, Bahrain, Qatar, and the UAE had entered protection agreements with Great Britain, agreeing to elevate the Crown as the exclusive mediator of their international relations, in exchange for Britain's guarantees to protect them from internal rebellion and external takeover.[7] The Arab rulers had little say over the terms of agreements dictated by a stronger power, which in some cases were forced on them after British forces destroyed their naval capabilities.[8] The territories constituting modern Saudi Arabia remained an exception to the pattern of imperial dominance in the Gulf. By 1932 King Abdel Aziz Al Saud (whom the British called "Ibn Saud") succeeded in uniting various tribes and independent kingdoms into modern Saudi Arabia, with Britain shifting its support behind him as a vital regional partner.

The advent of radio technology in the 1930s enabled Gulf residents to access broadcasts from across the Arab world. In 1936 news of the strike in Palestine reached the shores of the Gulf, where rising pan-Arabism and anti-imperialist movements elicited feelings of common cause with the Palestinians. The arrival of Palestinian teachers and other workers to the Gulf—where they played a major role in the region's development—had the further unintended consequence of disseminating a broader consciousness of their plight. While pan-Arabism influenced Gulf sentiments toward the Palestinians, solidarity also moved in the other direction. During the first months of the strike, Palestinian leaders reached out to their Gulf counterparts, requesting financial assistance to help cushion the impact of the strikes on Palestinian workers and their families. One of the first leaders they approached was the ruler of Kuwait, Sheikh Ahmad al-Jaber Al-Sabah.[9] Bound by the terms of his treaty obligations with Britain, the sheikh declined to contribute and forbade the public from lending their support. But public opinion proved more resilient than his warnings. A group of Kuwaitis defied the sheikh's orders by issuing a statement of unity with the Palestinians and collecting donations. Citizens in Bahrain followed suit, seeing themselves and the Palestinians as part of a single Arab nation struggling for liberation from imperial rule. In Sharjah, the ruler donated a substantial sum to the cause.[10]

After six months of unrest, the British government established the Peel Commission to investigate the causes of the rebellion. It concluded that Britain's mandate over Palestine had become unworkable and recommended partitioning the territory into an Arab and a Jewish state. Zionist leaders welcomed the proposal, with David Ben Gurion, chair of the Jewish Agency for Palestine, celebrating the report as a victory for Zionist statehood and a stepping stone to the eventual creation of a Jewish state in Palestine.[11] To the Palestinians, it marked a setback, which threatened to divide their lands. In

response, the Arab Higher Committee called for an emergency summit in Damascus. There, Arab leaders collectively rejected the proposal, calling on Britain to maintain a single state of Palestine.[12] They also demanded an end to Jewish land purchases and immigration, to maintain the demographic balance between Arabs and Jews.

As the strikes continued, British officials turned to King Abdel Aziz to assist in solving the crisis. It was not the first time they sought his input. Rosemarie Said Zahlan observes: "Throughout the 1936–9 crisis in Palestine, the Foreign and Colonial Offices sought to placate and obtain the approval of the king (of Saudi Arabia) rather than the Palestinians. They conjured up solutions to the different crises with Abdel Aziz very much in mind. Because of their exceptionally high regard for him, and because he spoke unfailingly of Palestine, they anxiously sought his mediation at every possible opportunity."[13]

Seeing Ibn Saud as a barometer for Arab sentiments and a trusted partner capable of steering the direction of those sentiments, British officials made "elaborate arrangements" to deliver the report to him, including by flying a copy of it from London to Jeddah and then transporting it to Riyadh on a private aircraft. Ibn Saud staunchly rejected the recommendation for partition and called on British officials to create an independent Palestinian state in which Arabs and Jews could share in government.[14]

A JEWISH EXODUS

The end of the Second World War brought to light the horrors of the Nazi genocide of six million Jews, deepening international support for the establishment of a Jewish state. Faced with a renewed threat on Arab claims to Palestine, the newly formed League of Arab States (Arab League) moved to discourage its formation by initiating a boycott of the Jewish community in mandate Palestine.[15] The

boycott would do little to turn the tide of international opinion. In November 1947 the United Nations General Assembly adopted Resolution 181, endorsing the division of Palestine into a Jewish and Arab state, and the placement of Jerusalem under international control.[16]

News of the partition plan spread across the Arab world, triggering reprisals against minority Jewish populations, who came to be perceived as complicit in Zionist plans to carve up Palestine. The trend carried over to Bahrain, home to one of the largest Jewish communities in the Persian Gulf, numbering approximately two thousand people. Bahrain's Jews were mostly of Iraqi origin and dominated Bahrain's banking and financial sectors and textile trade. By the 1930s the Jewish community was so heavily represented along a commercial street, Al Mutanabi Road, that it was nicknamed Sekkat al-Yahood, or Jews Street, and would close for the Sabbath.[17] At the time, a Jewish synagogue also stood proudly at the heart of Manama's commercial quarter, reflecting the social integration of Bahrain's Jews into the fabric of the community.[18]

News of the partition plan triggered the first documented acts of violence against Bahrain's Jewish minority. During three days of protests in December 1947, schoolboys and workers marched onto the streets, voicing their opposition to the plan and chanting slogans in support of the Palestinians. British officials describe how the strikes turned violent, noting:

> On the first day, two cars, one belonging to a Jew and one carrying Jews, were stopped and stones and mud were thrown at them. An elderly deaf Jew was beaten up by some unknown persons, and a doctor of the American mission (hospital) was stopped by a crowd shouting, "Down with America, Zionists, Russians and Communists," mud was also thrown at the houses of Jews and some Iraqi Christians, and the windows of the Eastern Bank, several of whose

> staff are Jews, were broken. On the second day, there was a larger procession but no incidents.

The report continues:

> On the third day, the procession was larger again and even more highly organized, including an open truck used as a rostrum for speakers. It conducted itself in an orderly way until it reached a building used as a synagogue where a pass of people with it thrust into the building. The real organizers of the demonstration then seemed to have disappeared. And the synagogue was looted by the lower and tougher element of the town, many of them non-Bahrainis. Within an hour, 12 houses and three shops belonging to Jews were looted. The police seemed to have behaved fairly well but found, as is not unusual in dealing with mobs in oriental cities, that on suppressing a riot in one quarter it broke out in another.[19]

British officials reflected on the impact of the attacks in the following weeks, noting: "The Jewish community is allowing itself to be mulcted of large sums of 'protection money' paid . . . to those who profess, in most cases quite falsely, to be able to shield them from further disturbance. The small community of Jews here—there are only a few hundred—have also broadened their sympathy with the 'Arab cause.'"[20]

Although the violence subsided within days, it triggered the first wave of Jewish migration out of Bahrain toward India, with many later settling more permanently in the United Kingdom, and what would become the state of Israel. By 1950 an estimated five hundred Jews remained in Bahrain.[21] Their fate mirrored that of Jewish communities across the Arab world, whose departure was triggered by threatened and actual violence, as well as promises of opportunity in

a new Jewish state. The Arab world would eventually lose most of its Jewish communities, with 31,000 Libyan, 50,000 Yemeni, and 125,000 Iraqi Jews eventually migrating to Israel.[22] In places like Baghdad—where Jews constituted 40 percent of the city's inhabitants—the exodus proved especially damaging to the city's cultural life. By 2021 just four Jewish Iraqis remained in Baghdad, with single-digit numbers left in Yemen.[23] In Bahrain, they would number no more than several dozen.[24]

THE FIRST ARAB-ISRAELI WAR

When Britain's mandate over Palestine expired on May 14, 1948, British forces left without implementing the United Nations partition plan or resolving the land dispute between the Palestinians and Zionists. On the day of Britain's departure, David Ben Gurion proclaimed the establishment of the state of Israel, triggering the first Arab-Israeli war and the dispatch of Arab armies from Syria, Iraq, Egypt, and Lebanon to assist the Palestinians. Saudi Arabia also sent a formation, under Egyptian command. The ensuing conflict proved calamitous for the Palestinians, who refer to it as the *nakba*—"catastrophe"—for resulting in the expulsion of 750,000 Palestinians civilians from their homes, the destruction of more than five hundred towns and villages, and the killing of fifteen thousand Palestinians, mostly at the hands of armed Zionist militias. Despite the killing of six thousand Zionists by Palestinian and Arab fighters, it constituted an unquestionable victory for the movement, marking the creation of a new state on their historic homeland.[25] The Arab League and the smaller Gulf States that remained under British authority responded by adopting a comprehensive, three-tiered boycott of the new Jewish state, prohibiting any dealings with it, its citizens, or entities that held ties with it. Faced with a rising refugee crisis, the

United Nations General Assembly established the UN Refugees and Works Agency (UNRWA) in 1950 to provide relief, health, and education services for the nearly one million Palestinians who lost their homes and livelihoods in the conflict. The agency continues its work to this day, serving an estimated six million Palestinians, including survivors of the nakba and their descendants.

The mass expulsion of the Palestinians triggered their dispersal across the Arab world, including to the Gulf states, where rising oil production fueled an economic boom and a demand for skilled workers. With a leadership committed to Arab nationalism, Kuwait took up an outsized share of the burden by welcoming hundreds of thousands of Palestinian refugees.[26] By 1990 the number of Palestinians residing in Kuwait reached 400,000, approaching the number of Kuwaiti citizens, who themselves numbered 600,000. Across the Gulf, the Palestinian refugees were received as immigrant guest workers, subject to ordinary residency rules applicable to foreigners. While Kuwait played the leading role in hosting Palestinian refugees, Saudi Arabia emerged as their main financial backer, and the largest single donor to UNRWA during the first three decades of its operations. Two other Gulf states, Qatar and Bahrain, made more modest pledges to the organization.[27]

THE SECOND ARAB-ISRAELI WAR

A change of leadership in Saudi Arabia and Egypt brought new dynamics to the Arab political landscape. In 1952 the Free Officers seized power in Egypt, setting the stage for the rise of Gamal Abdel Nasser, a charismatic socialist and pan-Arab nationalist. The following year Saudi Arabia's King Abdel Aziz passed away and was succeeded by his son, Saud bin Abdel Aziz. The new leaders represented opposite ends of the Arab political spectrum, with Nasser leading the

revolutionary republican camp, and Saud representing the camp of more conservative monarchs.[28] Despite their differences, the two leaders forged a partnership based on their converging views, which included a distrust of Britain, the need for justice for the Palestinians, and a commitment to neutrality in the ongoing Cold War between the United States, and the Soviet Union.[29]

In July 1956 Nasser announced the nationalization of the Suez Canal Company, declaring it was time for Egypt to take back its strategic resources from the Franco-British enterprise that owned, and profited from operating, the canal. The previous year, Nasser had closed the Straits of Tiran to all vessels, preventing ships from reaching Israel. Although Nasser offered to compensate Britain and France, they had grown increasingly threatened by his brand of revolutionary nationalism, which energized the Arab masses for freedom from Western imperialism. As news of the nationalization broke, the two states put into action a contingency plan they had developed with Israel in the preceding months. Israeli forces proceeded to attack Egypt's Sinai Peninsula, on October 29, 1956. British and French troops invaded a few days later. Fearing further escalation, President Dwight Eisenhower demanded they accept a ceasefire and approved a United Nations resolution calling for peacekeeping forces around the canal. The episode marked a victory in Nasser's favor, triggering a surge in his popularity across the Arab world.[30]

The climate of heightened Arab nationalism also affected Palestinian politics. In 1964 the Arab League, under Egypt's leadership, brought together a coalition of Palestinian parties from within the Palestinian territories and the diaspora to form the Palestinian Liberation Organization (PLO). By leading the initiative, Nasser aimed to maintain some control over what he saw as "burgeoning Palestinian activism."[31] Upon its formation, the PLO designated itself as a government in exile and announced its aims to liberate Palestine from occupation and work toward Arab unity, reflecting Egypt's aims, as

well as the growing convergence of the two causes in Arab political thought.[32] The historian Rashid Khalidi notes that within a few years, Harakat al-Tahrir al-Filastini (Fatah), a Palestinian nationalist organization set up by members of the diaspora, would take up a central role in the PLO and provide it with "purely Palestinian tenor."[33]

THE THIRD ARAB-ISRAELI WAR

The next conflict between Israel and the Arab states broke out on June 5, 1967, when Israel launched a series of surprise air strikes against Egyptian airfields, triggering the 1967 Arab-Israeli war (or, Six-Day War).[34] Within a week, Israel wiped out Egyptian, Syrian, and Jordanian air forces and seized control of Egypt's Sinai Peninsula, the Jordanian-controlled West Bank, and Syria's Golan Heights, tripling its land mass. As news of the war reached the Gulf, Saudi Arabia's King Faisal—who had succeeded King Saud in 1964—moved to assist Arab states on the front lines by dispatching a contingent of troops to Jordan and supporting an Iraqi proposal to halt oil exports to the states that supported Israel. But the troops arrived too late, and the oil cuts made little impact.[35] The ruler of Abu Dhabi, Sheikh Zayed bin Sultan Al-Nahyan, also offered his assistance, by dispatching medical supplies to states on the front lines of the conflict.[36] The quick and humiliating defeat of the Arab armies shocked the Arab world and even Israel, which did not anticipate securing the most dramatic military victory in its history.

Following their defeat, Arab leaders gathered at Khartoum, where they united around their refusal to negotiate with Israel.[37] Their stance surprised Israeli officials, who had grown confident that the Arab states would propose a settlement and offer to enter talks. Among Arab leaders, the articulation of a common position at Khartoum fostered a sense of solidarity, with all states pledging to also increase

their aid to the front-line states.[38] At the summit, Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, and Libya pledged annual aid of $280 million to Egypt, and $100 million to Jordan.[39] Several Gulf actors also began providing aid to UNRWA and the PLO for the first time, with Abu Dhabi pledging its first donation of $20,000 to UNRWA during fiscal year 1967–1968. It doubled its donation the next year, to $40,000. Saudi Arabia continued absorbing the largest share of the burden, pledging nearly $600,000 to UNRWA between 1967 and 1968 and exceeding donations made by Egypt and Iraq.[40]

In November 1967 the United Nations Security Council passed Resolution 242, setting out the basis of international law governing the conflict and a framework for negotiations between Israel and its Arab neighbors. The resolution called for the withdrawal of Israeli forces from the territories it occupied in the Six-Day War and affirmed "the right of every state in the region to live in peace, within secure and recognized borders."[41] While Egypt, Jordan, and eventually Israel (in 1980) endorsed the resolution, the two sides differed as to sequencing, with the Arab states insisting that Israel withdraw from the occupied territories as a first step to peace, and Israel conditioning its returned of captured land on the enactment of a binding peace settlement.[42] In the months after Israel's capture of the West Bank, Israeli settlers would begin developing the first Jewish-only settlements on occupied lands in that area.[43]

The Arab defeat of 1967 transformed the Arab regional order, triggering Nasser's downfall and propelling Saudi Arabia into a new leadership position. The role proved congruent with King Faisal's growing preoccupation over the status of Jerusalem and the fate of the Palestinians.[44] In 1968 the king tasked the governor of Riyadh and his younger brother Prince Salman (later, King Salman, r. 2015–) to head a committee to assist Palestinian freedom fighters and their families in their struggle against Israeli occupation. To this end, Salman established the "Popular Committee for Assisting the

Palestinian Mujahedeen" and appealed to all Saudi citizens to contribute to the cause.[45] It would be the first time the government set up a fund to collect donations from the public, signaling its importance to the leadership.[46]

Beyond aid, King Faisal also worked to convince the United States to adopt a more balanced position toward the conflict. In July 1972 he approached President Richard Nixon, urging him to pressure Israel to withdraw from the occupied territories. But Nixon was unwilling to discuss the matter. His stance convinced Faisal that the Arab states may need to act more forcefully to achieve their aims. The following year, Egypt's new president, Anwar Sadat, visited Riyadh to tell Faisal about his plans to launch a surprise attack on Israel, to recover land lost in the 1967 war. During their conversation, King Faisal expressed his readiness to use oil as a weapon in advancing the Arab cause, laying the groundwork for events to come.

THE FOURTH ARAB-ISRAELI WAR

The fourth Arab-Israeli war began on October 6, 1973, when an Arab coalition lead by Egypt and Syria launched a surprise attack against Israel on the Jewish holy day of Yom Kippur, to recover the territories it had captured from them in 1967. With backing from the Soviet Union, the Arab states began making major advances before President Nixon stepped in, authorizing the delivery of additional arms and supplies to Israel and tilting the balance in its favor. In reprisal, Saudi Arabia led the Arab members of the Organization of Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC) in slashing their oil production and banning the sale of oil to the United States and the countries that supported Israel in the conflict. Having recently gained independence from British rule, the smaller Gulf states joined in the effort. Kuwait took on the most direct role, by dispatching forces to the front lines

in Suez and the Golan Heights, where they followed Egyptian and Syrian commands.[47]

The oil embargo drove an upward spiral in oil prices to four times their previous level and coincided with a devaluation of the U.S. dollar, imposing massive strains on the U.S. economy. It also had lasting geopolitical consequences, triggering long-term efforts by the United States to diversify its energy sources, and a sustained increase in oil prices that resulted in a generational transfer of wealth to the oil-producing Gulf states.[48] Asif Sinvar notes the war also changed the trajectory of international diplomacy, marking "the demise of multi-party diplomacy" around the conflict and rise of the United States as the "principal and indispensable" mediator between Israel and the Arab states.[49] In part, this shift reflected U.S. calculations: although the 1973 war concluded with a ceasefire, it brought the United States and the Soviet Union to the brink of conflict for the first time since the Cuban Missile Crisis in 1962, prompting Washington to intensify its efforts to broker peace treaties between the Arabs and Israel.[50] The rise of the United States as the main broker was also enabled by its growing influence as the region's dominant superpower, triggered by Britain's decision to withdraw from all territories east of Suez in 1968. Simon Dunstan observes that war also heightened Israel's reliance on the United States, driving it into deeper military, diplomatic, and economic dependence.[51]

After the 1973 war, King Faisal once again reinvigorated his efforts to convince the United States to move closer to the Arab position, by leading the formation of a united Saudi-Syrian-Egyptian front.[52] But his assassination at the hands of his nephew (also named Faisal) in 1975 brought that chapter to a close, as events on the ground moved in a different direction.[53] On September 17, 1978, Egyptian president Anwar Sadat and Israeli prime minister Menachem Begin came together under the leadership of President Jimmy Carter to sign the Camp David Accords. Under their terms, Egypt agreed to establish

diplomatic relations with Israel, in exchange for Israel's military withdrawal from the Sinai Peninsula. The agreement effectively provided Egypt with the bilateral gains it would have made from an Arab-Israeli "land for peace" exchange, but it cost the Palestinians a valuable ally. Outraged by Egypt's abandonment of the Palestinians, Arab leaders suspended Egypt from the Arab League and transferred the organization's headquarters to Tunisia, further strengthening Riyadh's position of Arab leadership. Saudi Arabia, along with the smaller Gulf states, Kuwait and the UAE especially, would continue to provide vital financial support to the PLO, with their contributions reaching $10 billion in the decade between 1970 and 1980.[54]

A COMMON ENEMY

In 1979 a populist uprising swept across Iran, driving its corrupt, pro-Western Shah into exile and paving the way for the return of fiery cleric Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini to Tehran. Upon assuming power, Khomeini and his associates transformed Iran into a Shi'a theocracy governed by *velayat-e-faqih*, or rule by jurist, and adopted a virulently anti-American and anti-Israel stance.[55] His promises to "export the revolution" to the broader region and "wipe Israel off the map" would create a shared threat perception between the Sunni Arab monarchs and Israel, who saw the new regime as a threat to their survival. Although Iran did not directly identify the Gulf monarchies as its opponents, it saw them as part of the problem for hosting U.S. military facilities within striking distance of its shores.[56]

In the years after the revolution, Bahrain and Saudi Arabia accused Tehran of making good on its rhetoric by funneling weapons to militant cells within their borders and inciting their Shi'a populations toward rebellion. Bahrain is the only Gulf state with a Shi'a majority, and Saudi Arabia is home to a Shi'a population equivalent to

approximately 15 percent of its population. While the Iranian revolution did spark growing calls for greater political inclusion from these groups, the issue is at least partly the result of enduring discrimination toward the Shi'a at the hands of the Sunni regimes in power. Still, ruling elites in both states would begin blaming Iran for instigating domestic unrest in the neighborhood.[57]

Soon, Tehran became a major player in the Arab-Israeli conflict, where it acted to fund a network of militia, paramilitary, and proxy forces fighting against Israel. This strategy reflects its doctrine of "forward defense," which centers on the principle of fighting its enemies outside its borders, to prevent conflict inside the country.[58] At first the network consisted mostly of Hezbollah in Lebanon, a resistance group that it provided with arms, training, and intelligence to fight against Israel. Tehran would later extend its support to Hamas, an Islamist resistance group established in 1987 that adopted the goal of liberating Palestinian lands from within the occupied territories. Hamas would also receive donations from individuals sympathetic to the cause in Saudi Arabia and Qatar, as well as from Palestinians directly.[59]

As Iran extended its reach, it remained embroiled in a territorial dispute with the UAE over the status of three islands located in the waters between them. In 1980 the head of the United Arab Emirates, Sheikh Zayed bin Sultan Al Nahyan, attempted to refer the matter to the International Court of Justice, but Iran refused to allow the case to be heard. The matter would remain a source of bitterness for the sheikh.[60] Conscious of the UAE's relatively small size, he remained committed to diplomacy toward Tehran, refusing to let the dispute threaten the trade relationship between them. To date, the UAE maintains its status as one of the top three exporters to Iran, with Dubai hosting a sizable Iranian expatriate population.[61]

In 1981 six of the Gulf states—Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Kuwait, Bahrain, Qatar, and Oman—came together to form the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC), an organization aimed at deepening their unity and economic integration including in the face of another regional crisis: the outbreak of war between Iran and Iraq. With the Gulf states still reeling from the Iranian revolution, they would grow their procurement of arms from the United States and other Western powers to the tune of tens of billions of dollars annually, pushing the region toward becoming the largest defense procurement market in the world.[62] Most Gulf states also authorized the expansion of U.S. military and naval forces on their soil, reflecting a turn to Washington as their main security guarantor and their rising militarization in the face of regional threats. Defense expenditures reflected these strategic calculations. In 1982 Bahrain enacted its largest ever defense budget, amounting to 8.4 percent of its GDP.[63] In 1983 it began hosting the headquarters of the U.S. Naval Forces Central Command (NAVCENT) as well as a newly established Fifth Fleet, which maintained operational control of U.S. naval forces deployed to the Gulf region, elevating Bahrain as a key U.S. regional defense partner.[64]

THE KING FAHAD PLAN AND THE FIRST INTIFADA

The passing of Saudi Arabia's King Khaled bin Abdul-Aziz in 1982 brought his half-brother, Fahad bin Abdul-Aziz, to the throne. Even before assuming power, the prince worked to reinvigorate Saudi Arabia's attempts to resolve the Arab-Israeli conflict, this time through diplomacy. In 1981 he proposed an eight-point peace plan, calling for the withdrawal of Israel from the territories it had occupied since 1967 and affirming the right of Palestinian refugees to return to their lands.

His plan also asserted the "right of the states in the region to live in peace," leading to its rejection by several Arab states, including Syria, Libya, Iraq and Algeria, in addition to the Palestinians, for implicitly endorsing Israel's right to exist.[65]

Events on the ground escalated during the summer of 1982 when Israeli forces invaded Beirut in a bid to force the PLO out of Lebanon, in the wake of mounting cross-border attacks from PLO fighters. Faced with another crisis, President Ronald Reagan put forth a new peace plan, calling on Israel to withdraw from the territories that it had occupied in 1967 and freeze its expansion of settlements on those lands, in exchange for Arab recognition. Reagan's plan ruled out the possibility of an independent Palestinian state, instead setting out a proposed confederation between Jordan, the West Bank, and Gaza.[66] This time, Prime Minister Begin rejected the initiative, on the basis that the creation of a Palestinian state—even as part of a confederation—posed a "serious danger" to Israel's security. He also ruled out a freeze on Israeli settlements on occupied land, with Israel's cabinet calling them "an inalienable Jewish right."[67] Arab leaders also expressed disinterest in a plan that did not guarantee independent Palestinian statehood.

Faced with a deadlock, Saudi Arabia proposed a revised version of the King Fahad plan that retained some of the wording endorsing Israel's right to exist and included a new role for the United Nations Security Council to guarantee peace between all states in the region, a nod to bringing the Soviet Union into a settlement.[68] Arab leaders adopted the new initiative with near unanimity in September 1982, reflecting a new consensus on the need for diplomacy and their preference for a multilateral approach. But Israeli leaders rejected the plan, describing it as a "design for Israel's eventual annihilation."[69] By 1987, prospects for diplomacy would be shelved with the outbreak of the First Intifada: a Palestinian uprising for liberation marked by a series of protests, acts of civil disobedience, and a wave of suicide attacks.

The Intifada did not change the Arab diplomatic consensus around the King Fahad plan, which remained the official position of the Arab League for almost a decade, until the Madrid Peace Conference in 1991.

THE MADRID PROCESS

In August 1990 Iraqi president Saddam Hussain invaded Kuwait, triggering the First Gulf War. As most Arab states united against Saddam, the PLO abstained from voting on resolutions tabled by the Arab League and the Organization of Islamic Cooperation condemning the invasion. Instead, a statement issued by Yasser Arafat, chair of the PLO, spoke of the need to avoid foreign intervention, solidifying perceptions that he had sided with Saddam. Arafat's approach prompted an outcry from Kuwaiti leaders, who expected the Palestinian leadership to be the first to condemn their occupation at the hands of an expansionist power, especially after they had welcomed hundreds of thousands of Palestinian refugees.[70] Following Kuwait's liberation by a coalition of thirty-five states that summer, Kuwaiti security forces turned on the Palestinians by arbitrarily arresting, detaining, and assaulting hundreds, triggering their exodus out of Kuwait. Within a year the numbers of Palestinians in Kuwait shrunk to just under 20 percent of their former size.[71] The dispute had other implications, triggering a decade-long reduction in funding to the Palestinians from Kuwait and the other Gulf states that sided with their neighbor.

Beyond the Gulf, the end of the Cold War marked a period of resurgent multilateral efforts to resolve the Israeli-Palestinian conflict. The first push arrived with the Madrid Conference in 1991, which set in motion a peace process between Israel and the Palestinian leadership, as well as Jordan, Lebanon, and Syria. It also laid the

groundwork for the First Oslo Accords, signed by Israel and the PLO on September 13, 1993. Under the agreement's terms, the PLO committed to recognize Israel and renounce violence, in exchange for Israel's reciprocal recognition of the organization as the representative of the Palestinian people. Both sides agreed that the Palestinian Authority (a new body dominated by Fatah, with Yasser Arafat at its head) would assume administrative control over the West Bank and Gaza Strip and act as an interim governing body to pave the way for the creation of a Palestinian state. Yet the agreement remained silent on the most important issues, including the status of Jerusalem, the right of return of Palestinian refugees, and the borders of a future Palestinian state, leaving these matters in the air for future talks. It also did not commit Israel to end its construction of settlements on occupied lands.

The Oslo Accords were followed by a second interim agreement on the West Bank and Gaza Strip (Oslo II, or the Taba Agreement, 1995), which divided the West Bank into three zones, granting the Palestinian Authority administrative control over a noncontiguous area making up 18 percent of the West Bank ("Area A"), and shared security control with Israel over another 22 percent of the area ("Area B"). The remaining 60 percent—earmarked for transfer to the Palestinian Authority—is still fully controlled by Israel, which maintains authority over security, natural resources and borders, and land usage.[72]

Despite international enthusiasm for the process, Oslo would not deliver a lasting settlement. Instead, its main legacy was the creation of the Palestinian Authority—a feeble and increasingly corrupt administrative organization that remained under Israel's grip—and its endowment with international legitimacy as the representative body of the Palestinian people. The main beneficiaries of this recognition were not the Palestinian people but Fatah leaders like Yasser Arafat, who gained Israeli endorsement and became intermediaries

between the outside world and the Palestinians, enabling them to "strengthen their standing within the landscape of Palestinian politics."[73] By leaving the central issues related to the conflict to be decided at future deliberations, Oslo also enabled Israel to pay lip service to the prospect of a Palestinian state as it continued building new settlements on Palestinian lands and creating the material conditions to obstruct its future creation. Beyond these limitations, the process also sanitized Palestinian demands for liberation into a single, internationally endorsed framework of statehood, narrowing pathways for alternative solutions.

Ilan Pappe notes that the ability of the peace process to remain the exclusive framework for resolving the conflict is more a testament to the power of the coalition supporting it than to its feasibility or logic.[74] Hilde Henrikksen Waage, a former mediator at the Oslo negotiations, notes that the process resulted in "the parceling of the West Bank, the doubling of Israeli settlers, the construction of a draconian closure regime, and an unprecedented separation between Gaza and the West Bank," reflecting the limits of third-party mediation in highly asymmetric conditions.[75] The inability of the process to meaningfully advance Palestinian statehood would prompt Palestinian intellectuals like Edward Said to describe it as a "Palestinian Versailles," with Israeli journalist Danny Rubenstein comparing Palestinian autonomy resulting from the agreements to the kind of autonomy emerging from a prisoner-of-war camp "where the prisoners are autonomous to cook their meals without interference and to organize cultural events."[76]

While the Madrid process did not yield meaningful gains for the Palestinians, it laid the groundwork for a peace agreement for Israel and Jordan. In October 1994 the two states signed the Wadi Araba agreement, restoring Jordanian control over approximately 380 kilometers of occupied land and settling a protracted water-sharing dispute

between the two sides. The treaty also conclusively defined Jordan's western border, bringing, according to the Jordanian leadership, "an end to the Zionist suggestion that Jordan is Palestine."[77] Crucially, the Madrid process also threw open the doors to overt interim Arab engagement with Israel, on the basis that a final settlement between Israel and the Palestinians was in the works.

THE FIRST WAVE OF GULF NORMALIZATION

Oman and Qatar

In the Gulf, Oman took the lead in a first wave of normalization with Israel. It was not the first of its bilateral engagements. Covert ties between the two states began in the 1970s, when Israel funneled arms to assist Oman's absolutist ruler, Sultan Qaboos Al-Said, in crushing a Marxist uprising in the Dhofar region. Exchanges continued in the 1990s with a secretive visit by a Mossad director to Muscat, who claims to have lent Oman's leaders' desalination technology, and to have remained in the country for an extended period of time.[78] Within the new climate of optimism generated by Oslo, it appeared that Oman's covert, intermittent engagements with Israel could evolve into a more sustained public relationship. In 1994 Sultan Qaboos met with Israeli prime minister Yitzhak Rabin on an official visit. In January 1996 the two states signed an agreement on the reciprocal opening of trade representative offices, to kick-start economic relations.[79] The proposed mission in Muscat would be Israel's first in the Gulf.[80] During this period, Foreign Minister Yusuf bin Alawi also told Israeli media that his country hoped to establish diplomatic relations with Israel, noting that "Oman was never in a state of war with Israel, so there is no need for a peace agreement."[81]

The other country that opened its doors to Israel during the same period was Qatar. Clive Jones and Yoel Guzansky, authors of a book on Gulf-Israeli relations, note that Qatar's growing rapprochement with Israel was largely driven by its quest for a more independent foreign policy, as well as Doha's aim to build closer ties to the United States, reflecting an exaggerated but common perception among Arab leaders about Israel's outsized influence in Washington.[82] Like Oman, Qatar's rapprochement emerged off the back of the signing of the Oslo agreements between Israel and the Palestinians, amid a prevailing belief among Arab leaders that a final resolution to the conflict was on the horizon. In September 1993, as the talks were underway, Qatar's foreign minister Hamad bin Jassim Al-Thani met with his Israeli counterpart, Shimon Perez, and explained their encounter as intended to "encourage the Middle East peace process, particularly the Syrian and Lebanese tracks of it, and [on] Jerusalem."[83] Next, in September 1995, Foreign Minister Al-Thani attended the Oslo II signing ceremony, signaling Doha's support for the continued diplomatic process. Along with Omani officials, Qatar's minister of information also attended the funeral of Israel's assassinated prime minister Yitzhak Rabin in 1995, with Qatar hosting his successor, Shimon Perez, for an official visit in 1996. That year, Qatar opened an Israeli trade representative office and welcomed Israeli officials onto its satellite television channel, Al Jazeera.[84]

In 1996 Benjamin Netanyahu was elected to his first term in power as prime minister of Israel. He moved swiftly with plans to construct a tunnel in the Western Wall, prompting an outcry from Arab leaders, who saw the move as symbolizing Israel's continued claim to Jerusalem.[85] While condemning the move, Doha continued with its cautious rapprochement by inviting an Israeli representative to participate in a Middle East and North Africa Economic Conference it hosted in 1997. As the outreach continued, it appeared that Oman and Qatar

would remain on track to normalize their ties with Israel, if progress could continue to be made in a settlement between Israel and the Palestinians.

The United Arab Emirates

Direct talks between Israeli and Emirati officials also began following the signing of the Oslo Accord, as a resolution for the Palestinians appeared likely. Writing in the *New Yorker*, Adam Entous chronicles how Emirati officials reached out to their counterparts from the Clinton administration in 1994, to inquire about the acquisition of advanced F-16 military fighter jets. Until then, the United States had sold the aircraft exclusively to Israel among its Middle East partners, as part of an established policy of upholding its qualitative military edge. With the request pending, American interlocutors reached out to Jeremy Isacharoff, an Israeli diplomat stationed at the Embassy in Washington, to hear how the Israelis might view the sale. Isacharoff offered a hesitant response, telling U.S. officials that his government wanted to speak to UAE officials directly, to find out how they planned to use the jets.

The Israeli request for dialogue would be conveyed back to Mohammed bin Zayed (MbZ), then acting as chief of the UAE Armed Forces, through one of his consultants, Sandra Charles.[86] As part of her role in advising MbZ, Charles had assisted another of his most trusted advisors, Jamal al-Sowaidi, in setting up a new think tank: the Emirates Center for Strategic Studies and Research. Soon after its inception in 1994, the think tank began hosting "delegations of influential American Jews" in Abu Dhabi for meetings with UAE officials who believed them to be influential in devising U.S. policy toward the Middle East. Eventually, according to Entous, the think tank would become "a conduit for contacts with Israel."[87] At one of

the gatherings, an Emirati official reportedly told Israeli attendees that Mohammed bin Zayed did not rule out future cooperation with Israel to advance their shared interests.[88]

Following consultations, Charles brokered a meeting between Isacharoff and al-Sowaidi in Washington. The meeting would set the stage for another secretive encounter between more important figures: the head of the Mossad, Shabtai Shavit, and one of Sheikh Zayed's sons and minister of state for foreign affairs, Hamdan bin Zayed, in Geneva.[89] Their encounter marked the first documented meeting between an Israeli official and a member of the UAE's ruling family, with bin Zayed reportedly telling Shavit that it was made possible by the Oslo discussions, signaling Abu Dhabi's continued commitment to the Palestinians. Still, UAE officials openly acknowledged the benefits of closer ties with Israel, with bin Zayed reportedly urging Shavit not to block the sale of F-16s from the United States, adding that the two sides ought to maintain an open back channel due to their close ties to the United States and their shared threat from Tehran. For his part, MbZ would reportedly not be dissuaded from his plans to acquire the F-16 jets, after learning that their operation relied partly on Israeli technology. "The Emiratis wanted everything the Israelis had," a former U.S. official involved in the talks noted.[90]

The UAE's outreach to Israeli officials would soon bear fruit for the Emirates. Following the discussions, Prime Minister Yitzhak Rabin told the Clinton administration that he did not object to the sale of the F-16 aircraft to the Emiratis, adding that the move might help build trust between the two sides, and leading U.S. officials to give it the green light. For the first time, the UAE had achieved strategic gains from Washington via Israel, highlighting the utility of developing their bilateral relationship. In direct negotiations with the United States, the UAE reportedly raised the bar even higher, by requesting a more advanced version of the aircraft and telling the

Americans that they would look elsewhere if the upgrade requests were not met. The UAE had purchased thirty advanced French aircraft the previous year, prompting U.S. officials to believe that the entire deal might be on the line. With this strategy, the UAE would acquire the most advanced fourth-generation jets on the market.[91]

In Bahrain, preliminary discussions between government officials and their Israeli counterparts taking place in 2000 during the peak of the peace process between Israel and the Palestinians also reportedly hinted at the possibility of establishing formal diplomatic ties, contingent on a two-state solution.[92] But when news of the discussions leaked, Bahraini officials reportedly expelled the Israeli negotiators from the country, seeing the matter as a breach of trust that threatened their internal security.

While relations between Israel and several Gulf states had begun moving out into the open, the collapse of the Israeli-Palestinian peace process would push events in a different direction.

THE SECOND PALESTINIAN INTIFADA AND THE ARAB PEACE INITIATIVE

During the final stretch of his presidency, President Bill Clinton invited Israeli and Palestinian leaders to continue negotiations on a final status for the Oslo Accords at Camp David. But by late July 2000 he announced that the discussions had ended with the two sides unable to reach an agreement. By that year, the numbers of settlers in the West Bank had nearly doubled since the beginning of the Oslo talks in 1993, reaching 400,000.[93] The storming of the Al-Aqsa Mosque by Israeli prime ministerial candidate Ariel Sharon in September 2000 would spark the Second Intifada, a five-year Palestinian mass uprising. Faced with an insurrection, Israel began developing a new network of sprawling checkpoints and barriers, further isolating

Palestinian towns in the West Bank from one another and restricting Palestinian movement. Israel's construction of a seven-hundred-kilometer separation wall in the West Bank under the pretext of preventing armed attacks would also enable it to absorb further tracts of Palestinian lands.

The Second Intifada brought a swift end to the first wave of Gulf normalization initiatives with Israel. In November 2000, as Qatar prepared to host a pan-Islamic summit, both Iran and Saudi Arabia threatened to boycott the gathering if Qatar did not close its Israeli trade office. Qatar soon shuttered the bureau, with its minister of foreign affairs, Hamad bin Jassim Al-Thani, accusing Israel of jeopardizing the peace process.[94] The Intifada also reconsolidated Arab and Gulf support for the Palestinians. At an emergency Arab League summit in Cairo held in November 2000, Saudi Arabia spearheaded the establishment of two Arab funds for the Palestinians with a capital allocation of $1 billion. They included the "Fund of the Al-Quds Intifada," which supported the families of Palestinians martyred during the Intifada, and the "Al-Aqsa Fund," which financed projects to help maintain the Arab and Islamic identity of Jerusalem and assist with Palestinian resistance efforts.[95] Saudi Arabia also created a national fund, the "Saudi Committee for the Support of the Al Aqsa Intifada," which contributed $200 million in assistance, as part of a $793 million pledged by the kingdom between 2000 and 2005.[96] In parallel, the UAE ramped up its funding of the Palestinians, committing $273 million in the same five-year stretch, with Sheikh Zayed financing the reconstruction of eight hundred Palestinian homes destroyed by Israel in the Jenin refugee camp, and Sheikh Zayed City, a $62 million housing estate for Palestinians in Gaza whose homes were destroyed by Israel, or who had been bereaved in the conflict.[97]

As the Intifada continued, Saudi Arabia stepped in once again to offer a new diplomatic track, with its Arab Peace Initiative of 2002. This time, the peace plan offered Israel full normalization from all

twenty-two members of the Arab League in exchange for its withdrawal from the occupied territories, a "just settlement" for Palestinians, and the establishment of a Palestinian state with East Jerusalem as its capital.[98] The Arab League endorsed the resolution at its Beirut summit in 2002, and again at its 2007 and 2017 summits, but no Israeli leader accepted its terms. It remains the diplomatic framework adopted by most Arab states toward Israel.

ANOTHER REGIONAL SHOCKWAVE

President George W. Bush's invasion of Iraq in 2003 plunged the region into further turmoil, upsetting its fragile balance of power. Among the most disastrous U.S. decisions in Iraq was its dissolution of the Iraqi Army and purge of state officials through a policy of "de-baathification" intended to rid the country of Saddam Hussein's influence.[99] The policy broadly targeted as many as eighty-five thousand Iraqis based on their affiliation with Saddam's party, fueling widespread resentment against the Coalition Provision Authority and sowing the seeds of an anti-U.S. insurgency. In the years after the U.S. invasion, Iran opportunistically stepped in to fill Iraq's security void by funneling tens of millions of dollars to arm proxy Shi'a militias inside the country, describing its efforts as part of a campaign of resistance against American forces. Iran's support for a sprawling network of proxies enabled it to establish itself as an enormously influential player within Iraq, alarming Gulf Arab leaders who came to see one of the most powerful Arab states reduced to a vessel for Iranian overreach, and deepening distrust between the two sides.[100] The invasion would also end a period of relative calm between Iran and its Gulf states, undoing progress made between 1989 and 1997, as Iranian president Rafsanjani worked to rebuild trust between the two sides. The invasion would also strain U.S. relations

with its closest Arab partners, especially in the wake of unheeded warnings by Saudi and others leaders that the invasion would only embolden Tehran and bring suffering to the Iraqi people.[101]

THE RISE OF HAMAS

In 2005 Israeli and Palestinian leaders agreed to a ceasefire, bringing an end to the Second Intifada. Still, the uprising had lasting consequences within Palestinian politics, fueling growing disillusionment with the Palestinian Authority and the increasing popularity of Hamas.[102] In Israel, the end of the Second Intifada yielded the unexpected decision by Prime Minister Sharon to disengage from Gaza and a small section of the West Bank, with the hawkish prime minister appearing to lean toward the view prevalent among the Israeli left that Israel's occupation of the Palestinian territories was more of a liability than an asset. Sharon proceeded to withdraw eight thousand Israeli settlers from Gaza, marking a rare point of advancement for prospective Palestinian statehood.[103] But the election of Hamas to power in January 2006 brought with it Israel's imposition of a land, sea, and air blockade over the territory, choking its economy, plunging its inhabitants into poverty, and turning the enclave into "the world's largest open-air prison," according to Human Rights Watch.[104] Tareq Baconi, the author of *Hamas Contained: The Rise and Pacification of Palestinian Resistance*, notes that from 2005 onward, Hamas and Israel would be locked in a "violent equilibrium," with Hamas periodically deploying rockets and missiles toward Israel to compel it to ease its blockade over the territory, and Israel responding through "overwhelming force" to build deterrence in the areas around the Gaza Strip while still granting Hamas enough room to survive as a ruling force. Through this cyclical process, both entities could operate within an equilibrium that enabled Hamas to continue

its rule in Gaza and Israel to justify severing Gaza from the rest of the Palestinian territories, while playing off existing divisions in Palestinian politics and preventing advancements toward statehood.[105] To keep Hamas in power and reduce pressure for a Palestinian state, Prime Minister Netanyahu would allow Qatar to send millions of dollars a month into the Gaza Strip to support Hamas in paying government salaries, purchasing fuel, and providing humanitarian aid. In 2015 far-right member of the Knesset Bezalel Smotrich would remark on the usefulness of the group in delegitimizing the possibility of a Palestinian state, noting "the Palestinian Authority is a burden, and Hamas is an asset."[106]

IRAN FLEXES ITS STRENGTH

The rise of Hamas in Gaza would accompany the ascendancy of Iran as a regional and nuclear power. In April 2006 President Mahmoud Ahmadinejad announced that Iran had enriched uranium for the first time at rate of 3.5 percent, raising concerns globally that it was planning to manufacture a nuclear weapon. Before the announcement, Iran had notified the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) that it planned to stop allowing inspections of its nuclear facilities. In response, the United States began enforcing punitive sanctions and prohibiting dealings with Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, a main branch of its armed forces.[107]

That summer, Iran would go head-to-head with Israel through its proxies in Lebanon. On July 12, 2006, Hezbollah operatives in Lebanon launched a cross-border raid into Israel, killing several Israeli soldiers and capturing two others, whom they held to bargain for the release of Hezbollah fighters. Israel responded with devastating force, hitting Hezbollah targets, decimating civilian infrastructure in Beirut, and causing mass civilian casualties.[108] The deputy chief of

staff of the Israel Defense Forces (IDF) and head of its Northern Command, Major General Gadi Eizenkot, explained Israel's military strategy during the 2006 conflict as built on the deployment of "overwhelming and disproportionate" force as a mode of deterrence. "These are not civilian villages, they are military bases," he noted, referring to towns bombarded by the IDF.[109] The strategy would come to be known as the Dahiya Doctrine, named after the neighborhood in Beirut destroyed by the IDF.

Hezbollah survived the war with most of its arsenal intact and its higher leadership unscathed.[110] Its show of force against Israel, which it broadcast effectively through its Arabic-language media channels, triggered a surge in its popularity across the Arab world, providing it with a strategic and moral victory. In the aftermath of the war, Iran increased its payments to the group, enabling it to play a leading role in reconstruction and expand its role as a powerful player in Lebanese politics.[111]

Hezbollah's ability to emerge from a conflict with the region's most powerful military force mostly unscathed—and its growing popularity among the Arab masses—rang alarm bells among decision-makers in the Gulf states.[112] Rising concerns about Iran's regional ascendancy would convince several Gulf leaders to expand their security and intelligence coordination with Israel, outside a framework of peace with the Palestinians. Beyond their converging interests, the rise to power of a new generation of Gulf leaders would also play a pivotal role in driving engagement between the two sides.

2

A NEW GENERATION OF GULF LEADERS

By the early 2000s the ascent of a new generation of more pro-Western leaders in the UAE and Bahrain would reshape the foreign policies of both states. Less committed to ideals of Arab nationalism and increasingly preoccupied with countering Iran's regional ascendancy, these leaders began seeking new pathways to increase their defensive capabilities and influence the trajectory of America's approach toward the region. On both fronts, Israel would become an increasingly useful partner. A shared consensus on other regional developments—the Arab Spring and the strengthening of Sunni Islamist movements—would bring Israel and the two Gulf states even closer together, creating momentum for their growing covert ties to spill into the open.

THE RISE OF MOHAMMED BIN ZAYED

As the founder and first president of the UAE, Sheikh Zayed bin Sultan Al Nahyan (Sheikh Zayed) was characteristic of the first generation of Gulf Arab statesmen in his commitment to ideals of Arab nationalism. When Britain announced its plans to withdraw from the Gulf in 1968, he brought together the seven emirates into a

federation and encouraged the rulers of Qatar and Bahrain to join the union. Believing that the Arab people formed part of a single brotherly nation, he routinely urged greater international support for the Palestinians and contributed to their relief efforts.[1]

Sheikh Zayed's unexpected death in 2004 elevated his third son, Mohammed bin Zayed, to the role of crown prince of Abu Dhabi and, later, supreme commander of the UAE Armed Forces.[2] At the time, MbZ's older half-brother, Khalifa bin Zayed, held the presidency, but his declining health enabled the young crown prince to gradually concentrate power into his own hands, especially after the president's affliction with a series of strokes beginning in 2009. While acting as de facto leader of the UAE for over a decade, Mohammed bin Zayed formally assumed the role of president of the UAE and ruler of Abu Dhabi in May 2022, after Khalifa bin Zayed's passing.

As the force behind the country with the sixth largest oil reserves in the world, Mohammed bin Zayed began investing billions of dollars of Abu Dhabi's wealth into strengthening the UAE's military and its technological capabilities. His investments paid off, with the UAE developing into a strong military power and earning the nickname "little Sparta" from then commander of CENTCOM General James Mattis and other Western officials, who regularly described its air force as the best in the Arab world.[3] While putting his country on a stronger footing, MbZ also maintained his father's policy of nonescalation toward Tehran, to avoid antagonizing the UAE's larger neighbor.

Domestically, MbZ centralized federal power under Abu Dhabi, pushing the country away from the federalist, consensus-based style of governance adopted by his father, which involved greater power-sharing with smaller and less wealthy emirates like Dubai and Sharjah.[4] Within Abu Dhabi, he further consolidated power among a trusted inner circle of advisors, many of them his full brothers, and adopted a tougher approach toward dissent than his predecessors had

followed, by targeting sources of potential opposition to his rule: prodemocracy activists and Islamist actors. An astute politician, MbZ saw Islamist movements—whether tied to Shi'a or to Sunni Islam—as the main threats to the survival of the Gulf monarchies and acted to prevent these movements from gaining a foothold in the region. His strategy would give rise to a more assertive foreign policy built on containing the power of Islamist groups through direct military interventions in transitioning states across the Middle East, and the development of ideological strategies to limit their appeal, by associating them with radicalism. The director of a UAE think tank described the country's foreign policy under MbZ, noting: "We are engaged in a long-term fight against extremist ideas, whether from Iran or the Brotherhood."[5]

INTELLIGENCE AND TECHNOLOGY COOPERATION

In 2006 the UAE began ramping up its collaborative engagements with Israel. The turning point was Iran's decision to resume its enrichment of uranium. In the months after Iran made its decision public, the UAE took steps to strengthen its institutional defensive capabilities by establishing its Space Reconnaissance Center (SRC), an agency falling under its air force, tasked with advancing the UAE's aerial intelligence, data collection, and technological processing capabilities.[6] Shortly after its creation, the SRC entered an agreement with Israel's ImageSat International, a private Israeli satellite operator that works closely with its security services. The agreement provided the SRC with data from ImageSat's Eros-A, a satellite it had launched to gather images of Iran's aerial facilities. The two entities entered a second agreement in 2009, providing the UAE with access to additional data from ImageSat's next generation satellite,

the Eros-B, and updated images of Iran's nuclear facilities and infrastructure.[7]

The UAE relied on a handful of discrete interlocutors to procure Israeli technology. One man would become an especially useful partner. Born in Israel, Matanya (Mati) Kochavi graduated from the University of Haifa and completed his military service in an intelligence unit of the Israeli Defense Forces. After the terror attacks of September 11, 2001, Kochavi capitalized on a growing global demand for private intelligence, as well as his connections in Israel's defense establishments, to provide these services to a secretive client base. To this end, he founded Logic Industries in 2006, at Kibbutz Yakum in Israel. Its employees were drawn mostly from Israel's security establishment and included retired generals from the IDF and Shin Bet, Israel's counterintelligence and internal security agency.[8]

In 2007 Kochavi set up another corporation, Asia Global Technologies International (AGT), in Switzerland. While registered as an independent entity, AGT acted as a front organization for Israel's Logic Industries, enabling employees to be shuffled between the two entities.[9] AGT would also act as a cover for supplying the UAE with Israeli technology and services.[10] As part of this network, two other corporations—Advanced Integrated Systems (AIS) and Advanced Technological Solutions (AIT)—were registered in Abu Dhabi and headed by Emirati nationals.[11] An article appearing in the UAE newspaper *Khaleej Times* described AIS as a direct subsidiary of Kochavi's AGT, noting that its chief executive officer, Abdulaziz Al Khaili, was also the senior vice president of the parent company, based in Switzerland.[12] The impetus behind the complex arrangements would soon be brought to light.

In May 2007 the UAE's president, Sheikh Khalifa bin Zayed, issued a decree establishing the Critical National Infrastructure Authority, a governmental agency tasked with protecting the UAE's infrastructure and guarding its economic security.[13] The new body

reported to the Abu Dhabi Executive Council (ADEC), a centralized body chaired by Mohammed bin Zayed and staffed by the UAE's most senior defense and intelligence officials, including National Security Advisor Sheikh Tahnoun bin Zayed Al Nahyan.[14] The following year, at Abu Dhabi's annual defense exhibition, IDEX, senior officials unveiled "Security Shield," a new project that aimed to provide "fully integrated security solutions" to protect the UAE's utilities and its "vital assets," including oil wells and border with Oman, from attack.[15]

At the event, Emirati officials announced that Security Shield would be implemented by the Critical National Infrastructure Authority in cooperation with AGT and AIS, in a deal valued at 3 billion dirhams ($817 million).[16] Although AGT acted as the main party to the agreement, it would be Kochavi's other firm, Logic Industries, that supplied the technical expertise to run the project, effectively placing the UAE's most sensitive security systems in the hands of an Israeli firm with close ties to its military and security industries.[17] Still, it would not be until over a decade later when authorities revealed the full scope of the project by announcing the launch of Falcon Eye, a centralized monitoring system that receives live data from surveillance equipment installed across the city. Described by officials as a mechanism to monitor law violations, the new system was effectively the successor to Security Shield, linking thousands of street cameras across Abu Dhabi and enabling the government to track virtually anyone in the emirate through Israeli technology.[18]

BENJAMIN NETANYAHU

The election of Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu to a second term in power in 2009 (his first lasted from 1996 to 1999) placed Israel

on an increasingly right-wing trajectory. As early as 1996, Netanyahu centered his election campaign on promises of ending the peace process with the Palestinians, setting out to prove that Israel could thrive on the world stage without giving in to Palestinian demands for statehood or negotiating with them at all. While refusing a two-state solution, he touted an alternative model of economic peace that proposed that the Palestinians give up their national aspirations and all forms of resistance to occupation in exchange for marginally improved economic arrangements under conditions that major human rights organizations increasingly describe as apartheid. When it came to foreign affairs, Netanyahu adopted an "outside-in" approach by working to forge partnerships with global powers not involved in the conflict as well as Middle Eastern states on its periphery. He was especially scornful of the "land for peace" formula that shaped peace talks between Israel and the Arabs. He favored a "peace for peace" approach that posited that Israel's military, technological, and economic superiority would eventually convince the Arabs to pursue peace for its own sake. His decoupling of peace from territorial concessions would come to be known as the Netanyahu Doctrine, but it was advocated years before he came to power, including by Israel's seventh prime minister, Yitzhak Shamir.[19]

JOINT LOBBYING IN WASHINGTON

Under Netanyahu's watch, Israel's relationship with the UAE progressed from an initial phase of technology procurement toward more open bilateral diplomatic engagement. By 2009 these engagements evolved around the shared goal of convincing the Obama administration not to abandon a policy of containment toward Tehran, a goal that would also draw in Bahrain and Saudi Arabia around a shared axis.[20]

The growing convergence between Israel and the trilateral Gulf states formed the topic of several conversations between U.S. and Israeli officials in early 2009. At a meeting held in Washington, Yacov Hadas-Handelsman, deputy director of the Israeli Ministry of Foreign Affairs, spoke to Jeffrey Feltman, U.S. secretary for Near East affairs, about several conversations that he held with Gulf officials on Iran. Feltman then relayed the details of these conversations back to Washington in a diplomatic cable leaked by whistle-blower website WikiLeaks. Feltman wrote:

> The Arabs have told Israel that they are not convinced the US knows what it is doing with regard to Iran and are afraid that the USG (United States Government) will give up too much for too little in return. He (Hadas-Handelsman) urged the US to engage the Gulf Arabs and make clear that Washington understands how Iran operates. . . . Israel continues its quiet relationship with the Arab states, and is pleased with the UAE and Bahrain's stand against Iran.[21]

In the cable, Feltman also noted that his Israeli interlocutor had observed Oman and Qatar moving closer to Tehran, highlighting divergences in the foreign policy approaches of the Gulf states.

Another cable from 2009 shed further light on how Israeli officials understood the basis of their evolving relationship with the three Gulf states. This time, the deputy chief of the U.S. mission to Tel Aviv, Ambassador Luis Moreno, conveyed to Washington the details of a conversation he held with Hadas-Handelsman, noting:

> Israel's relations with the Gulf is a function of the Gulf Arabs fear of Iran, but also due to the Arabs belief in Israeli influence in Washington. The Gulf Arabs feel that the U.S. does not listen to them and therefore sometimes try to pass messages through Israel. [They] believe in Israel's role because of their perception of Israel's close relationship

> with the U.S., but also due to their sense that they can count on Israel against Iran. They believe Israel can work magic.[22]

In his cable, Moreno explained how Israeli officials saw the UAE's relationship with Tehran, adding: "The UAE has extensive trade and financial relations with Iran, including money laundering. It is unclear whether they [are] ready to use these relations as leverage. Foreign Minister Sheikh Abdullah [bin Zayed] has developed good personal relations with Foreign Minister Livni, but the Emiratis are not ready to do publicly what they say in private."[23]

A third cable released that year would provide a glimpse into how an American diplomat viewed the UAE's role in the region. This time, Richard Olson, U.S. ambassador to the UAE, wrote: "While the UAE pays lip service to the idea of GCC unity, the reality is that Abu Dhabi is deeply skeptical of multilateral approaches particularly on military matter(s). And while publicly expressing close ties with Riyadh, the UAE privately regards the Kingdom as its second greatest security threat after Iran (Israel is not on the list)." Highlighting the UAE's increasingly independent foreign policy, the ambassador concluded: "Since the death of Sheikh Zayed bin Sultan al Nahyan in late 2004, his sons President Khalifa bin Zayed, Crown Prince Mohammed bin Zayed, and Foreign Minister Abdullah bin Zayed, have demonstrated less willingness to defer to the Saudis on all issues."[24]

Consistent with the information revealed in the WikiLeaks cables, the backchannel conversations between Israeli and Emirati officials translated into open, joint lobbying efforts in Washington, DC, that year. Shortly after President Obama's inauguration in January 2009, the UAE's ambassador to the United States, Yousef al-Otaiba, joined his Israeli counterpart, Ambassador Sallai Meridor, at a meeting with Obama's Middle East advisor, Dennis Ross. Together, the Emirati and Israeli diplomats made a shared appeal, urging Obama's

representative not to make concessions toward Tehran and emphasizing that the most important U.S. regional partners were united on the matter. Commenting on the meeting, an unnamed former U.S. government official noted that the joint appeal showcased a level of cooperation that was both "real and practical" and "went far beyond intelligence sharing."[25]

The UAE's covert diplomatic engagements with Israel would assist in fulfilling another of its objectives: acquiring a civilian nuclear program. Emirati officials wanted the UAE to become the first Arab state to acquire those capabilities, placing the country ahead of the others. In December 2009 the UAE signed the 123 Agreement for Peaceful Civilian Nuclear Energy Cooperation, enabling it to receive nuclear know-how from the United States in exchange for pledging to forgo proliferation-sensitive capabilities, including domestic uranium enrichment.[26] Before entering into the agreement, Emirati officials reportedly reassured the Israeli defense establishment that its civilian nuclear program would be in full compliance with IAEA safeguards and urged them not to stand against it in Washington.[27] That year the UAE reportedly also relied on Israeli support to host the permanent headquarters of the International Renewable Energy Agency (IRENA), in exchange for future commitments to allow Israelis to attend conferences and sporting events held in Abu Dhabi and Dubai.[28]

The UAE's diplomats were not the only ones speaking with Israeli officials, although their levels of engagement appeared to be deepest among the GCC states. In 2008 Qatar welcomed Foreign Minister Livni as a participant in its diplomatic flagship event, the Doha Forum on Democracy, Development, and Free Trade. The minister's visit was made public, and while in the country she attended a reception at the home of the emir, Sheikh Hamad bin Khalifa Al Thani, along with foreign ministers of Oman and other Arab states. The engagements would showcase the reality of growing high-level

diplomatic exchanges between Israel and the Gulf states, which persisted despite public commitments by Gulf leaders to a boycott of all things Israel-related.[29]

NEW LEADERSHIP IN BAHRAIN

As in the Emirates, the rise of a new generation of pro-American leaders in Bahrain proved instrumental in spurring a more visible outreach to Israel. The changing of the guard began in 1999, when Sheikh Hamad bin Isa Al Khalifa became head of state, following the passing of his father, Sheikh Isa bin Salman Al-Khalifa. Responding to American pressures to democratize, as well as a restive internal movement for democracy, Sheikh Hamad reconfigured Bahrain into a constitutional monarchy by reinstating a weakened version of the parliament that his father had suspended in 1975 and enacting political reforms. Reflecting the country's new constitutional status, he also took up a new title as king. Although his reforms fell short of the expectations of opposition activists, the king permitted the formation of new political societies, lifted some restrictions on media freedoms, and passed an amnesty for political dissidents, earning him praise from the Bill Clinton administration.[30] When it came to foreign policy, the king adopted a more pro-Western outlook than his father, based on his belief that the region's stability depended on expanding and deepening the U.S. military presence.[31] Reflecting the strength of the bilateral relationship between the two sides, the United States made Bahrain the first Gulf country to gain the designation of a major non-NATO ally, in 2002.

Bahrain's move toward a closer foreign policy alignment with the United States was also favored by the king's Western-educated son, Crown Prince Salman bin Hamad Al Khalifa. Educated at an American high school in Manama and completing his university education at the American University in Washington, DC, and the

University of Cambridge, Crown Prince Salman was part of a new generation of Gulf leaders who placed economic modernization at the heart of their development plans. At home, Prince Salman adopted a so-called "McKinsey approach" by hiring teams of foreign consultants to slash public spending, overseeing an Economic Development Board that implemented sweeping neoliberal market reforms, and privatizing parts of Bahrain's healthcare system.[32] The crown prince also pushed his country closer to the United States by pursuing a bilateral free trade agreement with Washington, which the two countries signed on September 14, 2004. As part of the conditions of the agreement, Bahrain formally abandoned its boycott of Israel.[33] Still, few Israeli products appeared on supermarket shelves, owing to continued public support for the boycott. In one instance, a Bahraini supermarket faced an angry backlash after a user revealed that it stocked a supply of Israeli potatoes. The supermarket was quick to issue a recall and apologize to its patrons, explaining that the presence of the offensive spuds on its shelves was the result of a shortage of its usual supply of Irish potatoes and labeling the incident a misunderstanding.[34]

While President George W. Bush's invasion of Iraq in 2003 had damaged perceptions of the United States across the Arab world, President Obama would work to bring America's image back on track. Soon after his election in 2008, Obama traveled to Cairo and delivered a seminal speech promising a reset in American's relations with the Arab and Islamic world and the need to resolve the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, declaring that "the situation for the Palestinian people is intolerable. And America will not turn our backs on the legitimate Palestinian aspiration for dignity, opportunity, and a state of their own."[35] Obama's pledge paved the way for growing discussions between his administration and its Gulf partners on the role they might play as intermediaries in a diplomatic process between Israel and the Palestinians. These conversations reportedly took place following his delivery of a letter to at least seven Arab and Gulf states,

requesting they implement "confidence-building measures" toward Israel, to restart peace talks.[36] The possibility of a more activist role appealed to both King Hamad and Crown Prince Salman, who looked to take on the kind of role that might secure them greater influence on America's Middle East policy.[37]

It was within this context that Crown Prince Salman mulled the possibility of leading a new outreach to Israel, with the kind of candor that surprised even American officials. On July 16, 2009, he published an op-ed in the *Washington Post*, calling for "fresh thinking" around the Arab Peace Initiative and arguing that the Arabs had not done enough to communicate directly with the people of Israel. Crown Prince Salman blamed religious extremists for keeping Palestinians and Israelis at each other's throats, adding that the rest of the region—"its overwhelming majority"—held the opposite interest.[38] Although he did not name either Iran or Hamas, his rhetoric mirrored the views of Israeli officials who argued that their conflict was not with the Palestinians, but with the extremist groups like Hamas that profited from perpetuating the conflict. Predictably, the editorial sparked an uproar in Bahrain.[39]

Two weeks after the publication of the op-ed, on July 28, 2009, Crown Prince Salman met with a group of American officials, including CENTCOM Commanding General David Petraeus, Special Envoy for the Middle East Peace George Mitchell, and Acting Assistant Secretary Jeffrey Feltman. In a summary of their meeting leaked by WikiLeaks, the crown prince aired his views with even more candor, telling the American officials that the most pressing challenge facing the region was one of "extremists versus moderates," adding that "most Arabs are moderates who support peace with Israel," and concluding that the main threat to regional peace came from Iran, not Israel. At the meeting, he also raised his concerns about a joint statement released in prior weeks between the Qatar defense chief of staff and his Iranian counterpart on military-to-military exchanges, adding that the possibility having Iranian forces visit the territory of a

GCC member state would be of great concern. Crown Prince Salman further reminded the gathered officials of his country's pro-American track record, adding that Bahrain was the first in the Gulf region to buy F-16s from the United States, the first to conclude a free trade agreement with it, and the first to command a combined task force. He then urged officials to think about a "peace dividend" for countries like Bahrain that were willing to take risks for peace, an allusion to Bahrain taking up a larger role in a possible peace process and engaging in a more visible outreach to Israel.[40] His statement was not the first indication of the Bahraini leadership's willingness to soften its attitude toward Israel, especially as part of a broader peace process. As early as 2005, King Hamad reportedly told the U.S. ambassador in Manama that his country held contacts with the Mossad, suggesting that Bahrain would be "willing to move forward in other areas."[41]

The crown prince's editorial, along with rumors of continued contact between Bahrain's foreign minister and his Israeli counterpart Tzipi Livni, later confirmed by WikiLeaks, stirred Bahrain's parliament into action. With nearly half of the members of its lower, elected chamber composed of members of the Shi'a opposition group Al-Wefaq, the parliamentarians moved to send a message to the country's leadership that any outreach to Israel would not be tolerated. On October 27, 2009, the parliament approved a law penalizing communications with Israel with hefty fines and imprisonment of up to five years. Remarking on the move, a representative from Al-Wefaq told media sources that "the motivation [behind the law] is that steps are being taken by certain countries to allow certain talks to be held with Israeli officials."[42]

A SERIES OF SETBACKS

As the UAE and Bahrain's leaders grew their ties with Israel, setbacks emerged, reminders of the limits of covert dealing between them. In

2009 Abu Dhabi's government entered a contract with the Israeli defense manufacturer Aeronautics Defense Systems for the purchase of unmanned drone aircraft, in what came to be known as "Project Seawolf." As part of their agreement, the CEO of Aeronautics proposed converting Italian aircraft into remotely operated drone vehicles and sending Israeli engineers to Abu Dhabi to train operators on their use, at a cost of $500 million. Following Abu Dhabi's delivery of an $18 million deposit, Aeronautics began flying out Israeli technicians to the emirate on foreign passports, instructing them to not to leave their military stations during their stay.[43] Although Aeronautics had begun fulfilling its contractual obligations, it was not allowed to proceed without a green light from Israel's Ministry of Defense, which is required under Israeli law to approve any project involving the transfer of sensitive technology. Initially, the ministry's consent appeared as a mere formality, as Prime Minister Netanyahu reportedly viewed the deal as an opportunity to advance cooperation between the two sides.[44] But the ministry saw otherwise, calling the transfer of sensitive technology to the UAE a national security risk, and forcing its termination.[45] The episode brought to light the limits of clandestine security dealings between the two sides, in the absence of diplomatic relations.

In 2010 relations between the UAE and Israel collapsed unexpectedly, reaching their lowest point in decades. That year, Mossad operatives entered Dubai on forged passports and assassinated a Hamas operative, Mahmoud al-Mahbouh, in his room at the popular Rotana Hotel. The incident angered Emirati officials, who viewed it as a breach of their country's sovereignty and an embarrassing display of Israel's superior capabilities, which had enabled its agents to enter and exit their country undetected. The UAE's minister of foreign affairs, Sheikh Abdullah bin Zayed, made his indignation publicly known, noting that those who carried out the assassination would be "brought to account," and adding that the UAE

would do "everything possible to protect its reputation as a stable, safe nation."[46]

In a visible escalation, the UAE then took the matter to Interpol, requesting that the agency issue an arrest warrant for the thirty-three Mossad personnel whom they suspected of carrying out the assassination. The agency proceeded to issue eleven arrest warrants, as Mohammed bin Zayed ordered security ties between the two sides to be severed.[47] The affair caused "shockwaves" in the Mossad for triggering far more of a fallout than anticipated and jeopardizing a rare and valuable relationship with a friendly Arab state.[48]

THE 2011 ARAB SPRING

The outbreak of the Arab Spring would soon bring the UAE and Israel back into closer alignment, around a counterrevolutionary axis. For the Gulf states more broadly, it would also diminish the importance of the Palestinian question, as leaders grew concerned with their domestic survival, expanding their regional influence, and containing the power of rivals, like Iran.

The stage for the revolutions was set in December 2010, when Tunisian street vendor Mohammed Bouazizi engaged in an act of self-immolation, to protest his harassment by security forces who seized his vegetable cart for operating without a license. Bouazizi died of his injuries soon afterward, and his act symbolized the frustration held by millions of Arabs toward their leaders. It also triggered a wave of uprisings across the Middle East, with hundreds of thousands of protesters mobilizing for greater representation, dignity, and an end to corruption. From one city to another, protesters united in chanting the ubiquitous slogan "the people want the downfall of the regime" (Ash-sha'b yurīd isqāṭ an-niẓām), a catch-all phrase to signal their dissatisfaction with decades of poor governance, nepotism, and economic stagnation.

As the Arab uprisings toppled autocrats in Tunisia and Cairo, revolutionary fervor spread to Bahrain. Opposition groups in the Shi'a-majority state have long demanded reforms from its Sunni monarchy. But this time the movement galvanized support from diverse constituencies, including trade unions and secular parties, bringing unprecedented numbers of people onto the streets. Bahrain's neighbors looked on with growing alarm and adopted their own strategies of deterrence, to prevent revolutionary contagion in their countries. In March 2011 Saudi Arabia's King Abdulla announced $70 billion in planned spending, as government-backed religious authorities issued a fatwa forbidding protests as un-Islamic.[49] Next, the UAE announced $1.6 billion in planned infrastructure spending in the less-developed northern Emirates, previously the site of antigovernment activity. Bahrain and Kuwait provided cash handouts to their own citizens as well.[50] Beyond concessions, Gulf governments heightened the costs of unrest by enforcing new laws penalizing antigovernment activity and persecuting individuals implicated in stirring unrest. Their actions, however, would do little to stop protests from spreading to several Gulf capitals, including Muscat and Kuwait.

Together, Israel and the trilateral Gulf states viewed the Arab uprisings with shared alarm, fearing the emergence of a more democratic order that might challenge their survival. They also united around their concerns that the uprisings might empower two of their shared rivals: the Muslim Brotherhood and Iran, whom they accused of exploiting the climate of unrest to gain a foothold across the region.

THE MUSLIM BROTHERHOOD

The Muslim Brotherhood is a transnational Sunni Islamist movement that aims to establish a central place for Islam in political life. Established in 1928, the Brotherhood grew across the Arab world during

the 1950s before being suppressed by Arab nationalist governments in Cairo and Damascus. At the time, members of the group were welcomed in the Gulf states, where they staffed the nascent government bureaucracies and judicial and educational systems.[51] By the 1980s the movement began gaining domestic popularity in Saudi Arabia and the UAE, posing a nuisance to the monarchies in power that saw them as a rising threat to their authority and cracked down on their affiliates.[52]

The advent of the Arab Spring threatened to strengthen the Muslim Brotherhood, especially as activists tied to it began leading calls for change across the region. In Israel, concerns centered on the possibility that once in power, Islamist leaders might walk back on the peace treaties and tacit security arrangements that it had orchestrated with the region's autocrats. Israeli leaders also feared that Islamist leaders would join the Iranian-led axis of resistance that encompassed groups like Hamas and Hezbollah.[53] Similarly, the Gulf states feared the group's rise to power could empower these networks, alter the regions political balance, and threaten their authority.

The election of Mohammed Morsi, the Muslim Brotherhood's candidate, as Egypt's president appeared to validate these shared concerns. While Morsi agreed to maintain Egypt's peace treaty with Israel, he upended Cairo's policy toward neighboring Gaza. Since 2007, Egypt and Israel had worked in conjunction to impose a blockade on the territory, with Israel closing off land, air, and sea routes into Gaza, and Egypt shuttering its Rafah land border crossing with it. Humanitarian groups condemned the closures for destroying Gaza's economy and imposing collective punishment on its 2.3 million residents, but both states justified their actions as necessary to prevent the flow of weapons into the hands of Hamas, which had been elected to power in Gaza. In August 2011, after Morsi's election, Egypt's government appeared to change course by reopening the crossing, alarming Israeli officials.[54] Leaders in Abu Dhabi and

Riyadh observed the events with similar concern, fearing that Cairo might soon move away from their orbit and lead a new regional alliance of Islamist actors.

Not all states shared the same concerns toward the Muslim Brotherhood. As a state backer of political Islam, Qatar used the Arab Spring to seek out new ways to opportunistically expand its influence, including by deepening its support for groups like the Brotherhood, placing itself on a path of confrontation with its neighbors. Bahrain's internal dynamics also set it apart. In Manama, a Sunni-minority government faced opposition from mostly Shi'a parties and secular organizations. In that context, local chapters of the Muslim Brotherhood did not challenge the government's power, choosing instead to stand by it. Cognizant of its delicate standing as a small state, Bahrain's government benefited from the support of the Brotherhood-affiliated groups domestically, while backing Saudi Arabia and the UAE in their efforts to contain the movement's influence regionally.

One year after Egypt's revolution, Saudi Arabia and the UAE's financial support for Egypt's counterrevolutionary forces proved instrumental in ousting the Muslim Brotherhood from power. The two Gulf states then lent their financial backing to Field Marshall Abdelfattah El-Sisi, who consolidated power after the coup, including by providing Egypt with a $12 billion aid package.[55] In 2015 El-Sisi moved to shut down the Rafah border crossing for an indefinite period, restoring a status quo favored by the trilateral Gulf states as well as Israel.[56]

IRAN AND THE ARAB SPRING

As the UAE and Saudi Arabia acted to contain the power of the Muslim Brotherhood, they also worked to prevent Iran from gaining a

greater foothold in the region. As massive prodemocracy protests rocked Bahrain, the trilateral Gulf states accused Tehran of instigating the country's Shi'a majority toward revolt. Bahrain's opposition groups rejected the accusations, insisting they were acting independently. Tehran's vocal praise for their movement—along with its decades-old territorial claims to Bahrain—would do little to assure the Gulf monarchies that it was not secretly fomenting instability.[57]

Unwilling to tolerate the possibility of an Iranian-backed uprising in a neighboring Gulf state, the Gulf Cooperation Council, led by Saudi Arabia, dispatched the organization's Peninsula Shield forces to Manama in March 2011. The first contingents, including twelve hundred Saudi armed forces and six hundred members of the UAE's police force, crossed the King Fahad Causeway from Saudi Arabia into Bahrain in mid-March 2011, freeing up Bahrain's security forces to suppress the protests. The intervention tilted the balance in the government's favor, bringing an end to the uprising.[58]

Although Israel remained far removed from events in Manama, Prime Minister Netanyahu viewed the willingness of the UAE and Saudi Arabia to resort to force to suppress any hint of Iranian overreach as a further sign of their shared outlook and praised their interventions. Netanyahu had worked to discredit the Arab Spring movements by calling them "Islamic, anti-Western, anti-liberal, anti-Israeli" and comparing them to the Iranian revolution of 1979.[59] He also vehemently urged Western states not to support the protests. By the same token, Netanyahu capitalized on the atmosphere of regional turbulence to dismiss the possibility of restarting a peace process with the Palestinians, telling the Knesset that it was not the time to make concessions, given the uncertainties about the region's political future.

The Arab Spring had drawn Israel and the trilateral Gulf states into closer alignment. It had also downgraded the centrality of the

Palestinian cause, and the apparent urgency of resolving the conflict, in the eyes of Gulf actors. Israel could confidently point to the unfolding revolutions to make the case that the most pressing source of regional turmoil had nothing to do with the status of the Palestinians, or their conflict with Israel, but an array of other internal political, economic, and social issues plaguing the Arab states. Gulf leaders would largely see the region's landscape in the same way, elevating their own domestic survival and their immediate foreign policy concerns as the most urgent priorities.

THE UNITED STATES

As evidence of human rights abuses against Bahraini protesters continued to emerge in 2011, the Obama administration suspended $53 million in planned arms sales to the Bahraini government, citing excessive use of force by police and security forces.[60] His administration also pressed Bahrain to enact reforms, prompting grumbled murmurs from Bahrain's leaders that the United States did not understand their concerns.[61] At times their irritation was aired publicly. At a security conference held in December 2012, Crown Prince Salman praised Britain for standing head and shoulders above Bahrain's other partners in supporting the kingdom, while making no mention of the United States. The snub was widely interpreted as a clear signal of the kingdom's displeasure toward the Obama administration.[62]

The Arab Spring had shown the Gulf States that the United States would not hesitate in conditioning its arms sales to their progress on human rights. Yet it was not the only type of restriction that it imposed. The United States prohibits the sale of certain types of defensive weaponry to its Gulf partners, including armed drones and unmanned vehicles. These restrictions form part of the U.S. commitments under the Missile Technology Control Regime of 1987, which

aims to limit the global proliferation of missiles and missile technology, and the Arms Control Export Act, which imposes other limitations based on the determined objectives of the end user.[63] The United States also refused to authorize the sale of advanced aircraft, like F-35 fighter jets, to the Gulf states, as part of its policy of maintaining Israel's qualitative military edge.[64]

While the arms restrictions imposed by the United States on Bahrain fostered some insecurity in Gulf capitals, a new U.S. policy announcement raised a far more urgent set of fears around American abandonment. In 2011 President Obama unveiled his administration's plans to reposition U.S. military resources and strategic engagement away from the Middle East and toward the Asia-Pacific region, to address rising competition from China. Despite widening bipartisan support for the drawdown in the Middle East, subsequent U.S. administrations did little to alter the concentration of troop levels in the Gulf region or shutter any of it military bases.[65] Still, Gulf leaders viewed the rhetoric emerging from Washington as an indication that it was no longer committed to meeting their security needs.

SECRETIVE SPYWARE SALES

As the Arab Spring cooled, Israel began taking steps to mend its relationship with the UAE by offering Abu Dhabi an enticing olive branch: authorization to purchase powerful spyware from NSO Group, an Israeli cyber-intelligence firm. Headquartered in Herzliya, a district of Tel Aviv that boasts a robust "start-up" culture, NSO Group is most widely known for its production of Pegasus, a remotely operated spying tool that enables its operators to covertly gather data on a target, including by reading messages, tracking calls, and accessing a phone's microphone and camera.[66] Since its release in 2011, Pegasus has assisted Mexican security forces in capturing the

infamous drug lord El Chapo and European law enforcement in dismantling a global child-trafficking ring.[67] But in the wrong hands, it could be used for more sinister motives, by governments looking to track and punish dissidents. In view of its immense security implications, sales of the software require authorization from Israel's Ministry of Defense.

A yearlong investigation by the *New York Times* revealed how the software landed in the UAE's possession, with Israeli officials reportedly offering it to Mohammed bin Zayed in 2013 by way of a "truce" between them, one that the crown prince "readily accepted."[68] An investigation in 2016 by the University of Toronto's Citizen Lab, an organization that investigates and exposes digital threats to civil society, confirmed that software produced by NSO group had been used to target Ahmed Mansour, an Emirati blogger and reformist.[69] It was not the first time he had been targeted. In 2011 and 2012 other forms of spyware were found on Mansour's devices. They included FinSpy, distributed by a German provider, and Remote Control System, a tracking system sold by an Italian operator whose clients reportedly included Egypt, Saudi Arabia, Bahrain, and the UAE.[70] Citizen Lab also identified another tracking operation, which it called Stealth Falcon, that had been used to target critics of the UAE between 2012 and 2015.[71] Together, these investigations implicated a network of providers—including Israel's NSO Group—in proliferating the digital tools to enable the tracking and monitoring of prominent dissidents.

THE IRAN NUCLEAR DEAL

In September 2014 a new crisis began unfolding in the Gulf when Huthi rebels in Yemen partnered with former president Ali Abdullah

Saleh to capture the Yemeni capital, Sana'a. The Huthi takeover directly threatened Saudi Arabia's influence over the country, especially in the context of rising evidence that the group was deriving backing from Tehran. Anticipating a quick victory, then Saudi minister of defense Mohammed bin Salman gathered a coalition of Arab states to launch air strikes against the Huthis. But the intervention triggered a protracted conflict, plunging Yemen into the site of a proxy struggle between Iran and states like Saudi Arabia seeking to restore influence over it, and eventually triggering a humanitarian crisis that aid organizations would classify as the worst in the world.

On July 15, 2015, the Obama administration announced a breakthrough in multilateral nuclear negotiations with Iran and the enactment of the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA) among Iran, the P5+1, and the European Union. Endorsed by United Nation Security Council Resolution 2231 days later, the deal aimed to slow the development of Iran's nuclear program and subject it to oversight by the IAEA, in exchange for the removal of most nuclear, financial, and economic sanctions, paving the way for Iran's gradual reintegration into the global economy. In selling the agreement to a global audience, the Obama administration championed the deal's potential to remove all of Iran's pathways to a nuclear weapon and prolong its breakout time from two months to one year or more, in the event that it decided to break off its commitments.[72] The agreement gained the backing of nonproliferation advocacy groups like the Arms Control Association, which celebrated it as a "thorough agreement which will severely curtail Iran's nuclear program and stop it well short of nuclear weapons for a generation or more."[73]

Leaders from Israel, Bahrain, the UAE, and Saudi Arabia did not share the administration's enthusiasm. Instead, they lamented their exclusion from the multilateral talks leading up to the agreement and

argued that the Obama administration had naively prioritized the interests of a hostile regime over those of its closest regional allies and partners, while keeping them mostly in the dark. Beyond these general brushstrokes, each side held more specific concerns.

In Israel, opposition to the JCPOA initially emerged out of a consensus that the agreement did not go far enough in blocking Iran's pathway to a nuclear weapon. Since the late 1960s, Israel has held an undeclared regional monopoly on nuclear arms, a status it has maintained by bombing the nuclear facilities of its Arab neighbors: Iraq in 1981 and Syria in 2007.[74] Israeli leaders view the maintenance of their nuclear monopoly as a nonnegotiable pillar of their security, one they expect the United States to defend as an equal priority. In conversations with American counterparts, Israeli officials expressed their dissatisfaction with the JCPOA's sunset clauses, provisions establishing limits on Iran's uranium enrichment capabilities, which expired in periods of up to fifteen years from the start of the agreement, arguing that they did not do enough in stopping Iran from building up its know-how. To them, this possibility was kept alive by provisions of the deal allowing Tehran to maintain most of its nuclear infrastructure intact.[75] On March 2015 Prime Minister Netanyahu traveled to Washington, DC, bypassed President Obama, and appealed directly to Congress, warning that the deal "doesn't block Iran's path to the bomb; it paves Iran's path to the bomb."[76] Netanyahu's stance would place him in alignment with Republican critics of the deal and further strain the already tense relationship between the two leaders.

Saudi, UAE, and Bahraini officials were less fixated on the agreement's sunset clauses, or Iran's nuclear capabilities. Instead, they lamented its limited scope, which fell short of addressing either Iran's development of ballistic and cruise missiles or its funding and arming of proxy groups across the Middle East, which they viewed as even more pressing threats than its nuclear program. Complementing Israeli

concerns, Gulf officials argued that the lifting of international sanctions on Iran would provide it with access to billions of dollars in additional revenue, enabling it to build up its nonnuclear arsenal, expand its support for the region's most extreme nonstate groups, and proliferate advanced missile technology to them.[77] Despite their reservations, Gulf governments issued statements supporting the deal spearheaded by their main security guarantor.[78]

While Netanyahu loudly criticized the JCPOA as a failure of diplomacy, Gulf officials adopted a more discreet approach that vocalized these concerns privately to U.S. officials.[79] Despite differences in their approaches, the two sides found themselves in alignment yet again, agreeing that instead of working to contain Iran's ambitions, Obama had conceded to them and upended the balance of power maintained with regional partners since 1979. Weeks after the agreement was announced, Emirati officials reportedly traveled to Cyprus to meet with Netanyahu to discuss the development of a joint strategy to counter Tehran.[80] The meeting, which both sides deny, reportedly took place without the knowledge of the Obama administration.[81]

It was in the months after the enactment of the JCPOA, in November 2015, that Israel established a permanent diplomatic mission on Emirati soil, its first in the Gulf, at the headquarters of IRENA in Abu Dhabi.[82] Several Israeli officials, including Infrastructure Minister Uzi Landau, had traveled to Abu Dhabi as early as 2010 to attend conferences organized by the agency. Emirati officials had justified these visits as related exclusively to the mandate of the agency and bearing no impact on bilateral ties between the two sides.[83] This time, the UAE's Ministry of Foreign Affairs was quick to provide the same explanation.[84] But there was little doubt that the two sides would use the opportunity to grow their diplomatic back channel. The breaking of the diplomatic barrier between them could also not be downplayed, leading Israeli officials to entertain the

possibility that normalization could be on the horizon. Israel's Ministry of Foreign Affairs had already taken steps to socialize the possibility of a more permanent presence in the Gulf, including by establishing an "Israel in the Gulf" Twitter (now known as "X") account in 2013, which it described as a virtual embassy.[85] The rapprochement between Israel and the UAE would grow more public in the following years, with pilots from the two states taking part in joint, multinational training exercises with the United States in 2017, and Israel's national anthem, "Hatikva," blaring across an Abu Dhabi stadium after one of its athletes won gold at an international judo tournament the following year.[86]

BEYOND THE UNITED STATES

As early as 2011, Emirati officials had requested briefings from the United States on the capabilities of its fifth-generation fighter jet, the F-35, seeing its acquisition as the next step toward elevating their military capabilities.[87] To them, there was no reason for the United States not to authorize the sale, especially as the UAE had proven its reliability as the only Arab country to have participated alongside Washington in six coalition actions since 1991, encompassing Libya, Somalia, Bosnia-Kosovo, the 1990 Gulf War, and the fight against ISIS. Moreover, the United States had approved the sale of hundreds of F-35s to other partners across the world, including to Romania, Japan, and South Korea. Yet to their dismay, the United States would not authorize the aircraft's sale, largely owing to its policy of maintaining Israel's qualitative military edge.

Faced with a setback in their plans for advanced military expansion, the UAE's leaders began exploring alternatives, especially among the two other powers that also produced fifth-generation aircraft:

China and Russia. In 2017 the UAE entered a preliminary agreement with Rostec—a Russian state-owned defense conglomerate—for the joint development of a fifth-generation fighter aircraft. The deal has since been put on hold. That year, the two states also signed military contracts worth $2 billion. By 2019 Russia suggested that it was willing to sell its fifth-generation Su-57 Felon to Abu Dhabi and allow it to manufacture components for the jet, raising eyebrows in Washington.

The UAE also signaled its growing military ties with China, by announcing joint plans for the development of a collaborative research center: the China-Emirates Science and Technology Innovation Laboratory (CEST).[88] Its first project—since put on hold—aimed to develop surveillance and unmanned battle drones, which the United States also refuses to sell to the UAE. In previous years, the UAE had reportedly acquired a Chinese alternative to U.S. weaponized drone systems, the China's Wing Loong II, an aircraft that appeared in several conflicts in which it has been involved.[89] The defense engagements between the two sides would raise further questions from the United States, especially after reports by the *Wall Street Journal* revealed plans for the construction of a Chinese military port in Abu Dhabi, prompting U.S. military officials to caution their Emirati counterparts that its development would strain their bilateral relationship.[90] While the UAE's new engagements with Russia and China aimed to provide it with alternatives, these discussions played an even more important role in strengthening the UAE's negotiation strategy with the United States, by enabling Emirati officials to warn Washington that its refusal to supply them with advanced systems would only deepen their cooperation with its rivals.

In the wake of successive regional shockwaves, the UAE and its Gulf partners drew a sigh of relief toward one development. On

November 4, 2016, President Donald Trump defeated the odds to become forty-fifth president of the United States, promising to withdraw the United States from the JCPOA, negotiate a "better deal," and take a tougher stance toward America's adversaries, especially Iran. Soon a new administration would bring Israel and the trilateral Gulf states even closer together, around a shared outlook

3

THE TRUMP ADMINISTRATION

How did the UAE and Bahrain move from discreetly growing their engagements with Israel toward a formal rapprochement? Trump's presidency played a pivotal role in the shift, bringing together several Gulf and Israeli leaders around a shared vision for the region, and drawing them in as intermediaries in the administration's proposed peace plan between Israel and the Palestinians. The collapse of these plans would give rise to a different agreement: one that offered Netanyahu normalization from the UAE, in exchange for his promises to forgo the annexation of Palestinian lands in the West Bank. Despite Netanyahu walking back on his assurances on the day of the announcement, the UAE remained committed to the agreement, with Bahrain joining weeks later.

A NEW CAST OF CHARACTERS

The election of Donald J. Trump as president of the United States in 2016 surprised even the most optimistic of his supporters, not least the president himself. On election night his eldest daughter, Ivanka, delivered what appeared to be some bad news, telling Trump that the

latest polls offered him just a 20 percent chance at victory. "It's looking bad," Ivanka told him. "It's looking really, really bad."

Trump then passed on the news to his running mate. "It's not looking good, Mike," he stated. "It's not looking good."[1] But as poll numbers trickled in that evening, they delivered major wins across the most important swing states: Florida, Iowa, Michigan, North Carolina, Ohio, Pennsylvania, and Wisconsin, as well as traditionally Republican strongholds, bringing him a swift Electoral College victory. Trump's election to the presidency marked an astonishing victory for an outsider candidate with no prior experience in politics and no patience for its protocols.

As Trump announced his presidential run in 2015, he reached out to family members and trusted business associates to develop his campaign strategy. Loyalty was the most important qualification, and experience in politics was not necessary, nor especially desirable. Among the first to support his presidential bid was Jared Kushner, husband to Ivanka and a thirty-six-year-old real estate mogul. Kushner would become one of the main architects of Trump's campaign strategy, devising a social media campaign that relied on cutting-edge data analytics to track and transform voter sentiments.[2]

In April 2016 Trump was approached by his attorney, David Friedman, who urged the presidential candidate to appoint him as a campaign advisor on Israel and its neighbors. Friedman was a high-powered litigator who had helped Trump successfully negotiate several of his bankruptcy dealings, earning his gratitude. He was also the son of a rabbi, deeply devout, and an advocate of Israel's most controversial policies, especially its right to build settlements in the West Bank. In his role as president of the American Friends of Bet El Yeshiva Center, Friedman had helped raise tens of millions of dollars for a settlement on the outskirts of Ramallah.[3] He believed in the God-given right of settlers to the land and expressed distaste for

legal terminology that suggested otherwise, referring to Israel's presence on territories it captured during the 1967 war as an "alleged occupation." Nor was he comfortable with the narrative of Palestinian displacement. He would go on to call the Palestinians "alleged refugees" and accuse UNRWA of perpetuating hate toward Israel.[4]

Friedman did not distinguish between the spiritual and the political, often contemplating out loud how one might make peace between Israel and the Palestinians without going to war with God, who had promised the entirety of the land to the Jewish people. He was especially scornful of Palestinian claims to statehood, arguing that Jerusalem was "not mentioned once in the Quran." A critic of the Oslo Accords, he also believed that "everything we know about the Palestinian government represents a threat to Israel, the region, and even the Palestinian people." While the Palestinians absorbed the brunt of Friedman's criticism, it was not directly exclusively toward them. He also disliked Jewish liberal groups like J-Street, which campaigned for an end to the occupation. Friedman would describe the organization as "worse than kapos," the Jews who collaborated with the Nazis. He later defended his words, calling them neither a policy nor a political mistake but possibly a tactical one, for shifting the discourse away from the organization's attacks on Israel.[5]

At Friedman's insistence, Trump appointed him as one of the campaign's top two advisors on Israel and the Palestinians. The other was Jason Greenblatt, the chief legal officer of the Trump Organization, who shared Friedman's passion for defending Israel. During the 1980s Greenblatt studied at a Yeshiva located in a settlement, where he had carried out duties expected of its students, including guarding the area with an M-16.[6] When asked which sources he consulted to stay up-to-date on the conflict, he pointed to the email alerts sent out by the American Israel Public Affairs Committee, a pro-Israel lobby group. He would also add that he had not met any Palestinians

since he was a student, when he interacted with the Palestinian gardeners around the settlement. Greenblatt shared Friedman's frustration with the discourse of occupation, telling a forum of Israel supporters that he preferred to call the settlements "neighborhoods and cities."[7] The views espoused by Friedman and Greenblatt pushed them to the right of almost any mainstream U.S. politicians and in alignment with Israel's prosettler factions.

As Trump secured the Republican Party's nomination, Friedman and Greenblatt moved to shape the party platform on Israel. They tossed out past language endorsing a two-state solution, reversing a bipartisan consensus on the matter. Instead, they condemned what they saw as a series of threats against Israel—the Boycott, Divestment, Sanctions movement; the Iran nuclear deal; and even UNESCO—and promised to move the U.S. Embassy to Jerusalem in recognition of the city as Israel's undivided capital.[8] Although more pragmatic and less ideological in his stance, Kushner agreed on the importance of defending Israel. The connections between the presidential advisors were also personal: Kushner's parents had acted as major donors to the settlement-fundraising organization headed by Friedman and hosted Netanyahu at their New Jersey home when Jared was a teenager, reportedly temporarily relegating Jared to take up residence in the basement.[9] Trump was more than willing to ride the wave of what appeared to be a winning campaign strategy set out by his advisors, telling an Israeli newspaper: "I think that Obama has been very, very bad for the people of Israel. I am extremely strongly in favor of Israel; I respect it and have loved the people of Israel from a long time. I have many friends who are from Israel and we're going to make sure that Israel is going to be in very good shape forever."[10]

Trump's pro-Israel platform elicited excitement especially from two groups: Orthodox Jews and Christian Evangelicals. The latter term refers to a multitude of conservative, Protestant, and mostly Caucasian religious groups in the United States that are united by a

common social and political outlook, including opposition to abortion and same-sex marriage.[11] Evangelicals are among the most committed supporters of Israel in the United States, viewing its creation as part of the fulfilment of a biblical prophecy tied to the second coming of Christ. As more than one-quarter of Christians in the country, they also constitute one of America's most powerful voting blocs.[12] Trump's decision to appoint Mike Pence, a born-again evangelical and opponent of abortion rights, as his vice presidential candidate further galvanized conservative Christians in favor of his candidacy. The evangelicals did not disappoint, turning out in droves for Trump with 80 percent favorability and eventually pushing him over the finish line.[13]

TRUMP'S MIDDLE EAST TEAM

At 8 a.m. on the morning of Trump's electoral victory, Friedman raced to Trump Tower and weaved through Secret Service agents to get to the Trump's office on the twenty-sixth floor. "Mr. President, as we talked about before, please make me your ambassador to Israel," he pleaded.[14] Trump obliged, pushing his nomination in front of the U.S. Senate, where nearly all Democrats voted against his candidacy. Barely scraping together the necessary votes, Friedman eventually took up his role as U.S. ambassador to Israel.

Trump also began assembling his Middle East team from those closest to him. He appointed Kushner as his senior advisor and entrusted him with developing a peace plan for resolving the Israeli-Palestinian conflict. Trump also appointed Rex Tillerson, the former chief executive officer of ExxonMobil, as his secretary of state. Tillerson would remain in the position for one year, during which time he clashed openly with figures like Kushner, who reportedly sidelined him from his role. Trump would later replace Tillerson with Mike

Pompeo, one of the few establishment politicians on the team. A former CIA director and committed evangelical, Pompeo would become the first U.S. secretary of state to visit a settlement in the West Bank, telling a Christian television network that God may have "sent Trump to save the state of Israel."[15]

Trump's other notable appointees included Avi Berkowitz, who acted as the president's special assistant and, subsequently, special representative for international negotiations. Berkowitz was Kushner's recruit: the two had remained friends since meeting at a basketball game in 2011, with Berkowitz joining the Trump campaign immediately after his graduation from Harvard Law School, at the age of twenty-eight. Like other members of the team, he had spent several years studying at a yeshiva in Jerusalem, an experience that served as his main source of exposure to the Middle East.[16] Trump also appointed Greenblatt as his Middle East envoy. Together, Kushner, Friedman, and Berkowitz became the main figures responsible for devising the president's policies toward the Israeli-Palestinian conflict. The three would later tell an Israeli television network that nobody thought they would be able to accomplish much, as outsiders with virtually no experience in politics. "Three orthodox Jews, that doesn't sound like a good start!" joked Friedman.[17]

Trump's team wasted no time in delivering on their promises to elevate Israel's interests to the top of the presidential agenda. In December 2016, with Obama still in office, Kushner received a call from Israel's ambassador to Washington, Ron Dermer, telling him that the Obama administration planned to abstain on a United Nations Security Council Resolution condemning Israel's construction of settlements in the West Bank as a flagrant violation of international law. The United States usually vetoes most resolutions condemning Israel at the United Nations, but this time, Obama looked to take a stand against the growth of settlements in the West Bank as a major obstacle to peace efforts. Upon hearing the news,

Kushner got to work calling foreign officials directly—many for the first time—to convince them to act against Obama in blocking the resolution. Over in Israel, Netanyahu's office lobbied against the motion.[18] Their efforts would yield no results, with the resolution passing 14–0. It would, however, mark the beginning of a new approach that bullishly dispensed with the conventional rules of politics—including by discrediting the policies of an incumbent U.S. president—in favor of the aggressive promotion of the new administration's interests and those of its foreign partners.

PRINCES AND LOBBYISTS

As Trump settled into the presidency, the UAE along with Saudi Arabia saw a unique opportunity to influence a candidate that played outside the usual rules. Trump's reliance on interpersonal and familial relationships also struck a chord for the Arab monarchs, facilitating a rapport between them and Trump's most trusted advisors. Referring to his relationship with the UAE and Saudi Arabia's leaders, Kushner observed: "It helped that we quickly developed a mutual understanding. In the Arab world, politics is a family business, with members of royal families ruling for generations. As the son-in-law of the president and a former executive of a family business, I represented something that they found familiar and reassuring."[19]

The UAE's outreach to Trump began in the lead-up to the election. As the presidential candidate came head to head with Hillary Clinton, Abu Dhabi's Crown Prince Mohammed bin Zayed hired a consultant by the name of George Nader to develop back channels to both campaigns and assist him in hedging on the electoral outcome.[20] Nader had built his career as a shadowy interlocutor between Middle East officials and their American counterparts, including during a stint as a consultant for Blackwater, the private security firm that

had worked alongside the U.S. military in Afghanistan and Iraq. On August 2, 2016, Nader arrived at Trump Tower for a meeting with Donald Trump Jr. (Donald Trump's eldest son) and Michael Flynn, Trump's senior national security advisor. Also in attendance was Joel Zamil, an Israeli expert in social media strategy, and Erik Prince, the founder of Blackwater, who also acted as an informal consultant to Trump.[21]

As they gathered in New York, Nader told Trump Jr. that the young princes leading Saudi Arabia and the UAE were eager to help his father win the election. Next, Zamil jumped in, offering the Trump campaign a multimillion-dollar contract to help boost his online presence. Trump's advisors embraced Nader as a useful interlocutor, giving the Emirati crown prince a direct channel to the presidential candidate and his closest advisors.[22] The August encounter at Trump Tower also set the stage for Mohammed bin Zayed to travel to New York in December for meetings with several of Trump's top advisors. Days after that meeting, MbZ brokered another meeting between Erik Prince and an associate of Russian president Vladimir Putin in the Seychelles Islands. Although not in attendance, bin Zayed had reportedly organized the gathering to establish a back channel between Moscow and President-elect Trump, and explore whether the new president's team could convince Russia to distance itself from Iran, possibly in exchange for sanctions relief.[23]

In courting Trump, Mohammed bin Zayed solicited the aid of another figure close to the new president, Tom Barrack. Barrack was a senior advisor to the Trump campaign who later served as chair of his inaugural committee. At the direction of figures closer to the crown prince, Barrack would publish an editorial in *Fortune Magazine* arguing that the United States ought to work collaboratively with the "brilliant young leaders" in places like Saudi Arabia and the UAE.[24] He also later amended an energy-policy speech delivered by Trump during the campaign to make it more favorable to Abu Dhabi.

The relationship reaped Barrack personal dividends, with a company that he owned going on to raise more than $1.5 billion in investments from the UAE and Saudi Arabia.[25]

Nader's and Barrack's dealings with foreign officials would become the target of investigations by the Department of Justice. An indictment issued by a federal court accused Barrack of acting at the direction of UAE officials to "try to install candidates favored by Abu Dhabi in key U.S. diplomatic positions."[26] Another investigation led by Special Counsel Robert Mueller would reveal Nader's role in helping funnel $1 million to the Trump inaugural committee, as well as $3.5 million in illegal campaign donations from the UAE to the Clinton campaign.[27] Nader would tell FBI officials that Mohammed bin Zayed and Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman had instructed him to be on "good terms" with both campaigns, to secure their influence in Washington.[28]

With the president comfortably in office, the UAE, along with Saudi Arabia, began fixating on Qatar as a growing regional threat. Since 2011, relations between Qatar and the trilateral Gulf states had been strained because of Doha's foreign policy, which saw it champion the Arab uprisings, lend political and financial support to the Muslim Brotherhood and its affiliates, and strengthen its diplomatic ties to Tehran. In a sign of things to come, Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and Bahrain withdrew their ambassadors from Doha in March 2014 and reinstated them months later, sending Qatar a public warning that its approach would not be tolerated.[29]

Seeing fresh opportunities for financial profiteering, the lobbyists began pitching new contracts to the two crown princes, including a proposal to push anti-Qatar policies at the highest echelons of the U.S. government.[30] By 2017 Nader had partnered with Elliot Broidy, one of Trump's top fundraisers, to offer the two princes their joint services as part of more than $1 billion in proposed contracts, which also included helping the UAE gather intelligence, strengthening

Saudi Arabia's border security, and developing counterterrorism centers.[31] Broidy would go on to claim credit for several developments, including convincing Representative Ed Royce, chair of the House Foreign Affairs Committee, to back a new bill to sanction Qatar as a terror-supporting state, and helping set up a conference by the Foundation for Defense of Democracies, a pro-Israel think tank, highlighting Qatar's ties to terrorism and the regime in Tehran. Off the back of the event, multiple articles critical of Qatar were published in American media outlets, including a piece written by General Charles Wald, the former deputy head of the U.S. European Command Air Force, calling for the United States to transfer its military base in Qatar to the UAE.

FROM RIYADH TO TEL AVIV

As the two crown princes grew their influence in Washington, Kushner pressed the president to travel to Riyadh on his first overseas visit, telling him that the trip would provide him with an opportunity to forge stronger ties with the Arab world, issue a tough call against terrorism, and generate valuable business deals for American corporations. Early in the campaign, Kushner had established regular communication with then deputy crown prince Mohammed bin Salman, whom he saw as a valuable partner in strengthening the U.S. relationship with Arab states.[32] Trump agreed to Kushner's proposal, landing in Riyadh in mid-May 2017. Unlike the frosty reception doled out to President Obama on his final visit to the kingdom, the Saudis greeted Trump with ceremonial excess, with King Salman personally welcoming him at the airport tarmac as F-16 military jets soared above, leaving red, blue, and white trails across the sky.

In Riyadh, the president signed several bilateral military, economic, and counterterrorism agreements, including a $110 billion

arms deal, bringing an end to the "estranged" relationship between the two states during the Obama years.[33] Trump also took center stage at an Arab-Islamic-American summit to address the leaders of fifty-two Muslim and Arab states. In his speech, he delivered a message of friendship, promising that the United States would not seek to impose its way of life on others, but "outstretch its hands in a spirit of cooperation."[34] He highlighted priority areas for cooperation between the United States and the Arab-Islamic world, including the need for joint engagement to isolate the regime in Iran, and the need for fresh thinking to solve the Arab-Israeli conflict. Trump also attended a meeting of the Gulf Cooperation Council states, as a guest of honor. On its sidelines, the UAE and Saudi Arabia's leaders reportedly spoke candidly with the president, telling him that Qatar was a supporter of global terrorism and working to foster regional instability.[35]

Next, the president did something no American leader had done before: he boarded a direct flight from Riyadh to Ben Gurion Airport in Tel Aviv. Although his advisors told him he needed to make a stop in Amman, Trump interrupted them, stating: "I have to make a technical stop because these guys don't talk to each other? Didn't I just meet with the king?"[36] However symbolic, the move showcased the president's disregard for the constraints of diplomatic protocol and his desire to forge a more pragmatic approach. In Israel, Trump met with Netanyahu, as well as Palestinian Authority president Mahmoud Abbas. Before heading to see Abbas, Friedman pulled Trump aside and presented him with a video compilation, appearing to show Abbas making threatening statements toward Israelis and Jews. Tillerson, also present at the screening, swiftly interjected, telling Trump that the video was edited to make the remarks appear menacing. The bilateral meeting between Trump and Abbas did not go smoothly, with Trump appearing to share his advisor's perceptions that the Palestinian leader was the corrupt beneficiary of billions of dollars in

international aid and not a willing partner in peace, and openly calling the Abbas a "liar" and "murderer."[37]

Shortly after Trump's return to Washington, the UAE along with Saudi Arabia, Bahrain, and Egypt made a stunning announcement: they had severed their relations with Doha. As the four states collectively closed their airspace to Qatari flights, Saudi Arabia shuttered Qatar's only land border, leaving Doha scrambling to secure new pathways to import vital goods. Weeks after cutting ties, the four states issued a list of conditions to restore diplomatic relations, demanding that Qatar curb its ties to Tehran, sever all connections with the Muslim Brotherhood, and shut down state broadcaster Al Jazeera.[38] President Trump initially appeared supportive of their stance, publishing a tweet that described Qatar's isolation as "possibly, the beginning of the end to the horror of terrorism!"[39] U.S. officials would quickly downplay the statement, clarifying that the United States was not taking sides in the dispute. Trump's administration continued supporting different parties in the dispute by completing the sale of $12 billion in F-15 fighter jets to Doha and working to fulfill $110 billion in arms sales to Saudi Arabia. In Washington, Kushner insisted that he had tried to convince the Saudis not to act against Doha, seeing the dispute as contrary to America's regional interests.[40]

PUTTING TOGETHER A PEACE PLAN

With a dispute unfolding in the Gulf, Kushner got to work preparing the administration's plan for resolving the Israeli-Palestinian conflict. In setting out the framework of his proposal, he consulted regularly with Berkowitz, Friedman, Greenblatt, and Brian Hook, director of policy planning at the State Department, as well as Dina Powell, a deputy national security advisor, and more seasoned officials from past U.S. administrations. While thinking through the

main issues, Kushner drew inspiration from Friedman, recalling his statement that "Israel, as the only democracy in the region, ought to be treated as a secured creditor, [and the] Palestinians, as an unsecured creditor: they have corrupt leadership, a flailing economy, and no stability, and yet they think they have parity with the secured creditor."[41] In June 2017 Kushner set in motion a key component of his strategy: pitching it to Netanyahu and the Gulf Arab leaders for buy-in. Although Kushner also discussed it with President Mahmoud Abbas, he had few expectations that he would come to the table, seeing the ailing leader as unwilling to make a deal that might cost him political influence and a comfortable stream of aid from the international community.

In August Kushner traveled to the Red Sea for a joint meeting with Mohammed bin Zayed and Mohammed bin Salman. During two days of discussions, the crown princes reminded the president's advisor that the most critical issue they faced was the threat from Iran, telling Kushner that after Obama signed the Iran deal in 2015, Arabs started learning Chinese, because they believed China could be a better future partner than the United States.[42] They also lamented Obama's decision not to consult either of them prior to signing the Iran nuclear deal and reminded Kushner of their continued commitment to the United States. After the summit, Kushner traveled to Qatar, Egypt, Jordan, and Israel to pitch his preliminary proposal for Arab-Israeli peace and discuss the most pressing issues facing the region. The visits appeared to reaffirm his view the Arab states were grateful for Trump's tough approach toward Iran and that they valued his candid and unscripted style. His conversations with Israeli and Gulf leaders also clarified the fact that they were all on the same page when it came to the threat from Iran.

On May 8, 2018, Trump fulfilled his campaign promise to withdraw the United States from the Iran nuclear deal, calling it a one-sided agreement that did not bring peace. He also blamed the deal

for handing the Iranian regime more than $100 billion through the lifting of sanctions, allowing it to boost its military budget by nearly 40 percent.[43] The president proceeded to impose the toughest U.S. sanctions on Iran to date through a new "maximum pressure" campaign, leaving the nuclear agreement hanging by a thread, by virtue of the European parties that remained party to the agreement. Trump's withdrawal from the JCPOA drew praise from Netanyahu, as well as from the two crown princes. A statement released by Saudi Arabia on the subject of the U.S. withdrawal described Iran as having taken advantage of the economic benefits afforded by the lifting of sanctions to pursue destabilizing activities in the region, including advancing its ballistic missile program and funding terrorist organizations like Hezbollah and the Huthi militias in Yemen.[44] After eight years under Obama, it appeared that the Gulf states and Israel finally had the support of a sitting U.S. president who was willing to put their interests first.

MOVING THE EMBASSY

As Kushner courted the Arab leaders, Friedman settled into his new role as U.S. ambassador to Israel, seeing himself as embarking on a divinely ordained mission to protect the state of Israel. His passion for defending Israel translated into an immediately warm friendship with Netanyahu as well as the settler lobby, whom he consulted regularly about advancing Israel's interests in Washington.

Within weeks of arriving in Israel, Friedman began pressing Trump to fulfill his campaign promise to move the U.S. Embassy to Jerusalem, reminding the president that the move had already been approved by the Jerusalem Embassy Act, passed by the U.S. Congress in 1995. But the act was controversial, having been pushed through by

Republican congressional leaders despite objections from the Clinton and Rabin administrations, who saw it an attempt to sabotage the peace process.[45] It also had never gained the approval of any sitting U.S. president and was systematically waived by the Clinton, Bush, and Obama administrations. But Friedman and other members of Trump's team argued that four decades of waivers had not brought the parties closer to peace and that there was no reason to assume that maintaining the same policy would yield better results.[46] The move also held the support of pro-Israel billionaire Sheldon Adelson, who had poured tens of millions of dollars into the Trump campaign and reportedly urged the president to proceed as planned.[47]

On May 1, 2018, Israel's Knesset passed one of the most controversial laws in its history, the "nation-state" law, defining Israel as the nation-state of the Jewish people and the right to national self-determination as unique to the Jewish people. The law would alter Israel's constitutional framework by enshrining Jewish supremacy within it and would provide legal justification for regulations anchoring discrimination against its Palestinian population. As Netanyahu lauded the passage of the law as a defining moment for Israel, he would soon be handed another political victory. On May 14, 2018, on the seventieth anniversary of first Arab-Israeli war, the U.S. Embassy opened its doors at a new headquarters in Jerusalem. Nobody within the Trump administration had consulted with the Palestinian leadership before reaching the decision, and by one account, they had only found out about it from the president when a delegation led by chief negotiator Saeb Erakat visited the White House in December 2017.[48] Stunned by the news, Erakat reportedly told the president that the move would disqualify the United States from its role as a mediator in the peace process.[49] "It's our business and we will conduct our policies according to our interests . . . don't threaten me," Trump reportedly snapped in return.[50]

The Palestinians had lost one of the issues that mattered to them most. They responded by enacting a political boycott of the Trump administration. Abbas would personally refuse to speak to the president, and the two figures never spoke after the fallout.[51] Abbas's boycott appeared to further ingrain the president's perception that the Palestinian leadership had no incentive to pursue peace so long as cash flowed to them without preconditions. At the suggestion of his advisors, Trump began axing American aid to the Palestinians. In August 2018 he eliminated $200 million in planned aid from U.S. aid agency USAID and announced his plans to end U.S. funding for UNRWA, depriving the organization of $150 million in revenue and forcing it to cut back on essential services provided to Palestinian refugees, like schooling. Netanyahu had long urged the United States to cut funding to the organization, seeing it as a vessel for perpetuating the narrative of the Palestinian right of return, which the prime minister refused to accept. Commenting on the new policy, Netanyahu remarked it was "no question, the right move," adding that a reduction in funds was one way to "shut up and close UNRWA. How do you do it? By saying, UNRWA, you don't exist anymore with all due respect."[52]

A SURPRISE VISIT

In late October 2018 Prime Minister Netanyahu made a surprise visit to Muscat, the capital city of Oman, for the first trip by an Israeli prime minister to the country in over twenty years. Instigated by Oman's leadership, the official reason behind the visit was for the two sides to discuss prospects for restarting diplomacy between Israel and the Palestinians, in line with Oman's role as a regional mediator. But in private, Oman had more than one calculation. It appeared that during President Trump's visit to Riyadh, leaders from the UAE and

Saudi Arabia had complained to him about Muscat's close ties to Tehran, later hinting that it might be next in line to face consequences after Qatar, according to a source with knowledge of the matter.[53] Alarmed by what appeared to be a discreet but growing lobbying campaign by the two Gulf states against them in Washington, Oman's leaders looked to Israel to counter the narrative. While in Muscat, that possibility of kick-starting talks with the Palestinians would be laid to rest with Netanyahu's refusal to entertain the possibility.[54] Still, the visit appeared effective in improving Muscat's image in Washington, with Greenblatt calling the visit a "helpful step for our peace efforts" and seemingly reassuring Oman's leaders that they would not face the brunt of a backlash from their neighbors.[55]

THE GOLAN HEIGHTS

By early 2019, Kushner, Hook, and Greenblatt began pitching their peace plan for resolving the Israeli-Palestinian conflict to world leaders and Arab officials, including at a conference in Warsaw in February 2019, which notably brought together the prime minister of Israel and the foreign ministers of the UAE and Bahrain. In a leaked video of a closed dinner held on the sidelines of the gathering, foreign ministers from several Gulf states could reportedly be heard reiterating Netanyahu's message that Iran—not Israel—posed the single greatest threat to the region's stability.[56]

Next, Trump's team embarked on a tour of the Gulf states, landing in Muscat, Manama, Abu Dhabi, and Riyadh, where they courted Gulf leaders in support of the plan. While in the region, Kushner listened intently as leaders like Oman's Sultan Qaboos spoke of the desire of all Muslims to pray at the al-Aqsa mosque and described the Palestinians as carrying the burden of the Muslim world. Kushner would interpret the statement to suggest that there may be two

separate conflicts at play: the first, a territorial dispute between Israel and the Palestinians, and the second, a dispute between Israel and all Arabs about access to the mosque. He began shaping his thinking around this distinction, noting that a more promising strategy might be to "encourage the Palestinians to come to the table, while pursuing a parallel track of normalization between Israel and the Arab nations," who appeared to have a set of less complex demands.[57] With Israel scheduled to go to the polls in April, Kushner and his team scheduled the plan's release for after the elections, when there would be clarity as to whether it was Netanyahu or his rival Benny Gantz who would lead the country forward.

As Kushner courted Gulf leaders, Friedman got to work convincing the president to implement another item on Netanyahu's wish list: recognizing Israel's claims over the Golan Heights. Israel had captured the 1,800 km^2 territory from Syria during the 1967 war and effectively annexed it in 1981 by applying its own laws to the territory. The proposed annexation of the Golan Heights was widely rejected by the international community, as well as by the United Nations Security Council, as a violation of Israel's obligations as an occupying power and under the Geneva Conventions. The international consensus would do little to dissuade Friedman from coming together with Pompeo and Trump's national security advisor John Bolton to push the president to recognize Israel's sovereignty over the area, including by telling him that the move would set the foundations of a more assertive U.S. regional policy and earn him the respect of America's allies and enemies alike.[58]

On March 22, 2019, Trump published a tweet announcing that his administration's decision to recognize Israel's sovereignty over the Golan Heights. Friedman wasted no time in telephoning Netanyahu to deliver the good news.[59] The prime minister—preoccupied with campaigning for elections scheduled for April—responded with delight. His campaign strategy had centered on claiming personal

credit for all of Trump's pro-Israel decisions, from his withdrawal from the Iran nuclear deal to his recognition of Jerusalem as Israel's capital. He could now add recognition of Israel's sovereignty over the Golan Heights to the list and strengthen his campaign message as the only political leader capable of bringing the United States to support the kind of policies that past U.S. presidents had dismissed as an obstacle to regional peace.[60] He would also use these claims to distract from his anticipated indictment by a criminal court on allegations of corruption and bribery.

As the elections drew closer, Netanyahu made a radical promise, telling voters that he planned to annex the West Bank for Israel if elected to a fourth term.[61] Although Israel maintains de facto control over much of the West Bank, de jure annexation would mark the most dramatic rejection of the two-state solution by any Israeli prime minister in modern history, effectively absorbing into Israel much of the remaining land on which a Palestinian state could be formed.[62] The move would also meet the demands of the right-wing, prosettler factions that Netanyahu was working to court. After hearing that Trump had decided to recognize Israel's sovereignty over the Golan Heights, Netanyahu quietly mulled that the administration might prove to be his saving grace, allowing him to snatch victory form the jaws of defeat, save his political career, and secure his legacy as one of Israel's greatest leaders, without ceding an inch of territory to the Palestinians, or having to deal with them at all.[63]

THE MOST POWERFUL MAN YOU'VE NEVER HEARD OF

As Kushner finalized the details of his peace plan, a diplomat made an unexpected visit to his home in Washington, DC. It was Yousef al-Otaiba, the UAE's ambassador to the United States. A skilled and

charismatic statesman, al-Otaiba had completed his university education at Georgetown University and held an understanding of U.S. politics described as so intuitive that those who met him remarked "how easy it was to forget that he was not American." The depth of his influence among Washington's foreign policy elite had also earned him the title, from the *Huffington Post*, of "the most influential man in Washington you've never heard of."[64] Al-Otaiba benefited from his family's track record of loyalty to Abu Dhabi's rulers. His father, Mana al-Otaiba, served as the UAE's first minister of petroleum and was a close advisor to Sheikh Zayed bin Sultan Al Nahyan. It was fitting that Yousef and Mohammed bin Zayed would also develop a close connection, with the former beginning his career as an advisor to the latter and moving to become his director of international affairs and one of his top antiterrorism liaisons, responsible for shuttling between the crown prince and foreign officials.

It was one episode, dating back to 2006, that had convinced al-Otaiba and other Emirati officials not to take their relationship with the United States for granted. In March 2006 Dubai's port operator, Dubai Ports World (DP World), completed its acquisition of P&O, a British shipping and logistics company. The acquisition would have transferred management of six ports in the United States to DP World. The news initially flew under the radar until Senator Charles Schumer led a campaign against it, claiming that the management of these ports—part of the country's critical infrastructure—by a company that was mostly owned a foreign state posed a national security risk. Schumer's remarks led to a heated congressional debate, with his critics claiming that the U.S. government should not interfere in what amounted to a routine business transaction.[65] The U.S. Congress proceeded to block the deal, with President Bush threatening to veto the motion. In the face of sustained pressure, DP World agreed to sell its American operations to a U.S. entity and exit from the deal. The episode served as a painful reminder to the UAE's leaders that they might need to make further investments in improving their reputation in Washington.

In 2009 al-Otaiba took up the role of ambassador to the United States. Under his watch, the UAE would become one of the largest foreign lobbyists in the country, spending over $100 million on U.S. foreign agents between 2016 and 2021. During his tenure, al-Otaiba accomplished what few Arab diplomats could: gaining the trust of Washington's foreign policy elite. When the Pentagon held a confidential meeting to discuss its strategy toward the so-called Islamic state of Iraq and Syria (ISIS) in 2015, al-Otaiba was just one of two foreign officials at the meeting, the other being the British ambassador to the United States.[66] In advocating for his country's interests, al-Otaiba regularly urged U.S. officials to take a stronger stance against the Muslim Brotherhood and Iran, with the threat from both sources preoccupying much of his thinking.

During his visit to Kushner, al-Otaiba offered some surprising news, telling him that the UAE was ready to move forward and normalize relations with Israel, adding that Crown Prince Mohammed bin Zayed had taken note of Kushner's efforts to nudge the Arab states toward gradual normalization with Israel and wanted his country to be the first to do so.[67] Kushner responded enthusiastically, while acknowledging that the turbulence taking place within Israeli politics might hinder any peace process, whether with the Palestinians or with other Arab states. Still, the ambassador had affirmed Kushner's belief that if peace with the Palestinians did not bear fruit, maybe the administration could work toward peace between Israel and a forward-thinking country like the UAE, which appeared to have a much lower ceiling of demands.

THE ECONOMIC COMPONENT

Netanyahu's campaign strategy initially appeared to deliver him the desired results, with his Likud Party securing 35 out of 120 Knesset seats, and raising expectations that the Netanyahu might be able to

maintain power by forming a coalition with smaller parties. But a month later he proved unable to reach a compromise with Avigdor Lieberman, the head of the smaller Yisrael Beytenu Party, over a controversial conscription bill. Faced with a stalemate, Knesset members voted to disperse and initiate elections again, on September 17, 2019.

News of Israel's continued political deadlock was met with exasperation in Washington, forcing Kushner to further delay the rollout of the Middle East peace plan.[68] By the summer of 2019, the administration decided that the matter could no longer be delayed. They proceeded with a compromise solution: unveiling half of the peace plan—the economic component—and delaying the second half—the political component—until after Israel's September elections. Ahead of the rollout, Trump's team consulted with their Gulf partners to identify a partner state capable of hosting the launch event. It would be tiny Bahrain that stepped in, with King Hamad reportedly expressing his eagerness to take center stage in the process.

On a summer evening in June 2019, Kushner greeted an audience of three hundred American officials, Gulf and Arab diplomats, and business tycoons, who had gathered at Manama's waterfront Four Seasons Hotel. Participants included Mohammed Al Abbar, chair of UAE real estate giant Emaar Properties, former British prime minister Tony Blair, and Stephen Schwarzman, chair of Blackstone, one of the globe's largest private equity firms. At the meeting, Kushner set out his strategy, telling participants that the pursuit of diplomacy in isolation from economic incentives had been the main cause behind the failure of previous peace efforts. Kushner pledged to reverse more than seventy years of economic malaise and create real incentives for diplomacy by providing the Palestinians with $50 billion worth of investments over a ten-year period. The proposed investments aimed to kick-start economic growth through state-of-the art infrastructural projects, free-zone areas, and the injection of cash into the private

sector. Kushner further proposed an additional $5 billion to create a transportation corridor linking the West Bank and Gaza, with funding for the proposal to be raised from Gulf donors and private investors. He spoke of the economic opportunities his deal presented in creating over half a million jobs, cutting Palestinian poverty in half, and doubling the size of the Palestinian economy, all while reaping dividends for those who had invested into the project.[69] It would be the deal of the century.

As Kushner unveiled his vision for Palestinian prosperity, few made mention of the glaring absence of any Palestinian representative at the meeting. The Palestinian leadership had decided to boycott Kushner's workshop, in keeping with their view that the administration was unfairly siding with Israel. Absent, too, were any representatives from the multitude of Palestinian nongovernmental organizations with experience in development on the ground. Nor were any Israelis in attendance: the United States had made a last-minute decision to exclude them from participation to avoid the appearance of favoring either side.[70]

Kristin Diwan, a senior resident scholar at the Arab Gulf States Institute in Washington, notes that rather than bringing the Israelis and the Palestinians together, Kushner's economic plan appeared aimed at drawing the Gulf states toward normalization with Israel, including by setting them as financial intermediaries in the proposed economic plan and giving them a stake in the process.[71] The plan itself relied heavily on their generosity, aiming to garner the billions of dollars of proposed investments mostly from the Gulf states, with European and Asian states and private investors playing a supporting role. For their part, the Gulf states welcomed their moment in the sun. At the event, Bahraini officials praised Kushner's approach and chided the Palestinians for their refusal to participate, with Foreign Minister Sheikh Khalid bin Ahmed Al Khalifa describing the Palestinian boycott of the event as "unfortunate" and adding that

Kushner's initiative represented "a hopeful new beginning for the whole region."[72] The foreign minister also called for Israel's acceptance in the region, telling an Israeli television station: "Israel is a country in the Middle East. It is a part of the heritage of the region historically."[73]

While drawing the Gulf states closer toward normalization, the launch ceremony provided an opportunity for Gulf leaders and Trump's team to jointly condemn Tehran. In an op-ed published days after the workshop in Manama, Greenblatt and Hook blamed Iran for the region's most intractable problems, including the Israeli-Palestinian conflict itself, explaining that it had exploited the conflict to advance its malign activities and grow its regional influence. The officials noted that "Iran's support for Palestinian terror groups only furthered its own strategic interests," while posing a direct threat to Israel and other Arab countries and costing the Palestinians their own security and well-being. To support their point, Greenblatt and Hook cited a statement delivered by Bahrain's foreign minister at the workshop, who had noted that "if it weren't for Iran being present—Iranian soldiers, money, support for Hamas and jihadists that take control of Gaza—we'd have been much closer to achieving a better peace between Palestinians and Israelis." The two American officials went on to praise the cooperative efforts taking place among their administration, the Gulf states, and the Israelis in forging a peace plan between Israel and the Palestinians. Foreshadowing things to come, they concluded their editorial by noting that "the Iranian regime's regional aggression has brought the Arab nations and Israel together to an unprecedented degree."[74]

That summer, the Gulf states would face the brunt of a backlash against Trump's withdrawal from the JCPOA, in the form of a series of retaliatory acts from Tehran. In August 2019 mine limpet attacks targeted four Norwegian, Emirati, and Saudi tankers stationed off the coast of the UAE, causing extensive damage to the vessels. The

attack was followed by a September 2019 drone and missile strike against Saudi Arabia's state oil producer, Aramco, forcing it to temporarily cut half of its daily oil output.[75] The reprisals served as a fresh warning to the Gulf states that although they supported Trump's withdrawal from an agreement they believed had emboldened Iran, they would also be the first frontline states to endure a backlash, whether from Tehran directly or from its sprawling network of proxy militias.

Although the United States did not immediately retaliate against Tehran, a militia-backed missile strike on the U.S. Embassy in Iraq in late 2019 would convince Trump to act. On January 3, 2020, a drone strike authorized by President Trump killed Qassim Soleimani, the leader of the Quds Force of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (and the second most powerful man in Tehran), as well as Mahdi al-Muhandis, a key architect of Tehran's policies in Iraq. In an interview with President Trump, Israeli journalist Barak Ravid notes that the incident brought to the surface tensions between President Trump and Prime Minister Netanyahu, with Trump believing that Israel had not taken a large enough role in executing the attack, despite Netanyahu repeatedly pressuring the United States to target Tehran. Netanyahu was "willing to fight Iran down to the last American soldier," Trump complained.[76]

THE POLITICAL COMPONENT

In Washington, a shuffle within the administration did little to change the direction of its policies. In September 2019 Jason Greenblatt resigned from his role as U.S. Middle East envoy. Avi Berkowitz would take up a new position as the administration's special representative for international negotiations, effectively absorbing many of Greenblatt's responsibilities. In Israel, Friedman continued

working to legitimize Netanyahu's expansion of the settlements, which had increased twofold since Trump's election.

Since 1978 the United States had—at least in principle—stood against Israel's construction of settlements in the occupied territories. The main legal text on the matter, the Hansell Memorandum, described the settlements as "inconsistent with international law," a nod to the fourth Geneva convention, which prohibits an occupying power from transferring its civilian population to the territories it occupies.[77] But by November 2019, Friedman began working to tear up the policy, including by bringing together a team of American and Israeli lawyers in Jerusalem to study the memorandum, and justifying the joint consultation as necessary to consider Israeli views on the matter. After discussions, the delegation traveled back to Washington, DC, for talks with the administration. On November 19 Mike Pompeo announced a change in U.S. policy, declaring that the United States now held the view "that Israeli civilian settlements in the West Bank and Jerusalem were not per se inconsistent with international law."[78] The announcement sparked widespread speculation that the administration was preparing to endorse Netanyahu's proposed annexation of the West Bank.[79]

Elections in September 2019 had brought little clarity on the future direction of Israeli politics, with neither Netanyahu nor his rival, Benny Gantz, garnering enough of a majority to cobble together a coalition government. Netanyahu's fate worsened in November, when an Israeli court indicted him on corruption charges, including bribery, fraud, and breach of public trust. Unwilling to remain hostage to the twists and turns of Israeli politics, the Trump administration decided to proceed with unveiling the political component of the peace plan on January 28, 2020. To hedge on the outcomes of the election, they invited both Netanyahu and Gantz to the launch ceremony at the White House. Contrary to much of the speculation

circulating in Washington at the time, the timing of the rollout was not intended to salvage Netanyahu's political career. In fact, Trump had no particular attachment to Netanyahu and at times openly wondered whether Gantz's relatively less tainted relationship with the Palestinians might make him a better partner for the peace plan.[80] With the Palestinians persisting in their boycott of all things Trump-related, it would be Netanyahu who stood alongside the president on the White House stage.[81] Also in the audience were ambassadors from three Gulf states: the UAE, Bahrain, and Oman. The Arab states that had been central to peace efforts in the past—Jordan and Egypt—were not present, symbolizing the change in the Arab center of gravity when it came to the peace process and in the eyes of the Trump administration.[82]

Trump began presenting his plan, reaffirming Jerusalem as Israel's undivided capital and referencing a "potential" capital for the Palestinians, which he noted could be located on the outskirts of the city. Next, he addressed the issue of land, proposing the absorption of most Israeli settlements in the West Bank—in an area equivalent to one-third of the area—into Israel, and placing the Jordan Valley, an area that makes up another third of the West Bank, under Israeli sovereignty. As compensation, the Palestinians would be offered land swaps in two barren areas in the Negev Desert. The plan proposed making these swaps more attractive by linking them to Gaza and the West Bank by a high-speed rail.[83] And while the agreement did not entirely dismiss the possibility of a Palestinian state, it clarified that such an entity would not have real defensive or military capabilities. The plan also remained silent on the Palestinian right of return. In exchange for these concessions, it proposed a four-year freeze on the construction of settlements, during which Palestinian leaders could decide whether they wanted to engage in further talks.[84] Faced with a proposal that offered little more than one-sided concessions and

enabled Israel to extend its sovereignty over two-thirds of the West Bank, the Palestinians described the arrangement as closer to an "annexation plan" than a peace plan.[85]

THE PRESIDENT AND PRIME MINISTER FALL OUT

As Trump presented his proposal on stage, Netanyahu chimed in, declaring: "Israel will apply its laws to the Jordan Valley, to all Jewish communities in Judea and Samaria (the West Bank), and to other areas that your plan designates as part of Israel and which the US agrees to recognize as part of Israel." Ravid notes that Netanyahu's announcement caught Trump by surprise, with the president later turning to his advisors to ask, "What the hell was that?" It appeared that Friedman had provided Netanyahu with assurances that the United States would back his plans for unilateral annexation. Except Friedman never ran the idea by the White House, or by the president.[86] When it came to annexation, the Trump administration was entirely divided, with Friedman and Pompeo backing Netanyahu's plans for unilateral annexation of areas of the West Bank designated in the peace plan as under future Israeli sovereignty, and Kushner along with Berkowitz insisting that Israel's annexation could only happen as part of the conditions laid out in the plan itself, and in line with a peace process with the Palestinians.[87] Although the two approaches would have eventually led to differing versions of annexation, Netanyahu's unilateral approach would have fragmented a possible Palestinian state beyond the model envisaged under the Trump proposal. It also meant the dispensation of any discussions with the Palestinians, consigning Trump's plan to irrelevance. Kushner also expressed concern that the move would diminish Arab support for Trump's peace plan and even lead to the termination of Jordan's peace

treaty with Israel, as Jordan's King Abdulla had openly threatened.[88] Netanyahu's declaration plunged his relationship with the Trump administration into turmoil, with Trump's advisors reportedly refusing to speak to Netanyahu's team for weeks afterward, and the prime minister insisting that he had done nothing wrong.[89]

Faced with the impending threat of annexation, Palestinian prime minister Mahmoud Abbas turned to the Arab League for support. At an emergency summit held on February 1, 2020, the organization adopted a resolution rejecting Trump's plan as unfair to the Palestinians. Not wanting to criticize the U.S. administration, the UAE, Saudi Arabia, Bahrain, and Oman, along with several other Arab states, issued separate statements expressing support for the administration's efforts to resolve the conflict.[90] Next, the Palestinians turned to the United Nations. With the backing of Indonesia and Tunisia, Abbas proposed the introduction of a resolution denouncing the U.S. administration's peace plan as a violation of international law and the internationally endorsed terms for achieving a just solution to the Israeli-Palestinian conflict. Abbas hoped that the move would help isolate the United States and potentially trigger another vote on the matter at the General Assembly. If successful, a resolution there would erode the plan's legitimacy and end any pressure on the Palestinians to accept a so-called Swiss cheese Palestinian state.[91] As Abbas devised his plan, thousands of Palestinians poured onto the streets in the West Bank and Gaza. Polling data from the Palestinian Centre for Policy and Survey Research suggested almost unanimous opposition to the plan, from 94 percent of Palestinians. Days later, and following sustained U.S. pressure on Security Council members from the Trump administration, Palestinian officials announced that they had abandoned efforts to shore up the resolution, citing a lack of international support.[92]

Reflecting on U.S. policy toward the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, Vice President Mike Pence later observed: "One of the historic errors

the US made—going back to the Carter administration—was the fiction of being an honest broker. . . . I think what Trump and our administration understood is that if the world knows nothing else, it needs to know that the U.S. stands with Israel, we are on the side of the table with Israel."[93] It would be one of the few matters on which Netanyahu, the Trump administration, and the Palestinians might agree.

A SURPRISE OUTREACH

In the lead-up to the next round of Israeli elections, scheduled for March 23, 2020, Netanyahu continued to complain that the United States was not lending him the kind of support he needed to ensure electoral victory. In late February Israel's ambassador to the United States, Ron Dermer, visited Kushner to deliver the message on behalf of Netanyahu. He told Kushner that the president had embarrassed Netanyahu at a crucial juncture in his election campaign and that the prime minister was not sure whether he could trust the president anymore. "Ron, what you just said is disgusting. Get out of here," Kushner reportedly retorted in return.[94] Within Israel, the settler movement that Netanyahu was so desperate to court also appeared to be growing impatient. In early February David Elhayani, chair of the Yesha Council, an organization that oversees more than 150 settlements, began accusing Netanyahu of betrayal, and Kushner of driving a knife in the prime minister's back.[95]

The March elections appeared to mark a shift in Netanyahu's fortunes, as he succeeded in forming a coalition with Gantz. Empowered by his electoral victory, Netanyahu announced July 1 as a deadline for his plans to annex the West Bank and Jordan Valley. His announcement provoked widespread condemnation, with Jordan threatening to suspend parts of its peace agreement with Israel if Netanyahu went ahead with annexation.[96]

Amid a chorus of objections, an unexpected voice chimed in. On June 12, 2020, Yousef al-Otaiba published an editorial in Israel's most widely circulated newspaper, *Yedioth Ahronoth*, the first by any Arab official. Al-Otaiba spoke directly to an Israeli audience, warning that annexation would ignite violence across the region and defy an international consensus on the Palestinian right to self-determination. He delivered his message in a tone of friendship, dangling the possibility of deepening ties between the two sides and noting: "With the region's two most capable militaries, common concerns about terrorism and aggression, and a deep and long relationship with the United States, the UAE and Israel could form closer and more effective security cooperation." Al-Otaiba tied this possibility to the maintenance of a minimum status quo arrangement for the Palestinians, adding: "In the UAE and across much of the Arab world, we would like to believe Israel is an opportunity, not an enemy. We face too many common dangers and see the great potential of warmer ties. Israel's decision on annexation will be an unmistakable signal of whether it sees it the same way."[97] The article stirred a debate within Israel, where it served as a pertinent reminder that although no Arab state had normalized its ties with Israel in twenty-five years, the matter was not off the table, and that Netanyahu's bullish approach may be costlier than expected.

In Washington, Netanyahu's threats of annexation would soon be dwarfed by more urgent concerns, as the U.S. administration turned its attention to battling the COVID-19 pandemic. But Friedman did not relent in backing Netanyahu's plans for annexation and working to convince the president to support those plans. As most countries shuttered their borders, Friedman flew from Jerusalem back to Washington, DC, in late June to meet with the president and his Middle East advisors and urge them to support Netanyahu's plan. At one of their meetings, Trump reminded Friedman of the fallout between the two leaders in January, adding that he saw Netanyahu as unreliable

and untrustworthy. As the discussion among the president, Friedman, Kushner, and Berkowitz dragged on, Trump pointed to Pompeo, telling him in exasperation: "If you want to do it, I don't have a problem. Mike—you decide."[98]

Faced with the continued threat of unilateral annexation, Berkowitz decided to step in, accompanying Friedman back to Jerusalem for a series of meetings with the prime minister. At their meetings, Berkowitz reportedly urged Netanyahu not to go ahead with annexation, warning him that he would turn his greatest friend, the president of the United States, into an enemy. But Netanyahu refused to back down. Berkowitz then consulted Kushner, who decided to offer the prime minister a new proposal. In the last of their meetings that week, Berkowitz asked Netanyahu if he would be willing to drop annexation in exchange for normalizing relations with the UAE. He agreed to think about it.[99]

STOPPING ANNEXATION

Back in Washington, Berkowitz and Kushner presented their proposal to al-Otaiba, who told them that the same idea had crossed his mind. In fact, it was the ambassador who had raised the possibility not long before, during his meeting in 2019 with Kushner. Together, Berkowitz, Kushner, and al-Otaiba agreed that the move would serve the interests of each of the countries involved. For the UAE, it would mean new relations with a valuable strategic partner, and being able to claim credit for single-handedly keeping open the door to Palestinian statehood by halting annexation. For Netanyahu, the exchange would allow him to backtrack from annexation, while securing his legacy as the first Israeli prime minister to establish diplomatic relations with an Arab state in twenty-five years. When it came to the Trump administration, a normalization agreement would mark its

most important diplomatic success, proving that the team of political outsiders could deliver the kind of results that had eluded the most seasoned politicians. Trump's team mused that it might even earn the president a second term in office.

As Netanyahu's deadline for annexation expired, Trump's team began negotiations with Israeli and Emirati officials to set out the terms of their agreement. At the insistence of the Emiratis, the three sides did not meet at once. Instead, it would be Trump's team, especially Kushner and Berkowitz, who played the role of intermediaries: meeting bilaterally with each party, and relaying their messages to the other. The shuttle diplomacy was a core condition from UAE officials, who remained suspicious of Netanyahu's promises and wanted the United States to act as guarantor throughout the entirety of the process. Their suspicions would soon be validated. As the parties appeared on the verge of a breakthrough, Ron Dermer contacted Berkowitz to deliver a message from Netanyahu, telling him that the prime minister would agree to drop annexation only if three Arab states came on board. With Kushner livid at the news, Berkowitz coldly advised Netanyahu to take what was offered. The plan appeared to be back on track when, on the eve of the announcement, Netanyahu hesitated once again, telling Trump's team that he would not sign the agreement. Kushner furiously told Ambassador Dermer to inform the prime minister that the announcement would be made regardless, and that Netanyahu did not have a choice.[100]

As the parties discussed the terms of their normalization agreement, the UAE used the outbreak of the COVID-19 pandemic to hint at a change in its policy toward Israel. As it dispatched humanitarian flights across the world, Abu Dhabi sent a flight from its national carrier, Etihad Airways, to Ben Gurion Airport. Upon landing in Israel, its crew unveiled a banner that read: "UAE Aid for Palestine to fight Coronavirus." The move broke with established protocol dictating that Arab states direct their aid to the West Bank—the seat of

the Palestinian government—through Amman. The timing of the move was especially controversial, taking place just days before Netanyahu's June 1 deadline for annexation. Within the charged political atmosphere, Palestinian officials rejected the shipment, as Health Minister Mai Kaila declared: "Palestinians refuse to be a bridge [for Arab countries] seeking to have normalized relations with Israel."[101] Days later, Abu Dhabi dispatched a second humanitarian flight for the Palestinians, also to Ben Gurion Airport.[102] The Palestinian leadership rejected the shipment once again, with Prime Minister Mohamed Shtayyeh telling reporters that his government was not notified of the delivery and had to hear about it through the media.[103]

On August 13 Trump hosted a conference call with Prime Minister Netanyahu, Crown Prince Mohammed bin Zayed, Ambassador al-Otaiba, and Berkowitz. After the call, Trump typed out his infamous tweet, writing: "HUGE breakthrough today! Historic Peace Agreement between our two GREAT friends, Israel and the United Arab Emirates!" He then passed his phone over to Berkowitz, who reportedly hit the "tweet" button, sending the message into cyberspace. Next came a tweet from Mohammed bin Zayed clarifying that the purpose of the agreement was first and foremost to stop annexation. He wrote: "During a call with President Trump and Prime Minister Netanyahu, an agreement was reached to stop further Israeli annexation of Palestinian territories. The UAE and Israel also agreed to cooperation and setting a road map towards establishing a bilateral relationship."[104] A joint statement issued by the three countries affirmed the message, noting that "as a result of this diplomatic breakthrough and at the request of President Trump with the support of the United Arab Emirates, Israel will suspend declaring sovereignty over areas outlined in the President's Vision for Peace and focus its efforts now on expanding ties with other countries in the Arab and Muslim world."[105]

Almost immediately, Netanyahu backtracked on his promises once again. In a televised address made hours after Trump's announcement, the prime minister clarified that he had only agreed to delay his plans for annexation and not forgo them entirely. "There is no change to my plan to extend sovereignty, our sovereignty in Judea and Samaria, in full coordination with the United States," he declared.[106] The statement shocked the Emiratis, who insisted that they had obtained multiple guarantees from the Trump administration that Netanyahu had agreed to forgo annexation.[107] The terms of their bargain were also outlined in the joint statement published by the three sides. With Netanyahu walking back his promises, the Emiratis emerged as the target of ire from the Palestinian leadership, who accused them of betrayal. The Palestinians proceeded to recall their ambassador to the UAE and push forward a resolution at the Arab League to condemn the deal. But the resolution failed to gain a majority, marking a new blow to the Palestinians from Arab states who appeared reluctant to antagonize the UAE for its decision.

A NEW BEGINNING, AND AN END

Netanyahu's backtracking did little to dissuade other states from following in the UAE's footsteps. In another surprising turn of events, Bahrain's Minister of Finance, Sheikh Salman bin Khalifa Al Khalifa, called the White House on the same afternoon as the UAE's announcement was made public, telling Kushner and Berkowitz that his country wanted to be next in line to normalize ties with Israel.[108] For Bahrain, the move held one clear benefit: sending a signal to Iran—which it previously accused of meddling in its internal affairs—that it had the region's strongest military power on its side. Normalization also held other advantages: bringing Bahrain's leadership

closer to the United States, and enabling Manama to promote a message of tolerance that formed the backbone of its post–Arab Spring reputational management strategy. Kushner and Berkowitz would subsequently visit Riyadh, where Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman reportedly endorsed Bahrain's decision to normalize its relations with Israel and agreed to open Saudi airspace to flights traveling from Israel to the UAE and Bahrain.

On the anniversary of the 9/11 attacks, Trump made Bahrain's decision public, using the occasion to frame normalization as intended to advance religious and cultural tolerance between the two states. In delivering the announcement, he told reporters that he had hosted a call between Prime Minister Netanyahu and King Hamad Al Khalifa where both leaders expressed their condolences on the tragic events that took place on 9/11. He noted: "In the spirit of peace and cooperation, both leaders agree that Bahrain will fully normalize its diplomatic relations with Israel, they will exchange embassies and ambassadors to begin direct flights between their countries and launch cooperation initiatives across a broad range of sectors." Two days later, on September 13, 2020, President Trump and Prime Minister Netanyahu joined Bahraini and Emirati foreign ministers at the Abraham Accords signing ceremony at the White House. Reporting by Saudi media *Elaph* outlet suggested that Mohammed bin Zayed had decided not to attend the event, reportedly in protest against Netanyahu's decision to walk back his promises on annexation, a view he was said to have aired with Mossad chief Yossi Cohen.[109] Still, Netanyahu's betrayal would not be enough to derail the plan for normalization.

By November 2020 the UAE began seeing initial pay-offs for its decision, with the Trump administration notifying Congress that it approved the sale of fifty F-35 fighter jets to the country as part of a larger arms deal worth over $23 billion, intended to bolster the UAE's defenses against Tehran.[110] But the sale of the F-35s would eventually

fall through after the UAE refused to end its cooperation with Chinese technology giant Huawei on a new 5-G internet network, reportedly a condition imposed by Washington for the sale of the jets. The United States had insisted on the condition, fearing that China would use Huawei's 5-G technology to spy on—and eventually unlock—the sensitive technology that it uses in its fighter jets.

While observers had explained the UAE's decision to enter the accords as motivated mostly by its aim to secure the sale of the jets from the United States, all sides dismissed that narrative. Al-Otaiba would tell an Israeli television station that talks on the sale of the jets began only after normalization had taken place.[111] Friedman echoed the message, stating that the proposed sale would have to pass through the regular channels in Congress. "Would peace between Israel and the UAE make it easier for the UAE to purchase better weapons? Almost certainly, as the threat assessment would change in favor of the transaction. But the legally required process for Israel to maintain its qualitative military edge would run its course professionally, nonetheless," he noted.[112] Ravid observes that although the agreements did not contain a clause on the sale of the jets, their sale was the subject of continued discussions between American and Emirati officials, with the Trump administration agreeing that new relations between the two states meant that Israel had "nothing to worry about" in the event of a sale.[113] UAE officials corroborate the narrative, adding that it would take more than a single transaction—and the promise of a single payoff—to drive such a seismic change in its policy.

During the twilight weeks of Trump's presidency, his administration succeeded in drawing Morocco into the Abraham Accords, in exchange for U.S. recognition of Morocco's disputed claims over Western Sahara. Next came Sudan, which agreed to normalize ties with Israel in exchange for the removal of Sudan's designation as a state sponsor of terrorism, as well as the provision of a $1.2 billion loan from the United States to clear its debts to the World Bank. Despite

drawing four Arab states into the agreements, Netanyahu's relationship with Trump would come under increasing strain, especially after the prime minister issued a statement congratulating President Biden on winning the 2020 election, while Trump disputed the results. Trump would accuse him of disloyalty and a lack of gratitude. "Fuck him," Trump retorted.[114]

Before leaving office, Trump set the groundwork for closer security engagements between Israel and its Arab partners and fulfilled another of their demands against Iran. On January 11, 2021, his administration designated Yemen's Huthis as a terrorist organization, justifying the move as intended to deter further malign activity. The designation would establish penalties for those seeking to do business with the Huthis and complicate the delivery of humanitarian aid to Yemen, but it drew praise from Saudi Arabia as well as the UAE. On January 15 the outgoing president made another important announcement, ordering the Department of Defense to move Israel into U.S Central Command (CENTCOM), America's zone of security stretching from Africa, across the Middle East, to South Asia, which encompasses all six Gulf states, Pakistan, Iran, Yemen, and Afghanistan, among other states. Israel had previously remained in the U.S. European Central Command due to its long-standing conflict with its Arab neighbors and their refusal to cooperate with it.[115] The decision to move it to CENTCOM would encourage and facilitate closer cooperation between Israel and its Arab partners against Iran, especially in areas of air and missile defense. Israel would officially become part of CENTCOM under President Biden, a move consistent with bipartisan efforts to encourage closer cooperation between the Arab states and Israel and expand the accords. While marking a diplomatic triumph for the parties involved, the Abraham Accords failed to secure the immediate electoral fortunes of either Trump or Netanyahu, with both leaders forced out of power just months later.

In a surprise turn of events, the accords triggered—however briefly—a climate of optimism in Israel, paving the way for the emergence of an unprecedented governing coalition in the Knesset, bringing together the far-right parties that had advocated for annexation with members of the United Arab List, led by representatives from Israel's Arab minority, including Mansour Abbas. It would be the first time that an Arab party was included as part of a governing coalition within the Knesset. Yet any speculation that the accords might help shore up prospects for a lasting peace between Israel and the Palestinians would be conclusively laid to rest with a new military assault by Israel on the Gaza Strip in in May 2021 and the outbreak of a much larger and more devastating war between Israel and Hamas in late 2023.

Instead of forging peace between the conflicting parties, the Trump administration brokered a normalization agreement between Israel and states not directly involved in the conflict while emboldening Netanyahu to continue his expansion of settlements in the West Bank and deepening Israel's grip over the occupied territories. These policies would push Israel and the Palestinians further away from a settlement, diminish Arab pressure on Israel to shift course, and leave tensions simmering. The new agreements held significant implications beyond the Palestinians, opening the door to a series of bilateral agreements between the UAE, Bahrain, and Israel and bringing the two Gulf states into a new political, economic, and security alignment with Israel.

4

A NEW RELATIONSHIP

With the Abraham Accords in place, Israel and its Gulf partners began forging new economic, political, and military ties. Despite their deepening mistrust of Netanyahu, UAE leaders took the lead in pushing the relationship forward, not only through billion-dollar investments in Israel's economy, but also by welcoming trade with the illegal settlements. The new relationship would impact the economic unity of the Gulf Cooperation Council, with Oman and Kuwait enacting laws to limit the entry of Israeli goods into their territories through the Gulf common market. While affecting regional unity, the agreements enabled the United States to pursue a different kind of integration, by drawing its Arab partners and Israel into a new regional security architecture that would facilitate the ability of the Gulf states to acquire advanced defensive systems from Israel and Israel to deepen its ties further into the Arab world, including with Arab states not involved in the accords. Yet the UAE's willingness to put these strategic relations on display would also be tempered by its rising commitment to a process of de-escalation with Iran.

ECONOMIC INTEGRATION

In the weeks after the enactment of the Abraham Accords, officials from the UAE and Bahrain celebrated their turn to Israel as a gateway to economic prosperity, marking a new era of cultural and religious tolerance, based on a shared Abrahamic heritage. Gulf leaders spoke at length about their enthusiasm for Israel's "start-up culture," seeing potential for the accords to boost entrepreneurship, spur private sector growth, and bring in valuable technology from the Middle East's most advanced economy. Trade with Israel would also bring the two Gulf states closer to meeting their Vision 2030 Strategies: long-term development plans aimed at orienting their economies to a post-oil future.[1] Business figures in Israel were no less enthusiastic toward the accords, for their potential to yield lucrative investments from the resource-rich Gulf states, act as a gateway to bigger Gulf markets like Saudi Arabia, and chip away at Israel's regional isolation.

The first step for the UAE and Bahrain was dismantling any remaining legal infrastructure prohibiting dealings with Israel.[2] Seeking to kick-start integration, President Trump announced the creation of the Abraham Fund in October 2020, an initiative to distribute $3 billion in U.S. taxpayer money to businesses that promoted the economic objectives of the accords.[3] But reporting by the *Times of Israel* would find that his successor, President Biden, had not allocated any capital to the fund, accusing him of a "lack of enthusiasm" that reflected his spending priorities in the wake of the pandemic, and the planned U.S. pivot away from the Middle East more generally.[4]

Ten days after the publication of the revelations, the UAE stepped in to compensate for the shortfall. On March 12, 2021, the Emirates News Agency announced that following a "constructive" phone call with Netanyahu, Mohammed bin Zayed had decided to establish a $10 billion fund to support Emirati investments in Israel's most

strategic sectors, including across energy, manufacturing, and healthcare sectors.[5] Abu Dhabi's largest sovereign wealth funds, including Mubadala (which manages $250 billion in assets) and Abu Dhabi Developmental Holding Company (which manages $110 billion in assets), would act as two of the fund's largest investors.[6] The next state-backed initiative emerged in 2022, when Israel and the UAE announced their first joint technological research and development fund, with each state committing to allocate $4.2 million annually over the next decade.[7]

Gulf and Israeli leaders also enacted tariff and trade agreements to deepen their integration. The most significant among them is the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement between Israel and the UAE, which lifted tariffs, duties, and customs on ninety-six percent of traded goods between them.[8] As they finalized the agreement in May 2022, leaders from the two states announced their goal to grow bilateral trade to more than $10 billion within five years, a tenfold increase from the first year of trade.[9] The figure paled in comparison with the projections later announced by the UAE's economy minister, Abdullah bin Touq Al-Marri, who stated that his country was looking to establish $1 trillion in trade ties with Israel by 2031, amounting to more than double the UAE's entire GDP.[10]

The volume of trade between Israel and the UAE vastly outstripped the other parties to the agreements, approaching $1 billion by the end of 2021 and $2.5 billion by the end of 2022.[11] Israel's trade with Bahrain proved more modest, reaching just $6.5 million during the first year. The reason is one of scale: Israel is the fourth-largest economy in the MENA region, with a GDP valued at $481 billion in 2021, and the UAE follows it closely as the fifth-largest economy, with a GDP valued at $409 billion. Although 30 percent of the UAE's income comes from oil, its economic diversification efforts have enabled it to slash this proportion year-on-year.[12] Bahrain's economy, by comparison, is just one-tenth of the size of either state. Beyond

the similar sizes of their economies, trade between Israel and the UAE was also boosted by the massive investments by the UAE's sovereign wealth funds in Israel's energy and technology sectors, and a symbiosis in their commodities sectors, especially their diamond industries.

DIAMONDS ARE FOREVER

Within a new business-friendly climate, public- and private-sector entities from the two sides moved to establish the kind of relations that had remained off-limits. Leading the way were the Dubai and Israel Diamond Exchanges. In September 2020 the latter opened its doors in Dubai as its counterpart, the Dubai Multi Commodities Center, set up a sales office at the Israel Diamond Exchange in Tel Aviv.[13] Characteristic of the views among many Israeli business owners, the president of the Israel Diamond Exchange, Yoram Dvash, celebrated the accords for potentially providing Israel's diamond industry with a pathway into Saudi Arabia, Oman, and "other Arab countries that Israel, until today, could not reach."[14] Israeli media sources further noted the natural symbiosis between the two industries: as of 2020, Dubai was exporting $21.2 billion in mostly raw, uncut diamonds annually, while Israel exported $10.7 billion in mostly finished, consumer-ready products. Enabling direct trade would play to each side's comparative advantage. Although firms from Israel and the UAE had previously worked together, the absence of diplomatic relations means that most of their trade had taken place through shell companies or middlemen in Switzerland and Belgium, driving up the cost of business.

The accords could not have come at a better time for Israel's diamond industry. Over the past decade it had posted declining numbers in the face of rising competition from places like India. Israel

had also faced competition from the UAE itself when it came to exporting finished diamonds, especially after the opening of the world's largest diamond trading floor in September 2019 at the Dubai Diamond Exchange.[15] While industries in both states suffered setbacks from the pandemic, Dubai's diamond industry was mostly headed in an opposite direction, with the UAE rising to become one of the top three exporters of diamonds globally in 2020.[16]

Direct access to Dubai's market provided a new source of revenue for Israel's diamond merchants. By 2021 diamonds constituted a massive 70 percent of all Israeli exports to the UAE, totaling $700 million.[17] The uptick in trade enabled Israel's diamond industry to record a significant recovery, with the state registering "$2.94 billion in diamond imports for 2021 (a 91 percent increase from the previous year), and $3.65 billion in exports (a 54 percent increase)." Analysts in Israel partially attributed the pace of the recovery to Israel's new ties with the UAE, for "breathing fresh life" into the ailing luxury sector.[18] The new relationship also proved valuable to Dubai, further propelling it as a new global capital of the diamond trade and enabling it to overtake Belgium as the largest trading hub for rough diamonds in the world.[19] By 2022 the diamond trade between the two sides would more than double from the previous year, reaching $1.75 billion.[20]

HEALTHCARE

The healthcare sector emerged as another lucrative source of bilateral trade between the two sides, with Emirati firms taking the lead in importing medical technology from Israel. The first partnerships emerged before the accords had even been formally signed. On August 16, 2020, the UAE's Apex National Investment Company entered an agreement with an Israeli nanotechnology firm for cooperation on the development of a COVID-19 testing device.[21] The next

day Israel's Pluristem Technologies announced a partnership with Abu Dhabi Stem Cells Centre to develop disease therapies to fight the pandemic.[22] Later that month health ministers from both sides announced their plans to cooperate in medical research and vaccine trials, to boost progress against the pandemic.[23] Other initiatives followed. In September 2020 an Israeli healthcare software developer announced a partnership with a firm headed by one of the sons of President Khalifa bin Zayed Al Nahyan to jointly market an "internet of things" healthcare product regionally.[24] In December 2020 Israel's MediWound signed an agreement with the UAE's Ghassan Aboud Group to distribute a pineapple-based gel to treat burn victims.[25] And in April 2021 UAE media sources announced the opening of Aviv Clinics, a UAE-Israeli anti-ageing healthcare center in Dubai, calling it the first joint healthcare venture.[26] It is prominently positioned in Jumeirah Lake Towers along Dubai's main highway, Sheikh Zayed Road. Israel's Sheba Medical Center also announced a partnership with a Dubai healthcare group to bring Israeli doctors to Dubai for diagnostic consultations. Sheba Medical noted that it had already provided services to hundreds of diabetes patients serving in the UAE's military and police forces during an earlier round of consultation services, billing it as a step in the center's aim to set up a permanent presence in the country.[27]

ENERGY

The UAE made some of its largest investments in Israel's energy sector as part of its long-term plans to grow its stakes in the renewable and nonrenewable sectors and become a major energy player in regions beyond the Gulf, like the Mediterranean Sea. Cooperation got off to a shaky start when the first planned energy agreement, between an Israeli state-owned pipeline company (Europe-Asia Pipeline

Company) and a joint UAE-Israeli venture (Med-Red Land Bridge Ltd), failed to get off the ground. The two sides had planned to build a land bridge through Israel, to allow tankers to transport oil from the Red Sea port of Eilat to the Mediterranean coast, where the oil could be shipped directly to Europe. The land bridge would have created a possibly transformative pathway to move oil globally by linking producers and consumers from Europe to the East.[28] But Israel's environmental protection minister, Tamar Zandberg, blocked plans for its development, citing concerns about its impact on a coral reef in Eilat and noting that his country would not act as "a bridge to polluting oil, in an era of climate crisis."[29]

The next planned energy agreement moved ahead with fewer setbacks. In April 2021 an Israeli energy oil and gas partnership, NewMed Drilling (late renamed Delek Drilling LP), announced plans to sell shares in Israel's Tamar offshore natural gas field to Mubadala Petroleum, a subsidiary of Abu Dhabi's largest sovereign wealth fund. The two sides finalized the $1.025 billion deal in September 2021, providing Mubadala Petroleum with a 22 percent stake in the gas field and partial ownership of an important Israeli strategic asset.[30] The *Wall Street Journal* reported that the deal would also establish the UAE as another influential player—alongside Cyprus, Egypt, Greece, Turkey, and Israel—scrambling to assert influence over the Mediterranean's gas fields.

The UAE also used the accords to expand its diplomatic footprint, by brokering agreements between Israel and other Arab states. On November 22, 2021, Abu Dhabi negotiated an agreement between Israel and Jordan to swap solar energy produced for water. Under its terms, Jordan agreed to construct a solar power plant to generate electricity for Israel, in exchange for Israel's development of a desalination plant, to send water to Jordan. The deal also provided Abu Dhabi with construction rights for Jordan's plant.[31] After mediating the terms of the exchange, the UAE hosted a signing ceremony at Dubai's Expo

2020, in a further flex of its soft power. The agreement came months after Israel began exporting natural gas to Egypt through a new route via Jordan's Aqaba port, enabling it to increase the quantities exported to Egypt by more than 50 percent.[32] The CEO of NewMed Drilling, Yossi Abu, told Reuters: "A huge deal with a company from the UAE, alongside exporting gas to Egypt and Jordan, are actions on the ground and exactly how to build a new Middle East."[33]

Cooperation agreements between the two sides also encompassed clean energy and renewables, one of the UAE's priority areas for growth. The UAE has put in place measures to advance these plans, including by pledging to invest $163 billion in global renewable energy projects, setting up a nuclear power plant in Abu Dhabi, and announcing a nationwide goal to achieve net-zero emissions by 2050.[34] It has also worked to advance its reputation as a global leader on climate change, by hosting the annual Conference of the Parties (COP) in 2023. New agreements with Israeli energy firms would feed into these objectives. In February 2022 Israel's Electric Company, one of the largest energy suppliers in Israel and the Palestinian territories, entered an agreement with Energroup, a consortium of energy companies based in Dubai, to bring clean hydrogen energy to the UAE. Months later, Abu Dhabi's Department of Energy announced it was in talks with Israel to boost state-based cooperation in developing renewable energy.[35]

AGRICULTURE AND WATER

The Gulf states are among the most food insecure countries in the world and import between 80 and 90 percent of their food supplies. They also struggle with some of the lowest absolute and per inhabitant water resources globally. For example, while the region is home to 4.25 percent of the globe's population, it holds just 1.1 percent of all

renewable water resources, with rapid population growth posing a further strain on existing supplies.[36] All six Gulf states rely primarily on desalination to meet their water needs, a process that involves stripping salt from seawater and pouring the concentrated brine back into the sea. Over time, the process has made the Gulf's waters saltier and desalination costlier and more complicated, with scientists predicting that the region may soon reach "peak salt," a point at which desalination becomes unfeasible due to the high salt concentrations in the water.[37]

Beginning in the early 2000s, the Gulf states began expending billions of dollars on improving their food and water security. States like the UAE and Qatar also took the lead in purchasing large tracts of agricultural lands in fertile areas abroad, to reduce their dependence on imports. By 2022 Al Dahra Holding, a subsidiary of Abu Dhabi holding company ADQ, acquired 300,000 acres of agricultural land across the globe, an area equivalent to the size of Hong Kong. Other acquisitions by state-backed and private equity firms in the UAE included 1.2 million hectares of land in the Philippines, 800,000 acres of land in Pakistan, and over 400,000 hectares in Sudan.[38] The so-called land grabs would come under fire by agricultural experts and activists for depriving low-income states from their own farmlands and worsening their food insecurity.[39] The UAE also invested in the world's largest food and fertilizer producers. In 2021 ADQ acquired a majority share in the food commodity giant Louis Dreyfus. The following year Abu Dhabi National Oil Company (ADNOC) joined hands with a Dutch fertilizer producer to form the largest export-focused nitrogen fertilizer platform in the world, granting the UAE a major stake in the production of another vital agricultural resource.[40]

With over half of its internationally recognized territory made up of desert terrain, Israel shares several of the same challenges as the Gulf states when it comes to agriculture and water shortages. Israel has long touted its superior technology in helping "make the desert

bloom," one of its foundational narratives. The phrase has long drawn irritation from Palestinians, who argue the destruction of vast swathes of olive groves by Israeli settlers and Israel's restriction of Palestinian access to water in the occupied territories (a practice forming subject of the Amnesty International report "The Occupation of Water" in 2017) are neither equitable nor helpful to the environment. Israel used its presence at Dubai's Expo 2020 to tout its accomplishments in green agricultural technology, with a hologram host telling the audience:

> Four thousand students come to Israel annually to participate in agriculture training programs that help them become entrepreneurs. Despite the desert conditions, agriculture flourishes and we share this knowledge with over thirty countries. Over 60 percent of the fresh produce that Israel exports globally is grown in extreme desert conditions. Israel is a world leader in water loss prevention, half of water used in agriculture is recycled, and 80 percent of drinking water is desalinated sea water. We don't keep this to ourselves! Since its establishment, Israel has lent support to states across the world, especially developing countries. Israel's aid agency has connections with over 140 states, from the largest states like China and India, to tiny states in the Pacific.[41]

The UAE used its new ties to Israel to advance cooperation on water treatment and desalination. In December 2020 Israel's Fluence, a start-up specializing in decentralized wastewater treatment solutions, signed a trilateral agreement with an Emirati firm and an international supplier to develop centralized wastewater treatment plants in the UAE. The new plants enabled Dubai's wastewater to be treated within the city instead of at distant treatment sites, cutting down on the government's costs. The CEO of Fluence, Yaron Bar-Tal, told media sources that he hoped to expand his business deeper into the Gulf and bring the new water treatment technology

to GCC states like Saudi Arabia.[42] The partnership is exactly the kind the UAE hopes to foster. That same month, the UAE's minister of energy, Suhail Al Mazrouei, announced that Abu Dhabi had invested $2.08 billion in desalination plants to upgrade its water supply sector, in line with the country's 2036 Water Security Strategy.[43]

Israel and the UAE also expanded their collaborations in agriculture. On January 21, 2021, an Israeli start-up specializing in indoor agricultural production signed an agreement with Emirates Smart Solution and Technology to set up a pilot vertical farm ahead of a countrywide rollout. Like others before him, the CEO of Vertical Field noted that he hoped to expand the venture to other Gulf states.[44] Other partnerships included an agreement between Abu Dhabi's Al Dahra Holding Company and Watergen, an Israeli developer of "water-from-air solutions," to import devices to extract water from the air, with each device capable of providing six thousand liters of clean drinking water per day.[45] The agreement laid the groundwork for the establishment of a water studies institute in Abu Dhabi between a sister company of Al Dahra Holding and the Moshe Mirilashvli Institute for Applied Water Studies at Tel Aviv University.[46]

Bahrain also acted to procure Israeli agricultural and desalination technology. In March 2021 the state-owned Electricity and Water Authority signed a $3 million agreement with its Israeli counterpart, Mekorot, to assist Manama in developing advanced desalination technology and new desalination plants, and more efficiently exploiting its natural water sources. The two entities later announced plans to expand the scope of the agreement to $11 million. Remarking on the deal, Israel's energy and water minister Yuval Steinitz noted that "the four countries that have signed peace agreements in the framework of the Abraham Accords suffer, like us, from a water shortage, so innovative solutions from Mekorot and Israeli high-tech companies can serve as a strong basis for cooperation and for strengthening ties."[47]

EDUCATION AND RESEARCH

Universities and research institutes on both sides also forged new ties. On September 15, 2020, Abu Dhabi's Mohammed bin Zayed University of Artificial Intelligence (MBZUAI) signed a memorandum of understanding with Israel's Weizmann Institute of Science to promote student exchange programs and conferences and share computing resources. The two sides reached the agreement just months before MBZUAI opened its doors as the world's first "graduate-level, research-based artificial intelligence university," offering master's- and doctoral-level programs in technology and machine learning.[48] Academic libraries also announced joint initiatives with the Younes and Suraya Nazarian Library at the University of Haifa entering a cooperative agreement with Abu Dhabi's National Library and Archives to establish a visiting program of experts, promote exchanges of archival research, and carry out joint events.[49] Abu Dhabi's library also inked a three-year agreement with the National Library of Israel, a library located on the Givat Ram campus of the Hebrew University of Jerusalem, which holds one of the largest collections of Israeli and Jewish manuscripts worldwide, to carry out digitization and joint workshops.[50]

Research institutes on both sides followed suit. On October 15, 2021, the Atlantic Council, a think tank in Washington, DC, joined hands with Abu Dhabi's Emirates Policy Center and Tel Aviv's Institute for National Security Studies to announce a trilateral strategic partnership aimed at fostering dialogue and deepening understanding of issues of mutual concern, usually suggesting discussions of shared security interests. Together, the three think tanks also announced the launch of a joint conference on Gulf-Israel relations, to discuss opportunities and challenges for advancing relations across the region, including their shared threat from Iran.[51] Bahrain also

enacted its own partnerships, including between the Bahrain Center for Strategic, International, and Energy Studies and Israel's Institute for National Security Studies, to establish closer research ties and joint programs.[52]

NOT JUST ISRAEL: TRADE WITH THE SETTLEMENTS

As the Gulf states opened their doors to Israel, the UAE also welcomed trade with Israeli settlements in the occupied West Bank and Golan Heights. The move showed how far the UAE had come from its initial claims that the accords were intended to stop annexation and effectively prevent Palestinian lands from being occupied by the same settlers that were now being welcomed to the Emirates.

On November 11, 2020, a group of business figures from the Samaria Regional Council, an entity that represents thirty-five Israeli settlements in the northern West Bank, landed in Dubai for "marathon" business meetings.[53] The delegation was headed by Yossi Dagan, chair of the council and one of the most recognized faces of the settler movement.[54] Dagan gained notoriety for leading Homesh First, an organization that lobbied for the resettlement and reconstruction of the Homesh settlement, which was built on private Palestinian lands in 1978. The Israeli military had forcibly evacuated and demolished the settlement in 2005, as part of Prime Minister Sharon's disengagement from Gaza and limited parts of the West Bank. But the settlers had forcefully resisted the government's attempts to expel them from territory and returned to the area time and time again in the following years to reestablish their presence.

As a settlement advocate, Dagan spent his career working to support efforts to resurrect the dismantled settlements and outposts,

insisting that God had given the land to the Jewish people. As late as 2021, the Israel Defense Forces reported that they had once again demolished structures around the former site of Homesh, built by settlers who refused to abandon their claims to it.[55] For the Palestinian inhabitants of the area, it was not only the settlers' territorial claims that posed an issue. In 2019 they reported at least thirty-one incidents of violence from settlers, including against a shepherd who had incurred a broken skull after settlers threw rocks at him.[56] The attacks formed part of a documented pattern of violence. In 2021 the United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA) cataloged 410 attacks by settlers against Palestinians in the West Bank, including attacks involving the use of live ammunition and torching of their fields and livestock.[57] The actual figure is likely higher, as settler violence often goes unreported by Palestinians, who say that Israeli does little to stop the attacks or bring perpetrators to justice. In 2019 an Israeli human rights organization, Yesh Din, corroborated their claims, reporting that 91 percent of Israeli investigations into settler attacks against Palestinians made over a fourteen-year window were closed by the Israeli authorities, with no charges filed.[58]

While all settlements in the West Bank are illegal under international law, Israel divides them into two categories: those it recognizes, and those it does not.[59] The distinction has practical implications: Israel builds road networks and provides utility services to settlements it recognizes, and it leaves those it does not recognize, the so-called wildcat outposts, off its grids. Settlers have few incentives to stop developing new outposts, as several governments have provided them with retroactive authorization. Netanyahu adopted an especially lenient approach, by supporting their growth and courting settlers as an electoral demographic.[60] By the end of his presidency, Barack Obama openly clashed with Netanyahu, demanding he stop their expansion. He also allowed the passage of a United Nations Security Council Resolution describing them as a violation of international

law. But Trump took an opposite approach, tearing up U.S. policy that classified the settlements as illegal at the insistence of advisors like David Friedman, while turning a blind eye to their expansion.[61]

The pace of settlement construction in the West Bank more than doubled under the Trump presidency, as Israel approved plans for more than twenty-seven thousand settler homes during his four-year term, bringing the numbers of settlers in the West Bank and Jerusalem closer to seven hundred thousand.[62] Yet even the prime minister's approach proved too dovish for settlement advocates like Dagan. In 2021 he led protests and a hunger strike outside Netanyahu's home, demanding that the prime minister recognize seventy wildcat outposts, home to twenty-five thousand settlers, and told reporters that the denial of equal recognition to all settlers sent a message of encouragement to Israel's enemies.[63]

As news of the Abraham Accords broke, Dagan took the opportunity to criticize Netanyahu once more, accusing him of betrayal for trading his promises to annex the West Bank for peace with an Arab state. But the lure of economic opportunity spurred a change in Dagan's thinking. On landing in Dubai in November 2020, he praised the UAE's leadership, adding that it was "an honor" to forge trade ties with a country at the "forefront of development and investment."[64] His visit helped lay the groundwork for new partnerships between the two sides, including between FAM Holdings—an Emirati business conglomerate—and companies based in the settlements, for the sale of tahini, olive oil, honey, and wines from settlement wineries.[65] In December 2020 Dagan returned to the Emirates, this time to attend a ceremony at the Dubai headquarters of FAM Holdings, where its CEO Dr. Faisal Ali Mousa described the trade milestone as one he "could never have imagined or dreamed about."[66]

At first, Bahrain appeared ready to adopt the same approach. On December 3, 2020, Minister of Industry and Commerce Zayed al-Zayani announced that Bahrain would not distinguish between

imports from Israel and those made in West Bank settlements, telling reporters his country would treat Israeli products as Israeli products. "We have no issue with labelling or origin," he added.[67] Although the minister backtracked on his pledge two days later, following widespread criticism from pro-Palestinian activists in Bahrain, his initial statement signaled Manama's willingness to follow the UAE in abandoning past claims of solidarity with the Palestinians against occupation, in favor of stronger ties with Israel's most extreme factions.[68]

The UAE's decision to allow trade with Israeli settlements showed how quickly things had changed. Three years earlier, in 2017, an editorial in a Sharjah-based newspaper slammed the expansion of settlements as illegal and as an obstacle to peace efforts. The Emirates News Agency carried approving coverage of the editorial, citing a passage that called on the international community to "take serious note of the fact that Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has unabashedly pledged to build thousands of new homes in a major West Bank settlement," and another that called on Arabs and Palestinians to unite more strongly against Israel's atrocities.[69] The UAE's willingness to trade with the settlements would also go against a growing international settlement boycott, which attracted the support of the city of Oslo, U.S. ice cream producer Ben and Jerry's, and the UN Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights, which endorsed the movement by publishing a list of corporations with ties to the settlements.[70]

As the UAE opened its doors to trade with Israel's settlements, its decision appeared to hold mostly symbolic value for the Gulf state. David Rosenberg, business editor at Israel's *Haaretz* newspaper, noted that the settlers who had traveled to the UAE largely represented state-owned development companies that were "not engaged in anything that could be exported." Others, he noted, represented "tiny businesses that have factories in the West Bank, but are headquartered in Israel." In making his case that the settlers had little to offer the UAE in the way of business opportunities, he

added that trading with industries in the West Bank amounted to "small change" for the UAE. "They're not the kind of businesses that are going to whet the appetite of Gulf investors, even if Emiratis are willing to ignore the politics," he concluded.[71] While trading with the settlements made little difference to the fifth-largest economy in the MENA region, the matter held far greater importance to the settlement enterprises. In the face of a growing international boycott of their goods, mounting criticism from intergovernmental organizations, and some pressure from activists within Israel calling for an end to the occupation, the establishment of a new trade corridor with a wealthy Gulf state provided them with a new source of revenue to sustain their economies of occupation, in addition to an unquestionable symbolic victory.

THE GCC BOYCOTT

One of the earliest accomplishments of the Gulf Cooperation Council was the formation of a Free Trade Area in 1983, enabling goods from all six states to be traded internally without customs or tariff barriers. When it came to Israel, matters were simplified by the fact that all six states participated in a shared boycott, leaving no avenues for Israeli goods to enter through the common market. But the Abraham Accords complicated matters, opening the doors for Israeli goods that had made their way to the UAE and Bahrain—or those produced in those states by Israeli firms, or relying on Israeli components—to find their way to the rest of the Gulf states, in contravention of the boycott laws.

Faced with a rupture in the joint Gulf position, Kuwait's parliament acted first, by doubling down on its boycott of Israel and passing a bill setting out prison terms and heightened fines for citizens found dealing with, traveling to, or even expressing verbal sympathy with Israel.[72] Next, Kuwait's government hosted a regional meeting

of Arab boycott offices in July 2021, reaffirming its commitment to the cause.[73] Oman's parliament took similar steps in 2022, passing a bill to strengthen an existing ban on athletic, cultural, and economic collaborations with Israel, and further criminalizing online and in-person interactions with Israelis.[74] But weeks after the parliament made its stance known, Oman's leadership opened up the country's airspace to Israeli flights, revealing differences between a civic refusal to move toward normalization and a more lenient state policy.

Saudi Arabia would adopt a more complex policy that maintained some aspects of its boycott and loosened others. In 2021 it enacted a decree prohibiting the application of GCC tariff concessions on goods containing components made by Israel and those produced by companies owned by Israelis. The decree appeared intended to target products made by Israeli corporations with a presence in either the UAE or Bahrain. While the decree did not entirely ban products made by these entities from entering its market, it subjected them to a less preferential tariff scheme, in the context of an ongoing Saudi boycott of all goods coming from Israel.[75] By late 2022 Saudi Arabia appeared to move closer toward normalization by opening its doors to athletes to compete on its soil, all the while reaffirming its commitment to the Arab Peace Initiative as a framework for Arab-Israeli relations and formally rejecting the possibility of normalization without Palestinian statehood.[76] By 2023 Saudi Arabia began talks with the Biden administration on the possibility of establishing formal relations, reflecting a further evolution in its posture. Only Qatar took no additional steps, beyond maintaining its existing boycott.

THE POLITICAL RELATIONSHIP

As the UAE and Israel deepened their trade ties, their new relationship faced setbacks. First came logistical challenges.[77] With plans for

Netanyahu's visit to Abu Dhabi in the works since November 2020, the pandemic forced its postponement to December, then to January, and finally February 2021, when the visit was canceled amid a countrywide lockdown in Israel. By March 2021 it appeared that the trip might go ahead, before parliamentary elections scheduled for later that month. But the prime minister again canceled his visit, citing delays in Jordan's approval of his flight path over the Hashemite Kingdom. For his part, Netanyahu had hoped that the visit would take place before the latest round of elections in Israel, scheduled for May 2021, and remind voters of his role as the first Israeli prime minister to deliver peace with multiple Arab states without making any concessions to the Palestinians. In his campaign speeches, Netanyahu went further: taking personal credit for Mohammed bin Zayed's decision to establish a $10 billion investment fund in Israel (which the crown prince had announced a week earlier, on March 12) and warning that the funds might be conditional on his reelection.[78]

ACCUSATIONS OF ELECTIONEERING

Netanyahu's unabashed strategy soon placed his relationship with the UAE under strain, with Israeli media reporting in mid-March 2021 that senior Emirati officials had canceled a planned summit between the prime minister, senior U.S. officials, and other Arab leaders from the normalizing states.[79] As Israeli media carried news of the cancellation, Anwar Gargash, the former UAE minister of state for foreign affairs and a senior diplomatic advisor to the president, published an unusually candid statement, noting: "From the UAE's perspective, the purpose of the Abrahamic Accords is to provide a robust strategic foundation to foster peace and prosperity with the State of Israel and in the wider region. The UAE will not be a part in any internal electioneering in Israel, now or ever."[80] The UAE's minister of industry

and advanced technology, Dr. Sultan Al Jaber, weighed in next, noting that the planned $10 billion investment fund in Israel was at a "preliminary stage of being considered," and that it would be "economically motivated, and not based on politics."[81] Another Emirati official told CNN: "The UAE signed the Accords for the hope and opportunities they provide our people, not individual leaders."[82] Mohammed bin Zayed proceeded to freeze the planned investment fund, claiming he wanted Israeli politics to "stabilize" before releasing any capital.[83] Faced with a mounting backlash from the UAE, Netanyahu doubled down on his approach as the exclusive arbiter of relations with the Gulf state, by reportedly forbidding members of his government from traveling to the UAE until he had made an official state visit first.[84]

VIOLENCE IN GAZA

The outbreak of a new round of violence in Jerusalem and Gaza presented another challenge to the nascent relationship. Tensions between Israel and the Palestinians began escalating during the Muslim holy month of Ramadhan in April 2021, when Israeli police installed barricades at Jerusalem's Damascus Gate, preventing Palestinians from congregating in the area. It soon became the site of confrontations between Palestinians and far-right Israelis who arrived to the site chanting "death to Arabs."[85] After several nightly clashes injured dozens of Palestinians, the UAE's Foreign Ministry called on Israeli authorities to "assume responsibility toward de-escalation" and preserve Jerusalem's historical identity, a statement that alluded to Israel's growing control over Arab areas in occupied East Jerusalem.[86] Israeli police lifted the barricades days later, but the move did little to reduce the rising Palestinian protests.

Matters escalated further the following week, when Palestinian activists began protesting an upcoming ruling by Israel's Supreme Court, widely expected to uphold the eviction of six Palestinian families from their homes in East Jerusalem's Sheikh Jarrah neighborhood.[87] Their plight had emerged as a rallying point against the kinds of legally sanctioned evictions that cost dozens of Palestinian families their homes in the area and forcibly displaced others before them. Faced with another wave of protests in the Al-Aqsa Compound, or Temple Mount Complex, an area of immense significant to Jews and Muslims, Israeli security forces stormed the area, to dispel protesters. That day, the Palestinian Red Crescent reported over two hundred injuries among Palestinians. Israel also reported that seventeen police officers had been wounded in the clashes.[88] In response to the mounting violence, Bahrain's Ministry of Foreign Affairs condemned the attack and called on the Israeli government to "stop these rejected provocations against the people of Jerusalem, and work to prevent its forces from attacking worshipers in the holy month." The statement also criticized Israel's planned evictions in East Jerusalem, calling it a move that undermined regional stability.[89]

On May 10, 2021, Hamas stepped in, issuing Israel an ultimatum to withdraw its remaining security forces from the complex. When the deadline passed without a response, the militant group ramped up its deployment of rockets from the Gaza Strip into Israel, sending up to 150 rockets in a single day. Most were intercepted by Israel's air defenses, but they triggered a reprisal.[90] Over the course of eleven days, Israeli forces bombarded the besieged Gaza Strip, killing at least 260 people and injuring nearly two thousand others, before agreeing to a ceasefire brokered by Egypt.[91] During the same period, rockets deployed by Hamas killed thirteen Israelis and seven Palestinians.[92] As criticism of Israel's actions mounted across the Arab world, the UAE issued a subdued response that did not allocate blame. Instead,

its minister of foreign affairs called on "all parties to commit to a ceasefire, initiate a political dialogue, and exercise maximum restraint."[93] The UAE's minister of state for international cooperation, Reem al-Hashimi, echoed the measured approach by calling for restraint and de-escalation.[94] The statements appeared especially muted when compared with those issued by pan-Arab, pan-Islamic organizations like the Organization of Islamic Cooperation, of which both the UAE and Bahrain are members, and which described Israel's attacks on Gaza as "barbaric" and blamed it for committing "systematic crimes" against the Palestinians.[95]

As officials in the UAE and Bahrain called on both sides to de-escalate, public figures took a more impassioned stance. Following news that Israel had flattened a building hosting the headquarters of the Associated Press in Gaza, a prominent Emirati commentator took to Twitter to mock Israel's claims to be the region's "only democracy."[96] Next, an Emirati academic who had until then avoided publicly criticizing the accords posted photos of injured Palestinian children on social media, accusing Israel of apartheid.[97] In Bahrain, criticism of Israel was more visible, with civic organizations holding demonstrations in support of the Palestinians and demanding the government walk back its agreement. At least one of the protests obtained the requisite licensing from the government, signaling its willingness to absorb some of the outcry.[98] The mood mirrored rising anger across the Arab world, leading some Israeli analysts to question whether Israel's actions in Gaza might place an "unbearable strain" on its new relations with the Gulf states.[99]

A RESHUFFLE IN ISRAEL

Israel's June 2021 elections brought welcome news for Netanyahu's opponents. After more than a decade in power, the prime minister

was finally ousted from his role. Far-right Minister of Defense Naftali Bennett would replace him, in rotation with opposition leader Yair Lapid, who became foreign minister. Bennett did not depart substantially from Netanyahu's approach toward the Palestinians and spoke of "shrinking the conflict" by marginally improving economic conditions for Palestinians in the West Bank, while authorizing the further expansion of settlements.[100] Just two weeks after the election, Lapid landed in the UAE to inaugurate the Israeli Embassy in Abu Dhabi and its consulate in Dubai. By traveling to the UAE as one of his first orders of business, the foreign minister signaled that a change of guard would not alter Abu Dhabi's status as a diplomatic priority.

With the violence of the Gaza war looming in recent memory, the UAE modified its approach toward Israel, tamping down its celebratory tone and shifting toward more sober messaging. In this context, the first visit by a senior Israeli official would turn out to be a sober affair. Upon landing in Abu Dhabi, Lapid was greeted at the airport by a junior minister rather than his counterpart, although the two foreign ministers did meet later. The UAE's official news agency would also keep his visit low profile by avoiding immediate reporting of his arrival and granting international media limited access, according to *Bloomberg*. Remarking on the approach, a prominent Emirati political science professor, Abdelkhaleq Abdulla, noted: "Israel would like to tout this as a historic visit, but evidently the UAE wants to keep it as low profile as possible and treat it like any other visit. The UAE's relationship with Israel is there, but this isn't the time to brag, after Gaza."[101]

The inauguration ceremonies were equally subdued. On June 30, 2021, Lapid tweeted a photo of himself at the embassy's opening ceremony in Abu Dhabi, standing alongside the UAE's minister of culture and youth, Noura al-Kaabi. No other Emirati officials were photographed at the event or listed as attendees. Still, Lapid used the occasion to deliver a message of confidence. "Israel wants peace with

all its neighbors," he declared. "We aren't going anywhere. We call on all the countries of the region to recognize that. And to come to talk to us," he added bluntly.[102] Next, Lapid traveled an hour down the road to inaugurate the consulate in Dubai. It would be another junior minister, the UAE's minister of state for artificial intelligence, Omar Sultan Al Olama, who greeted Lapid as the official representative at the event.[103]

One month later, Lapid visited Bahrain for the first time. The occasion was especially muted, in the context of security concerns sparked by planned protests.[104] Israel's bombardment of Gaza in 2021 had pushed the UAE and Bahrain to tamp down their celebratory tone toward Israel and issue carefully worded criticisms of its actions. Yet their rhetoric made little impact on the overall trajectory of normalization, or on Israel's leaders, who found themselves under no real pressure to choose between peace with the Palestinians and their new ties with the Gulf states. The precedent would repeat itself in strikingly similar form in late 2023, in the context of Israel's much more destructive bombardment of Gaza.

SPYWARE REVELATIONS

Two months after the 2021 Gaza war, a series of new revelations would bring Israel back into the headlines. On July 18 an investigation by a consortium of journalists detailed the proliferation of NSO spyware to at least forty governments across the globe. The revelations showed how an array of democratic and nondemocratic governments worldwide had used the organization's sophisticated wiretap system, Pegasus, to secretly hack into the mobile devices of journalists, human rights activists, and dissidents, as well as diplomats and government officials.

In England, Pegasus targets encompassed multiple public figures with connections to the UAE. They included Fiona Shackleton, a

lawyer representing Princess Haya (then wife of Dubai's ruler Sheikh Mohammed bin Rashid Al Maktoum), in a prolonged and bitter custody battle with the sheikh. They also included Sheikh Mohammed's daughter, Princess Latifa, who attempted to flee Dubai in 2018; Matthew Hedges, a British academic detained in the UAE on spying charges; and Roula Khalaf, the editor of Britain's *Financial Times*. In its reporting, the *Guardian* identified the UAE as the principal government responsible for selecting the UK numbers listed as Pegasus targets. Investigations would also suggest that Crown Prince Mohammed bin Zayed of Abu Dhabi, as well as Mohammed bin Rashid, ruler of Dubai, had acquired the spyware separately from each other, without the other's knowledge. Although earlier reports from 2016 had revealed the UAE's reported use of NSO spyware to track dissidents like Ahmed Mansour, the most recent round of revelations detailed the extent of its usage by a broader array of governments, against a much wider range of targets.

This time, the extent of the revelations provoked a backlash against NSO Group, prompting the U.S. Department of Commerce to blacklist the organization and the European Parliament to create a new committee to investigate abuses of the spyware by at least five of its member states.[105] By October 2021, and after a UK court determined that the ruler of Dubai had used it to hack into his ex-wife's phone, NSO Group cut its ties with the UAE, citing improper use of its software.[106] Still, the episode brought to light the growing reliance of Gulf leaders on Israeli technology to track and monitor a range of targets, and the lack of oversight over their clandestine dealings.

NEGOTIATING A RETURN TO THE JCPOA

The election of Joe Biden as president of the United States in November 2020 brought with it a cooling in the candid and unusually close relationship between America and its Gulf partners. Instead, Biden

vowed to isolate Saudi Arabia's crown prince for his human rights record and promised to bring the United States back to a nuclear deal with Iran, raising fears in the Gulf states toward a resurgent Tehran. When it came to Saudi Arabia, Biden's promises reflected growing calls within the Democratic Party to hold Mohammed bin Salman personally accountable for the murder of Saudi journalist Jamal Khashoggi and the conflict in Yemen.

During his first months in office, Biden appeared to make good on his promises, by suspending the sale of offensive weaponry to Saudi Arabia and the UAE and removing the Huthis from the U.S. list of foreign terrorist organizations. He also appointed Rob Malley as U.S. special envoy to Iran, to lead his administration's efforts to restore the JCPOA. Malley had acted as a lead U.S. negotiator on the JCPOA under Obama and one of his top Middle East advisors.[107] The Gulf states publicly stood behind President Biden in his efforts to restore the deal, while calling on him to include provisions in the agreement to limit Iran's ballistic missile program and end its support for affiliated proxy groups like the Huthis. They also continued calling for a seat at the table and involvement in the talks.[108] During Biden's first weeks in office, and building on diplomatic progress made under President Trump, Qatar and the four blockading states entered the al-Ula Declaration, formally restoring diplomatic ties between them.

In April 2021 the Biden administration kicked off its first round of negotiations with Iranian officials in Vienna. Biden's team hoped for a quick return to the agreement, given that many of the original architects of the deal remained in their roles, especially Iranian foreign minister Javad Zarif. As negotiations stalled, Iranians went to the polls in June 2021, electing hard-line candidate Ebrahim Raisi.[109] Consistent with his electoral promises, Raisi adopted a tougher stance on the negotiations, demanding the United States accept fault for abandoning the deal and lift all sanctions imposed on Tehran since then. He also insisted that the United States commit not to renege on the agreement in the future, as a condition to the talks. The United

States would make its own demands, pressing Iran to commit to future talks, to broaden the scope of the discussions. With neither side willing to cede ground, they embarked on multiple rounds of dialogue, with little progress.[110]

As the nuclear talks continued, the UAE and Saudi Arabia began taking steps to de-escalate their relations with Tehran. The attacks of 2019 had triggered their fears of further reprisals and convinced leaders in both states of the urgent need for diplomacy. Their concerns were made more pronounced by their perception that even President Trump had not gone far enough in defending their interests after the attacks, and that they needed to solve matters directly. The economic pressures of the pandemic had further persuaded state leaders across the region of the need to cool their rivalries and prioritize economic growth. It was in this context that the UAE's national security advisor, Tahnoun bin Zayed, landed in Tehran on December 13, 2021, to meet with President Raisi. His visit took place amid growing efforts by the UAE's leadership to improve its relations with other regional rivals, including Turkey and Syria.[111] During the same period, Saudi Arabia entered its own bilateral dialogue with Iran, facilitated by Oman and Iraq.

In Israel, Prime Minister Bennett maintained Netanyahu's hawkish approach toward Tehran, warning global leaders not to give in to its "nuclear blackmail." His message was challenged by figures in Israel's security establishment—the Shin Bet and IDF—which emerged as "lone voices," calling for a return to the agreement as the least worst option to contain Iran.[112] Bennett's government would exert its available leverage to stop a revival of the agreement. In mid-December Defense Minister Benny Gantz traveled to the United States to meet with defense officials and discuss Israel's possible military action against Iran's nuclear facilities.[113] Next, he traveled to the UAE to meet with Crown Prince Mohammed bin Zayed, on his first official visit. In keeping with its policy of de-escalation, Abu Dhabi downplayed any mention of Tehran in its press briefings and emphasized

the purpose of the meeting as aimed at strengthening trade ties with Israel. Israeli media took a more candid approach, reporting that the two leaders had spoken at length about Iran's nuclear program and the 2019 tanker attacks, including during a private bilateral session that lasted over two and a half hours. Israel's media would also not hold back in explaining the UAE's more discreet approach, adding that the omission of any mention of Iran in their joint statement was not because the matter was not discussed, but out of sensitivity to "the UAE's need for diplomacy with Tehran."[114]

AID TO THE PALESTINIANS

As it grew its ties with Israel, the UAE maintained its channel to the Palestinians by continuing to fund their relief efforts. Initially, a drastic reduction in the UAE's aid to UNRWA (which fell from $53 million in 2019 to just $1 million in 2020) prompted speculation that the UAE was ending its aid to the Palestinians as part of its new overture to Israel.[115] At the time, the UAE had cut back on other international commitments, including its support of the United Nations relief efforts in Yemen, and refocused its aid efforts toward the provision of bilateral humanitarian relief tied to the pandemic.[116] But the UAE moved within closer reach of its past commitments by dispatching $10 million in medical supplies to Gaza in 2022 and pledging $20 million in aid to UNRWA in 2023, reflecting its intent to continue maintaining its relationships with both sides.[117]

DEFENSE RELATIONS

The UAE's defense engagements with Israel began cautiously. Early on, Iran had warned that any attempts by neighboring states to bring

the "Zionist entity" to its doorstep would reap instability for the entire region.[118] With the tanker attacks looming in recent memory, the UAE began developing defense ties indirectly, between its own quasi-public corporations and Israeli defense companies. As their exchanges grew more pronounced, Emirati officials maintained their narrative that the accords were intended to advance economic and cultural cooperation rather than a new militaristic alliance.

Reflecting the general direction of the UAE's engagements with Israel, defense and security ties between the two sides centered mostly on delivering Israeli technology to the UAE. As Dubai prepared to host Expo 2020, its ruler, Sheikh Mohammed bin Rashid Al Maktoum, approved an agreement between the government of Dubai and Israeli drone company Airobotics for the deployment of an autonomous drone fleet throughout the city, aimed at reducing emergence response times by its police forces from over four minutes to just one minute.[119] The new fleet would integrate drone video technology alongside the 300,000 security cameras already monitoring the movements of persons and goods in the Emirate.[120]

An Abu Dhabi–based defense conglomerate, EDGE Group, took the lead in bringing Israeli defense technology to the UAE. EDGE is one of the largest defense entities in the country, made up of private and governmental bodies, twenty-five subsidiary organizations, and thirteen thousand employees divided into sectors including missile defense, electronic warfare, and intelligence. In March 2021 the group signed an agreement with Israeli Aerospace Industries (IAI), Israel's largest aerospace and defense corporation, for the joint development of a customized, advanced, antidrone system capable of detecting and intercepting drones and other aerial threats.[121]

In November 2021 EDGE Group and IAI signed a second agreement, to jointly design modular-unmanned surface vessels (USVs). Effectively functioning as seafaring drones, the vessels have military applications that include "intelligence, surveillance, reconnaissance,

and mine detection."[122] Weeks later, the UAE, Bahrain, and Israel participated in their first joint public naval exercise, under the auspices of the United States Naval Forces Central Command (NAVCENT) in the Red Sea. An Israeli officer described the drill as aimed at countering Iran's regional "power projection."[123] During the first year of the relationship, the UAE and Bahrain acquired $853 million in arms from Israel, out of a total $11.4 billion in overall Israeli arms exports, providing the industry with a lucrative boost.[124]

A series of surprise attacks on the UAE acted as a fresh reminder of its vulnerability, accelerating its reliance on Israeli defense systems. On January 17, 2022, a drone and ballistic missile attack targeted an oil storage facility in Abu Dhabi, killing three workers. A week later a second missile attack targeted Abu Dhabi's Al Dhafra air base, which houses two thousand American service personnel, before being intercepted by American Patriot missiles.[125] The UAE intercepted a third missile attack on January 31, just hours after Israeli president Isaac Herzog landed in the country on his first official visit. Yemen's Huthi militias claimed responsibility for the first and third attacks, describing them as retaliation for Abu Dhabi's intensifying role in the conflict in Yemen.[126] A little-known Iraqi militia group claimed responsibility for the second attack, which it described as retaliation for the UAE's policies in Iraq and Yemen.[127] The attacks raised alert levels in Abu Dhabi, with Emirati officials interpreting all three incidents as coordinated acts of escalation orchestrated by Iran through its regional proxies.[128]

The attacks would bring to light the utility of Abu Dhabi's new relationship with Israel. Israeli officials were eager to put these benefits on clear display. Immediately after the first strike, Prime Minister Naftali Bennett stepped in to offer his support to Mohammed bin Zayed. He also dispatched of a delegation of Mossad officials to Abu Dhabi, to assist the UAE in gathering forensic intelligence. Visibly reeling from the assault, Emirati officials requested the purchase

of advanced missile defense and antidrone technology from Israel, including the "Iron Dome" and "David's Sling" systems that Israel uses to intercept rockets from Hamas in a deal that analysts estimated would have been worth approximately $3.5 billion. But Israeli officials refused the offer, citing concerns about the possibility of technology leakages to third parties.[129] Instead, they proposed selling alternatives, including SYPDER, an air defense system produced by Israeli defense manufacturer Rafael Advanced Defence Systems, which uses the same radar technology as Iron Dome and can track the kind of cruise missiles and drones that had passed through the UAE's THAAD and Patriot missile defense systems undetected. Israel also approved the sale of a modified version of its Barak Air Defence System manufactured by Israel Aerospace Industries, which is designed to defend against multiple airborne threats, including ballistic missiles and cruise missiles. On April 14, 2022, Israel began transferring the SYPDER systems to the UAE. It would begin transferring the Barak system that October.[130]

As Emirati leaders saw Israel rushing to their defenses, they perceived Washington as stalling, by taking two weeks to agree to replenish its missile defense interceptors.[131] Eventually, after the third attack, Secretary of Defense Lloyd Austin spoke with Mohammed bin Zayed and agreed to send the navy guided missile destroyer USS *Cole* as well as F-18 and F-22 fighter jets to the UAE to bolster its defense systems.[132] Against this backdrop, the Biden administration also refused to revisit its decision to remove the Huthis from the list of state sponsors of terrorism, leading Emirati officials to complain that unlike Israel, the United States was not doing enough to come to its defense. Later in February Mohammed bin Zayed refused to meet a top U.S. general, Kenneth McKenzie, in Abu Dhabi. One month later the UAE would abstain on a resolution tabled by the United States at the United Nations Security Council that condemned Russia's invasion of Ukraine.[133] Together, these actions reflected

growing consternation in the UAE toward what they saw as expressions of U.S. unreliability.

Rattled by the Huthi attacks, Bahrain began publicizing its new security engagements with Israel, showcasing a more confrontational policy of deterrence toward Iran. In February 2022 Bahrain's leaders welcomed Israel's defense minister Benny Gantz to Manama, where the two sides signed a defense collaboration memorandum to support their intelligence, military, and defense industrial collaboration.[134] That month Bahraini officials also announced that an Israeli Navy officer would be permanently stationed in the country, as a liaison to the U.S. Fifth Fleet.[135] Days later an undersecretary at Bahrain's Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Sheikh Abdullah bin Ahmed Al Khalifa, publicly acknowledged for the first time that Israel's intelligence agency maintained a presence in his country. Speaking to Defense Minister Gantz at the Munich Security Conference, Sheikh Abdullah announced: "There is intelligence cooperation between Bahrain and Israel. Mossad is in Bahrain and they're present in the region."[136] By the end of 2022, Bahrain, the UAE, and Morocco would account for 24 percent of Israel's entire arms exports for that year, amounting to $3 billion out of a total $12 billion.

While publicizing its security relationship with Israel, Bahrain also used the new relationship to sending a warning to domestic opposition movements. The date February 14 holds significance for Bahrain's opposition groups, marking the anniversary of its 2011 Arab Spring uprising. The government allows little room for annual commemorations and regularly targets activists who participate in them. On the eleventh anniversary of the uprising in 2022, Israeli prime minister Naftali Bennett landed in Manama on his first visit to the country, to meet with the king and crown prince. Speaking to Bahraini media outlets, Bennett declared that his country was "fighting Iran and its henchmen in the region," adding that Israel would "help its friends" who shared the same goal.[137] Activists interpreted his

message as a direct warning that the government now had Israel's support in targeting domestic activity deemed to be supported by Tehran. One activist drew parallels between Israel's treatment of the Palestinians and their own oppression, noting that the autocrats on both sides "deserved each other."[138]

THE NEGEV SUMMIT

In March 2022 Israel, its Arab partners, and the United States came together collectively for the first time at the Negev Summit, held at Sde Boker, the burial place of Israel's founding prime minister, David Ben Gurion. In attendance were foreign ministers from Israel, Bahrain, the UAE, Morocco, and Egypt, and Secretary of State Antony Blinken. The summit had reportedly been organized by Lapid at short notice, to lay the foundations of a regional security architecture aimed at "building deterrence against threats from the air and sea," a nod to developing a united front against Iran, especially in the wake of continued discussions to revive the nuclear deal.[139] The arrival of Arab ministers at the site—a symbol of Zionism and the state of Israel—was not lost on observers, who saw it as a clear endorsement of Israel's Zionist ideology. The summit's date was also significant, falling on the twentieth anniversary of the Arab League's adoption of the Arab Peace Initiative, and serving as a further reminder of how far the tide had shifted in Israel's favor when it came to its recognition by the Arabs.

For the Gulf states in attendance, the meeting provided them with an opportunity to press U.S. representatives for greater security commitments. Together with Israel's foreign minister, they called on the Biden administration not to concede to Iran's demand that the United States de-list its Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps from its Foreign Terrorist Organization list, as a condition for returning to the nuclear

deal. Remarking on the summit, Bahrain's minister of foreign affairs, Abdellatif Al Zayani, noted that growing attacks on Gulf states by the Huthi militias as well as the need to "resolve the Iranian nuclear file" made the need to join forces with Israel "more urgent than ever."[140] The Biden administration pursued its own objectives, urging its Gulf partners to support its efforts to isolate Russia in the wake of its invasion of Ukraine and increase their oil production to stabilize global energy prices. The issue of the Palestinians was raised only by Blinken and Egypt's foreign minister, who called on Israel to resume diplomacy with the Palestinian leadership.[141] Saudi media sources echoed their support for the summit, describing it as part of a new front to enhance coordination against a shared threat.[142]

The UAE's public messaging was noteworthy for what it did and did not carry. Remarking on the gathering, the Minister of Foreign Affairs Abdullah bin Zayed noted that the parties aimed to cooperate and promote values of "peace, coexistence and tolerance across the world." Characteristic of past UAE public messaging, the brief statement released by the Emirates News Agency mentioned the term "peace" seven times and did not make a single reference to Tehran. At the summit, bin Zayed delivered the same message, noting that the gathering provided an opportunity for both sides to "get to know each other."[143] Other Emirati officials openly dismissed the idea that the summit had anything to do with Iran. In a tweet published just days after the summit, the UAE's former minister of state for foreign affairs and a diplomatic advisor to President Anwar Gargash noted that his country was "distancing itself from discourses of confrontation and polarization with Iran," insisting that its approach was "to build bridges and promote stability." "Diplomatic communication and economic cooperation are how we deal with the challenges of the past and the ambitions of the future. Hear it from the Emirates, and not about it," Gargash concluded emphatically.[144]

Israel and the UAE continued to maintain divergent narratives on their bilateral cooperation, in line with their posturing, and the UAE's commitment to a process of de-escalation with Tehran. In December 2022 the heads of cyber agencies from Morocco, Bahrain, the UAE, and Israel gathered publicly for the first time, at an interregional conference on cybersecurity held in Manama. At the summit, Gabi Portnoy, director-general of Israel's National Cyber Directorate, described the aim of the meeting as enhancing cooperation "against our common enemies." The UAE did not issue a statement.[145]

THE UNITED STATES AND A NEW REGIONAL SECURITY ARCHITECTURE

The Abraham Accords transformed the U.S. approach to the Middle East. Across decades, it had had to silo its defense relationship with Israel from the multitude of Arab states hostile to it. But the accords opened the doors to direct military coordination between Israel and the Gulf signatories and triggered bipartisan efforts to bring Israel into direct security coordination with the remainder of the United States' Arab partners, including the states that still did not recognize it. The push for closer multilateral integration served several objectives for Washington, enabling it to advance a more efficient defense policy among its partners, to strengthen their defenses against Iran, and to delegate a greater share of its security burden to them at a time when it looked to downsize its regional footprint. Past U.S. administrations had urged the Gulf states to integrate their missile defense systems as a crucial step toward advancing their ability to detect and intercept airborne threats. But these efforts proved unsuccessful, mostly because of a lack of trust among the Gulf states. This

time, the United States held the institutional capacity to make concrete advancements in laying out the building blocks of closer integration among its most important regional partners.

The foundations of a new arrangement were set into motion with the Trump administration's decision to move Israel from the European zone of command to CENTCOM. Israel's presence in the European Command never made sense from a geographic or strategic perspective, but it had proven necessary in the face of a refusal by the Arab states to cooperate with it. The move held practical payoffs for Israel, facilitating its ability to coordinate intelligence exchanges and carry out joint aerial operations with other CENTCOM states. It also facilitated closer cooperation between Israel and the U.S. Fifth Fleet and improved Israel's ability to coordinate military and air operations with the United States in places like Syria, where both states are involved.[146]

U.S. lawmakers lent their support to integration efforts. In 2022 the House and Senate approved the Deterring Enemy Forces and Enabling National Defenses (or "DEFEND") Act, which aims to establish an integrated air defense system among Israel, the six Gulf states, Egypt, Jordan, and Iraq.[147] Early conversations among lawmakers in Washington suggested that the nine states could rely on Israeli technology to build a network of radar, detectors, and interceptors, connect their air defense systems, and strengthen their ability to identify and intercept drone and missile attacks. According to reports, the idea had also been introduced to several Arab states at a meeting attended by CENTCOM member states. Yet several Arab states, including Kuwait, Qatar, and Iraq, reportedly expressed hesitation toward participating in an initiative alongside Israel, bringing to the fore some of the challenges limiting the U.S. vision of a more integrated regional security architecture.[148]

Although the Arab states expressed reservations, Israeli officials would lend their weight to advocating for the proposal and even make

claims that it had already been implemented. In mid-2022 Defense Minister Benny Gantz told Israeli lawmakers that a regional air defense system (also called the Middle East Air Defence Alliance) was already operational, and that it had "enabled the successful interception of Iranian attempts to attack Israel and other countries."[149] Remarking on the growing coordination between the two sides, former U.S. ambassador to Israel Dan Shapiro noted that the main driver of closer Arab-Israeli security integration is a shared threat perception toward Iran and its proxies. Shapiro expressed optimism toward a Saudi-Israel rapprochement, noting that it raised the possibility of a "truly unified Sunni Arab coalition to stand with Israel against Shi'a-led Iran."[150]

The UAE's new defense relationship with Israel provided practical payoffs.[151] By October 2022 satellite images revealed at least two of Israel's Barak Air Defence Systems being deployed within proximity of Al Dhafra airbase, the site of one of the missile attacks earlier that year.[152] The United States stepped in too, by authorizing $3 billion in arms sales to Saudi Arabia and the UAE, reinforcing its continued commitment to their security despite sustained perceptions in both states that it was not doing enough to defend their interests.[153]

Bahrain would also reap rewards from the United States. In mid-September 2023 the two states signed the Comprehensive Security Integration and Prosperity Agreement, strengthening their military and intelligence coordination. Under the deal, the United States pledged to defend Bahrain in case of external attack, a massive boon to Bahrain rulers who long sought more concrete security guarantees from the United States. While falling short of a NATO-style Article 5 commitment, the agreement nonetheless provides a clear symbolic commitment from the United States. It also contains a clause allowing its expansion to other states, prompting speculation on whether U.S. officials intended it as a preliminary basis for offering

security guarantees to Gulf Arab states like Saudi Arabia, in exchange for normalization.

While beginning primarily as a trade relationship, the Abraham Accords had evolved into a military and defense relationship between the two sides, bringing Israeli technology and missile defense systems to the Gulf and drawing both states into a new U.S.-led regional security architecture. Aside from the strategic benefits of normalization, Bahrain and the UAE would also instrumentalize the new relationship to play up their liberal and tolerant credentials, especially in front of a Western audience that had long criticized their human rights records.

5

TOLERANCE-WASHING

Beyond delivering a flow of technology and arms from Israel, the Abraham Accords provided the UAE and Bahrain with a new opportunity to reframe their images in the eyes of their Western partners, by instrumentalizing their ties with Israel as part of a new embrace of the Jewish people. In Bahrain, the strategy marked the latest iteration of a decade-long drive by its government to showcase itself as tolerant and divert attention away from accusations—made often by U.S. lawmakers—that it was targeting its Shi'a population. While facing less criticism for its human rights record, the UAE also used the accords to deepen its image as a liberal, business-friendly hub and taint its political rivals as religious extremists. In Dubai, the government's drive to accommodate Jewish tourists created new opportunities for an entrepreneurial rabbi.

A PUBLIC RELATIONS DRIVE

Ruling classes in the Gulf states have long depicted themselves as guardians of stability and moderation, in a region beset with religious extremism. A crisis triggered one of the first periods of introspection. The attacks of September 11, 2001, had thrust the leaders of

Muslim-majority states into the global spotlight, where many faced scrutiny from the West on the role they may have played in promoting the ideologies that influenced the hijackers to carry out their mission. The matter rang especially true for Saudi Arabia, whose citizens constituted fifteen out of the nineteen hijackers.

In the aftermath of the attacks, and amid rising Islamophobia in European and American quarters, Gulf Arab leaders worked to distance themselves from the atrocities and their ideological underpinnings. After 9/11, Saudi officials especially went to lengths to condemn extremism, with Prince Salman noting: "Terrorism and fanaticism have done more harm to Islam than anything else. Saudi Arabia stands in the face of those trying to hijack Islam and present it to the world as a religion of extremism and terrorism."[1] As part of his aim to affirm Saudi Arabia's commitment to moderation, Crown Prince Abdullah spearheaded dialogue initiatives between leaders of Islam sects, and between leaders of the Abrahamic faiths, warning: "Something serious has gone wrong, and we must try to put it right."[2] Across the region, regimes in power also used the specter of Islamic extremism for another purpose: to keep democracy at bay, pointing to Hamas's electoral victory in the Palestinian territories as proof of its dangers.

A NEW NARRATIVE

As the Arab Spring threatened the power of ruling regimes, Arab leaders turned to a tried and tested strategy: framing the movements as part of yet another wave of extremism. When protests reached the shores of Bahrain, its government began cracking down on domestic opposition groups, and especially Shi'a activists, accusing them of seeking to overthrow the monarchy and replace it with an Iranian-style theocracy. In one of the most damaging acts to its reputation,

Bahrain's government bulldozed more than thirty Shi'a religious sites—some hundreds of years old—alleging they did not meet zoning requirements and galvanizing accusations that it was engaged in sectarian retaliation.[3]

As the government's crackdown began making headlines, Bahraini activists called for global solidarity. Sympathetic voices in the United States echoed their message, pressing Washington to shutter its navy base in Manama to affirm its commitment to values of human rights and democracy.[4] The Obama administration's decision to suspend arms sales to Bahrain appeared to reflect the growing success of the campaign. Fearing a loss of control over the narrative, Bahrain's government poured millions of dollars into reputational management by hiring public relations firms like Bell Pottinger to improve its image abroad.[5] Its leaders also set up a commission of inquiry headed by international human rights experts to investigate events taking place during the uprising. When the commission released its report in late 2011—outlining systematic abuses committed by security forces—King Hamad pledged to take its message to heart and implement reforms.[6] A few token changes enabled the government to claim that it had turned the page on the past, but no members of its security forces faced accountability, and political prisoners remained locked away in the country's prisons.

By mid-2012 the reputational drive appeared to be succeeding. In May of that year, President Obama agreed to partially reinstate arms sales, with a State Department spokeswoman calling Bahrain "an important security partner and ally in a region facing enormous challenges."[7] Meanwhile, Bahrain continued its crackdown and poured even greater sums into developing new institutions and initiatives to maintain its tolerant narrative—and a steady flow of arms from the United States.

Despite facing a much smaller internal opposition movement, the UAE deployed a similar strategy. As the Arab Spring unfolded across

the region, a group of Emirati intellectuals came together to sign a petition calling for parliamentary elections.[8] Their calls were echoed by the Reform and Social Guidance Association (al-Islah), an Islamist group with ties to the Muslim Brotherhood. Fearing a coordinated uprising, the UAE began prosecuting dozens of activists, accusing them of harboring a radical Islamist agenda and acting on behalf of the Muslim Brotherhood. They included the "UAE-94," a group of activists, lawyers, and academics sentenced to prison terms of up to fifteen years on charges including plotting to overthrow the government.[9] While the UAE did not face as much scrutiny for its crackdown, it also made major investments in reputational management, by depicting itself at the forefront of global efforts to counter violent extremism. The strategy served several purposes: elevating the UAE's reputation as a safe business hub and justifying its increasingly confrontational foreign policy against regional backers of political Islam. It also served state-building aims, including the UAE's promotion of a state-sanctioned, counterrevolutionary brand of Islam.[10]

By the time President Trump announced the Abraham Accords in August 2020, the UAE and Bahrain were already knee-deep in cultivating their strategies of tolerance. The accords provided a new platform for both Gulf states to double down on their claims of moderation more convincingly than ever before, by co-opting the fight against antisemitism and spearheading a new outreach the Jewish people. Their strategy proved especially effective in front of a Western audience that lauded both states for boldly breaking with the constraints of the past and forging a new Middle East.

MANAMA'S MESSAGE OF TOLERANCE

During his first year in office, President Trump announced his plans to move the United States Embassy from Tel Aviv to Jerusalem,

triggering widespread anger across the Arab world and accusations that his administration was endorsing Israel's occupation of Palestinian lands. The decision did not deter twenty-four representatives of a Bahrain-based progovernment lobby group from visiting Israel days later.[11] Calling itself "This Is Bahrain," the delegation was led by Western expatriates and included token representatives from Sunni, Shi'a, Hindu, Christian, and Jewish faiths residing in the country.[12] In Israel, the delegation worked to dispel conceptions of Bahrain as repressive by describing their own, positive, experiences in the country. Although the group claimed it was traveling at its own behest, it announced its intent to deliver a message of peace on behalf of Bahrain's king, prompting speculation that he had authorized their visit as a first step toward the normalization of ties between the two states.[13]

Bahrain's delegation had arrived to Israel as guests of the Simon Wiesenthal Center, an organization with branches in Los Angeles and Jerusalem, which describes its mission as combatting antisemitism and promoting "global harmony and a love of Israel."[14] The center established a reputation for hounding even Israel's most moderate critics, including through the publication of an annual "Global Anti-Semitism Top Ten List." In 2022 the list included the BBC, the state of Germany, and Jewish Voice for Peace—a liberal Jewish organization that called for an end to the occupation. The designations prompted an outcry from the EU's top antisemitism commissioner and an umbrella group of Jewish communities in Germany that called them "heinous."[15]

The visit by the Bahrain-based delegation took place in the context of growing ties between Bahrain's leadership and the Wiesenthal Center. A year before the delegation's visit to Israel, the king dispatched his son, Sheikh Nasser bin Hamad Al Khalifa, to visit the Los Angeles branch of the center and its flagship institution, the Museum of Tolerance, which houses the world's largest Holocaust

exhibition. During his visit, Prince Nasser attended an interfaith gathering along with hundreds of religious figures and released the "Kingdom of Bahrain Declaration," principles affirming the country's commitment to religious freedom and coexistence. Remarking on the visit, the *Los Angeles Times* noted that a main objective of the trip was for "Bahrain to highlight, on its own terms, how tolerant of a country it can be," adding that "Jews, Hindus, and Christians are encouraged to practice freely, even as their Shiite counterparts struggle to get an equal footing in society."[16]

In the weeks after the visit, King Hamad further publicized his commitment to religious pluralism. Writing in the *Washington Times*, the monarch described the Kingdom of Bahrain Declaration as the outcome of widespread consultation with Sunni and Shi'a scholars, Christian clergy, and Jewish rabbis, including his "personal friend," the center's founder Rabbi Marvin Hier. King Hamad singled out his commitment to Bahrain's Jewish minority, writing:

> We celebrate our small—but precious—Jewish community, who feel free to wear their yarmulke and worship in their own synagogue, which, we are informed, is the only one in the Arabian Peninsula. In fact, our Jewish community plays a very active role at the highest levels of society, including an ambassador from Bahrain to Washington in 2008, the first Jewish diplomat to the United States from an Arab country. We wanted to protect our religious pluralism for future generations, so we have enshrined this in law, which guarantees everyone the right to worship unhindered in safety and to build their houses of worship.[17]

In the lead-up to the delegation's visit to Israel, King Hamad had welcomed Rabbi Hier to Manama as his guest, where he reportedly told him that he opposed the Arab states' boycott of Israel, and that he was planning to allow citizens of his country to travel to Israel

without restriction.[18] The two figures also reportedly discussed prospects for opening a Museum of Tolerance in Bahrain.[19] The visit would set the stage for the delegation's trip, with the rabbi telling the king that he and any of his representatives were welcome to visit the Wiesenthal Center in Jerusalem.

FOREIGN VOICES, LOCAL CAUSE

Bahrain's first delegation to Israel was headed by an unexpected figure, Betsy Mathieson-Abdulrahman. A self-described peace activist, Mathieson told reporters that she was born to a religious Christian family in Scotland, before migrating to Bahrain in 1980.[20] She would go on to marry a Bahraini, take up citizenship, and establish her own beauty salon, Betsy's Day Spa. Although Betsy may not have appeared as the most likely candidate to lead Bahrain's outreach to Israel, she had a track record of loyalty to the country's leadership that made her an ideal contender for the role. As security forces cracked down on prodemocracy protesters in 2011, Betsy emerged as one of the government's staunchest defenders, taking to social media to smear protesters as violent, Iran-backed terrorists, and berating journalists and human rights advocates who called for their release. Her identity—as a naturalized expatriate born outside the complexities of Bahrain's sectarian dynamics—appeared to provide her claims with an added veneer of credibility, at least in the eyes of government figures who worked to amplify her voice.

In 2012, as hundreds of political activists, protesters, and opposition figures remained detained in Bahrain's prisons, Betsy engaged in a characteristic defense of the government's actions, tweeting: "I wish we had a credible healthy opposition in Bahrain and not cowards terrorists racists murderers. We could achieve so much with peace."[21] When a sports journalist from the *Telegraph* arrived to

Bahrain to cover the annual Formula One race, he took to Twitter to observe that he had spoken with activists who were divided over the potential for the race to bring international attention to their cause. Betsy urged the journalist to instead speak with "decent, law-abiding people" whose lives were "ruined by terror acts" instigated by the protesters.[22]

Betsy was not the only Western figure who appeared eager to defend Bahrain's government from ill-repute. Her views were echoed by other progovernment social media accounts claiming to be run by expatriates, including "Sally from Saar," a self-described supporter of humanity and peace and a long-term British resident of the country. Although no images of Sally appeared online, her articles and editorials featured prominently in Bahrain's online forums and local opinion pages.[23] As the Obama administration pressed Bahrain to release detained activists in 2012, Sally penned an open letter to the president in Bahrain's main English-language newspaper, the *Gulf Daily News*, accusing him of being "unaware" of the realities of life in Bahrain. She urged the president to see the country in a different light, writing: "Over the years, I have visited mosques, m'atams (Shi'a houses of worship), synagogues, temples and churches—enjoyed Ramadan, celebrated Eid, Diwali, Christmas and Easter and experienced Muharram" and ended her message with the pronouncement, "this is Bahrain."[24]

The growing number of online accounts defending the government also amplified several conspiracy theories, tying Bahrain's Arab Spring protests to a Zionist, Jewish, and American conspiracy to destabilize the Arab world. The first mentions of the conspiracy emerged after Ludovic Hood, a human rights officer at the U.S. Embassy in Manama, greeted protesters gathered outside the embassy with a box of doughnuts in February 2011. The protesters had marched to the embassy to call on the United States to end its support for the government. But as photos of the officer mingling with protesters

circulated, multiple accounts began accusing him of instigating the movement. A prominent progovernment forum would go on to publish photos of Hood's wife, identifying her as Jewish, and calling on the "honest people" of Bahrain to avenge him for his role in purportedly training the demonstrators. By June 2011 the campaign forced Hood and his family to leave the country.[25] Accounts including that of "Sally from Saar" amplified similar claims, accusing the U.S ambassador of promoting a Zionist agenda, while regurgitating a stream of antisemitic tropes. In a feature on the *GDN*'s letters page, Sally wrote: "The international media support these heinous voices (the protesters). The fact of the matter is the Rothschild Zionist family owns 96 percent of the world's media and with Soros' link to this family—the media, the UN, European Union, and human rights rhetoric becomes crystal clear. Obviously, the agenda of the greater Middle East as planned by Israel and the U.S. is in play."[26] While the conspiracy theories appeared to resonate with progovernment voices in Bahrain, they had an opposite effect in the United States. In an editorial titled "Bahrain: From Bad to Worse," Elliot Abrams, an advisor to successive U.S. presidents, recalled the circumstances forcing Hood to flee the country, observing: "Not so long ago, Bahrain was considered one of the more liberal Arab states. No longer."[27]

Soon Betsy took the lead in steering a more palatable narrative. By 2012 she emerged as the official head of the Bahrain Federation of Expatriate Associations, a government-backed organization established that year. The BFEA quickly secured its role at the forefront of Bahrain's rebranding efforts by organizing dozens of events inside the country and abroad, praising the country's leadership and its tolerant approach. Instead of relying on antisemitic claims, it took an opposite approach, showcasing the different ethnic and religious groups residing in Bahrain and amplifying the message that societal coexistence was the product of the liberal policies enacted by the country's leadership. State media covered their events with

fanfare, eager to provide a more cheerful alternative to the narrative of violence and repression reiterated by international media and by local activists seeking accountability for the government's human rights abuses.

One of the first events organized by the BFEA was a Ramadan celebration, held at one of the oldest churches in Manama, under the sponsorship of Prince Nasser. Bahrain's media covered the event as the first of its kind, for celebrating an Islamic occasion at a Christian venue. It also described widespread enthusiasm for the leadership and its approach, with crowds at the church reportedly "roused to a frenzy as they chanted in one accord: Long Live King Hamad!"[28] At other events, the BFEA acted to pressure Bahrain's residents to display their gratitude to the regime. In January 2013 the organization put together "Thank You Bahrain" at Bahrain's national stadium, encouraging attendees to sign a petition in support of Bahrain's leadership. Sheikh Nasser would later stand alongside Betsy at a separate ceremony and thank participants for their involvement. While showcasing the symbiotic relationship between the organization and the highest figures in government, the move also appeared to send a thinly veiled warning to the public that the government was taking note of who did—and did not—attend Betsy's events.[29]

Some of the federation's most important functions took place abroad. In September 2015 a two-hundred-member delegation representing This Is Bahrain traveled to Washington, DC, and New York to publicize "Bahrain's multi-cultural society, and promote peace, tolerance, and co-existence."[30] Their visit took place months after President Obama agreed to restart arms sales to the Bahrain Defense Force and its National Guard, in recognition of Bahrain's progress on human rights, which included the release of secular Sunni opposition leader Ebrahim Sharif. But weeks ahead of the visit, several senators submitted a congressional bill to introduce a complete ban on arms sales to Bahrain, citing the fact that Sharif had been

rearrested just nineteen days following his release, for making a speech calling for democratic reforms.[31]

While in Washington, the BFEA began acting directly on behalf of Bahrain's government, including by entering an agreement with the Middle East Media Research Institute (MEMRI) to "change negative media perceptions of the situation in Bahrain."[32] Founded by Yigal Carmon, an Israeli counterterrorism advisor to several past Israeli prime ministers, MEMRI has a track record of propagating an anti-Arab and pro-Israel narrative. In 2002 Brian Whitaker, the *Guardian*'s Middle East correspondent, published an investigation of the organization, noting it was staffed mostly by former Israeli intelligence officers. Whitaker described the organization's role in disseminating English-language translations of Arab media stories, nearly all of which either "reflected badly on the character of Arabs" or "furthered the political agenda of Israel."[33] In its past coverage of Bahrain, MEMRI had aired a mistranslated clip of a cleric purportedly telling an audience that Jews and Christians were seeking to destroy family values.[34] Still, Bahrain's government appeared more than willing to join hands with an organization that had once worked to tarnish its image, if progress could be made in the opposite direction.

THE CRACKDOWN CONTINUES

As Bahrain shuttled its defenders across the globe, it did little to reform the policies that had elicited international condemnation in the first place. Instead, it doubled down on its approach by continuing a cycle of arresting, releasing, and rearresting prominent opposition activists and dismantling the civic organizations that might provide a platform for mobilization. Nabeel Rajab's story is a case in point. Described by his supporters as a Shi'a, secular activist, Rajab

rose to prominence in the early 2000s when he advocated for the release of six Bahraini detainees held at Guantanamo Bay, all of them Sunnis, placing him in alignment with the government's stance.[35] He then took up the role of president of the Bahrain Center for Human Rights, a nonprofit organization. As the center publicized abuses committed by security forces during the Arab Spring, Rajab fell out of favor with the government that once supported him. He faced immediate reprisal, with a Bahraini court sentencing him to three years in prison in 2013 on charges including "disturbing the public order."[36] Rajab would be released two years later, but his criticism of the country's ministries in 2015 landed him in prison once more, with a royal pardon granting him early release three months later. His criticism of Saudi Arabia's role in the Yemen conflict would lead to fresh charges against him in 2016, including "disseminating false rumors," for which he served a four-year sentence.[37]

Bahrain's government also continued targeting political opposition groups. In 2016 a court ordered the dissolution of the country's largest Shi'a political opposition group, Al-Wefaq, for "inciting violence."[38] The group had held eighteen out of forty parliamentary seats in Bahrain's elected chamber of parliament, before its representatives resigned in 2011 to protest the government's crackdown.[39] Rajab's arrest in 2016 and the dissolution of Al-Wefaq that year drew condemnation from the United States, which urged Bahrain's government to return to a path of reconciliation.[40] Instead, Bahrain continued its repressive approach by shuttering the National Democratic Action Society, the main leftist and secular political group, headed by Ebrahim Sharif.[41] Next came the closure in 2018 of *Al Wasat*, Bahrain's only independent newspaper, on charges including "inciting division, and jeopardizing national unity."[42] The Committee to Protect Journalists had previously awarded its editor-in-chief, Mansour Al-Jamri, a prestigious International Press Freedom Award in recognition of the newspaper's role in providing "independent, nonsectarian coverage" of protests in Bahrain.[43]

A NEW WAVE OF TOLERANCE

As Bahrain's crackdown continued, its government funneled further funds into promoting its countermessage of tolerance. In March 2018 the King Hamad Global Centre for Peaceful Co-existence opened its doors to the public, describing its mission to promote Bahrain as the world's leading hub for peaceful coexistence and interfaith dialogue.[44] With a member of the royal family, Dr. Shaikh Khalid bin Khalifa Al Khalifa, at its helm, the organization's board included ten figures representing Bahrain's different faiths, one being Betsy Mathieson, who took up the role of board member and second deputy chairperson. As one of its first activities, the center organized a ceremony in New York—cosponsored with This Is Bahrain—to mark the opening of the seventy-third UN General Assembly. The ceremony publicized Bahrain's commitment to the sixteenth Sustainable Development Goal: Peace, Justice, and Strong Institutions while affirming its commitment to tolerance and religious liberties.[45]

Bahrain extended its tolerance drive into academia in 2018, with the inauguration of a professorship, the King Hamad Chair in Interfaith Dialogue and Peaceful Co-Existence, at an Italian public institute of higher education, Universita di Roma La Sapienza. The chair received its funding from the Royal Charity Organization, the government's main charitable arm.[46] The university described the endowment as the culmination of three years of cooperation with the government of Bahrain to turn "royal vision into reality" and "provide the opportunity for training young researchers on the same values which the Kingdom of Bahrain is recognized for," especially tolerance.[47] Weeks after the inauguration, the chair-holder, Professor Alessandro Saggiori, joined Mathieson, in her capacity as a representative of the center, at an event hosted by the London School of Economics. Together, the two figures championed developments in Bahrain, telling an audience of academics that the release of the Kingdom of Bahrain Declaration, the creation of the King Hamad

Chair, and the establishment of the King Hamad Global Centre formed part of the kingdom's efforts to combat extremism and terrorism and boost moderation, tolerance, and peace.[48]

Bahrain also worked to deepen its ties with the kind of world leaders that could prove useful in promoting its tolerant image. In August 2019 the center welcomed Narendra Modi to Manama for the first official visit by an Indian prime minister. At a special ceremony, King Hamad awarded Modi the King Hamad Order of the Renaissance First Class, an honor he had bestowed on just four other stately figures.[49] In Manama, Modi lauded the government's commitment to religious pluralism and launched the redevelopment of Bahrain's Shreenathji Hindu temple, which the government pledged to renovate, refurbish, and expand, at a cost of one and a half million Bahrain dinars ($4.2 million).[50] Although Prime Minister Modi had presided over the most anti-Muslim policies in India's modern history, including by revoking Kashmir's semiautonomous status, passing an act excluding Muslim refugees from Indian citizenship, and enabling the demolitions of Muslim homes and places of worship, Bahrain would not let the details of his track record stand in the way of a new opportunity to tout their tolerant credentials.[51] In describing Modi's visit, Bahrain's news agency lauded the trip as "conveying a clear message to the world that Bahrain is an unparalleled land for co-existence and religious freedom."[52]

A NEW CHURCH OPENS ITS DOORS

After signing the Abraham Accords, Bahrain began adapting its message of tolerance. While it had previously worked to amplify broad narratives on coexistence, the enactment of the accords provided it with an opportunity to issue a more focused message, centering on its role in combatting antisemitism. Among the first initiatives

Bahrain pursued in the wake of the accords was an agreement between the King Hamad Centre and the U.S. special envoy to monitor and combat antisemitism, to "promote mutual respect and peaceful coexistence between Arab and Jewish peoples and their respective nation-states."[53] In a first for an Arab state, Bahrain also appeared to endorse the controversial definition of antisemitism adopted by the International Holocaust Remembrance Alliance (IHRA), which equates criticism of Israel with antisemitism.[54] The definition has been criticized by progressive Jewish groups, as well as academic institutions, for suppressing legitimate freedom of expression and pro-Palestinian advocacy.[55] Bahrain's recognition of the designation earned it praise from European and American officials, as well as influential Zionist organizations like the American Israel Public Affairs Committee.[56]

In November 2020 the King Hamad Centre began capitalizing on the new relationship with Israel by dispatching a delegation of senior officials to the country and portraying the visit as part of Bahrain's efforts to combat anti-Jewish sentiment. Israeli president Reuven Rivlin would meet with the delegation and thank the Bahraini government for supporting peace, the Jewish community, and "standing against antisemitism."[57] While in Israel, the delegation also met with representatives from the Hebrew University of Jerusalem and toured their Mount Scopus campus, where the two sides signed a memorandum of understanding to carry out joint activities. Although Palestinian activists had singled out the university for developing a campus on occupied lands in East Jerusalem, the matter would not stand in the way of Bahrain's tolerance drive, with the chair of the center telling university representatives that "people in Bahrain have changed in recent years," adding that "a few days ago, I told friends I was visiting Israel. They replied that they'd also like to visit. I told them we should thank God for giving me the opportunity to visit Israel before my time on this earth is up."[58]

By September 2021 Bahrain faced fresh pressure to reform from a group of bipartisan senators, including Marco Rubio, Patrick Leahy, and Bernie Sanders, who called on Secretary of State Antony Blinken to push Manama to end its "violent, systematic, repression of its people" and release detained political activists.[59] With copies of the senators' letter circulating, Bahrain's officials continued aggressively courting Jewish groups, to turn the narrative in their favor. In October 2021 Bahrain's undersecretary for political affairs, Sheikh Abdullah bin Ahmed Al Khalifa, landed in New York for meetings with Jewish figures, the heads of American-Jewish organizations, and students at the Yeshiva University. During his visit, Al Khalifa addressed an audience of rabbis, telling them that his country was facing unfair attacks from European human rights institutions, and adding that the accords aimed to build bridges of peace with the global Jewish community. The undersecretary then urged the delegation to use their influence over Jewish communities to "visit, invest in, and get to know Bahrain."[60]

Bahrain's leadership continued investing in showcasing their religious tolerance, with further reputational payoffs. In December 2021 the largest Catholic church in the Arabian Peninsula, the Cathedral of Mary Queen of Arabia, opened its doors in Bahrain. King Hamad had donated a 9,000-square-meter plot of land for the project, which included a pastoral center and a bishop's house.[61] As the complex began construction, he traveled to the Vatican to present the pontiff with a model of the planned complex. In turn, the pope awarded him with a medal of the Angel of Peace.[62] After the cathedral's completion, the pope made his first visit to Bahrain and delivered a mass in front of thirty thousand gatherers who packed into its national stadium, where he praised the country as a "living image of coexistence in diversity."[63] His message was echoed by Rabbi Marc Schneier, a special advisor to the king on interfaith matters, who used the opportunity to praise

Bahrain as "a role model in the Arab world for co-existence and tolerance."[64] The previous year, Bahrain's king had also earned praise from a French rabbi whom he invited to lead a candle-lighting ceremony at his palace to mark the festival of Hanukkah, with the rabbi reportedly telling him: "Bahrain under your rule is a little light in a dark world of radical fundamentalism."[65]

As Bahrain inaugurated its cathedral, it drew criticism from groups like Americans for Democracy and Human Rights in Bahrain, a U.S—based lobby group, which observed that the government was yet to rebuild the Shi'a mosques it had demolished during its Arab Spring crackdown. A representative of the organization would tell *Vice News* that although some of the Shi'a mosques had been rebuilt by local communities, they lacked funds to maintain them properly. "When it comes to the building of the cathedral, they're abandoning other responsibilities in the name of pushing this tolerance," she added.[66]

In a column in the *New York Times*, the journalist Peter Beinart highlighted the growing instrumentalization of tolerance by the Gulf states. He wrote:

> As relations have warmed between Israel and the monarchies of the Persian Gulf, American officials have begun using the struggle against antisemitism to shield those regimes from human rights pressure, too. In June, [the Biden administration's special envoy to monitor and combat antisemitism] Ms. Lipstadt met the Saudi ambassador in Washington and celebrated "our shared objectives of overcoming intolerance and hate." From there, she flew to Saudi Arabia, where she met its minister of Islamic affairs and affirmed, once again, "our shared goals of promoting tolerance and combatting hate." In the United Arab Emirates, she sat down with the country's foreign minister, whom she declared "a sincere partner in our shared goals of"—you guessed it "promoting tolerance and fighting hate."[67]

Beinart continues: "In a terrible irony, the campaign against 'antisemitism,' as waged by influential Jewish groups and the U.S. government, has become a threat to freedom. It is wielded as a weapon against the world's most respected human rights organizations and a shield for some of the world's most repressive regimes."

After nearly a decade of working to turn the tide in its favor, Bahrain's turn to Israel enabled it to deflect criticism of its human rights record and reframe the narrative in its favor, earning the small Gulf state lasting goodwill from Western capitals.

A PRAYER HOUSE REOPENS ITS DOORS

Beyond the regime's reputational redemption, Bahrain's tolerance drive had one other clear beneficiary: Bahrain's Jewish community. State efforts to court Jewish groups generated excitement among the community and led to the resurrection of Manama's neglected Jewish cultural and religious institutions. In 2021 Bahrain's House of the Ten Commandments Synagogue opened its doors to the first public prayer services, on the first anniversary of the accords. It was the synagogue's first public opening since the outbreak of public protests in 1947 forced its closure, although it had held occasional, private services. In preparation for its reopening, the synagogue benefited from comprehensive renovation, at a cost of $160,000, although it is not clear whether the government or members of the community funded the effort. The head of the Jewish community, Ebrahim Nonoo, would tell reporters that the synagogue enabled Bahrain's Jewish minority to practice their faith openly. He also defended the country and its people, noting that the backlash against the Jewish community in 1948 did not come from Bahrainis but from a group of foreign workers. "The Bahraini leadership has always protected the Jewish minority," he added.[68]

The accords also encouraged the development of new Jewish cultural associations. The most notable among them includes the Association of Gulf Jewish Communities, an umbrella organization that aims to bring together Jewish communities from across the Gulf. In 2021 the association announced its plans to revive Bahrain's historic Jewish cemetery, with the support of the Bahraini government. Construction work to repair the hundred-year-old site began on January 16, to coincide with the Jewish New Year.[69] That year, the association also announced the opening of a new rabbinical court in Bahrain, the Beth Din of Arabia, headquartered at the synagogue. It presides over issues including marriages, divorces, inheritance, and business agreements, as part of an understanding with the government of Bahrain to recognize its rulings as legally binding.[70]

Newly created Jewish groups also worked to ensure that a new generation of Jews remained in Bahrain, to carry out the community's traditions. In October 2021 the Association of Gulf Jewish Communities launched a dedicated dating app, to help Jewish singles in the Gulf find love. "By helping these singles find their spouses in the GCC, they are more likely to get married here and establish families here, which in turn grows Jewish communal life," the president of the association remarked. "We've received interest from dozens of singles."[71]

For their part, Bahrain's Jewish community appeared more than willing to champion the government's cause by lauding the leadership for its progressive approach and its embrace of religious pluralism. They would also embrace the turn to Israel, with Ebrahim Nonoo describing his excitement about the future expansion of the accords, noting: "It is unstoppable. Other countries will want to enjoy the benefits of the new openness, too."[72] Nonoo also thanked the leadership for acting as guardians of the community, adding that it would be a "very heartening thing" to guide Jewish visitors from Israel.[73] When Israel's prime minister, Naftali Bennett, made his first

visit to Bahrain in early 2022, he would also make a personal visit to the community, noting that he could think of no better way to begin his trip than by visiting his family in Bahrain.[74]

RUMORS OF A RIFT

In July 2022 rumors of a governmental rift swept across Bahrain when the head of the Bahrain Authority for Culture and Antiquities, Sheikha Mai bint Ebrahim Al Khalifa, was abruptly dismissed from her post. A prominent member of the royal family, Sheikha Mai had served as head of the organization mandated with overseeing the kingdom's cultural sector since 2014 and was previously minister of culture. A government restructuring had transformed the ministry into a Cultural Authority, but Sheikha Mai retained the title of minister, maintaining her status as a veteran diplomat and one of the most widely recognized faces of Bahraini diplomacy, who had earned her title in 2014 as the sixth most powerful Arab woman from *Forbes Middle East*.

As most government ministers took to social media to celebrate the accords, Shaikha Mai avoided making public statements on the matter. In October 2021 she welcomed the prominent Israeli historian Ilan Pappe to Manama, to deliver a lecture at a cultural center named in honor of her father.[75] Pappe is one of four Israeli scholars who emerged at the forefront of efforts to challenge the predominant historical narrative inside Israel, which blamed the Palestinians themselves for their 1948 exodus. On November 30, 2021, Pappe took to the stage at the Sheikh Ebrahim Cultural Centre to deliver a damning indictment of Israel's treatment of its Arab and Palestinian minority, describing the situation as an invisible apartheid.[76]

Pappe would later remark that his arrival to Bahrain, on the first commercial flight from Tel Aviv, may not have been what authorities

had expected from one of their first Israeli guests.[77] Still, Bahrain's government appeared to tolerate his presence as well as his public lecture, raising hopes among activists that there remained space for pro-Palestinian activism, especially when endorsed by officials higher up in government, like the minister.

News of Shaikha Mai's unexpected dismissal in the summer of 2022 prompted a flurry of speculation, with local news sources alleging that her removal was tied to her refusal to shake hands with the Israeli ambassador to Bahrain at an official event, the final straw in her continued commitment to Palestinians.[78] The rumors gained further traction after images of her much younger replacement sitting side-by-side with the Israeli ambassador were plastered across local newspapers, just days after his appointment to the role.[79] Shaikha Mai's expulsion appeared to send a message that when it came to Israel, the government had little appetite for dissent, even if it came from some of its most seasoned diplomats. Meanwhile, one year later, Betsy would receive the National Action Pioneer Medal from King Hamad, in recognition of her contributions as a leading female figure in the country.[80]

THE UAE'S MESSAGE OF TOLERANCE

Like Bahrain, the UAE's tolerance drive began in response to the Arab uprisings of 2011. On the afternoon of July 17, 2011, security forces arrived at the home of Mohammed al-Roken to arrest the Emirati human rights lawyer. Al-Roken had drawn the ire of officials for acting as legal counsel to al-Islah, a reformist group in the UAE with ties to the Muslim Brotherhood, and for representing a group of five activists (the "UAE-5") detained for signing a petition that called for an elected parliament. Although the petition had gathered 160 signatures from Emirati reformists—including al-Roken

himself—the government singled out the five men for reprisal. They included Ahmed Mansoor and Nasser bin Ghaith, a lecturer at the Abu Dhabi branch of the Sorbonne University.[81] Al-Roken would remain detained in a high-security prison for two years before facing trial by a State Security Court, which sentenced him to serve a ten-year prison term on accusations of belonging to a terrorist organization.[82] The same court would later sentence Mansoor and bin Ghaith to extended prison terms and accuse the latter of belonging to al-Islah. Although al-Roken completed his sentence in 2021, he remains in incommunicado detention as of 2024, as do Mansoor and bin Ghaith.[83]

As Abu Dhabi worked to silence its critics, it also shuttered Western nongovernmental organizations based in the country, especially those whose objectives involved democracy promotion. In early 2012 authorities ordered the closure of the Abu Dhabi offices of Konrad-Adenauer-Stiftung, a German think tank affiliated with Germany's center-right Christian Democratic Union, which aims to promote the rule of law and democracy. Next came the closure of the Dubai offices of the National Endowment for Democracy, a Washington, DC–based nonprofit. The previous year, Egyptian security forces expelled both organizations from Cairo, accusing them of stoking opposition toward Abdelfattah El-Sisi, the military leader that the UAE had helped bring to power.[84]

To deflect from its crackdown, the UAE worked to disseminate a more favorable narrative, depicting itself at the forefront of global efforts to fight extremism. To that end, Abu Dhabi began pouring millions of dollars into developing the new institutions to promote its liberal credentials. In 2012 the UAE's International Center for Excellence in Countering Violent Extremism (the Hedayah Centre) opened its doors in Abu Dhabi, with the UAE's officials touting the organization as the first international hub for policymakers to exchange best practices on combatting violent extremism through dialogue, capacity-building, and research.[85] Following its

establishment, the Hedayah Centre partnered with the European Union on several programs, including to develop a curriculum for the UAE's schoolchildren to "quell extremist thinking and encourage dialogue," and a program to strengthen the capacity of state and nonstate actors to challenge radicalization.[86] Over time, al-Hedayah would serve as one of the UAE's most effective platforms for strengthening its relationships with European states, with figures like EU ambassador Patrizio Fond praising it as "an important and unique initiative."[87]

As it championed its counterextremist credentials, the UAE began developing other institutions to disseminate interpretations of Islam more consistent with its restrictive political leanings. In 2014 a new organization, the Forum for Promoting Peace in Muslim Societies, opened its doors in Abu Dhabi. At its inaugural ceremony, the forum's president, Sheikh Abdullah bin Bayyah, told a room of diplomats and dignitaries that the subjects of Muslim states had a religious obligation to obey their rulers, adding that calling for democracy in the Arab world amounted to "a declaration of war."[88] Bin Bayyah would go on to chair the UAE's Fatwa Council, a supervisory body established by authorities in 2018 to regulate edicts issued by preachers in the country and ensure their compatibility with "true, moderate values of Islam."[89]

Abu Dhabi also used its military engagements to reinforce other aspects of its messaging, including its claims to support female empowerment. In 2014, as the Islamic State seized control over an area covering one-third of Syria and nearly half of Iraq, a coalition of Western and Arab states launched joint military strikes against the extremist group. The UAE, along with Jordan, took the lead as the most active partners in the coalition, with the U.S. State Department reporting that the number of strikes carried out by Abu Dhabi was second only to those by the United States. Military experts also noted that the UAE likely carried out the "most sophisticated" air strikes.[90]

The UAE's media seized on the opportunity to frame the narrative in its favor by publishing photos of a young female pilot seated in a military jet, wearing a helmet imprinted with the UAE's flag, and giving a "thumbs up" to the camera. Images of the pilot, Mariam al-Mansouri, quickly spread across social media, spurring discussions on the UAE's role in empowering a new generation of women.[91] Even skeptics of the UAE's strategies would concede the effectiveness of the move. In a column, the *Washington Post*'s Ishan Tharoor observed that "the symbolism of a female fighter pilot bringing the heat to the women-enslaving Islamic state ought to be lost on no one," adding that it constituted "useful propaganda" in setting the UAE apart from its neighbors like Saudi Arabia, where women are not permitted to even drive cars.[92]

As it amplified its commitment to liberal values, the UAE continued targeting suspected members of the Muslim Brotherhood within its borders and dissuading neighboring states from supporting its affiliates. After the trilateral Gulf states recalled their ambassadors from Doha in 2014, a UAE cabinet decree designated the Brotherhood and its local affiliates as terrorist organizations, a status they shared with the Islamic State.[93] The designation enabled authorities to impose harsher prison terms against accused members of the group.[94] The UAE's Fatwa Council would later lend religious credence to the designation and accuse the group of supporting extremism.[95] Another law passed the next month cast an even wider net by granting prosecutors discretion to impose the death penalty or life in prison for acts that "spread terror or harm the public."[96] Organizations like Human Rights Watch called on the UAE to reverse course, with its then MENA director Sarah Leah Whitson noting: "The UAE claims to be a key ally in the fight against violent extremism, but it has just passed a violent and extreme law of its own."[97] The UAE's aim of weakening political Islam also shaped its foreign policy, drawing it into conflicts in Sudan, Somalia, and Libya,

where it financed parties acting against the group. By mid-2016 the UAE and Saudi Arabia would lead the blockade of Qatar along with Saudi Arabia, Bahrain, and Egypt, and accuse Doha of supporting the Brotherhood.[98]

A MINISTRY OF TOLERANCE

In 2016 the UAE's cabinet launched the country's most significant tolerance drive to date, with the establishment of a National Tolerance Program. The program provided a blueprint for the creation of the world's first Ministry of Tolerance and Coexistence headed by Sheikha Lubna al-Qassimi, the first woman to hold a ministerial post in the country.[99] In 2017 al-Qassimi took the helm at another new organization, the International Institute for Tolerance, established by Dubai's ruler Mohammed bin Rashid Al Maktoum to "provide solutions to the challenges of extremism, and instill a spirit of tolerance in the UAE."[100] To showcase their commitment to the cause, the UAE's leadership renamed several sites. A prominent bridge in Abu Dhabi would become the "Mary Mother of Jesus Mosque," and a new overpass in Dubai, the "Tolerance Bridge."[101]

The UAE's tolerance program set the stage for the launch of the Year of Tolerance in 2019, an entire year dedicated to the promotion of tolerance. Its leadership used the occasion to welcome Pope Francis to Abu Dhabi, for the first visit by a pontiff to the Arabian Peninsula.[102] After holding a mass attended by over 120,000 people, the pope joined the grand imam of Al Azhar (the leading center of Sunni religious learning in the Muslim world) and chair of the Muslim Council of Elders to sign the Document on Human Fraternity, outlining their commitment to peace and coexistence. The UAE also unveiled the construction of the Abrahamic Family House that year, an interfaith complex housing a mosque, church, and synagogue. The

complex took center stage at one of Abu Dhabi's most iconic developments, Saadiyat Island, also home to the Louvre Abu Dhabi and the Abu Dhabi campus of New York University.[103] The Year of Tolerance also provided the UAE with a new platform to extend its outreach to Jewish organizations, like the Simon Wiesenthal Center. Two years after Bahrain dispatched Prince Nasser to Los Angeles, Abu Dhabi followed in its footsteps by sending Ambassador Yousef al-Otaiba to the Museum of Tolerance. Like Prince Nasser before him, al-Otaiba took part in a discussion with interfaith leaders, telling an audience: "Inclusion and tolerance aren't new for us. Our founder, Sheikh Zayed made these values part of his own daily life, UAE policy, and Emirati society."[104]

A SYNAGOGUE STEPS OUT OF THE SHADOWS

Unlike Bahrain, the UAE does not have a native Jewish population. Instead, nearly all its Jewish residents are foreign-born expatriates, with less of a vested interest in securing an equal social footing than their Bahraini counterparts. Still, the UAE's Jewish residents emerged as some of the main beneficiaries of its tolerance drive, enabling them to practice their faith more openly.

As the government amplified its commitment to tolerance in the lead-up to the accords, the UAE's Jewish community began asserting a more public presence. In 2018 the *Times of Israel* and *Bloomberg* published the first public profiles of the Dubai Synagogue, a prayer house located in an unmarked villa in the upscale district of Umm Suqeim.[105] The synagogue was established in 2008, when a group of mostly American and European Jewish residents began praying at the Dubai home of Ross Kriel, a South African lawyer and long-time

resident of the emirate. Over time, community members converted a villa into an unmarked Ashkenazi synagogue for their weekly prayers and to host guests. Conscious of their precarious status as expatriates and unsure about the prevalence of antisemitic sentiments in the region, the community maintained a low profile, including by referring to the synagogue as "the Villa" in their conversations.[106]

Sometimes, prayers would be led by Rabbi Yehuda Sarna, a chaplain from New York University. The chaplain initially had little knowledge of the Gulf region, but while employed with the university's Center for Jewish Student Life in 2008, he was approached by the university's president, John Sexton, who invited him to travel to Abu Dhabi and interview high school students seeking admission to the university's new branch campus in the emirate. Established as part of Abu Dhabi's efforts to market itself as a global hub for culture, NYU's new Abu Dhabi branch campus received nearly all its funding from the Abu Dhabi government and offered generous scholarships to its students, which arrived from all over the world. The rabbi agreed to travel to the emirate on one condition: he would not hide his Jewish identify from the students he interviewed. Sexton agreed. The rabbi continued traveling to the university several times a year to meet with and interview prospective students. Over time, he would gain involvement in the synagogue in Dubai.[107]

In one of the most surveilled cities in the world, it would have been virtually impossible for a prayer house to operate in the emirate without the approval of high-level figures in its government, and other powerful individuals. They reportedly included Mohammed al-Abbar, chair of UAE real estate giant Emaar Properties. Speaking to reporters, New York businessman Eli Epstein explained that the real estate mogul's commitment to the Jewish community had prompted him to gift the synagogue with a Torah in his honor. Another of the synagogue's founding members suggested that its

presence was also known to the UAE's ambassador to the United States, Yousef al-Otaiba, and "officials higher up in the chain."[108] The importance of these endorsements was not lost on the congregants. At a weekly Shabbat service, Ross Kriel would pray for the welfare of the UAE government by calling on the Lord to "Bless and protect, guard and help, exalt, magnify and uplift the President of the UAE Sheikh Khalifa bin Zayed and his Deputy the Ruler of Dubai, Sheikh Mohammed bin Rashid and all the Rulers of the other Emirates and their Crown Princes."[109]

As authorities began encouraging the group to step out into the public, Kriel established a new institution: the Jewish Council of the Emirates (JCE), billing it as the first publicly representative body of Dubai's Jewish community. It would be NYU's Rabbi Sarna who acted as its chief rabbi.[110] Soon after its establishment, the JCE faced an unexpected rivalry from another organization claiming to represent Dubai's Jewish community: the Jewish Community of the UAE. Established in 2020, the organization was headed by a lesser-known figure, Rabbi Levi Duchman. The Brooklyn-born emissary had arrived in the UAE in 2014, after hearing that a growing number of Jews were moving to the country. While initially joining Kriel's congregation as a member, Duchman represented the Chabad-Lubavitch movement, a Hasidic Orthodox branch of the faith. Looking to head his own movement, he splintered off to set up his own organization in 2020, complete with a community center and small synagogue.[111] Duchman approached media networks, to champion his role as the UAE's "first chief residential rabbi" and the head of its Jewish community.[112] But by July 2020 the rabbi's claims appeared to land him in trouble with authorities, with a source telling the *Times of Israel* that they had reprimanded Duchman for falsely claiming to represent the UAE's entire Jewish community. Days later he renamed his organization "Jewish UAE" and dropped his claims of acting as an official representative.[113]

AN ENTREPRENEURIAL RABBI

As in Bahrain, the enactment of the Abraham Accords transformed the UAE's approach to tolerance. Whereas it had previously channeled its message through broad-based narratives on tolerance and the creation of institutions to counter extremism, it would begin adopting a more focused outreach to Jewish groups. This outreach was also made possible by a massive interest from Israelis in visiting Dubai. In the month after the establishment of direct flights between the two states, more than fifty thousand Israeli tourists flock to the Emirates, including during eight days of Hanukkah.[114] Within a year, a total of seven airlines would shuttle up to fourteen daily flights between the two countries.[115]

The UAE's efforts to market itself as a place of tolerance provided a new opportunity for Rabbi Duchman to fulfill his ambitions to become the face of Jewish cultural life in the country. In the weeks after the signing of the accords, the rabbi set up a new organization: the Jewish Community Center of Dubai, an offshoot of Jewish UAE, which he marketed as a hub of community activity for Jews living in the UAE and abroad.[116] By December 2020 the government approved its proposal to host a nightly Hanukkah celebration at the base of the Burj Khalifa—Dubai's most iconic building—complete with a large menorah and a DJ flown in from Israel. Reporters at the scene described a musical extravaganza, with hundreds of Israelis dancing, as blaring music echoed off the tower.[117]

In 2020 the rabbi set up another organization, the Emirates Agency for Kosher Certification, championing it as the first and only organization offering kosher certification in the UAE.[118] The agency received a boost in revenue when the UAE's Department of Culture and Tourism issued a circular to hotels across the country in September 2020, advising them to include kosher food options at all food and beverage outlets, and to seek kosher certification.[119] To facilitate

compliance, the Department of Culture and Tourism then launched the Abu Dhabi Hotels Kosher Certification Project, a program providing hotels with access to free yearlong certification from the only firm offering the service.[120] The new regulations would effectively provide Duchman's certification agency with revenue from every hotel in Abu Dhabi that found itself obligated to obtain the certification, and from the government that had subsidized their access to certification, for one year. By December, Duchman's Jewish Community Center obtained contracts from the UAE Department of Culture and Tourism to train more than 150 hotel kitchens as kosher-compliant.[121]

Next, Duchman established the Beit Tefilah Synagogue in Abu Dhabi, the first synagogue in the emirate. He also announced plans to create the "Mikvah of Dubai," a business providing ritual bath services to women. In selling the initiative to reporters, he explained that he planned to maintain the high luxury standards expected of Dubai. "The Mikvah will probably the nicest mikvah in the world," he added.[122] Duchman also recruited his brother, Rabbi Mendel Levison, as his business partner. From their base in Dubai, the brothers expanded their reach into education, setting up the Mini Miracles Nursery, the UAE's only Hebrew-speaking nursery, and the Hebrew School of Dubai, a kindergarten and Talmud after-school program. The UAE's media would enthusiastically cover his role in promoting the Jewish faith in the Emirates and its culture of tolerance.[123] Rabbi Mendel would also return the praise, pointing to the numbers of Jewish tourists visiting the UAE as evidence of its tolerant approach, and noting that his Jewish Community Centre was receiving "about three hundred emails a day" from visitors who wanted to know where they could eat, pray, and find a mikvah.[124]

Rabbi Levi would go on to organize the Arab world's largest-ever seder, serving over one thousand people in Abu Dhabi. He also celebrated his own wedding in Abu Dhabi, earning him further coverage from UAE media sources.[125] He would continue praising the UAE

and its leadership, especially in Jewish and Israeli media outlets.[126] When interviewed by an Israeli podcast, Duchman expressed his admiration for the UAE's visionary leadership, noting: "The founding father of the UAE, Sheikh Zayed—*Allah Yerhamo*—established the UAE on this idea of respecting everyone, on co-existence. From the first time you come to the UAE, no one will judge you based on your religion, or background, or nationality. It is about respecting you for who you are, it is about teaching the youth this message of co-existence."[127]

REDEFINING THE CURRICULUM

In keeping with its message of tolerance, the UAE announced plans to transform its educational curriculum, to promote the values of the accords. Weeks after establishing ties with Israel, Abu Dhabi announced that it had removed anti-Israel material from its state educational textbooks and included mentioned of the accords in three Islamic education textbooks, with one exercise instructing students to write essays about the positive impacts of the treaty.[128] The move earned the UAE praise from the Institute for Monitoring Peace and Tolerance in School Education (IMPACT-se), an Israeli nonprofit organization that monitors content critical of Israel in educational curricula.[129] The organization had previously come under fire by academics, including Nathan J. Brown, professor of political science at George Washington University, for making misleading claims of antisemitism in Palestinian textbooks.[130] For its part, Bahrain also took steps to censor private-school textbooks, including by prohibiting content deemed critical of Israel, or content that referenced collective Arab action against it.[131]

Next, the UAE announced its plans to include Holocaust education in its school curriculums, becoming the first Arab state to do so

and earning further praise from Western officials, including Deborah Lipstadt, the U.S. special envoy to monitor antisemitism, who commended the UAE for the initiative and noted that she "expected other countries to follow suit soon."[132] The UAE publicized other initiatives to memorialize the Holocaust, including the launch of a Holocaust memorial exhibition at the privately owned Crossroads of Civilization Museum, with a section dedicated to Arabs and Muslims who had assisted Jews in fleeing the genocide. Commenting on the initiative, Peter Fischer, Germany's ambassador to the UAE, noted: "I congratulate the UAE for its policy of tolerance. The way of intolerance is not the right way. It will lead to great suffering, even to catastrophe. Take it from a German."[133] Days later the American Jewish Committee, a pro-Israel advocacy group, announced its plans to open an office in the UAE, its first in the Arab region, with the UAE's minister of foreign affairs noting that it would help promote dialogue.[134]

The UAE's continued outreach efforts to Jewish and Israeli institutions also earned it praise from Israel's leaders. In January 2022 President Isaac Herzog traveled to the country for a meeting with Mohammed bin Zayed, describing him as a "bold and amazing" leader, and noting that he was someone from whom he "drew immense inspiration."[135] In an interview, the Israeli ambassador to the UAE reiterated the sentiment, expressing his admiration for the UAE's tolerant approach and its ability to "get things done," noting that it was something Israel might learn from.[136]

LEARNING FROM ISRAEL

Bahrain and the UAE's tolerance drive would come to resemble the *hasbara* strategies that Israel uses to cultivate its image as a liberal haven in a violent neighborhood, or a "villa in the jungle."[137] Central

to Israel's messaging are its claims to be the region's only democracy and advance the rights of two groups especially: women and LGBTQ+ communities, who have long faced discrimination in the Middle East. Israel's critics have pointed to these efforts as part of propaganda strategies to "pink-wash" and "rainbow-wash" its history of occupation and settler-colonialism, and its continuing imposition of a system of apartheid against the Palestinians.[138]

Activists note that Israel, while claiming to act as a liberal democracy, uses antiterrorism legislation to target Palestinian civil society organizations and silence the groups working to pursue accountability for its actions.[139] In 2021 Israel raided the offices of six Palestinian NGOs and ordered their closure, accusing them of harboring connections to terrorism.[140] The groups in question included Al-Haq, a human rights organization that had previously petitioned the International Criminal Court to investigate Israel's alleged practice of apartheid in the occupied territories, and Addameer Prisoner Support and Human Rights Association, which advocates against Israel's use of administrative detention to hold prisoners in indefinite detention without charge or trial. Another organization subject to the designation was the Union of Palestinian Women Committees, a feminist collective established in 1980 that documents Israeli practices that specifically harm women.[141] Israel's targeting of these organizations is made possible by the Combatting Terrorism Law No. 5776 of 2016, which grants authorities the right to proscribe virtually any organization as a terrorist group and shutter its activities.[142]

Activists further allege that Israel regularly puts a spotlight on its female soldiers to obscure the brutality of its occupation. In 2015 the Israel Defense Forces published profiles of several female soldiers and celebrated their role in "securing the volatile city of Nablus," a West Bank city that it illegally occupies through military force.[143] And while the IDF regularly lights up its headquarters in pink to coincide with Breast Cancer Awareness Month, the same institution

also systematically prevents Palestinian women and children from accessing healthcare within its borders, often with fatal consequences. In April 2022 media sources carried news of the death of nineteen-month-old infant Fatima al-Masri, after her parents waited for more than five months for Israel to issue a travel permit to allow her to leave Gaza to treat a heart condition.[144] Earlier studies from the United Nations Population Fund found that one-fifth of pregnant women in Gaza and the West Bank could not receive prenatal care due to the difficult of traveling through Israeli checkpoints.[145] By March 2024, Israel's bombardment of Gaza would kill at least thirteen thousand children and leave 180 women unable to give birth in safe conditions every day, without anesthetic or painkillers.

Israel's claims to empower LGBTQ+ communities have also come under fire. As Tel Aviv champions its role as the only place in the Middle East to host a public gay pride parade, it actively makes life more difficult for queer Palestinians.[146] Shiri Eisner, an Israeli activist, noted: "LGBT Palestinians are forced to deal with the occupation, apartheid, and discrimination on a daily basis. LGBT Palestinians from the West Bank are routinely refused refugee status . . . and others are regularly blackmailed by the IDF for information under the threat of outing them to their communities, and that's just the tip of the iceberg." A Toronto-based group, Queers Against Israeli Apartheid (QuAIA), describes the aim of the strategy as intended to "transform public perceptions of Israel from an Apartheid settler state to a harmless, liberal, gay-friendly playground, by juxtaposing this false image with a portrayal of Palestinian and Arab societies as backwards, repressive, and intolerant."[147]

By 2023, Israel appeared to be drawing inspiration from the UAE with its establishment of a new Ministry for Public Diplomacy, at a cost of $2.35 million. Although short-lived, the new entity worked to highlight Israel's role as a champion of liberal values. A day after its launch, the new minister of public diplomacy, Galit Distal Atbaryan,

told media sources that she planned to launch a ministerial campaign "to explain to the global community that there is no occupation." "We have not occupied any territory, there is no occupation," she told Israel Radio.[148] While the Gulf states and Israel advanced their symbiotic reputational management strategies, their critics also echoed convergent messages, in opposition to the agreements in 2020 that had brought the two sides closer together.

6

PEACE AND ITS DISCONTENTS

The Abraham Accords triggered a wave of protests and petitions across the Gulf states, especially in Bahrain. Opposition to the agreements emerged from two other sources: the Palestinians themselves, who accused the Arab states of abandonment, and left-wing Israelis, who saw the accords as a dangerous endorsement of Netanyahu's plans to entrench a permanent occupation of the Palestinian territories. Among most Israelis, however, there was little to oppose when it came to an agreement that offered them a cost-free peace with the Arab states. Their enthusiasm for normalization was shared by a minority of elite, English-speaking Gulf citizens, some of whom would become the faces of the new government policy. Yet Israel's bombardment of Gaza in 2021—and its near-total destruction of the territory in 2023—would act as turning points, hardening public attitudes toward Israel in the Gulf.

PREEMPTING DISSENT

In the months leading up to normalization, Bahrain's government enacted new regulations penalizing criticism of state policy, adding to a growing body of legislation passed since 2011 to curb dissent. In

May 2019 Bahraini mobile phone users received an SMS message from Bahrain's Ministry of Interior warning that "those who follow inciting accounts on social media that promote sedition, and circulate their posts, will be held legally accountable."[1] Since the Arab Spring, the most prominent opposition accounts—run by activists in Bahrain and in exile—garnered hundreds of thousands of followers, topping the numbers accumulated by most state officials and its news agency. Social media platforms had provided activists with room to speak freely and the organizational capacity to plan protests on the ground. An anonymous user responded to the ministry online, pointing out that it had not even clarified which accounts people were not allowed to follow.[2]

The warning appeared aimed at least partly at quelling a growing backlash against Bahrain's public outreach to Israel, which had grown more visible in past months. In April 2019 a campaign organized by online activists had forced a thirty-member Israeli delegation to cancel its plans to attend a government-organized entrepreneurship conference in Manama.[3] Beginning on Twitter, the campaign garnered support from several members of parliament before escalating into street protests and forcing the cancellation.

By May 2020 Bahrain's government appeared to be moving toward criminalizing pro-Palestinian activism in its entirety. That month, authorities shuttered an online discussion about Bahrain's growing ties with Israel, organized by the Bahrain Democratic Youth Society, a reformist organization. Within minutes of the event's launch, the organizers reported that they received a telephone call from a security agency demanding they terminate the live-streamed conversation, "without discussion."[4] The panel had brought together activists from across the Gulf states, including a Saudi researcher, an Omani writer, a Kuwaiti academic, and two Bahraini journalists. Ibrahim Kamaleddin, president of the Bahrain chapter of the Palestinian-led Boycott, Divestment, Sanctions (BDS) movement

and an organizer of the event, reported that authorities told him that the organizers had not obtained a requisite permit for the event, even though the society had hosted multiple discussions on the topic of the BDS movement without objection from the government.

In July 2020 Bahrain's government issued a new series of vaguely worded prohibitions, this time preventing public-sector employees from "criticizing government policy and decisions by any means" or publishing personal opinions that "foster discord in society" or "affect national unity." Disciplinary actions for the new offenses ranged from salary cuts to outright dismissal in cases of multiple transgressions.[5] In September 2020 the head of Bahrain's highest court established similar restrictions on judicial employees, prohibiting them from criticizing government policy or expressing opinions liable to "harm national unity."[6] The new restrictions sparked objection from Freedom House, which would go on to award Bahrain a paltry 12 out of 100 in its Global Freedom Score that year.[7]

THE NEIGHBORHOOD RESPONDS

When President Trump announced the first normalization agreement between Israel and the UAE, the Gulf Cooperation Council states issued mixed reactions in response. In a sign of things to come, Bahrain became the first Arab state to congratulate the UAE, praising it for taking a "historic step towards lasting regional peace."[8] Oman issued a similar statement of congratulations, prompting speculation that it may be next in line.[9] Other Gulf Arab states were more cautious in their reactions, balancing between their continued commitment to Saudi Arabia's Arab Peace Initiative as well as the Palestinians and a desire not to antagonize the UAE for breaking from their joint consensus. In Riyadh, Saudi Arabia's foreign minister, Prince Faisal bin Farhan, waited several days before eventually

issuing a statement, noting that he "cautiously welcomed" the agreement. Bin Farhan also reiterated Saudi Arabia's continued commitment to its Arab Peace Initiative, adding that his country was open to establishing similar relations, on condition of a peace agreement between Israel and the Palestinians.[10] Kuwait more forcefully rejected the possibility of normalization. "We will be the last to normalize," a Kuwaiti official declared, adding that "only what the Palestinians accept will be acceptable to Kuwait."[11] Embroiled in its continued fallout with the three Gulf states, Qatar's foreign minister, Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdulrahman Al-Thani, issued a politely worded statement describing the move as a "sovereign decision" in which Doha did not seek to interfere and adding diplomatically that the maintenance of a united Arab front would have been preferable for the Palestinians.[12]

CIVIC MOBILIZATION IN THE GULF

Before Bahrain's government normalized its relations with Israel, civic groups mobilized to condemn the UAE's decision. For decades, opposition toward Israel marked a rare point of unity among Bahrain's divided civil society. With strict COVID-19 restrictions limiting prospects for street protests, most expressions of opposition emerged online. A group of twenty-three civic and political groups spearheaded by the Bahrain Democratic Youth Society signed the first petition denouncing the move, calling on the UAE to reverse course, in part because the decision did not reflect the will of its people. The statement noted: "We believe that [national decisions should] reflect the principles and values of civil society, and there should be no departure from this regardless of circumstances or external pressures. The people of Bahrain stand firm against normalization of any kind with the Zionist entity that occupies the historic land of Palestine."[13]

Signatories to the petition included leftist groups with a history of mobilizing for reforms, such as the General Federation of Bahrain Trade Unions, an umbrella group of trade unions representing more than forty thousand workers across a range of industries. It also included signatories from smaller civic groups like the Bahrain Sociologists Association and the Bahrain Women's Union. The petition also garnered the support of groups usually aligned with the government, such as the Gathering of National Unity. Established by a Sunni religious scholar as a counterweight to the protests sweeping across the country in 2011, that organization had played a key in mobilizing support for Bahrain's leadership during the Arab Spring, organizing several counterprotests, among other actions. Other usually progovernment signatories included al-Menbar Islamic Society, an organization affiliated with the Muslim Brotherhood. The last time any of these disparate groups had united so visibly was in the year 2000, when Bahrain's Emir announced reforms aimed at transforming the country into a constitutional monarchy. A decade later the unified stance was made even more significant given that Bahrain's political scene remained in a state of hardened polarization and sectarian distrust, reverberations of the government's crackdown on its Arab Spring movement in 2011.

As civic and political groups mobilized to voice their opposition toward the UAE's decision, activists went further, openly mocking Bahraini government officials who praised the developments. When Bahrain's former minister of foreign affairs, Sheikh Khalid bin Ahmed Al-Khalifa, published a tweet congratulating the UAE for taking a bold step in advancing peace, Ebrahim Sharif, a prominent secular opposition leader previously detained for his activism, responded angrily, noting that nobody believed the minister, or his "nonsense."[14] Sharif's statement received hundreds of likes online.

Politicians and civic activists in Kuwait also made statements denouncing the UAE's decision. With its elected parliament and

emboldened opposition movement, Kuwait is one of the Arab world's most politically liberal and democratic states. On August 16, 2020, twenty-nine Kuwaiti civic and political organizations offered a statement of condemnation, describing normalization as a stab in the back of the Palestinians and their cause as a pan-Arab imperative.[15] The petition garnered signatures from groups such as the Kuwait Teachers Union, the Kuwait Lawyers Society, and the Kuwait Union for Democratic Development. A group of thirty-seven Kuwaiti members of parliament—out of fifty total members—issued a separate petition, calling on the Kuwaiti government to reaffirm its stance against normalization.[16] Other petitions followed, including from a coalition of fourteen student groups, such as the Kuwait Students Union, which represents forty thousand students. A group of twenty-five prominent public figures and intellectuals also put forth their own statement, noting that they stood with Kuwait's civil society in its support for the Palestinians, while suggesting that the Kuwaiti government had not gone far enough in condemning the agreement.[17]

In Saudi Arabia, activists and citizens also made their views known on Twitter, with the hashtag "Normalization is Treason" jumping to the number one trending topic on the social media platform.[18] The same hashtag had also reached the number one slot in other states, like Bahrain. Saudi Arabia has the highest number of active Twitter users in the Arab world, with over fourteen million active accounts, among a population of thirty-five million Saudi citizens.[19] Despite efforts by the Saudi government to infiltrate and manipulate public opinion on the platform, Twitter is often described as the kingdom's "public square," or its closest approximation to a public forum. The hashtag condemning normalization would remain a trending topic for several days across the country, with tens of thousands of tweets echoing the message.

Some of Saudi Arabia's most powerful officials also made their opposition known. In December 2020 Prince Turki al-Faisal, former

intelligence chief and a high-level member of the ruling family, addressed an audience at a security summit in Manama, where he described Israel as a "Western, colonizing power" and declared that his country would never normalize relations with it without statehood for the Palestinians.[20] Prince Turki delivered his statement in front of an audience including Israeli foreign minister Gabi Ashkenazi, who called his comments unreflective of the spirit and changes taking place in the Middle East. Some Saudi newspapers, like the state-aligned *al-Sharq al-Awsat*, would take a less impassioned stance that fell more in line with the government's tone, with one of its columnists arguing that the UAE has the right to make its own, sovereign decisions as it sees fit.[21]

Some of the strongest criticisms of the UAE emerged from organizations affiliated with the BDS movement, which has chapter organizations in Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, and Qatar. A statement released by the Qatari chapter was especially notable for calling for a unified Gulf stance against the UAE's decision, despite Doha then being under blockade from three of its neighbors. In the following weeks, a Gulf-wide BDS umbrella group, the Gulf Coalition Against Normalization, held a series of online events, bringing together speakers from all six states and calling for continued boycotts of Israel.[22] Most Gulf states also have their own local antinormalization societies that predate the BDS movement. They include the Bahrain Society Against Normalization with the Zionist Enemy, a society founded in 2002 during the Second Palestinian Intifada, as well as the Bahrain Palestine Support Society and the Youth League for Al-Quds.[23] These groups also issued statements of condemnation and demanded that UAE reverse course.

With strict penalties in place for dissent, national sentiments in the UAE proved more difficult to measure. On the day of the announcement, a prominent Emirati professor of political science with more than 250,000 Twitter followers at the time posted a lone

crying emoji.[24] Analysts described his tweet as the "most he could express by way of dissent," with the academic having previously been briefly detained for airing views softly critical of the government.[25] Days later, a group of six Emirati activists established a new organization, the Emirates Union to Resist Normalization, announcing their plans to raise awareness of the dangers of normalization among UAE nationals and describing normalization as an act of "historic betrayal" by the UAE's rulers, which ought to be reversed. The union's founding members included lawyers and academics, mostly in self-imposed exile, including from prominent Emirati families. As part of their efforts to rally public sentiments against the decision, they issued a petition—the Palestine Charter—denouncing any form of cooperation with Israel, which they later announced had garnered more than a million signatures from across the Arab world.[26] In explaining the relatively muted response to normalization within the Emirates, the group noted that most Emiratis rejected their government's stance, but the threat of criminal penalties—which included up to ten years' imprisonment—had deterred them from speaking up publicly.[27]

In an article published on the organization's website, one of the union's founding members, Saeed al-Taniji, went beyond moral appeals, pointing to dangers of normalization in jeopardizing the UAE's security interests and noting that it had given Iran a new pretext to interfere in the UAE's affairs, to protect itself from a possible new Israeli presence on its borders.[28] Other founding members, like Hamad al-Shamsi, described normalization as enabled by the UAE's turn toward authoritarianism. A former member of al-Islah, al-Shamsi is one of dozens of Emiratis previously sentenced, in his case in absentia, to fifteen years in prison in 2013 on national security-related charges.[29] From exile, he cofounded the Emirates Detainees Advocacy Centre in 2021 to raise awareness of the plight of prisoners of conscience held in the UAE's prisons. Remarking on the Abraham

Accords, he noted: "The Emirati normalization with the Zionist entity would not have been possible without Abu Dhabi first shackling its society with laws that criminalize freedom of speech, and treat dissent as a breach of security. We have reached a point where our society is not even able to express its condemnation of this betrayal."[30] By late 2022 the UAE's cabinet included al-Shamsi, along with the other cofounders of the union, on a national terrorism list, describing them as a threat to national security.[31]

Al-Shamsi's claim that most Emiratis opposed normalization appeared congruent with polling data, including a survey carried out by the Washington Institute for Near East Policy in July 2020, on the eve of normalization, which found that 80 percent of Emirati respondents disagreed with the statement "people who want to have business or sports contacts with Israelis should be allowed to do so."[32] The poll appeared to situate Emiratis firmly within the contours of Arab public opinion, rather than outside it, with survey data for 2019–2020 released by the Arab Opinion Index (a survey of 28,300 people across thirteen Arab states) revealing that just 6 percent of polled Saudi nationals and 12 percent of polled Kuwaitis and Qataris supported normalization, and the survey organizers concluding that "the vast majority of Arabs oppose normalization, and express a high degree of support for Palestinian statehood and rights."[33]

OPPOSITION IN BAHRAIN

On September 11, 2020, Bahrain announced its plans to establish diplomatic relations with Israel. This time, there would be no mention of the Palestinians, or stopping annexation. Instead, Bahrain's government described the decision as a bid to increase regional stability and advance peace. With an array of laws in place penalizing criticism of the government's policies and COVID-19 regulations

restricting public gatherings, Bahrainis would find almost no permissible avenues for mobilizing against the accords. Still, activists defied the government's orders by organizing nightly protests in lower- and middle-income villages across the country, where they could evade detection by security forces. Footage of the protests showed demonstrators marching in the dark, chanting "no to normalization" and "normalization is a betrayal," with both slogans also emerging as trending topics on Twitter in subsequent weeks.[34]

Civil society groups and religious figures in Manama continued issuing petitions, denouncing their government's decision to normalize. In September 2020 a group of 143 Sunni and Shi'a clerics issued a joint statement of condemnation, noting that they "wholly rejected any normalization with the Zionist entity." The clerics reiterated their solidarity with the Palestinians and described Jerusalem as an Islamic city, which should not be divided.[35] Next, a group of eight political societies from pro- and antigovernment leanings came together in condemning normalization. They included two groups that usually remained on opposite sides of the political spectrum: the dissolved Shi'a Islamist party Al-Wefaq and the Sunni Islamist al-Menbar Islamic Society, the group associated with the Muslim Brotherhood.[36] Another show of unity emerged with the formation of the Bahrain National Initiative Against Normalization in 2021, an umbrella organization made up of twenty-four political societies—mostly from opposition groups but also including one Salafist Sunni Islamic organization usually aligned with the government—to resist the government's decision. In May 2021 the group demanded the immediate expulsion of the Israeli ambassador and called on all Arab states to cancel their normalization agreements with Israel.[37]

Outside Bahrain, opposition figures in exile rallied against the announcement, drawing links between injustices facing Bahrainis at home and Israel's mistreatment of the Palestinians. A prominent activist, Maryam al-Khawaja, noted: "I see a lot of [people] in

Bahrain writing they're ashamed to be Bahraini. I'll never be ashamed to be Bahraini. I'm proud of the people who fight injustice locally and have always stood with justice in Palestine. Bahrain is its people, the regimes only represent themselves."[38] A separate statement released by Al-Wefaq National Islamic Society framed its opposition in religious terms, declaring: "At the moment of treason and when [the leaders] sign on the conspiracy against al-Quds [Jerusalem] and Palestine, we shout God is Great, God is Great."[39] At a Shi'a commemoration marking the death of Imam Hussain held in July 2023, a group of Shi'a religious figures could be seen walking over a photo of the Israeli flag, continuing to protest their government's ties with Israel.[40]

SUPPORTERS OF THE ACCORDS

The Abraham Accords are not without their supporters in the Gulf. The loudest champions of the agreements are mostly from Western-educated, upper-class backgrounds and typically articulate their support in English, reflecting a more elite social status.

When news of normalization broke, a Saudi-born public relations specialist, Loay Al-Shareef, took to Twitter to defend the decision, noting that "revolutionary Iran and Erdogan's Turkey have killed more Arabs and incurred more devastation in the region than Israel ever has." He also dismissed the Palestinian cause as passé, citing another commentator who noted that "the Israeli-Palestinian issue is now marginal compared to what it used to be before 2011, when it used to occupy center stage. It has been overshadowed by other issues such as the war in Syria and the conflict with Iran."[41]

Several Emirati social media personalities expressed their jubilation at the announcement. They included Hassan Sajwani, who tweeted: "Finally we, Emiratis, will be able to pray at al-Aqsa

Mosque." His message included a photo of a golden-domed structure. Palestinians were quick to correct the influencer: he had posted a photo of the Dome of the Rock, a different monument.[42]

Over time, proponents of the accords amplified the official narrative, equating normalization with an embrace of the Jewish faith, and dismissing the Arab-Israeli conflict as the product of hateful and irrational beliefs prevalent among Muslims. The self-orientalizing rhetoric enabled these players to portray themselves—and state leaders from the normalizing countries—as forward-thinking and above the hateful instincts of the masses. It would also enable them to gain media publicity and move closer to centers of power: at home, in Israel, and in the West. Weeks after his initial statements on Twitter, a fawning profile of Loay Al-Shareef appeared on the pages of *Jewish Insider*, a U.S. news source, praising him as part of a new generation of moderate and educated Arab Zionists. "It took courage to leave the herd," he told the publication emphatically. "You cannot blame people for being taught for seventy years, hatred towards Jews and Israel."[43] Over time, Al-Shareef would become involved in several of the UAE's outreach programs, allowing him to brush shoulders with heads of prominent think tanks, diplomats, and ambassadors.[44]

In Bahrain, a similar demographic amplified the message of support. Twenty-year-old university student Yousif Mohammed, upon returning from a trip to Israel, told media sources: "I faced a bit of pressure and criticism online probably due to being one of the first Bahrainis to visit Israel, but I think it's expected that people need some time to open their minds. Ignorance can sometimes hinder us."[45] Another young Bahraini entrepreneur stated: "It's amazing news. This brings us so much opportunity."[46]

Institutional initiatives also emerged, bringing together Arab and Israeli supporters of the agreements. In the weeks after the accords were signed, Israeli and American donors pledged funding for a new

organization to strengthen people-to-people ties. Sharaka, which means unity in Arabic, has led a series of initiatives bringing Arab youth to Israel and Israelis to the Gulf states. Participants in the initiative gained an audience with Israel's most influential leaders, including Presidents Reuven Rivlin and Isaac Herzog, Minister of Foreign Affairs Gabi Ashkenazi, as well as Knesset members.[47] In the Gulf, the organization also put together numerous events to commemorate the Holocaust.[48] Writing in the *Times of Israel* following her visit to the site of the Auschwitz concentration camp, the Bahraini director of Gulf affairs at Sharaka, Fatima al-Harbi, echoed the government's narrative by noting that the accords set in motion an "encouraging trend of tolerance across the Arab world."[49]

By 2023, Talal al-Zain, the former chief executive of Bahrain's sovereign wealth fund Mumtalakat, would become a target for criticism after taking up a leadership role with an Israeli firm that brings Israeli technology to the Middle East.[50] His move reinforced the general perception in Bahrain that supporters of the accords were representatives of the elite business community most able to profit from the new ties with Israel, as well as Westernized youth who had not grown up with much attachment to the Palestinian cause.

Despite civic opposition to the accords across the Gulf states, the agreement appeared to create an initial opening. As noted earlier, polling data from the Washington Institute for Near East Policy on the eve of the accords offered a benchmark, placing support for business and sporting ties at 20 percent in the UAE, higher than most other Arab states. The accords would push these numbers higher, with data from the same organization taken on November 2020 showing that 45 percent of Bahrainis and 51 percent of Emiratis held positive views of the agreement. But by May 2022, one year after Israel's bombardment of Gaza, another survey from the Washington Institute for Near East Policy would reveal that the percentage of citizens who viewed the accords favorably in Saudi Arabia, Bahrain, and the

UAE had dropped, reaching just 20 percent in Bahrain and just over 30 percent in the UAE. The same poll would also note a "counter-current" of willingness among Gulf citizens to tolerate economic and social ties with Israel, indicating that many citizens had come to begrudgingly accept the inevitability of a new reality with which they might not agree. Still, tourism figures showed a continued trepidation by Gulf citizens to embrace normalization. Although half a million Israelis flocked to the UAE in the first two years since the establishment of channels, a mere 1,400 Emiratis visited Israel in the year after it lifted COVID-19 travel restrictions. In Bahrain the numbers would be even smaller, with Israel's Ministry of Tourism describing the figures as "too small" to reference. Israel's decimation of Gaza in 2023 would push perceptions of Israel to an all-time low, undoing any progress made since 2020 and driving another wave of protests, along with mass boycotts of corporations with ties to Israel.

AN OUTCRY FROM THE PALESTINIANS

For the Palestinians, Gulf normalization marked nothing short of a historic betrayal, for fracturing Arab unity in support of their plight and setting off a cascade of other normalization deals that drew in Morocco and Sudan. The turn toward Israel appeared entirely unwarranted: unlike Egypt and Jordan, neither the UAE nor Bahrain had been in a state of conflict with Israel, nor did they have any lost territory to recuperate. In fact, the Gulf's oil resources had enabled them to act as vital financiers of Palestinian resistance and relief efforts over the years and exert diplomatic pressure on the United States to act as a more neutral peace broker. And while Jordan and Egypt had made the difficult but pragmatic decision to establish relations with Israel, their peace treaties were a far cry from the cultural embrace of Israel championed by Abu Dhabi and Manama. By shattering a once

immovable tenant of Arab diplomacy, the two states had cost the Palestinians one of their most important bargaining chips with Israel, at a time when Trump's endorsement of Israel's expanding occupation appeared to most urgently warrant a united Arab front.[51]

Initial frustration from the Palestinians first erupted over the wording of a joint communiqué issued by the United States, the UAE, and Israel outlining the terms of their agreement. The English-language version of the document detailed Israel's plans to "suspend annexation," but the Arabic-language translation described annexation as having been more permanently "stopped."[52] The divergence in the two texts prompted anger from senior Palestinian officials, including Hanan Ashrawi, the official spokesperson of the Palestinian delegation during the Madrid Peace Conference of 1991, who accused the UAE of deception. "The Arabic translation is a way of misleading Arab public opinion by saying they have succeeded in stopping annexation when actually they suspended it," she declared.[53] Jamal al-Musharakh, the chief of policy planning and international cooperation at the UAE Ministry of Foreign Affairs, stepped in, clarifying that the UAE had obtained guarantees from Israel to "halt" annexation as a precondition to normalization, calling the discrepancy a mere translation issue. "If anyone can think of a better synonym than 'eqaf' (stopping) for 'suspending' then please let me know," he told reporters. Friedman jumped in next to defend Netanyahu, adding: "Suspend, by definition, means a temporary halt. It's off the table now, but it's not off the table permanently."[54]

Growing frustration among the Palestinians soon brewed into public hostility. In an interview with a French magazine published in October 2020, Palestinian ambassador to France Salman El Herfi described the UAE and Bahrain as "more Israeli than Israel," and Mohammed bin Zayed as a "little dictator." Al Herfi went on to describe Abu Dhabi's and Manama's decisions as lacking in popular legitimacy and unreflective of Arab sentiments, adding: "With all due

respect, how many Emiratis are there in the world, 800 thousand? And Bahrain, 500 thousand? There are 340 million Arabs." Al Herfi's remarks triggered a response from Anwar Gargash, the UAE's minister of state for foreign affairs, who stated that his country had "grown accustomed to the lack of loyalty and the ingratitude" from the Palestinians. Earlier, the UAE's assistant minister for cultural and public diplomacy, Omar Saif Ghobash, had also suggested that the Palestinians needed to "want to help themselves."[55] Hostile exchanges between Palestinian and Emirati diplomats—and growing clarity on Netanyahu's position—soon brought an end to attempts by UAE officials to frame the plan as intended to halt annexation.

Palestinian anger toward the agreements boiled over into a series of protests. As officials from the United States, Israel, the UAE, and Bahrain came together to sign the Abraham Accords on September 15, 2020, hundreds of Palestinians in Ramallah, Gaza, Nablus, and Hebron took to the streets to denounce the agreements. A protester told *Al Jazeera*: "At a time where companies in the West are boycotting Israel, two Arab countries are about to make trade agreements with it. We call on them to backtrack from the agreement and go back to being supportive of the Palestinians in the same way we've always known them to be."[56] That day, Palestinian president Mahmoud Abbas issued a rebuke of the agreements, noting: "The Palestinian leadership emphasizes that the main conflict is not between the states that signed the agreement with Israel, but with the Palestinian people who are suffering under occupation," adding that the agreements could not possibly bring about peace as long as occupation continued. To signal its dissatisfaction, Hamas fired two rockets from the Gaza Strip into Israel, to coincide with the timing of the signing ceremony.[57]

Outside the Palestinian territories, Rashid Khalidi, one of the most celebrated Palestinian intellectuals and professor of modern Arab studies at Columbia University, provided context on the interests

driving the agreements and their implications for the Palestinians. In a piece titled "What's Wrong with Peace?," published by Egyptian outlet *Mada Masr*, he noted:

> The deal is an extension of a longstanding U.S. policy to use individual deals between Israel and the Arab countries and the "economic peace" model long touted by Netanyahu to further weaken and isolate the Palestinians and dampen pan-Arabism. Far from helping to create peace, this agreement exacerbates the real battle between Arabs and Israelis, the original one, the one over Palestine, by strengthening the oppressor, while enabling Netanyahu to continue to evade real peace while expanding colonization and further entrenching military occupation.
>
> Another overlooked fact is that this is not an agreement between Israel and "the Arabs." It is an agreement between Israel, a settler colonial apartheid state, and the absolute ruler of a monarchy that enjoys neither popular legitimacy nor the consent of the governed. . . . Arab public opinion, brutally repressed by these and other undemocratic regimes across the region (many of them propped up by massive infusions of Saudi and Emirati cash), is in fact supportive of the Palestinian liberation struggle, and highly critical of Israel, as is shown by regular public opinion surveys.
>
> Both parties to this agreement and its midwife, the Trump administration, are staunch opponents of democracy in the Arab world, since the spread of democratic governance would not only bring down these absolute monarchies from which U.S. arms and oil corporations benefit so much, but also bring Arab governments into line with their peoples' support for the Palestinians. Out of their desire to preserve their untrammeled power and their ill-gotten gains stolen from their own peoples, the kleptocracies of the Gulf naturally fight democratic trends and support dictatorships all over the Arab world.[58]

Other Arab intellectuals adopted a similar argument, describing the agreements as postideological and marking the collapse of the shared political positions that had united Arab leaders in the past.[59]

In Ramallah, the Palestinian Authority began exercising its diplomatic leverage to convince Arab leaders to isolate the UAE and Bahrain for their decisions. Its first step was to recall ambassadors from both states.[60] Next, it sponsored an Arab League resolution calling for the twenty-two-member body to hold an emergency summit and condemn the Abraham Accords as a contravention of the 2002 Arab Peace Initiative, which the organization had officially endorsed.[61] Although they maintained their formal commitment to the initiative, the member states of the Arab League rejected the Palestinian proposal and largely refused to carry out an emergency discussion. Their decision signaled the relative strength of the UAE and its allies within the Arab world, even as they left the joint Arab policy toward the Palestinians in pieces. It also signaled the contemporary ineffectiveness of the body that had been established at the height of the era of Arab nationalism with the dual objectives of promoting Arab unity and the liberation of Palestine.

Unable to generate diplomatic accountability for the decisions made by the UAE and Bahrain, the Palestinians would at last receive what appeared to be good news with the election of Joe Biden to the U.S. presidency in November 2020. Biden promised to undo some of the most damaging Trump-era policies toward them, including by scrapping Trump's Peace to Prosperity plan and restoring both U.S. aid to UNRWA and bilateral aid to the Palestinian Authority. The Palestinian Authority quietly reinstated its ambassadors to the UAE and Bahrain.[62] Still, the Palestinians found themselves navigating a new regional landscape in which Arab leaders no longer elevated their cause to the forefront of their foreign policies, at a time when Israel accelerated its occupation over Palestinian lands in the West Bank and maintained its blockade on Gaza. While Biden

might have temporarily loosened some of the chokeholds, Palestinian intellectuals and activists began reiterating their view that liberation would not come because of the support of the unelected Arab leaders, but rather in spite of its absence.[63]

THE VIEW FROM ISRAEL

As Israel's longest-serving prime minister, Benjamin Netanyahu appeared politically unvanquishable. Despite his indictment on corruption charges and his deepening unpopularity among the Israeli electorate, the prime minister had miraculously clung to power for over a decade, strengthening Israel's free-market economy and its military, and entrenching the occupation as a permanent feature of Israeli life. Across his multiple terms in power, from 1996 to 1999 and again from 2009 to 2021, Netanyahu oversaw a massive spike in settlement construction, a collapse in the viability of a two-state solution, and the marginalization of left-wing voices within Israel that continued to call for an end to the occupation. His rejection of diplomacy with the Palestinians and vocal opposition to the JCPOA also brought him closer to hard-line Republican figures in the United States.[64]

For the Israeli electorate, the enactment of the Abraham Accords appeared to validate Netanyahu's most outrageous claims. Over the course of mere months, four Arab states had established diplomatic ties with Israel, effectively ending its regional isolation and fracturing what remained of a united Arab front. Rather than costing Israel any of the territory it had captured from the Arabs, the normalization agreements gave credence to Netanyahu's claims that Israel did not have to choose between peace with its neighbors and the return of land to the Palestinians. For most Israelis, there was nothing not to celebrate. Remarking on the turn of events, Eran Etzion, the

former deputy head of Israel's National Security Council at the Prime Minister's Office, asked rhetorically: "Which Israeli-Jewish political actor can say 'no' to a cost-free peace in the Middle East?"[65] The very feature of the accords most lamentable to the Palestinians—their total exclusion from the agreements—was in fact one of the most celebrated aspects of the deal for Netanyahu, his supporters, and many within Israel. A senior diplomatic correspondent for *Israel Hayom*, the country's most widely distributed newspaper, wrote:

> One of the things that made the Abraham Accords [possible] is the fact that neither Israel nor the Arab states that were part of the process wanted to deal with the Palestinian issue this time around, but to go to the interests of both sides. That is what created the opportunity to push this forward. Once you deal with the Palestinian issue, which you have no solution for in Gaza, or Judea and Samaria, once you deal with that problem that you have no solution for, that might stop the process.

He continued: "There is a consensus in Israel, everyone wants this peace. We had 200,000 Israeli tourists who went to visit the UAE just during the last year, during a COVID year. The numbers are unbelievable. The peace is not like other agreements in the past. There is a consensus, everyone in Israel supports it—right and left—are happy with it, and want it to go forward."[66]

Other Israelis analysts would remark on the role of the agreements in bringing Israel closer to a part of the Arab world that had never been at the forefront of the country's political consciousness. In an interview, an Israeli professor of political science observed: "When we thought about the Arabs, our focus was mainly on neighboring countries, like Jordan, Egypt, or Syria. That's what Israelis usually think about, when we talk about the Arabs, or peace. Of course, the Gulf countries are part of the Arab world but from the perspective

of Israel, they have not been relevant in the political discourse. For the average Jewish Israeli citizen, these new relations with Dubai mean a shopping trip, or a beach vacation. And of course, there is excitement about the possibility of more countries following suit."[67]

With no apparent reason to oppose an agreement that had established new relations with four Arab states at no cost, it would be Israel's ideological and demographic minorities, most notably its Arab Israeli population and leftist and progressive Jewish voices in the country, that articulated any real opposition to the accords. These actors largely echoed criticisms made by Palestinians in the West Bank, Gaza, and the diaspora in condemning normalization for legitimizing a brutal and untenable status quo. As Israel's Knesset voted on the passage of the normalization agreements on October 15, 2020, thirty out of the eighty lawmakers, all of them from the Arab-majority Joint List, voted against the agreement.[68] The night before the vote, An Arab Israeli member of the Knesset, Sami Abu Shehada, penned an editorial in the *Guardian* outlining the views of the Joint List, noting:

> This week, I was given copies of the agreement, which I read in the three languages [Arabic, Hebrew, and English] and figured out a few things. First of all, those who wrote it in different languages tailored it to their audiences. While in English and Hebrew, they repeated the word "normalization" several times, that term is not even mentioned in Arabic. In Arabic, it is portrayed as a business deal that merely establishes diplomatic relations, and not a peace agreement. The word "annexation" [of Palestinian territory] is not even mentioned.

He continued:

> This deal cannot be taken out of context of the US presidential campaign and President Trump's need for a success story after many

failures. The recognition of illegal settlements as part of Israel will not change international law. Similarly, cutting aid to Palestinian hospitals will not force Palestinians to accept Israeli domination. As mentioned in its preamble, this agreement is based on the Trump plan that normalizes colonialism, fully endorses the rightwing Zionist narrative, and kills the prospect of an independent state of Palestine. It also threatens the status of Jerusalem's holy sites and treats Palestinians as strangers in their homeland. The UAE, an Arab country that claims to care about Palestine should reject this framework, as most of the international community has done.

Why does Israel talk about co-existence with a country thousands of kilometers away? At the same time, within its borders, 100,000 Arab citizens [from Palestinian Bedouin communities] live in villages older than the state of Israel itself, yet are unrecognized and lack access to essential services such as water and electricity? Discrimination and racism against Arab-Palestinian citizens of Israel, an indigenous population that makes up over 20% of the country's population, is present in every aspect of life. More than 50 laws discriminate against non-Jewish citizens. Israel's trains do not stop in a single Arab city. . . . Just look at the large Israeli delegation that went to the UAE in August: not a single non-Jewish official was included. For the UAE, the agreement is in effect a generous donation to Trump's election campaign, while at the same time giving Abu Dhabi more access to weapons and intelligence. A simple review of Israeli media will show how security-related companies are the most excited about this deal.[69]

Abu Shehada delivered further criticism on *Al Jazeera*'s Arabic channel, adding: "It is the Israeli weapons-manufacturing companies, cyber-security companies, and security experts who are celebrating this deal the most. If this is the kind of peace that Israel offers to the Arab world, more wars and more arms, this is not the kind of peace that we want."[70] For Arab citizens of Israel like Abu Shehada, labeling

the Abraham Accords as a peace agreement added insult to injury, especially in the wake of Israel's continued occupation of Palestinian lands and its treatment of Palestinians as second-class citizens.

Leftist voices in Israel echoed similar opposition to the agreement. They included Aviv Tatarsky, a researcher at Ir Amin, a Jerusalem-based NGO that works to establish a more equitable future for the city, including by assisting East Jerusalem Palestinians fight against legally sanctioned home demolitions. Writing for the Regional Thinking Forum, a liberal platform, Tatarsky noted that the accords served to delay and deepen the inevitable pain of ending occupation. He wrote:

> Netanyahu's most consistent policy in leading Israel, is his desire to grow Israel's power, not expand peace. The Accords are an expression of Israel's strength. The UAE does not need "peace" with Israel, the opposite is true. It needs Israel's power—against Iran, against opposition groups, it needs technological power, military power, the power to influence American policy. Israel is stronger than ever and more players in the Arab world believe they need its strength. The price that the UAE pays for access to this power is simply normalization.
>
> As Israelis, it is obvious to us that the strengthening of Israel is an achievement. However, Israel is so strong today that its power no longer benefits its citizens, but harms and endangers them. Even in a world where the powerful use all the power at their disposal to set the rules, seven million Jews cannot dictate the rules of the game to seven million Palestinians forever. The Palestinians may give up the quest for independence, but not the quest for equality. Jews and Palestinians will not be able to live the same space and maintain an artificial separation between them, certainly when the economic benefits are concentrated on the Israeli side. Israel will have to be strong forever, and determined to oppress the Palestinians forever.

> However strong we may be, and however weak the Palestinians may be, we will never be able to resolve the conflict by dictating terms by force. . . . Whatever the "logical" answer to the power dilemma, Israel's growing power works against it: it brings it closer to the mass deportation of Palestinians, or postpones the inevitable end of the end of the occupation, and causes the price to be paid for it to be much higher than its current price. All this, as mentioned, is when we look at the conflict only from a utilitarian Israeli point of view, and ignore human and moral considerations of the occupation's impact on the lives of the Palestinians.[71]

Other progressive voices within Israel echoed his sentiments, describing the role of the accords in strengthening Netanyahu, and antidemocratic forces across the Middle East, at the expense of the Palestinians. Katie Waxberger, a researcher at the Van Leer Jerusalem Institute, an interdisciplinary research center in Israel, noted: "Netanyahu and the Emirates proved that Israel can normalize its relations with the Arab world without an agreement with the Palestinians or coordination with their leadership. This weakens the initially meager power of the Palestinian Authority, intensifies its helplessness at the regional level and arouses frustration and anger among Palestinians from all walks of life." She continues:

> The deal is particularly relevant for Netanyahu, because it presents him as the only Israeli ruler capable of establishing political agreements with the Gulf states. This illusion of essentiality draws attention away from the growing public protest in Israel against governmental corruption and the ongoing damage to democracy. The cynical but successful use of the word "peace" restores Netanyahu's image among parts of the political center, although it alienates the ideological right from him. Trump also wins points among the political center in the United States and perhaps among Zionist Jews from the center-left.

> The three leaders who spearheaded the agreement share a deep fear of popular movements in the region that they label as extremist, leftist, anarchist or Islamist, depending on the context. The agreement allows for official cooperation, and in coordination with the United States, against popular movements that may harm the autocratic rule in the Emirates. Israel, for its part, has long been assisting the UAE in using surveillance technology to spy on citizens, silence internal criticism and human rights activists, and suppress political opponents.[72]

PROSPECTS FOR UNITY

In the UAE and Bahrain, the turn to Israel would further restrict remaining avenues for activists to promote the development of a mainstream political consciousness. While enduring various levels of domestic repression, the Gulf's civil society had historically rallied in support of the Palestinians. Political activists had also counted on their cause to cultivate awareness on themes of justice and liberation, as an easy segue to press for more localized demands around the same values. Many of the pro-Palestine organizations established in places like Bahrain, such as its al-Uruba Club, served both purposes. Established as a social club to promote values of Arab unity and nationalism in the late 1950s, it regularly hosts discussions on Palestinian rights, while also providing a platform for reformists to discuss the need for transparency and reform in Bahrain itself. In 2022 it welcomed a former government minister who connected the Abraham Accords to an absence of democratic accountability in the state, asking: "Why don't they consult us on these decisions? No decision that is this important should be allowed to proceed without consultation."[73]

The common cause to end occupation would prompt liberal thinkers in Israel to speculate whether activists from the Gulf states and Israel might come together more closely, around a shared drive for human rights, equality, and democracy.[74] But prospects for that kind of a unified movement would be precluded by a continued commitment by Gulf civic actors to the BDS movement, as the central framework for pressurizing Israel into ending its occupation. While the regimes in power had come together around their shared visions for a more securitized regional landscape designed to strengthen their standing and guarantee their survival, activists opposing these moves would remain in a state of much greater fragmentation.

CONCLUSION

In March 2018 Saudi Arabia's thirty-two-year-old Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman (MbS) landed in the United States on his first visit to the country since beating out dozens of royal princes to become next in line to the Saudi throne and de facto ruler of the most powerful Arab state. Across a three-week charm offensive, the crown prince traveled to Silicon Valley to discuss technology investments with its top executives, delivered lectures at Ivy League universities, and dined with Hollywood's elite. He also visited President Trump at the White House and stopped in New York for an off-the-record meeting with representatives of Jewish groups. There, he spoke about prospects for Middle East peace and astonished those in attendance by reportedly stating: "In the last several decades, the Palestinian leadership has missed one opportunity after the other, and rejected all the peace proposals it was given. It is about time the Palestinians take the proposals and agree to come to the negotiations table or shut up and stop complaining."[1]

The crown prince went on to state that the Palestinian plight was not a priority for Saudi Arabia or its people, and that the country had "much more important issues to deal with," like confronting Iran. In a conversation with an American journalist, MbS reportedly reiterated his contempt for the Palestinian leadership, appearing to share

the view with the Trump administration that they continued to pose an unjustified burden on the other Arab states.[2] The next indication that MbS might bring his country closer to Israel came in 2020 when he reportedly welcomed Prime Minister Netanyahu to the Saudi city of Neom, the site of a planned futuristic giga-development located on the Red Sea. The secretive meeting allegedly took place just days after Biden's election victory and provided the men with the opportunity to discuss their shared aim of countering Iran, alongside outgoing secretary of state Mike Pompeo. MbS's decisions to allow Israeli aircraft to fly over Saudi airspace and Israeli athletes to compete on Saudi soil prompted further speculation that a change in policy might be on the horizon.[3] By 2023, Egyptian president El-Sisi's approval of the transfer of the Red Sea islands of Tiran and Sanafir to Saudi Arabia—at MbS's request and following Israel's consent—fueled another round of rumors that Riyadh was looking to grow its maritime ties with Israel by positioning itself at the gateway to Israel's southern port of Eilat.[4] Pan-Arab news sources speculated that Saudi Arabia planned to open the islands to Israeli tourists.[5]

By the summer of 2023, the Biden administration began engaging in a diplomatic push to bring Saudi Arabia into the Abraham Accords. In July President Biden dispatched his top Middle East advisors, Jake Sullivan, Brett McGurk, and Secretary of State Antony Blinken, to Riyadh for preliminary talks with Saudi officials on the matter. The advisors were united in seeing Saudi-Israel normalization as their most important regional foreign policy priority. The move held numerous anticipated payoffs, enabling them to deepen an evolving Arab-Israeli regional security architecture, integrate the capabilities of Washington's partner states against Iran (especially in areas of air and missile defense), and confidently delegate a greater share of its regional security burden to them, at a time when the United States looked to prioritize its engagements outside the Middle East. The Trump-era decision to move Israel out of its European zone of

command and into its Central zone of command had already facilitated U.S.-led multilateral coordination between the U.S. Arab partners and Israel through joint military exercises and intelligence-sharing. It had also enabled greater bilateral coordination between the United States and Israel in the states falling under CENTCOM's authority, such as Syria. Drawing Saudi Arabia, the most powerful Arab and Islamic state, into normalization with Israel was the most obvious next step in the progression of this integration. But to Biden's officials, it mattered for other reasons.

Over the past years, evidence of growing ties between Saudi Arabia and China had begun sparking concerns in Washington. In 2022 the two states announced advances in their evolving military relationship, with plans to design and manufacture combat drones in the kingdom. The move formed part of Saudi Arabia's efforts to kick-start its own domestic arms industry, one of the goals articulated in Vision 2030, MbS's ambitious road map for economic development aimed at moving the kingdom away from its dependence on oil and attracting tourism and investments. That year, several democratic lawmakers wrote directly to President Biden to deliver a warning, urging him to address Riyadh's "growing strategic cooperation with China," amid evidence that Saudi Arabia was procuring ballistic missiles from Beijing and seemingly building its own ballistic missile arsenal using Chinese technology.[6]

Policymakers in Washington had long urged the Gulf states not to partner with Beijing. Aside from the rivalry between the two powers, American officials also accused China of using espionage to reverse engineer American military technology for its own advancement. For example, when China launched the Chengdu J-20 Mighty Dragon, its upgraded fifth-generation fighter jet, senior U.S. defense officials like General Kenneth Wilsbach, head of the United States Pacific Air Forces, accused it of copying Lockheed Martin's F-22. "Pretty much most of the technology from that airplane was stolen

from the U.S.," he told an audience.[7] The matter held massive national security implications, shaping Washington's decisions to approve hardware sales to its own partners. The U.S. decision not to approve the sale of F-35 fighter jets to the United Arab Emirates ultimately came down to its refusal to end reliance on Chinese giant Huawei's 5-G technology, which American officials feared could be used to hack into the sensitive operating systems it planned to sell the UAE.

Over the years, the Gulf states had developed their own counterstrategies to deal with this sort of U.S. reticence. As early as 1998, the UAE dangled the possibility of acquiring advanced military jets from France if the United States did not agree to supply it with F-16 jets, the predecessor to the F-35. And when the United States refused to provide the UAE with armed drones, it reportedly acquired them from China. This time, Saudi Arabia would publicize its growing ties to Beijing to achieve another of its objectives: convincing the United States to make lasting security commitments to the kingdom.

In March 2022 Saudi officials stated that the kingdom was considering accepting oil payments from Chinese in renminbi, a move that would threaten the supremacy of the dollar as the world's currency. The following year Beijing brokered the hugely significant reconciliation agreement between Iran and Saudi Arabia, paving the way for the restoration of diplomatic ties between the two sides for the first time since 2016. Although Oman and Iraq had absorbed the greatest share of back-channel diplomacy leading up to the agreement, Saudi Arabia wanted Beijing to claim credit for the move, to use as leverage against the United States. The move had its intended effect, sparking alarm in Washington over what appeared to be Beijing's expanding diplomatic footprint into its strategic backyard.

Saudi Arabia also piled on the pressure, by hinting at a closer turn toward Russia. In July 2022 President Biden traveled to Riyadh to call on MbS to support the United States by increasing its oil production. The move would have stabilized global energy markets in the

wake of Russia's invasion of Ukraine. But the crown prince took the opposite stance, joining hands with Russian president Vladimir Putin to slash oil production at OPEC, driving oil prices upward and adding to domestic pressures facing the Democratic Party during the 2022 midterm elections. Later the UAE and Saudi Arabia announced their plans to join BRICS, the economic bloc uniting Global South players like Russia, China, Brazil, and South Africa. Signs of closer cooperation between Riyadh and America's rivals would have the desired effect, prompting the Biden administration to aggressively court Saudi Arabia and bring it back in line. Biden viewed the expansion of the Abraham Accords as the most obvious route toward meeting this goal, one that served the dual function of supporting Israel's regional integration and fostering a pro-Western regional alliance.

The Saudi-U.S. talks on normalization kicked off as the most far-right government in Israel's history settled into power. By late 2022 Netanyahu had miraculously clawed his way back from political exile, toward a sixth term in office. His resurrection as prime minister rested on what critics in Israel condemned as an unholy bargain with Israel's most extremist political figures. They included Itamar Ben Gvir, a far-right politician previously convicted by an Israeli court of incitement against Arabs and of supporting the Kahanist movement, a Jewish supremacist organization banned by Israel in 1998 and designated as a terror organization by the United States. They also included Bezalel Smotrich, who told Arab Knesset members in 2021 that they were only there by mistake "because Ben Gurion didn't finish the job and [threw] you out in 1948."[8] Both men are also champions of—and residents in—illegal settlements in the occupied West Bank. As Netanyahu's coalition partners in government, Ben Gvir took up the role of minister of national security, placing him front and center in formulating Israel's security policies in the Palestinian territories. Smotrich assumed the position of finance minister. The UAE

officials reportedly warned Netanyahu not bring them into a coalition government, but his decision to ignore their warnings would not alter the course of business.

As discussions with the United States progressed, Saudi Arabia raised several demands as preconditions to normalization. They included the establishment of a NATO-style security treaty that would require Washington to come to its aid in the event of an attack on its territory. The defense pact would require congressional approval and constitute the first mutual defense agreement signed between the United States and a nondemocratic government since 1953.[9] Riyadh also requested authorization to purchase more advanced U.S. weapons, including the Terminal High Altitude Defense (THAAD) antiballistic missile system, which would assist it in defending itself against the kind of medium and long-range missiles possessed by Iran and its partner groups. Another demand was Washington's assistance in the development of a civilian nuclear program, with reported uranium enrichment capabilities. The technology would bring Riyadh within reach of a military-grade nuclear program and surpass the nuclear capabilities possessed by Abu Dhabi.[10] Critics warned that it could also trigger a regional nuclear arms race.

Another core condition from Riyadh remained the establishment of a two-state solution for the Palestinians. Saudi officials publicly reiterated their commitment to the Arab Peace Initiative on multiple occasions, warning that they would not move forward without a viable pathway to a Palestinian state.[11] The United States also raised its own demands, asking the Saudis to establish clear limits on their relationship with Beijing and commit to ending their involvement in Yemen.[12] With their fate appearing to hang in the balance, envoys from the Palestinian Authority traveled to Riyadh in August 2023 to urge Saudi Arabia to maintain its commitments to an independent state, along the internationally recognized borders from 1967.[13] In keeping with his past position, Netanyahu remained opposed to the

possibility of a Palestinian state. Instead, he reportedly backed much flimsier measures aimed at "improving conditions" for the Palestinians, including by offering to issue more work permits for Palestinians to work inside Israel and upgrading infrastructure in the West Bank, a move likely to be at least partly financed by external parties like Saudi Arabia.

While Riyadh's high bar for normalization reflects its status as the most influential Arab and Islamic state—and a grand prize for any Israeli or American government—it also partly reflects an unspoken refusal by its leadership to follow a path spearheaded by the UAE, especially in the context of rising competition between the two sides. In 2023 evidence of growing tensions between the two crown princes began spilling into the open, with MbS notably absent from a GCC summit hosted by Abu Dhabi. He reportedly later told a group of journalists that he had sent the UAE a list of demands (a move reminiscent of events that had transpired after the blockade of Doha) warning that it would face punitive measures if it continued to undermine Saudi Arabia in places like Yemen, where the two states are at odds.[14] MbS's decision to avoid handing Israel an easy path to normalization also appeared at least partly influenced by a deferential nod to his father's views. As founder of the Popular Committee for Assisting the Palestinian Mujadhideen (Freedom Fighters) in 1968, the governor of Riyadh (later, King Salman) began his career supporting Palestinian resistance efforts. To many observers, normalization during King Salman's lifetime would prove a step too far even for the bold crown prince. Nor did it appear likely that MbS wanted to hand that kind of major political victory to Biden, who had embarrassed him on the global stage by calling for his political isolation. But American officials would continue to insist that a deal was imminent.

Without making any commitments, Saudi Arabia began reaping the rewards of entertaining normalization with Israel from a

Western political class committed to upholding Israel's interests. Biden would put the kingdom front and center in his Middle East policy, marking a complete reversal from past promises to turn it into a pariah. Meanwhile, states like Germany would restore their arms sales to the kingdom, which it had suspended in the wake of the Khashoggi killing, citing its cooperative stance on Israel.

OCTOBER 7 AND BEYOND

Hamas's attacks on Gaza and Israel's reprisal plunged the Middle East into its most urgent crisis in decades. On the morning of October 7, 2023, Hamas operatives deployed three thousand rockets into Israel, as its fighters used paragliders to breach the Gaza border and descend on Israeli towns and military checkpoints. In a single day, an estimated 695 Israeli civilians were killed, in addition to 373 soldiers. Another 250 Israelis were taken into Gaza as hostages.[15] The deadly operation triggered Israel's retaliation and its indiscriminate bombardment of civilian infrastructure, including refugee camps, hospitals, churches, mosques, and schools in Gaza, under the pretext of targeting Hamas. Five months into its operations, Israel had killed at least thirty thousand Palestinians, including eleven thousand children, and displaced over three-quarters of the Gaza population. At least seventy-five thousand Palestinians were injured by the strikes, with most unable to receive adequate medical care from the hospitals that had become targets for bombardment and emptied of supplies. With 70 percent of Gaza's population suffering from catastrophic levels of hunger, the United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs warned of an unfolding humanitarian catastrophe unlike anything they had seen in recent memory. In a landmark ruling, the International Court of Justice also found plausible risk that Israel's actions in Gaza could amount to genocide.

With Gaza rendered virtually uninhabitable, Netanyahu continued describing Israel's main goal in the territory as eliminating Hamas, an objective that several of Israel's defense experts described as unrealistic.[16] In February 2024 he set out a postwar plan that proposed establishing Israeli security control over the Palestinian territories and granting the IDF "indefinite freedom" to operate in Gaza. His plan also called for the elimination of UNRWA.[17] Figures like former Israeli prime minister Ehud Olmert accused Netanyahu and his coalition of extremists of seeking to purge the West Bank of its Palestinian inhabitants and annex the Palestinian territories to Israel. Olmert also accused them of seeking a regional war to justify meeting these objectives.[18]

The United States lent its full weight to backing Netanyahu and his war cabinet. Shortly after the Hamas attacks, President Biden traveled to Israel to reassure the prime minister of his support. His administration then exercised veto power over multiple resolutions at the United Nations Security Council calling for a ceasefire and approved an unprecedented support package of $14.3 billion in additional military assistance.[19] As the death toll in Gaza reached eighteen thousand in early December 2023, Biden bypassed congressional review to approve the sale of an additional $106 million in tank ammunition to Israel. While Biden eventually backed calls for a ceasefire, his unwavering military and diplomatic support for Israel handed Netanyahu a carte blanche to act with impunity, even amid mounting evidence of Israeli war crimes in Gaza, including the deliberate targeting of hospitals, and as humanitarian agencies warned of famine in the north of the territory. Throughout the war, the Biden administration continued championing a Saudi-Israel normalization deal, selling the initiative as a pathway to a broader settlement as well as a two-state solution, even as Netanyahu openly rejected the possibility of an independent Palestinian state and showed no appetite for that kind of diplomacy.

Two weeks into Israel's operations, Saudi Arabia announced the suspension of its normalization talks as it embarked on a diplomatic drive to lead Arab efforts to press Israel into enacting a ceasefire, a stance recalling its historic leadership on the Palestinian issue. On November 11, MbS hosted a combined summit of the Arab League and Organization of Islamic Cooperation, which included Iran, and told participants that he "held the occupation authorities responsible for the crimes committed against the Palestinian people."[20] In a joint show of solidarity, leaders present at the summit called for a ceasefire, the entry of humanitarian aid into Gaza, and the revival of talks around a two-state solution as the only viable framework for addressing the conflict. Yet the summit also showcased their differences, with states like Iran and Algeria urging the Arab countries with ties to Israel to end their relationship, and the six states in question refusing to do so. Only Jordan recalled its ambassador in open protest, marking a far cry from the joint oil embargo the Arab states had collectively adopted during the conflict in 1973. Saudi Arabia continued its diplomatic offensive by heading a delegation of Arab and Islamic states to tour the permanent members (P-5) of the Security Council, urging them to support a ceasefire. By early 2024 Riyadh also spearheaded efforts by key Arab actors—including Egypt, Jordan, Qatar, the UAE, and the Palestinian Authority—to press for talks around a two-state solution.

The unanimous calls by the Arab states for a ceasefire reflected a measure of solidarity with the Palestinians but, as pressingly, their fears that a prolonged conflict would trigger a regional conflagration. Evidence of the conflict expanding beyond Gaza's borders emerged early on, when Iranian-backed groups in Syria and Iraq began targeting U.S. forces in both states, in response to events in Gaza.[21] In Lebanon, renewed clashes between Hezbollah and Israel would remain mostly contained within border areas but threatened to engulf the country amid Netanyahu's threats of an invasion. The most

effective reprisals came from the Huthis in Yemen, who stepped up their attacks on dozens of ships crossing the Red Sea, warning that all Israeli ships—and all those headed toward Israel—were targets. By mid-December 2023, shipping giant Maersk announced that it was rerouting its vessels away from the area. In response to the Huthi attacks, the United States established Operation Prosperity Guardian, a multinational operation to protect commercial ships crossing through the Red Sea toward Israel. Bahrain would be the only Arab state to join the naval coalition, with its larger Gulf neighbors opting out of participation to avoid escalating tensions with Tehran or jeopardizing prospects for a long-term solution to the conflict in Yemen. Many Arab states also recognized the inflammatory optics of joining a coalition that worked to protect Israel's economy. But Bahrain's decision to join the coalition signaled the extent of its leadership's commitment to Israel and the United States and its continued willingness to put that commitment on clear display.

Many Arab states also sought a quick end to the conflict, fearing it could trigger internal unrest. Across social media channels, Palestinian journalists took the lead in bringing news of daily atrocities directly to a generation of young Arabs, reinvigorating the Palestinian cause among millions. Their message was amplified by nonstop coverage of the unfolding crisis from traditional media networks, like Al Jazeera. Daily images of dead and injured Palestinian children and decimated neighborhoods triggered growing fury, and the outpouring of tens of thousands of protesters onto the streets in places like Egypt and Jordan, in numbers not seen since the Arab Spring. In Bahrain, the same groups that had led calls against normalization in the past, like the Bahrain Society Against Normalization with the Zionist Enemy, spearheaded weekly Friday protests demanding the government cut its ties with Israel and expel the U.S. Fifth Fleet from the country. Fearing the protests could lead to more sustained civic unrest, Bahrain acted to deter mobilization by rearresting secular

opposition leader Ebrahim Sharif after he criticized Bahrain's decision to join the Red Sea coalition. His arrest served as a reminder to many that normalization rested on the continued suppression of civil society.

The war in Gaza had reinvigorated anti-Israel sentiments. Beyond demonstrations, renewed mass boycotts of corporations accused of supporting Israel would leave popular coffee houses like Starbucks and fast food chains like McDonalds empty across the Arab world. By early December 2023, the coffee giant reported losses of $11 billion in its share price, with the slump linked to the Arab boycott. McDonalds also posted a decline in its profits and its failure to meet its fourth-quarter growth targets across the region. A representative from a major credit card company confirmed that transactions to Starbucks had declined by 50 percent in the UAE and by 90 percent in Kuwait and Qatar in the month of December.[22] This time the boycott also drew in the elite classes that had been most amenable to normalization. When the well-known Italian owner of several high-end restaurants in Bahrain was found to have endorsed pro-Israel content on social media, hundreds of posts circulated calling for a boycott of her businesses. The owners of several restaurants she claimed to have established took legal action to distance themselves from her.[23] Similar calls for a targeted boycott circulated among Emiratis after a French restaurant owner of a popular vegan cafe was found to have posted pro-Israel content.

In the states where protests are prohibited, polling data reaffirmed the hardening of public attitudes toward Israel. A survey of one thousand Saudi nationals released by a Washington, DC, think tank in the weeks after Israel's reprisal found that 96 percent of respondents believed that all Arab states should cut ties with Israel. In the same poll, 40 percent of Saudis expressed "positive attitudes" toward Hamas, compared with just 10 percent in the preceding months. Public support for the Huthis was also on the rise, signaling a more general increase in support for the Iranian-backed nonstate actors that

Saudi Arabia and its partners had long hoped to weaken militarily and ideologically.[24] With stringent laws prohibiting protests, the UAE also remained one of the few Arab states without a visible public backlash. But in private conversations and on social media channels, Emiratis joined their Arab counterparts in condemning Israel, while engaging in boycotts of corporations with reported ties to Israel. Any goodwill generated toward Israel from the Abraham Accords appeared to be rapidly diminishing across the Arab world.

While the 2023 Gaza War did not reverse the trajectory of normalization, it chilled government efforts to propel its advancement across the Gulf states. In the UAE and Bahrain, initial high-level condemnations of Hamas's actions as "barbaric" gave way to a sharper rebuke of Israel's retaliation.[25] In late December 2023, the UAE's permanent representative to the UN, Lana Nusseibah, issued the UAE's sternest statement yet, noting that Israel's approach "did not reflect the trajectory we signed the Accords on."[26] Opinions were initially divided at the upper levels of the UAE's government, with some figures reportedly seeing Hamas's weakening as possibly worth its initial cost in Palestinian lives, and others, like Nusseibah, appearing more concerned to put the region back on a path of greater stability. Still, as had been the case during Israel's May 2021 bombardment of Gaza, these criticisms would fall short of reversing the direction of the relationship. Nor would they affect trade relations. By June 2024, Israel's Bureau of Statistics reported a rise in exports from the UAE and Jordan compared with the previous year. It also reported a doubling in exports from Egypt during the same period, as a result of rising energy cooperation between the two states.[27]

THE PATH AHEAD

The Israel-Hamas war fueled another round of calls by Arab and Western officials for the revival of a two-state solution as the only

framework for resolving the Israeli-Palestinian conflict. To many Palestinians, these calls constituted meaningless platitudes. Even before Israel's war on Gaza rendered the largest contiguous area of Palestinian land unlivable, a sixteen-year blockade and routine Israeli military assaults had decimated its economy and triggered a growing humanitarian crisis, with 96 percent of its water rendered undrinkable. The presence of 700,000 settlers in the West Bank—which established their jurisdiction over 42 percent of the area—had also left little territory in that area for the creation of a Palestinian state. Under Israeli military authority, the daily realities of being Palestinian in the West Bank meant navigating a sprawling network of checkpoints, Jewish-only roads, and the perpetual threat of violence from settlers, as well as state-sanctioned land seizures. It also meant being subjected to trial by military courts, ethnic segregation, and deliberate policies of economic deprivation, matters that had collectively prompted leading human rights organizations like Amnesty International and Human Rights Watch to describe the system in the occupied territories as apartheid.

With a two-state solution rendered increasingly unviable, Palestinian intellectuals, activists, and human rights organizations put forward thinking around a one-state solution, in line with what they describe as a one-state reality on the ground. The idea itself is not new, having been first proposed in the 1920s and included in the charter of the PLO in 1964, which called for the creation of a unified, democratic, and secular state where Jews, Muslim, and Christians could share in government on equal terms. Proponents of a one-state solution compare the reality on the ground to apartheid South Africa and argue that Israel already controls the swath of territory stretching from the Jordan River to the Mediterranean Sea. Its denial of equal rights to the Palestinians does not change the fact that it remains responsible for internal and external security, zoning and planning, and daily life across the entirety of the land.

A one-state solution is gaining traction in mainstream policy and academic circles. Writing in *Foreign Affairs* in 2023, Marc Lynch, professor of political science and international affairs at George Washington University, notes: "Palestine is not a state in waiting, and Israel is not a democratic state incidentally occupying Palestinian territory. All the territory west of the Jordan River has long constituted a single state under Israeli rule, where the land the people are subject to radically different legal regimes, and Palestinians are permanently treated as a lower caste. Policymakers and analysts who ignore this one-state reality will be condemned to failure and irrelevance, doing little beyond providing a smokescreen for the entrenchment of the status quo."[28] Others have reiterated these calls for renewed thinking beyond a two-state solution. Writing collectively in 2021, Daniel Levy, a former Israeli negotiator, and Marwan Muasher, the former foreign minister of Jordan, came together to call for a rights-based approach that affirms Israel's right to peace and security and urges equal attention to Palestinian rights, including freedom of movement and freedom from occupation, whether in the West Bank, Gaza, or the borders of Israel.[29]

Resolving the conflict will require a seismic shift in Israel. Since his rise to power, Netanyahu has built his career on the idea that Israel can continue occupying Palestinian lands forever, at no cost to its domestic security or its international standing. This view is now largely accepted among Israel's political class. Even before the attacks of October 7, no mainstream Israeli leader entertained the idea of reviving a peace process with the Palestinians or dealing with them except as a security threat. Many have openly called for the further ethnic cleansing of the Palestinians. The attacks that transpired on October 7 brought home the violent consequences of this permanent occupation.[30] They also served as a reminder that the conflict with the Palestinians is a threat to Israel's security, and that its continued iron grip over them will not deliver the stability it seeks.

This is a reality that the United States will need to reckon with. Since 2020 the focal point of U.S. regional diplomatic efforts has been the expansion of normalization between Israel and Arab states not directly involved in a conflict with it. These efforts have diverted diplomatic capital from what ought to be—and once was—the focus of U.S. regional diplomacy: the revival of talks between Israel and Palestinians. As long as the United States continues supporting Israel unconditionally and prioritizes Arab-Israeli normalization ahead of the resolution of the core conflict at hand, there will be no incentive for the kind of lasting political settlement needed to bring the region back from the brink.

For their part, the Palestinians also lack adequate political leadership. The Palestinian Authority is largely discredited among Palestinians for serving as an arm of the occupation, and Hamas has permanently erased any international credibility it may have held with its attack on Israel. A more representative and accountable body is needed to deliver a lasting settlement.

What is the legacy of the Abraham Accords in their first years? The agreements brought Israel and its Gulf partners together around a shared vision for the region and a view that the Palestinians and their demands for statehood and equality could be consigned to irrelevance in pursuit of more important objectives. It is no surprise that the accords have survived the most violent manifestations of Israel's continued campaigns against the Palestinians since they were built, by design, on Palestinians' continued marginalization and isolation. The enduring relationship between Israel and its Gulf partners serves both sides, enabling Israel to deepen its ties to the Arab world and Gulf leaders to secure an array of technological and military tools from Israel and its main backer, the United States. A bipartisan U.S. consensus on advancing the agreements will also drive momentum toward their expansion.

While the Abraham Accords have proven more resilient than some expected, they have also demonstrated their limitations. The

agreements have not generated the warm civic ties that state leaders had hoped for, in the face of a continued commitment by Arab populations to the Palestinians, especially in the wake of Israel's attacks on Gaza. More important, they have not yielded a meaningful alternative to a sustained peace process between Israel and the Palestinians or brought the region greater stability as their architects promised.

The evolution of the Gulf-Iran relationship has also shaped the trajectory of the agreements. While a shared threat perception toward Iran's regional ascendancy set the stage for growing cooperation between Israel and several Gulf states beginning in 2006, a rising commitment by states like the UAE and Saudi Arabia to a process of de-escalation with Tehran has also precluded the agreements from evolving into an overt, regional anti-Iran alliance championed by some Israeli political figures. Instead, the Gulf states have largely looked to balance their evolving ties with Israel with their growing interest in avoiding a confrontation with other regional powers and adding the relationship to a network of interests they seek to develop and maintain as they expand their influence. Yet as the 2023 Gaza War has shown, the region's ability to embark on a path of greater stability cannot take place in isolation from a just resolution of the most pressing dispute: that between Israel and the Palestinians.

NOTES

PREFACE

1. Donald J. Trump (@realDonaldTrump), "HUGE breakthrough today! Historic Peace Agreement between our two GREAT friends, Israel and the United Arab Emirates!" Twitter, August 13, 2020, https://twitter.com/realDonaldTrump/status/1293922936609546240?ref_src=twsrc%5Etfw.

INTRODUCTION

1. "I Hate Israel—Bakrah Israel," *IndyBay* (blog), November 28, 2001, https://www.indybay.org/newsitems/2001/11/28/1107601.php.
2. Shareef Mahdi, "Ana Bakrah Israel. Ayqonat Sha'baan 'Abdelrahim Adkhalatho Quloob Al-Malayin," *Al Emarat Alyowm*, December 3, 2019, https://www.emaratalyoum.com/politics/international/2019-12-03-1.1280340.
3. "Arab Opinion Index 2019–2020," Arab Centre for Research and Policy Studies, https://www.dohainstitute.org/en/Lists/ACRPS-PDFDocumentLibrary/Arab-Opinion-Index-2019-2020-Inbreef-English-Version.pdf.
4. Hend Al Otaiba, "UAE: We Seek a Warm Peace with Israel," *Haaretz*, September 14, 2020, https://www.haaretz.com/middle-east-news/2020-09-14/ty-article-opinion/.premium/uae-we-seek-a-warm-peace-with-israel/0000017f-efea-d223-a97f-efff9f100000.
5. "Israel's Dead: the Names of those killed in Hamas attacks, massacres, and the Israel-Hamas War," *Haaretz*, October 19, 2023, https://www.haaretz.com/haaretz-explains/2023-10-19/ty-article-magazine/israels-dead-the

-names-of-those-killed-in-hamas-massacres-and-the-israel-hamas-war/0000018b-325c-d450-a3af-7b5cf0210000.

6. Sarah El Deeb, "The war in Gaza has wiped out entire Palestinian families. AP documents 60 who lost dozens or more," *Associated Press*, June 16, 2024, https://apnews.com/article/gaza-palestinians-families-israel-war-deaths-a9f8bcfe402c17f1f78903eae67b7a7d.

1. A PROMISED LAND

1. Theodor Herzl is widely considered the father of political Zionism. In 1896 he published a pamphlet, *The Jewish State*, making the case for the question of Jewish statehood to become the subject of international deliberation, "to be discussed and settled by the civilized nations of the world in council." Although not the first to raise the possibility of Jewish statehood as an antidote to the ongoing problems of Jewish marginalization and racism in Europe, his work laid the foundations for the emergence of Zionism as a modern political ideology. Theodor Herzl, *A Jewish State: An Attempt at a Modern Solution of the Jewish Question* (New York: Maccabean, 1904), first published as Theodor Herzl, *Der Judenstaat* (Vienna: Verlags-Buchhandlung, 1896).
2. Mayir Verete, "The Balfour Declaration and Its Makers," *Middle Eastern Studies* 6, no. 1 (1970): 48–76.
3. Arthur James Balfour, "The Balfour Declaration," in *Speeches on Zionism by the Rt. Hon. the Earl of Balfour* (1917), 19–21.
4. Rothschild Archive, *Walter Rothschild and the Balfour Declaration* (London: NM Rothschild & Sons, 2002–2023), https://www.rothschildarchive.org/family/family_interests/walter_rothschild_and_the_balfour_declaration.
5. Avi Shlaim, *The Iron Wall: Israel and the Arab World* (New York: Norton, 2000), 7.
6. Jacob Metzer, "Jewish Immigration to Palestine in the Long 1920s: An Exploratory Examination," *Journal of Israeli History* 27, no. 2 (2008): 223.
7. James Only, *The Arabian Frontier of the British Raj: Merchants, Rulers, and the British in the Nineteenth Century Gulf* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2007).
8. J. G. Lorimer, *Gazetteer of the Persian Gulf (1915)*, India Office Records, London, IOR/L/PS/20 C91/1, 653.
9. Rashid Khalidi, *Palestinian Identity: The Construction of Modern National Consciousness* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1997), 190.

10. Rosemarie Said Zahlan, *Palestine and the Gulf States: The Presence at the Table* (New York: Routledge, 2009), 18.
11. Benny Morris, *Righteous Victims: A History of the Zionist-Arab Conflict, 1881–2001* (New York: Vintage Books, 2001), 136–37.
12. Morris.
13. Zahlan, *Palestine and the Gulf States*, 18.
14. Zahlan.
15. Thomas Mayer, "Arab Unity of Action and the Question of Palestine," *Middle Eastern Studies* 22, no. 3 (1986): 331–49.
16. United Nations, "United Nations General Assembly Resolution 181," adopted November 29, 1947, https://undocs.org/Home/Mobile?FinalSymbol=A%2FRES%2F181(II)&Language=E&DeviceType=Desktop&LangRequested=False.
17. Sharifah Alhinai, "The Jews of Bahrain and the Arabian Gulf's Only Synagogue," *Sekka Magazine*, October 1, 2017, https://sekkamag.com/2017/10/01/the-jews-of-bahrain-and-the-arabian-gulfs-only-synagogue/.
18. Meera Ravi, "Region's Oldest Synagogue Represents New Hope for Bahrain's Jews," *Majalla*, April 2, 2021, https://eng.majalla.com/node/128181/politicsregion%E2%80%99s-oldest-synagogue-represents-new-hope-bahrain%E2%80%99s-jews.
19. Qatar National Library, "Coll 30/52(3) 'Persian Gulf. Diaries: Bahrain Intelligence Summaries 1946' [f10r] (19/276)," December 1–15, 1947, https://www.qdl.qa/en/archive/81055/vdc_100055736398.0x000014.
20. Qatar National Library.
21. "The History of Jews in Bahrain," *Breaking Matzo*, September 30, 2020, https://breakingmatzo.com/history-of-jews/the-history-of-jews-in-bahrain/.
22. Esther Meir-Glitzenstein, "Turning Points in the Historiography of Jewish Immigration from Arab Countries to Israel," *Israel Studies* 23, no. 3 (2018): 114–22.
23. AFP, "Iraq's Jewish Community Dwindles to Fewer than Five," *France 24*, March 28, 2021, https://www.france24.com/en/live-news/20210328-iraq-s-jewish-community-dwindles-to-fewer-than-five.
24. Nadia Al-Faour, "Gulf Arab Embrace of Jewish Minority Reflected in Bahrain Cemetery-Restoration Project," *Arab News*, January 22, 2022, https://www.arabnews.com/node/2009406/middle-east.
25. Ilan Pappe, "The 1948 Ethnic Cleansing of Palestine," *Journal of Palestine Studies* 36, no. 1 (2006): 6–20. See also Uri Misgav, "Jews Were Massacred

in 1948 Too, So Why Dwell Only on the Nakba?," *Haaretz*, December 16, 2021, https://www.haaretz.com/israel-news/2021-12-16/ty-article-opinion/.highlight/jews-were-massacred-in-48-too-so-why-dwell-only-on-the-nakba/0000017f-f192-d487-abff-f3fef1b50000.

26. Eric Rouleau, "Palestinian Diaspora of the Gulf," *MERIP*, May/June 1985, https://merip.org/1985/05/the-palestinian-diaspora-of-the-gulf/.
27. UNRWA Commissioner-General, "Annual Report of the Director of the UNRWA (1 July 1959–30 June 1960)," United Nations Digital Library, 1960, https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/715794?ln=en.
28. Adeed Dawisha, "Saudi Arabia and the Arab-Israeli Conflict: The Ups and Downs of Pragmatic Moderation," *International Journal* 38, no. 4 (1983).
29. Elie Podeh, "The Drift Towards Neutrality: Egyptian Foreign Policy During the Early Nasserist Era, 1952–55," *Middle Eastern Studies* 32, no. 1 (1996): 170.
30. Kirsten Schulze notes: "From a regional post-war perspective, Nasser clearly emerged on the winning side. . . . He was hailed as the only Arab leader able to challenge the West and to expel the British and French imperialism forces, as well as Israel, from Egyptian territory. From this position, Nasser expanded his regional influence and established Egypt's leadership of the Arab world." Kristen Schulze, *The Arab-Israeli Conflict* (London: Routledge, 2008), 32.
31. Rashid Khalidi, *The Iron Cage* (Boston: Beacon Press, 2006), 36.
32. For example, the Movement of Arab Nationalists, founded by George Habash and other students at the American University of Beirut in 1952, preached that only Arab unity could free the region from colonialism and liberate Palestine. See Yezid Sayegh, "Reconstructing the Paradox: The Arab Nationalist Movement, Armed Struggle, and Palestine, (1951–1966)," *Middle East Journal* 45, no. 4 (1991): 608–29.
33. Khalidi, *The Iron Cage*, 36.
34. For years, Israeli offices maintained that the strike on Egypt was carried out to preempt an Arab attack. But in August 1982 Prime Minister Menachem Begin noted: "In June 1967, we had a choice. The Egyptian army concentrations in the Sinai approaches did not prove that Nasser was really about to attack us. We must be honest with ourselves. We decided to attack him." "Excerpts from Begin Speech at National Defense College," *New York Times*, August 21, 1982, https://www.nytimes.com/1982/08/21/world/excerpts-from-begin-speech-at-national-defense-college.html.
35. Bruce Riedel, "How the 1967 War Dramatically Reoriented Saudi Arabia's Foreign Policy," *Brookings* (blog), May 30, 2017, https://www.brookings.edu

/blog/markaz/2017/05/30/how-the-1967-war-dramatically-re-oriented-saudi-arabias-foreign-policy/.

36. Kristian Coates Ulrichsen, "Pegasus as a Case Study of Evolving Ties Between the UAE and Israel," *Gulf State Analytics*, June 9, 2022, https://gulfstateanalytics.com/pegasus-as-a-case-study-of-evolving-ties-between-the-united-arab-emirates-and-israel/.
37. Shlaim, *The Iron Wall*, 260.
38. At Khartoum, the Arab states issued the three nos: "no peace with Israel, no recognition of Israel, and no negotiations with it, and insistence on the rights of the Palestinian people in their own country." Efraim Halevy notes: "The Arab world rejected Israel's right to exist at the infamous Khartoum Conference in response to Israel's appeal to negotiate without any preconditions." See Halevy, "Israel's Hamas Portfolio," *Israel Journal of Foreign Affairs* 2, no. 3 (2008): 41–47. Shlaim argues in *The Iron Wall*, 258–59, that the declaration was intended to mean no formal peace treaty, but not a rejection of a state of peace; no direct negotiations, but not a refusal to talk to third parties; and no de jure recognition of Israel, but acceptance of its existence as a state.
39. Dawisha, "Saudi Arabia," 676.
40. UNRWA Commissioner-General, "Report of the Director of the United Nations Relief and Works Agency."
41. United Nations Security Council Resolution 242, November 22, 1967 (S/RES/242).
42. Shlaim, *The Iron Wall*, 260.
43. "Who Are Israeli Settlers, and Why Do They Live on Palestinian Lands?," *Al Jazeera*, November 6, 2023, https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2023/11/6/who-are-israeli-settlers-and-why-do-they-live-on-palestinian-lands.
44. Bruce Riedel, "How the 1967 War Dramatically Reoriented Saudi Arabia's Foreign Policy," *Brookings* (blog), May 30, 2017, https://www.brookings.edu/blog/markaz/2017/05/30/how-the-1967-war-dramatically-re-oriented-saudi-arabias-foreign-policy/.
45. Arab News Staff Writer, "Prince Salman Rejects Terrorism Charges Against Charities," *Arab News*, November 3, 2002, https://www.arabnews.com/node/225658.
46. Alfred Prados and Christopher Blanchard, "Saudi Arabia: Terrorist Financing Issues," Congressional Research Service, December 8, 2004, https://www.hsdl.org/?view&did=450759.

47. "1973 October War Reflective of Arab Solidarity, Strength—Kuwait's Amb," Kuwait News Agency, October 6, 2018, https://www.kuna.net.kw/ArticleDetails.aspx?id=2749849&language=en#.
48. U.S. Department of State, Office of the Historian, "Oil Embargo: 1973–1974," https://history.state.gov/milestones/1969-1976/oil-embargo.
49. Siniver also notes that American dominance would become complete with the weakening and eventual demise of the Soviet Union. See Asaf Siniver, ed., *The October 1973 War: Politics, Diplomacy, Legacy* (London: Hurst, 2013).
50. Dawisha, "Saudi Arabia," 676.
51. Simon Dunstan, *The Yom Kippur War: The Arab-Israeli War of 1973* (Oxford, UK: Osprey, 2007).
52. Clive Jones and Yoel Guzansky, *Fraternal Enemies* (London: Hurst, 2019), 26.
53. King Faisal was succeeded by King Khaled, who ruled from 1975 to 1982.
54. Youssef Ibrahim, "Confrontation in the Gulf: Arafat's Support of Iraq Creates Rift in PLO," *New York Times*, August 14, 1990, https://www.nytimes.com/1990/08/14/world/confrontation-in-the-gulf-arafat-s-support-of-iraq-creates-rift-in-plo.html.
55. *Velayat-e-faqih*, or the Guardianship of the Islamic Jurist (Arabic: *Wilayat al-faqih*), is a theory in Shi'a Islam that holds that Islam gives a *faqih* (Islamic jurist) custodianship over the people. Islamic clerics supporting the theory disagree over how encompassing custodianship should be. The constitution of Iran is built on this principle, calling for a *faqih*, or *Vali-ye faqih* (Guardian Jurist), to serve as the supreme leader of the government, combining the political and spiritual roles into a single figure. See Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini, *Governance of the Jurist: Velayat-e-Faqeeh* (London: Manor House Books, 1979).
56. Hamidreza Azizi, "The Concept of 'Forward Defence': How Has the Syrian Crisis Shaped the Evolution of Iran's Military Strategy?," *Geneva Center for Security Policy*, February 2021, https://dam.gcsp.ch/files/doc/iran-forward-defence-strategy-en.
57. "The Shiite Question in Saudi Arabia," International Crisis Group, September 19, 2005, https://www.crisisgroup.org/middle-east-north-africa/gulf-and-arabian-peninsula/saudi-arabia/shiite-question-saudi-arabia.
58. Amr Yossef, "Upgrading Iran's Military Doctrine: An Offensive Forward Defence," Middle East Institute, December 10, 2019, https://www.mei.edu/publications/upgrading-irans-military-doctrine-offensive-forward-defense.

59. Beginning in 2006, Qatar began channeling its aid to the Palestinians through Hamas, engaging with the group as part of its commitment to providing humanitarian aid to Gaza. See Mahjoub Zweiri and Farah Al Qawasmi, eds., *Contemporary Qatar: Examining State and Society* (Singapore: Springer Nature, 2021).
60. Shortly before Britain's withdrawal from the Gulf in 1971, and before the unification of the United Arab Emirates as a federal state, Iran and the ruler of the emirate of Sharjah signed a memorandum to jointly administer the island of Abu Musa, located in the narrow straits between them. The memorandum also laid out a system for the equal division of petroleum revenues derived from the territory. On the day of Britain's withdrawal, Iran deployed its military to seize control over Abu Musa, as well as two tiny neighboring islands, Greater and Lesser Tunb, claimed by the emirate of Ras Al Khaimah. See Richard Mobley, "The Tunbs and Abu Musa Islands: Britain's Perspective," *Middle East Journal* 57, no. 4 (2003).
61. Benoit Faucon, "UAE Trade Provides Iran with Western Goods, from Perfume to Laptops," *Wall Street Journal*, July 5, 2022, https://www.wsj.com/articles/u-a-e-trade-provides-iran-with-western-goods-from-perfume-to-laptops-11657048268.
62. Nadim Hasbani, "The Geopolitics of Weapons Procurement in the Gulf States," *Defence and Security Analysis* 22, no. 1 (2006): 73–88.
63. "Bahrain: Military Spending, Percent of GDP," *Global Economy*, December 2021, https://www.theglobaleconomy.com/Bahrain/mil_spend_gdp/.
64. The construction of the Al Udeid Air Base in 1996 would make Qatar home to the largest American military base in the Middle East. United States Naval Forces Central Command, "About Us: History," accessed July 23, 2023, https://www.cusnc.navy.mil/Sub-and-Squadrons/.
65. Dawisha, "Saudi Arabia," 680–89.
66. Nasser Aruri and Fouad Maghrabi, "The Reagan Middle East Initiative," *Journal of Palestine Studies* 12, no. 2 (1983): 10–30.
67. David Shipler, "Israel Rejects Reagan Plan for Palestinians Self-Rule: Terms It a 'Serious Danger,'" *New York Times*, September 3, 1982.
68. Dawisha, "Saudi Arabia," 680–89. See also "King Fahad Peace Initiative 1982," *Wikileaks: The Saudi Cables*, https://wikileaks.org/saudi-cables/docs/591cd409d616694ef9c72048aa91fce9_King%20Fahad%20peace%20Initiative%201982.doc.

69. David Shipler, "Israel Rejects Arab Plan, Terming It Destructive," *New York Times,* September 11, 1982, https://www.nytimes.com/1982/09/11/world/israel-rejects-arab-plan-terming-it-destructive.html.
70. Philip Mattar, "The PLO and the Gulf Crisis," *Middle East Journal* 48, no. 1 (1994): 31–36.
71. Mai Al-Nakib, "'The People Are Missing': Palestinians in Kuwait," *Deleuze Studies* 8, no. 1 (2014): 23–44, http://www.jstor.org/stable/45331560.
72. Noam Chomsky, "The Oslo Accords: Their Context, Their Consequences," in *The Oslo Accords: 1993–2013: A Critical Assessment*," ed. Bauck Petter and Omer Mohammed (New York: Tauris, 2013).
73. Hilde Waage, "Postscript to Oslo: The Mystery of Norway's Missing Files," *Journal of Palestine Studies* 38, no. 1 (2008): 54–65; and Edward Said, "The Morning After," *London Review of Books* 15, no. 20 (October 21, 1993), https://www.lrb.co.uk/the-paper/v15/n20/edward-said/the-morning-after.
74. Pappe, "Revisiting 1967."
75. Waage, "Postscript to Oslo."
76. Joe Kincheloe and Shirley R. Steinberg, eds., *The Miseducation of the West: How Schools and the Media Distort Our Understanding of the Islamic World* (Westport, CT: Greenwood, 2004).
77. King Hussein, "The Madrid Peace Process," official website of King Abdullah II, 2001, http://www.kinghussein.gov.jo/his_peace2.html.
78. Efraim Halevy, interview by author, January 2022.
79. Jones and Guzansky, *Fraternal Enemies*, 53.
80. Israel Ministry of Foreign Affairs, "Israel-Oman Agree to Open Trade Offices," January 28, 1996, https://www.mfa.gov.il/mfa/foreignpolicy/peace/guide/pages/israel-%20oman%20agree%20to%20open%20trade%20offices.aspx.
81. Jones and Guzansky, *Fraternal Enemies*, 53. See also Ariel Admoni, "Same Reasons: Different Outcomes: Qatar's Policy on Israel Up to 1996," *Middle Eastern Studies* 58, no. 6 (2021): 830–42.
82. Jones and Guzansky, *Fraternal Enemies*, 54.
83. Bahaa Elkoussy, "Qatari Minister Confirms Unprecedented Meeting with Peres," United Press International Archives, October 17, 1993, https://www.upi.com/Archives/1993/10/17/Qatari-minister-confirms-unprecedented-meeting-with-Peres/5593750830400/. Foreign Minister Al-Thani would later corroborate reports of the meeting in an extended interview with *Al Qabas*

newspaper. See Anas Al-Salem, "Hamad bin Jassim Yaftah 'al-sindooq al-aswad' li-siyasat Qatar wa yatahadath 'an 'inqilabat damawiyya, wa-aljazeera, wa-Saddam Hussein," *Watan News*, January 16, 2022, https://www.watanserb.com/2022/01/16/%D8%AD%D9%85%D8%AF-%D8%A8%D9%86-%D8%AC%D8%A7%D8%B3%D9%85-%D9%8A%D9%81%D8%AA%D8%AD-%D8%A7%D9%84%D8%B5%D9%86%D8%AF%D9%88%D9%82-%D8%A7%D9%84%D8%A3%D8%B3%D9%88%D8%AF-%D9%84%D8%B3%D9%8A%D8%A7%D8%B3/.

84. Giorgio Cafiero and Claire Fuchs, "Would an Israeli Embassy Ever Open in Doha?," *Doha News*, August 17, 2020, https://dohanews.co/would-an-israeli-embassy-ever-open-in-doha/.
85. Uzi Rabi, "Qatar's Relations with Israel: Challenging Arab and Gulf Norms," *Middle East Journal* 63, no. 3 (2009): 443–59.
86. Adam Entous, "Donald Trump's New World Order," *New Yorker*, June 11, 2018, https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2018/06/18/donald-trumps-new-world-order; and AFP, "Mohammed bin Zayed, a Quiet Force to Lead UAE as a Regional Player," *Times of Israel*, May 14, 2022, https://www.timesofisrael.com/mohamed-bin-zayed-a-quiet-force-to-lead-uae-as-a-regional-player/.
87. Entous, "Donald Trump's New World Order." See also Raphael Ahren, "26 Years After First Israeli-UAE Meet, New Ties Bring a Diplomat Full Circle," *Times of Israel*, September 17, 2020, https://www.timesofisrael.com/26-years-after-first-israeli-uae-meet-accord-brings-diplomat-full-circle/.
88. The official added that when it came to Israel, the adage "the enemy of my enemy is my friend" rang especially true. Entous, "Donald Trump's New World Order."
89. Barak Ravid, *Trump's Peace: The Abraham Accords and the Reshaping of the Middle East* (independently published, 2023), 169.
90. Entous, "Donald Trump's New World Order." See also Ahren, "26 Years After First Israeli-UAE Meet."
91. Grant Rumley, "Unpacking the UAE F-35 Negotiations," Washington Institute for Near East Policy, February 15, 2022, https://www.washingtoninstitute.org/policy-analysis/unpacking-uae-f-35-negotiations.
92. Ravid, *Trump's Peace*, 368.
93. Ali Adam, "Palestinian Intifada: How Israel Orchestrated a Bloody Takeover," *Al Jazeera*, September 28, 2020, https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2020/9/28/palestinian-intifada-20-years-later-israeli-occupation-continues.

94. "Qatar: Israel Trade Office Closed," Associated Press Archive, November 9, 2000, http://www.aparchive.com/metadata/QATAR-ISRAEL-TRADE-OFFICE-CLOSED/3ea04bcb02b6e311f663638a71da0561?Assassinations: Subject; and Rabi, "Qatar's Relations with Israel," 443–59.
95. Steven Stalinksy, "Palestinian Foreign Aid: Saudi Financial Aid," *Jewish Virtual Library*, July 2003, https://www.jewishvirtuallibrary.org/saudi-financial-aid-to-the-palestinian-authority.
96. For the UAE, see "UAE Adopts Moderate, Balanced Foreign Policy," Emirates News Agency, November 29, 2005, http://wam.ae/en/details/1395227539356. For Saudi Arabia, see "Foreign Aid Management in Palestine," *Palestine Economic Portal*, 2022, https://www.palestineeconomy.ps/donors/en.
97. "Zayed Committed to Helping Palestinians: Says Hamdan," Emirates News Agency, May 17, 2002, http://wam.ae/en/details/1395226903823. See also Hugh Naylor, "Gaza's Zayed City Development Provides Solace to Palestinians," *National*, April 16, 2014, https://www.thenationalnews.com/world/mena/gaza-s-zayed-city-development-provides-solace-to-palestinians-1.310570.
98. Saddam AlJughaifi, "Al-Mamlaka al-arabiyya al-suoodiyya wa-alqadhiya alfilistineeya (1991–2001)," *Dar al-mutaz lilnashr wa-altawzee'* (Muscat, 2016).
99. Under this policy, imposed by the Coalition Provisional Authority, as many as eighty-five thousand Iraqi officials who had served under Saddam were removed from their roles because of their membership in his Ba'ath Party (a requirement of their service). The policy is widely viewed to have played a key role in spurring widespread resentment of the U.S. invasion and driving thousands of mostly Sunnis into the anti-U.S. insurgency and fanning the flames of conflict in Iraq. Thomas Ricks, *Fiasco: The American Military Adventure in Iraq 2003–2005* (New York: Penguin, 2007), 160.
100. John Hannah, "Iran-Backed Militias Are in Iraq to Stay," *Foreign Policy*, July 31, 2019, https://foreignpolicy.com/2019/07/31/iran-backed-militias-are-in-iraq-to-stay/.
101. Bruce Reidel, "9/11 and Iraq: The Making of a Tragedy," *Brookings* (blog), September 17, 2021, https://www.brookings.edu/blog/order-from-chaos/2021/09/17/9-11-and-iraq-the-making-of-a-tragedy/.
102. Ghaith Al-Omari, "Oslo's Mangled Legacy," Washington Institute for Near East Policy, March 4, 2019.
103. Clive Jones, "The Writing on the Wall: Israel, the Security Barrier and the Future of Zionism," *Mediterranean Politics* 14, no. 1 (2009): 3–20, https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/13629390902747335.

104. "Gaza: An Open-Air Prison," Human Rights Watch, June 13, 2022, https://www.hrw.org/video-photos/video/2022/06/13/gaza-open-air-prison.
105. Tareq Baconi, *Hamas Contained: The Rise and Pacification of Palestinian Resistance* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2018).
106. "Israeli Far-Right Minister Bezalel Smotrich Described Hamas as 'Asset' in Unearthed Tweet," *National*, January 23, 2024, https://www.thenationalnews.com/mena/palestine-israel/2024/01/23/israel-bezalel-smotrich-hamas-asset/#.
107. "Fact-Sheet: Sanctions Related to Iran," Obama White House Archives, July 31, 2012, https://obamawhitehouse.archives.gov/the-press-office/2012/07/31/fact-sheet-sanctions-related-iran.
108. Kareem Chehayeb, "Hezbollah and Israel Maintain Tense Peace 15 Years After War," *Al Jazeera*, August 15, 2021, https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2021/8/15/hezbollah-and-israel-maintain-tense-peace-15-years-after-war.
109. Rashid Khalidi, "The Dahiya Doctrine, Proportionality, and War Crimes," *Journal of Palestine Studies* 44, no. 1 (2014).
110. Neil MacFarquhar, "Tide of Arab Opinion Turns to Support for Hezbollah," *New York Times*, July 28, 2006, https://www.nytimes.com/2006/07/28/world/middleeast/28arabs.html.
111. Multiple think-tank reports place the value of Iran's payments to Hezbollah after the war at between $700 and $1 billion annually. The source of this figure is a speech delivered by Israel's chief of armed forces, Lieutenant-General Gadi Eizenkot, at IDC Herzliya University in 2018. The figure appears in reports, including "The Axis of Resistance: Iran's Expansion in the Middle East Is Hitting a Wall," German Institute of International and Security Affairs, August 12, 2021, https://www.econstor.eu/bitstream/10419/253237/1/2021RP06.pdf; and Matthew Levitt, "Hezbollah's Regional Activities in Support of Iran's Proxy Networks," Middle East Institute, July 26, 2021, https://www.mei.edu/publications/hezbollahs-regional-activities-support-irans-proxy-networks.
112. Gulf and Israeli security officials, interview by author, January 15, 2022.

2. A NEW GENERATION OF GULF LEADERS

1. "Zayed Committed to Helping Palestinians Says Hamdan," Emirates News Agency (WAM), May 17, 2002, https://wam.ae/en/details/1395226903823.

2. Mohammed bin Zayed is the eldest of the Bani Fatima, the children of Zayed's third and reportedly most beloved wife. "Mohammed bin Zayed, a Quiet Force to Lead UAE as a Regional Player," *Times of Israel*, May 14, 2022, https://www.timesofisrael.com/mohamed-bin-zayed-a-quiet-force-to-lead-uae-as-a-regional-player/.
3. General Mattis popularized the description in 2011. See "Sizing Up Little Sparta: Understanding UAE Military Effectiveness," American Enterprise Institute, October 27, 2020, https://www.aei.org/research-products/report/sizing-up-little-sparta-understanding-uae-military-effectiveness/.
4. Peter Salisbury, "Risk Perception and Appetite in UAE Foreign and National Security Policy," Chatham House, July 2020, https://www.chathamhouse.org/sites/default/files/2020-07-01-risk-in-uae-salisbury.pdf.
5. UAE think tank, interview by author, Dubai, March 2021.
6. AIN Staff, "UAE Establishes Space Reconnaissance Center," *Ain Online*, December 11, 2006, https://www.ainonline.com/aviation-news/aerospace/2006-12-11/uae-establishes-space-reconnaissance-center.
7. ISRAEL21c Staff, "Abu Dhabi to Sign Deal with Israeli Satellite Service," *Israel 21c*, February 25, 2009, https://www.israel21c.org/abu-dhabi-to-sign-deal-with-israeli-satellite-service.
8. Yossi Melman and Haaretz Correspondent, "Should Retired IDF Officers Do Business in Arab States or Not?," *Haaretz*, September 18, 2006, https://www.haaretz.com/1.5034022.
9. Inbal Orpaz, "Logic Industries Lays Off Israeli Employees for Major Arab Client," *Haaretz*, February 9, 2015, https://www.haaretz.com/israel-news/business/2015-02-09/ty-article/logic-cuts-payroll-for-arab-client/0000017f-e4db-d804-ad7f-f5fb91d30000.
10. Neri Zilber, "Gulf Cyber Cooperation with Israel: Balancing Threats and Rights," Washington Institute for Near East Policy, January 17, 2019, https://www.washingtoninstitute.org/policy-analysis/gulf-cyber-cooperation-israel-balancing-threats-and-rights.
11. Rori Donaghy, "Falcon Eye: The Israeli-Installed Mass Surveillance System of Abu Dhabi," *Middle East Eye*, July 15, 2015, https://www.middleeasteye.net/news/falcon-eye-israeli-installed-mass-civil-surveillance-system-abu-dhabi.
12. "Mohammed Bin Zayed: Al-Istratijiyya il-amniyya tastajeeb li-mutatalibaat altanmiya al-shamila" [The security strategy is part of our comprehensive development plans], *Al Ittihad*, March 5, 2008, https://bit.ly/3SfhkjR.

13. Linda Kay, "Critical National Infrastructure Authority (CNIA), UAE Home Land Security Will Be at IDEX 2009," *Defense World*, February 20, 2009, https://www.defenseworld.net/2009/05/20/critical-national-infrastructure-authoritycnia-uae-home-land-security-will-be-at-idex-2009.html.
14. Government of Abu Dhabi, website of the Abu Dhabi Executive Council, accessed July 23, 2023, https://www.ecouncil.ae/en/ADGovernment/Pages/ExecutiveCouncil.aspx.
15. Government of Abu Dhabi. See also Melman and Correspondent, "Should Retired IDF Officers Do Business."
16. "CNIA Signs AED 3b Project Agreement with AGT/AIS," Emirates News Agency, March 4, 2008, http://wam.ae/en/details/1395228063123. See also Melman and Correspondent, "Should Retired IDF Officers Do Business."
17. Zilber, "Gulf Cyber Cooperation."
18. "Abu Dhabi Launches Falcon Eye," *Gulf News*, July 13, 2016, https://gulfnews.com/uae/government/abu-dhabi-launches-falcon-eye-1.1861841.
19. Elie Podeh, "Netanyahu's 'Brilliant' Mideast Peace Strategy Has a Big Problem," *Haaretz*, September 13, 2020, https://www.haaretz.com/middle-east-news/.premium-netanyahu-s-brilliant-mideast-peace-strategy-has-a-big-problem-1.9150936.
20. Clive Jones, "Israel and the Gulf States: Regimes, Rivalry, and Regional Security," in *Israel in a Turbulent Region: Security and Foreign Policy*, ed. Tore T. Peterson (New York: Routledge, 2020).
21. Public Library of U.S. Diplomacy, "Acting A/S Feltman, Discussions with MFA Focus on Lebanon, Engagement with Syria, Israel's Relations with the Gulf States," WikiLeaks, March 12, 2009, http://wikileaks.org/plusd/cables/09TELAVIV605_a.html. An account of this is also included in Jones, "Israel and the Gulf States."
22. Public Library of U.S. Diplomacy, "Israel's Relations with the Gulf States Focus on Iran, Perception of Israeli Influence in Washington," WikiLeaks, March 19, 2009, https://wikileaks.org/plusd/cables/09TELAVIV654_a.html.
23. Public Library of U.S. Diplomacy.
24. Public Library of U.S. Diplomacy, "A Long Hot Summer for UAE-Saudi Relations," WikiLeaks, October 15, 2009, https://wikileaks.org/plusd/cables/09ABUDHABI981_a.html.

25. Adam Entous, "Donald Trump's New World Order," *New Yorker*, June 11, 2018, https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2018/06/18/donald-trumps-new-world-order.
26. Kristian Ulrichsen, *The United Arab Emirates: Power, Politics, and Policy-Making* (London: Hurst, 2017), 118.
27. Sigurd Neubauer, "Israel: A Strategic Partner for the UAE." *Gulf State Analytics,* November 9, 2017, https://gulfstateanalytics.com/israel-strategic-partner-uae/.
28. Neubauer.
29. Barak Ravid, "Wikileaks Blows Cover Off Israel's Covert Gulf States Ties," *Haaretz*, November 23, 2010, https://www.haaretz.com/2010-11-29/ty-article/wikileaks-blows-cover-off-israels-covert-gulf-states-ties/0000017f-dbc7-db22-a17f-fff7c8f40000.
30. King Hamad also promised to restore Bahrain's constitution but instead implemented a new, amended document that significantly weakened the power of the elected parliament.
31. "US Embassy Cables: Bahrain's Changing Political Scene," *Guardian*, February 15, 2011, https://www.theguardian.com/world/us-embassy-cables-documents/237614.
32. For more on the role of McKinsey in Bahrain and the Gulf states, see Salem Saif, "When Consultants Rein," *Jacobin*, May 9, 2016, https://jacobin.com/2016/05/saudi-arabia-aramco-salman-mckinsey-privatization/.
33. "Bahrain to End Ban on Import of Israeli Goods," *Gulf News*, September 25, 2005, https://gulfnews.com/world/gulf/bahrain/bahrain-to-end-ban-on-import-of-israeli-goods-1.301722.
34. "Alosra Supermarket Says Israeli Products Were Sold by Mistake and Individually," *Bahrain Mirror*, July 10, 2019, http://bahrainmirror.com/en/news/54850.html.
35. "Remarks by the President at Cairo University," Obama White House Archives, June 4, 2009, https://obamawhitehouse.archives.gov/the-press-office/remarks-president-cairo-university-6-04-09.
36. Laura Rozen, "In Letters, Obama Asked Arab States for Confidence-Building Measures Toward Israel," *Foreign Policy*, July 26, 2009, https://foreignpolicy.com/2009/07/26/in-letters-obama-asked-arab-states-for-confidence-building-measures-toward-israel/.

37. "US Embassy Cables." In 2008 King Hamad appointed Houda Nonoo as Bahraini ambassador to Washington, the first Jewish woman to take up the role.
38. Sheikh Salman bin Hamad Al Khalifa, "The Arab Peace Initiative for Israel and the Palestinians," *Washington Post*, July 16, 2009, https://www.washingtonpost.com/wp-dyn/content/article/2009/07/16/AR2009071602737.html?sid=ST2009071603564
39. WikiLeaks, "Bahraini Crown Prince's July 28 Meeting with CENTCOM Commander Petraeus, Special Envoy Mitchel, and NEA Acting Assistant Secretary Feltman," *Telegraph*, February 18, 2011, https://www.telegraph.co.uk/news/wikileaks-files/bahrain-wikileaks-cables/8334589/bahraini-crown-princes-july-28-meeting-with-centcom-commander-petraeus-special-envoy-mitchell-and-nea-acting-assistant-secretary-feltman.html.
40. WikiLeaks.
41. Yossi Melman, "Haaretz Wikileaks Exclusive: Bahrain King Boasted of Intelligence Ties with Israel," *HaaretzI* April 8, 2011, https://www.haaretz.com/2011-04-08/ty-article/haaretz-wikileaks-exclusive-bahrain-king-boasted-of-intelligence-ties-with-israel/0000017f-dc64-df62-a9ff-dcf7fe2d0000.
42. Reuters Staff, "Bahrain Parliament Votes to Stop Contacts with Israel," Reuters, October 27, 2009, https://www.reuters.com/article/idINIndia-43469920091027.
43. Udi Etsion, "Friendly Adversaries: How Israel Secretly Helped Build Up the UAE's Military Capabilities," *C Tech*, August 18, 2020, https://www.calcalistech.com/ctech/articles/0,7340,L-3845579,00.html.
44. Barak Ravid, "Exclusive: The Secret Drone Deal That Created an Israel-UAE Rift," *Axios*, February 11, 2019, https://www.axios.com/secret-drone-deal-israel-uae-iran-netanyahu-mbz-48caa235-1ed8-45fe-b691-b9bd41223ebb.html.
45. Etsion, "Friendly Adversaries."
46. Loveday Morris, "Abdullah: We'll Bring Assassins to Justice," *National*, February 22, 2010, https://www.thenationalnews.com/uae/abdullah-we-ll-bring-assassins-to-justice-1.482788.
47. On the arrest warrant, see Ariel Kahana, "Exclusive: Former World Leader Played Key Role in Israel-UAE deal," *Israel Hayom*, September 9, 2020, https://www.israelhayom.com/2020/09/11/exclusive-former-world-leader

-played-key-role-in-israel-uae-deal/. On the severance of ties, see Ronen Bergman and Mark Mazzetti, "The Battle for the World's Most Powerful Cyberweapon," *New York Times*, January 28, 2022, https://www.nytimes.com/2022/01/28/magazine/nso-group-israel-spyware.html.

48. Kahana, "Exclusive."
49. Mourad Haroutunian, "Saudi Arabia Creates Ministry of Housing, SPA Reports," *Bloomberg*, March 26, 2011, https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2011-03-26/saudi-arabia-creates-ministry-of-housing-spa-reports. See also "Saudi Scholars Forbid Protest Calls," *Al Jazeera*, March 10, 2011, https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2011/3/10/saudi-scholars-forbid-protest-calls.
50. "UAE to Invest in Poorer, Northern Emirates," Reuters, March 2, 2011, https://www.reuters.com/article/oukwd-uk-emirates-utilities-idAFTRE72121720110302; and Yasmina Abouzzohour, "Heavy Lies the Crown: The Survival of Arab Monarchies, 10 Years After the Arab Spring," *Brookings* (blog), March 8, 2021, https://www.brookings.edu/blog/order-from-chaos/2021/03/08/heavy-lies-the-crown-the-survival-of-arab-monarchies-10-years-after-the-arab-spring/.
51. Courtney Freer, *Rentier Islam: The Influence of the Muslim Brotherhood in Gulf Monarchies* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2018).
52. In Saudi Arabia and the UAE, Sunni political Islamist movements have previously constituted the backbone of opposition movements and mobilized for political reforms and popular representation. See Stephane LaCroix, "Saudi Islamists and the Potential for Protest," *Foreign Policy*, June 2, 2011, https://foreignpolicy.com/2011/06/02/saudi-islamists-and-the-potential-for-protest/. See also Pekka Hakala, "Opposition in the United Arab Emirates," European Parliament Directorate-General for External Policies, November 15, 2012, https://www.europarl.europa.eu/RegData/etudes/briefing_note/join/2012/491458/EXPO-AFET_SP%282012%29491458_EN.pdf.
53. Andrea Dessi, *Israel and the Palestinians After the Arab Spring: No Time for Peace*, Instituto Affari Internazionali, IAI Working Papers, 1216, May 2012, https://www.files.ethz.ch/isn/142706/iaiwp1216.pdf.
54. "Egypt Reopens Border with Gaza," *Deutsche Welle*, August 25, 2012, https://www.dw.com/en/egypt-reopens-its-border-with-gaza/a-16194026. The crossing had been reopened by Egypt's transitional government in May 2011 but closed following outbreaks of violence in Sinai. Following his election,

Morsi's government announced plans to reopen the crossing once again, in August of that year. "Gaza: Egypt to Re-open Rafah Crossing to Palestinians," *BBC News*, May 25, 2011, https://www.bbc.com/news/world-middle-east-13552685.

55. Kuwait also contributed to the aid package. David Butter, "Egypt and the Gulf: Allies and Rivals," Chatham House (Royal Institute for International Affairs), April 20, 2020, https://www.chathamhouse.org/2020/04/egypt-and-gulf/sisis-debt-his-gulf-arab-backers. See also David Kirkpatrick, "Leaks Gain Credibility and Potential to Embarrass Egypt's Leaders," *New York Times*, May 12, 2015, https://www.nytimes.com/2015/05/13/world/middleeast/leaks-gain-credibility-and-potential-to-embarrass-egypts-leaders.html.
56. MEE Staff, "Egypt Closes Rafah Border Crossing with Gaza Strip Until Further Notice," *Middle East Eye*, February 13, 2015, https://www.middleeasteye.net/news/egypt-closes-rafah-border-crossing-gaza-strip-until-further-notice.
57. Elham Fakhro, "Revolution and Counter-Revolution in Bahrain," in *Civil Resistance in the Arab Spring: Triumphs and Disasters*, ed. A. Roberts, M. Willis, R. McCarthy, and T. Garton-Ash (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2016).
58. Fakhro.
59. Harriet Sherwood, "Binyamin Netanyahu Attacks Arab Spring Uprising," *Guardian*, November 24, 2011, https://www.theguardian.com/world/2011/nov/24/israel-netanyahu-attacks-arab-spring. See also Lazar Berman, "How Israel Kept the Arab Spring from Becoming the Winter of Its Discontent," *Times of Israel*, April 16, 2021, https://www.timesofisrael.com/how-israel-kept-the-arab-spring-from-becoming-the-winter-of-its-discontent/.
60. Fakhro, "Revolution."
61. Reuters Staff, "U.S. Resumes Bahrain Arms Sales Despite Rights Concerns," Reuters, May 12, 2012, https://www.reuters.com/article/us-usa-bahrain-idUSBRE84A11R20120512.
62. Josh Rogin, "Why Did the Bahraini Crown Prince Snub the USA?," *Foreign Policy,* December 8, 2012, https://foreignpolicy.com/2012/12/08/why-did-the-bahraini-crown-prince-snub-the-usa/.
63. Daryl Kimball, "U.S. Reinterprets MTCR Rules," *Arms Control Today*, September 2020, https://www.armscontrol.org/act/2020-09/news/us-reinterprets-mtcr-rules.

64. The United States grants Israel "first access" to certain technologies, ahead of other Arab states. For example, Israel acquired the F-15 from the United States in 1976, six years before Saudi Arabia. In instances where Israel and an Arab state operate the same system, the United States has at times given Israel a more advanced version of it. See Congressional Research Service, *Israel's Qualitative Military Edge and Possible U.S. Arms Sales to the United Arab Emirates*, CRS Report, October 26, 2020, https://sgp.fas.org/crs/mideast/R46580.pdf.
65. Edward Delman, "Obama Promised to End America's Wars—Has He?," *Atlantic*, March 30, 2016, https://www.theatlantic.com/international/archive/2016/03/obama-doctrine-wars-numbers/474531/.
66. Bill Marczack and John Scott-Railton, "The Million Dollar Dissident: NSO Group's iPhone Zero-Days Used Against a UAE Human Rights Defender," *Citizen Lab*, August 24, 2016, https://citizenlab.ca/2016/08/million-dollar-dissident-iphone-zero-day-nso-group-uae/.
67. Ronen Bergman and Mark Mazzetti, "The Battle for the World's Most Powerful Cyberweapon," *New York Times*, January 28, 2022, https://www.nytimes.com/2022/01/28/magazine/nso-group-israel-spyware.html.
68. Bergman and Mazzetti.
69. Marczack and Scott-Railton, "The Million Dollar Dissident."
70. "Hacking Team," Masaar Technology and Law Community, June 22, 2022, https://masaar.net/en/hacking-team-surveillance-companies-in-the-mena-region/.
71. Marczack and Scott-Railton, "The Million Dollar Dissident."
72. "The Historic Deal That Will Prevent Iran from Acquiring a Nuclear Weapon," Obama White House Archives, accessed July 23, 2023, https://obamawhitehouse.archives.gov/issues/foreign-policy/iran-deal.
73. Daryl G. Kimball, "Senate Failure to Block JCPOA Is a Victory for Nuclear Non-proliferation," Press release, Arms Control Association, September 10, 2015, https://www.armscontrol.org/pressroom/2015-09/senate-failure-block-jcpoa-victory-nuclear-nonproliferation.
74. Stephen Farrell, "Israel Admits Bombing Suspected Syrian Nuclear Reactor in 2007, Warns Iran," Reuters, March 21, 2018. See also Borzou Daraghi, "Israel's 1981 Bombing of Iraq Nuclear Reactor May Have Fueled Saddam's Nuclear Ambitions," *Independent*, June 7, 2021, https://www.independent.co.uk/news/world/israel-iraq-nuclear-osirak-military-b1861255.html.

75. Arms Control Association, "Understanding the JCPOA," August 2015, https://www.armscontrol.org/2015-08/section-3-understanding-jcpoa.
76. Washington Post Staff, "The Complete Transcript of Netanyahu's Address to Congress," *Washington Post*, March 3, 2015, https://www.washingtonpost.com/news/post-politics/wp/2015/03/03/full-text-netanyahus-address-to-congress/.
77. Saudi official, interview by author, Riyadh, August 2021. See also International Crisis Group, *A Time for Talks: Toward Dialogue Between the Gulf States and Iran*, Report no. 226, Middle East and North Africa, August 24, 2021, https://www.crisisgroup.org/middle-east-north-africa/gulf-and-arabian-peninsula/226-time-talks-toward-dialogue-between-gulf-arab-states-and-iran.
78. "Saudi Statement on Iran Nuclear Deal," Embassy of the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia, Washington, DC, July 14, 2015, https://www.saudiembassy.net/press-release/saudi-statement-iran-nuclear-dea
79. Saudi official, interview by author, Riyadh, August 2021. In general, Gulf leaders were more vocal about their unhappiness with the deal after the U.S. withdrawal from it. See also Faisal Abbas, "Trump's Iran Position Deserves Praise, Not Criticism," *Arab News*, May 9, 2018, https://www.arabnews.com/node/1299186/%7B%7B; and Stephen Kalin and Sarah Dadouch, "Gulf Arab Allies Hail Triump After U.S. Quits Iran Deal," May 10, 2018, Reuters, https://www.firstpost.com/world/gulf-arab-allies-hail-triumph-after-u-s-quits-iran-deal-4463423.html.
80. Neubauer, "Israel."
81. Entous, "Donald Trump's New World Order."
82. Caline Malek, "The UAE Chosen as Home for IRENA HQ," *National*, June 5, 2012, https://www.thenationalnews.com/uae/uae-chosen-as-home-for-irena-hq-1.380181.
83. "Israeli Minister Visits Abu Dhabi," Associated Press, January 17, 2010, https://www.jpost.com/middle-east/israeli-minister-visits-abu-dhabi-165943.
84. Barak Ravid, "United Arab Emirates: Israeli Mission in Abu Dhabi Not a Sign of Changed Attitude Towards Israel," *Haaretz*, November 28, 2015, https://www.haaretz.com/israel-news/.premium-u-a-e-israel-mission-not-sign-of-changed-relations-1.5427837.
85. "Israel in the Gulf," Twitter, https://twitter.com/IsraelintheGulf.

86. TOI Staff and Agencies, "In First, 'Hatikva' Anthem Played at UAE Contest as Israeli Judoka Wins Gold," *Times of Israel*, October 28, 2018, https://www.timesofisrael.com/in-first-hatikva-anthem-played-at-uae-contest-after-israeli-judoka-wins-gold/.
87. Grant Rumley, "Unpacking the UAE F-35 Negotiations," Washington Institute for Near East Policy, February 15, 2022, https://www.washingtoninstitute.org/policy-analysis/unpacking-uae-f-35-negotiations.
88. Agnes Helous, "Chinese and Saudi Firms Create Joint Venture to Make Military Drones in the Kingdom," *Defence News*, March 9, 2022, https://breakingdefense.com/2021/02/china-uae-forge-new-deals-joint-rd-plan-new-drone-sales/.
89. "From Moscow with Weapons: UAE-Russia Sign Anti-armour Missile Deal," *New Arab*, February 21, 2017, https://english.alaraby.co.uk/news/moscow-weapons-uae-russia-sign-anti-armour-missile-deal.
90. Warren Strobel, "UAE Shut Down China Facility Under U.S. Pressure, Emirates Says," *Wall Street Journal*, December 9, 2021, https://www.wsj.com/articles/u-a-e-confirms-it-halted-work-on-secret-chinese-port-project-after-pressure-from-u-s-11639070894.

3. THE TRUMP ADMINISTRATION

1. Nolan D Mccaskill, "Trump Tells Wisconsin: Victory Was a Surprise," *Politico*, December 13, 2016, https://www.politico.com/story/2016/12/donald-trump-wisconsin-232605.
2. Steven Bertoni, "Exclusive Interview: How Jared Kushner Won Trump the White House," *Forbes*, November 22, 2016, https://www.forbes.com/sites/stevenbertoni/2016/11/22/exclusive-interview-how-jared-kushner-won-trump-the-white-house/.
3. Judy Maltz, "David Friedman Raised Millions for Radical West Bank Jewish Settlers," *Haaretz*, December 16, 2016, https://www.haaretz.com/israel-news/2016-12-16/ty-article/.premium/fund-headed-by-trumps-ambassador-raised-millions-of-dollars-for-settlement/0000017f-df39-d3a5-af7f-ffbfa05c0000.
4. David Friedman, *Sledgehammer: How Breaking with the Past Brought Peace to the Middle East* (New York: Harper Collins, 2022), 90, 151–54.
5. Friedman, 149, 150, 45, 41.

6. Uriel Heilman, "How Did an Orthodox Ex-Settler Become Donald Trump's Israel Adviser?," *Haaretz*, April 18, 2016, https://www.haaretz.com/world-news/2016-04-18/ty-article/trumps-israel-adviser-an-orthodox-ex-settler/0000017f-f0e8-d487-abff-f3fe3a310000.
7. Jacob Magid, "Greenblatt Says He Prefers to Call Settlements Neighborhoods and Cities," *Times of Israel*, June 28, 2019, https://www.timesofisrael.com/greenblatt-says-he-prefers-to-call-settlements-neighborhoods-and-cities/.
8. Tal Kopan, "GOP Moves to the Right on Israel," CNN, July 11, 2016, https://edition.cnn.com/2016/07/11/politics/gop-platform-republican-convention-israel/index.html.
9. Daniel Estrin, "Trump Son-in-Law's Family Donated to Israeli Settler Groups," *Associated Press News*, December 6, 2016, https://apnews.com/article/0b655e0e7a8c41a6b0c8d9806962de6b.
10. Boaz Bismuth, "Trump to Israel Hayom: Israel Is the US's Bastion of Hope," *Israel Hayom*, May 13, 2016, https://digital-edition.israelhayom.co.il/Olive/odn/israel/.
11. Ryan Kohls, "Explained: Evangelicals, the Religious Right, and Trump," *Al Jazeera*, November 6, 2018, https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2018/11/6/explained-evangelicals-the-religious-right-and-trump.
12. "The Experiment Podcast: Evangelical Is Not a Religious Identity. It's a Political One," *Atlantic*, May 13, 2021, https://www.theatlantic.com/podcasts/archive/2021/05/evangelicals-republican-voters/618845/.
13. Eugene Scott, "Comparing Trump to Jesus, and Why Some Evangelicals Believe Trump Is God's Chosen One," *Washington Post*, December 18, 2019, https://www.washingtonpost.com/politics/2019/11/25/why-evangelicals-like-rick-perry-believe-that-trump-is-gods-chosen-one/.
14. Friedman, *Sledgehammer*, 47.
15. Alex Johnson, "Pompeo Suggests God Sent Trump to Save Israel," *NBC News*, March 21, 2019, https://www.nbcnews.com/politics/white-house/pompeo-suggests-god-sent-trump-save-israel-n986136.
16. Ron Kampeas, "Who Is Avi Berkowitz, the Kushner Adviser Stepping in to Work on Israeli-Palestinian Peace?," *Haaretz*, September 9, 2019, https://www.haaretz.com/israel-news/2019-09-09/ty-article/who-is-avi-berkowitz-the-kushner-adviser-stepping-in-to-work-on-mideast-peace/0000017f-e9b6-dc91-a17f-fdbfd8920000.

17. TBN Israel, "The Abraham Accords: How Israel Began Peace with the Middle East," November 6, 2021, YouTube Video, Trinity Broadcasting Network Israel, 11:40, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wBwJww9zFRQ&t=623s.
18. Jared Kushner, *Breaking History* (New York: Harper Collins, 2022), 70.
19. Kushner, 126.
20. Matthew Cole, "UAE Adviser Illegally Funneled Foreign Cash Into Hillary Clinton's 2016 Campaign," *Intercept*, January 16, 2022, https://theintercept.com/2022/01/16/uae-2016-election-trump-clinton-george-nader/.
21. Mark Mazzetti, Ronen Bergman, and David Kirkpatrick, "Trump Jr. and Other Aides Met with Gulf Emissary Offering Help to Win Election," *New York Times*, May 19, 2018, https://www.nytimes.com/2018/05/19/us/politics/trump-jr-saudi-uae-nader-prince-zamel.html.
22. Mazzetti, Bergman, and Kirkpatrick.
23. Adam Entous, Greg Miller, Kevin Sieff, and Karen DeYoung, "Blackwater Founder Held Secret Seychelles Meeting to Establish Trump-Putin Back Channel," *Washington Post*, April 3, 2017, https://www.washingtonpost.com/world/national-security/blackwater-founder-held-secret-seychelles-meeting-to-establish-trump-putin-back-channel/2017/04/03/95908a08-1648-11e7-ada0-1489b735b3a3_story.html.
24. Karen DeYoung, "How Thomas Barrack's Alleged Illegal Lobbying Shaped Trump's Policies in the Gulf," *Washington Post*, July 21, 2021, https://www.washingtonpost.com/national-security/trump-barrack-emirates-qatar/2021/07/21/f903a388-ea36-11eb-97a0-a09d1018e36_story.html.
25. David Kirkpatrick, "Who Is Behind Trump's Links to Arab Princes? A Billionaire Friend," *New York Times*, June 13, 2018, https://www.nytimes.com/2018/06/13/world/middleeast/trump-tom-barrack-saudi.html.
26. Kirkpatrick.
27. Katelyn Polantz, "Key Mueller Witness Charged with Funnelling Contributions to Clinton Campaign," CNN, December 4, 2019, https://edition.cnn.com/2019/12/04/politics/george-nader-key-mueller-witness-charged-with-funneling-contributions-to-clinton-campaign/index.html. See also Desmond Butler and Tom LoBianco, "The Princes, the President, and the Fortune Seekers," *Associated Press News*, May 22, 2018, https://apnews.com/article/north-america-donald-trump-ap-top-news-qatar-international-news-a3521859cf8d4c199cb9a8567abd2b71?.

28. Matthew Cole, "UAE Adviser Illegally Funnelled Foreign Cash Into Hillary Clinton's 2016 Campaign," *Intercept*, January 16, 2022, https://theintercept.com/2022/01/16/uae-2016-election-trump-clinton-george-nader/.
29. Ian Black, "Arab States Withdraw Ambassadors from Qatar in Protest at 'Interference,'" *Guardian*, March 5, 2014, https://www.theguardian.com/world/2014/mar/05/arab-states-qatar-withdraw-ambassadors-protest.
30. Black.
31. Butler and LoBianco, "The Princes."
32. Kushner, *Breaking History*, 93–94.
33. Karen DeYoung, "First Stop on Trump's First Official Trip Overseas Signals Saudi Arabia's Importance," *Washington Post*, May 18, 2017, https://www.washingtonpost.com/world/national-security/first-stop-on-trumps-first-official-trip-overseas-signals-saudi-arabias-importance/2017/05/18/a70e9ba4-39c9-11e7-8854-21f359183e8c_story.html.
34. "President Trump Delivers Remarks at the Arab Islamic Summit," Trump White House Archives, May 21, 2017, https://trumpwhitehouse.archives.gov/articles/president-trump-delivers-remarks-arab-islamic-american-summit/.
35. DeYoung, "How Thomas Barrack's Alleged."
36. TBN Israel, "The Abraham Accords."
37. Bob Woodward, *Rage* (London: Simon and Schuster, 2020), 148.
38. "Qatar Crisis: What You Need to Know," *BBC News*, July 19, 2017, https://www.bbc.com/news/world-middle-east-40173757.
39. "Trump Says Perhaps Isolating Qatar Beginning of End of Terrorism," *Al Arabiya News*, June 6, 2017, https://english.alarabiya.net/News/gulf/2017/06/06/Trump-says-perhaps-isolating-Qatar-beginning-of-end-of-terrorism-.
40. Kushner, *Breaking History*, 3.
41. Kushner, 119.
42. Kushner, 170.
43. Kushner, 170.
44. "Kingdom of Saudi Arabia's Statement on the United States Withdrawal from the JCPOA," Embassy of Kingdom of Saudi Arabia, Washington, DC, May 8, 2018, https://www.saudiembassy.net/news/kingdom-saudi-arabias-statement-united-states-withdrawal-jcpoa. See also Reuters Staff, "UAE Supports U.S. Withdrawal from Iran Nuclear Deal: State News Agency,"

Reuters, May 9, 2018, https://www.reuters.com/article/us-iran-nuclear-emirates-idUSKBN1I92Z1.

45. Daniel Levy, "Is t Good for the Jews," *American Prospect*, June 18, 2006, https://prospect.org/features/good-jews/.
46. "Statement by President Trump on Jerusalem," Trump White House Archives, December 6, 2017, https://trumpwhitehouse.archives.gov/briefings-statements/statement-president-trump-jerusalem/.
47. Barak Ravid, "Trump's Big Deal Part I: May Your House Be Destroyed," interview, *Axios*, Podcast, December 13, 2021, https://www.axios.com/how-it-happened-podcast-trump-netanyahu-5947910d-dad6-4e3b-8461-a7e87ada6d73.html.
48. Ravid.
49. "Leader of the Palestinian U.S. Delegation Reacts to Trump's Jerusalem Decision," NPR, December 6, 2017, https://www.npr.org/2017/12/06/568920314/leader-of-the-palestinian-u-n-delegation-reacts-to-trumps-jerusalem-decision.
50. Tom Gara, "Here's How Chief Palestinian Negotiator Described His Last Meeting with Jared Kushner," *Buzzfeed News*, December 16, 2018, https://www.buzzfeednews.com/article/tomgara/saeb-erekat-kushner-last-meeting-jerusalem-embassy.
51. Ali Sawafta, "Palestinians Congratulate Biden, Indicate End to Boycott of U.S.," Reuters, November 8, 2020, https://www.reuters.com/article/uk-usa-election-palestinians-idUKKBN27O0AF.
52. Peter Beaumont and Oliver Holmes, "US Confirms End to Funding for UN Palestinian Refugees," *Guardian*, August 31, 2018, https://www.theguardian.com/world/2018/aug/31/trump-to-cut-all-us-funding-for-uns-main-palestinian-refugee-programme.
53. Interview by author, London, June 2023.
54. Interview by author, London, June 2023.
55. Katie Paul, "Oman Says Time to Accept Israel in the Region, Offers Help for Peace," Reuters, October 27, 2018, https://www.reuters.com/article/bahrain-summit-oman-idINKCN1N10DU.
56. The video was first aired on the official YouTube channel of Prime Miniser Netanyahu's office. See Ravid, "Trump's Big Deal Part I," 234.
57. Kushner, *Breaking History*, 239
58. Friedman, *Sledgehammer*, 158.

59. Friedman.
60. Oliver Holmes and Julian Borger, "Israel's Netanyahu to Play Trump Card in Tight Election," *Guardian*, March 23, 2019, https://www.theguardian.com/us-news/2019/mar/23/israel-netanyahu-election-trump-golan-heights.
61. "Netanyahu Vows to Start Annexing West Bank in Bid to Rally the Right," *New York Times*, April 6, 2019, https://www.nytimes.com/2019/04/06/world/middleeast/netanyahu-annex-west-bank.html.
62. Zack Beauchamp, "Benjamin Netanyahu Won Israel's Election. Here's What Comes Next," *Vox*, April 10, 2019, https://www.vox.com/world/2019/4/10/18302233/israel-election-results-benjamin-netanyahu-2019.
63. Ravid observes: "Netanyahu began to see Trump's Presidency as an 'all you can eat' buffet, an opportunity of a lifetime that might allow him not only to secure his legacy but also save his political career." See Ravid, "Trump's Big Deal Part I."
64. Ryan Grim and Akbar Shahid Akbar, "Yousef Al-Otaiba Is the Most Powerful Man in Washington You've Never Heard of," *Huffington Post Highline*, September 3, 2015, https://highline.huffingtonpost.com/articles/en/his-town/.
65. Jade Miller, "The Dubai Ports Controversy: An Uproar Heard Round the World," University of Southern California Center of Public Diplomacy, March, 2006, https://uscpublicdiplomacy.org/pdin_monitor_article/dubai-ports-controversy-uproar-heard-round-world.
66. Miller.
67. Kushner, *Breaking History*, 245.
68. TBN Israel, "The Abraham Accords: The Beginning of Peace in the Middle East (Episode One)," Trinity Broadcasting Network Israel, November 6, 2021, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ubGRvpvBe7w&t=2s.
69. Matt Spetalnick and Steve Holland, "Exclusive: White House's Kushner Unveils Economic Portion of Middle East Peace Plan," Reuters, June 22, 2019, https://www.reuters.com/article/us-israel-palestinians-plan-exclusive-idUSKCN1TN0ES.
70. "White House Will Not Invite Israeli Officials to Bahrain Event: Senior U.S. Official," Reuters, June 17, 2019, https://www.reuters.com/article/us-usa-trump-middleeast-idUSKCN1TI29D.
71. Kristin Smith Diwan, "The Manama Workshop and the Course of Normalization in the Gulf," Arab Gulf States Institute in Washington,

July 3, 2019, https://agsiw.org/the-manama-workshop-and-the-course-of-normalization-in-the-gulf/.

72. "Bahrain FM: Peace to Prosperity Workshop a New Beginning for the Region," *Al Arabiya English*, June 26, 2019, https://english.alarabiya.net/features/2019/06/26/Bahrain-FM-Peace-to-Prosperity-workshop-a-new-beginning-for-the-region.
73. "Bahrain FM Says Israel Part of Region's 'Heritage,'" *Arab Weekly*, June 6, 2019, https://thearabweekly.com/bahrain-fm-says-israel-part-regions-heritage
74. Jason Greenblatt and Brian Hook, "Greenblatt and Hook: Israeli-Palestinian Peace Would Be Iran's Worst Nightmare," Fox News, July 30, 2019, https://www.foxnews.com/opinion/greenblatt-and-hook-israeli-palestinian-peace-would-be-irans-worst-nightmare.
75. John Defterios and Victoria Cavaliere, "Coordinated Strikes Knock out Half of Saudi Oil Capacity, More than 5 Million Barrels a Day," CNN, September 15, 2019, https://edition.cnn.com/2019/09/14/business/saudi-oil-output-impacted-drone-attack/index.html.
76. Ravid, "Trump's Big Deal Part I," 252.
77. Julian Borger and Oliver Holmes, "U.S. No Longer Considers Israeli West Bank Settlements Illegal," *Guardian*, November 18, 2019, https://www.theguardian.com/world/2019/nov/18/us-israeli-settlements-no-longer-considered-illegal-palestinian-land-mike-pompeo.
78. Friedman, *Sledgehammer*, 165.
79. Geoffrey Aronson, "Trump's Decision on Settlements Opens the Way to Annexation," *Arab Weekly*, November 24, 2019, https://thearabweekly.com/trumps-decision-settlements-opens-way-annexation.
80. Ben Caspit, "Episode 72," December 20, 2021, in *Israeli Journalist Barak Ravid Tells How the Abraham Accords Came About on Israel with Ben Caspit*, produced by Ben Caspit, Al-Monitor podcast, MP3 audio, 40:30, https://www.al-monitor.com/podcasts/israeli-journalist-barak-ravid-tells-how-abraham-accords-came-about.
81. Michael Crowly and David Halbfinger, "Trump Releases Mideast Peace Plan That Strongly Favors Israel," *New York Times*, January 28, 2020, https://www.nytimes.com/2020/01/28/world/middleeast/peace-plan.html.
82. Oliver Holmes, Sufian Taha, and Hazem Balousha, "Trump Unveils Middle East Peace Plan with No Palestinian Support," *Guardian*, January 28,

2020, https://www.theguardian.com/world/2020/jan/28/donald-trump-middle-east-peace-plan-israel-netanyahu-palestinians.

83. Eric Cortellessa, "Kushner Peace Plan Once Urged Huge Palestinian-Jordanian-Saudi Land Swap—Book," *Times of Israel*, March 20, 2019, https://www.timesofisrael.com/kushner-peace-plan-urged-palestinian-jordanian-saudi-land-swap-book/.
84. Holmes, Taha and Balousha, "Trump Unveils Middle East."
85. Alex Ward, "Trump's Israel-Palestine Peace Plan, Explained," *Vox News*, January 28, 2020, https://www.vox.com/2020/1/28/21083615/trump-peace-plan-map-netanyahu-israel-palestine.
86. TOI Staff, "What the Hell Was That? Netanyahu Annexation Announcement Caught Trump off Guard," *Times of Israel*, December 14, 2021, https://www.timesofisrael.com/what-the-hell-was-that-netanyahu-annexation-announcement-caught-trump-off-guard/.
87. Anshel Pfeffer, "How an Impeached President, Indicted Prime Minister, and Power-Hungry Prince Changed the Middle East Forever," *Haaretz*, December 14, 2021, https://www.haaretz.com/israel-news/.premium.HIGHLIGHT.MAGAZINE-how-trump-netanyahu-and-mbz-totally-transformed-the-middle-east-1.10465045?lts=1646814363619.
88. Ravid, "Trump's Big Deal Part I," 119.
89. Caspit, "Episode 72."
90. Mohamed Abdelaziz, "Arab Reactions to Trump's Peace Plan: An Analysis and Recommendation," Washington Institute for Near East Policy, January 31, 2020, https://www.washingtoninstitute.org/policy-analysis/arab-reactions-trumps-peace-plan-analysis-and-recommendation.
91. "Abbas Blasts Trump's Plan for a 'Swiss Cheese' Palestinian State in UN Speech," *France 24*, February 11, 2020, https://www.france24.com/en/20200211-palestinian-leader-attempts-to-drum-up-opposition-to-trump-plan-at-un.
92. Patrick Wintour and Oliver Holmes, "Palestinians Shelve Plan for UN Vote on Trump's Middle East Plan," *Guardian*, February 11, 2020, https://www.theguardian.com/world/2020/feb/10/tunisia-to-shelve-plan-for-un-vote-on-trumps-middle-east-plan.
93. TBN Israel, "The Abraham Accords."
94. Caspit, "Episode 72."

95. "Settler Chiefs Say PM Betrayed Them, Is Adopting Rhetoric of Extreme Left," *Times of Israel*, August 16, 2020, https://www.timesofisrael.com/settlement-leaders-accuse-netanyahu-of-betrayal-over-annexation-reversal/; and Steven Hendrix, Ruth Eglash, and Anne Gearan, "Jared Kushner Put a Knife in Netanyahu's Back Over Annexation Delay, Says Israeli Settler Leader," *Washington Post*, February 4, 2020, https://www.washingtonpost.com/world/middle_east/reports-jared-kushner-angers-netanyahu-camp-by-slowing-annexation-moves/2020/02/04/82376ac6-4719-11ea-91ab-ce439aa5c7c1_story.html.
96. Osama Al Sharif, "What Are Jordan's Options if Israel Annexes West Bank?," *Al Monitor*, May 25, 2020, https://www.al-monitor.com/originals/2020/05/jordan-king-threats-peace-treaty-israel-annexation-plans.html#ixzz7NEZhMlis.
97. Yousef Al-Otaiba, "Annexation Will Be a Serious Setback for Better Relations with the Arab World," *Yedioth Ahronoth*, June 12, 2020, https://www.ynetnews.com/article/H1GuIceTL.
98. Ravid, "Trump's Big Deal Part I."
99. Ravid; and Kushner, *Breaking History*, 388.
100. Ravid, "Trump's Big Deal Part I."
101. "Palestinian Authority Rejects UAE Aid Via Israeli Airport," *Al Jazeera*, May 21, 2020, https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2020/5/21/palestinian-authority-rejects-uae-aid-sent-via-israeli-airport.
102. "Palestinians Again Refuse Planeload of Virus Aid from UAE," *Times of Israel*, June 11, 2020, https://www.timesofisrael.com/palestinians-again-refuse-planeload-of-virus-aid-from-uae/#.
103. Ahmad Melhem, "Palestinians Reject Aid from UAE Again," *Al-Monitor*, June 16, 2020, https://www.al-monitor.com/originals/2020/06/palestinian-authority-reject-uae-aid-israel-normalization.html.
104. Sara Al Shurafa and Jaya Chandran, "UAE, US and Israel Reach Historic Deal to End Further Annexation of Palestinian Territories," *Gulf News*, August 13, 2020, https://gulfnews.com/uae/uae-us-and-israel-reach-historic-deal-to-end-further-annexation-of-palestinian-territories-1.1597325693904.
105. "Read the Full Statement by the US, Israel, and UAE on Normalizing Israel-UAE relations," CNN, August 13, 2020, https://edition.cnn.com/2020/08/13/middleeast/mideast-trump-full-statement-uae-israel-intl/index.html.

106. "Netanyahu Says West Bank Annexation Plans Still on the Table," *Al Jazeera English*, August 13, 2020. https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2020/8/13/netanyahu-says-west-bank-annexation-plans-still-on-the-table+&cd=14&hl=en&ct=clnk&gl=bh.
107. Emirati official, interview by author, Dubai, September 2020.
108. Kushner, *Breaking History*, 388.
109. "Report: UAE Crown Prince Skipped White House Signing Over PM's Annexation Stance," *Times of Israel*, September 19, 2020, https://www.timesofisrael.com/report-uae-crown-prince-skipped-white-house-signing-over-pms-annexation-stance/; and "Elaf Takshuf Sabab Ghiyab Wali Ahd Abu Dhabi 'An Tawqee' Ibrahim" *Elaph*, September 18, 2020, https://www.elaph.com/Web/News/2020/09/1305231.html.
110. Natasha Turak, "UAE to Get Its First Reaper Drones, Clinches F-35 Deal as Trump Administration Pushes Through Final Arms Sales," CNBC, November 12, 2020, https://www.cnbc.com/2020/11/12/uae-set-to-get-its-first-reaper-drones-clinch-f-35-deal-as-trump-administration-pushes-through-final-arms-sales-.html.
111. Jacob Magid and TOI Staff, "UAE Diplomat: Talks with US on F-35s Began After Normalization Deal Was Signed," *Times of Israel*, November 11, 2020, https://www.timesofisrael.com/uae-diplomat-talks-with-us-on-f-35s-began-after-normalization-deal-was-signed/.
112. Friedman, *Sledgehammer*, 215.
113. Ravid, "Trump's Big Deal Part I," 355.
114. Barak Ravid, "Trump Blasts Netanyahu for Disloyalty: F**k Him," *Axios*, December 10, 2021, https://www.axios.com/trump-netanyahu-disloyalty-fuck-him-276ac6cc-3f70-4fba-b315-c82a59603e67.html.
115. "Israel Officially Moves to CENTCOM," Jewish Institute for National Security of America, September 2, 2021, https://jinsa.org/jinsa_report/israel-officially-moves-to-centcom/.

4. A NEW RELATIONSHIP

1. For the UAE, these objectives also formed part its "Strategy for the Fourth Industrial Revolution," outlining plans to develop the kind of advanced, services-oriented economy more closely resembling Israel than those of other petro-states. See "The UAE's Fourth Industrial Revolution Strategy," United

Arab Emirates Government Portal, November 24, 2022, https://u.ae/en/about-the-uae/strategies-initiatives-and-awards/strategies-plans-and-visions/government-services-and-digital-transformation/the-uae-strategy-for-the-fourth-industrial-revolution#.

2. Raphael Ahren, "Bahrain Won't Have to Abolish Israeli Boycott Law—Because It Did So Years Ago," *Times of Israel*, September 14, 2020, https://www.timesofisrael.com/bahrain-wont-have-to-abolish-israel-boycott-law-because-it-did-so-years-ago/.
3. The fund also later became open to Sudan and Morocco, after they normalized their relations with Israel. See Tal Schneider, "Trump's $3 Billion Abraham Fund May Be Tapped out Before Staking a Dime," *Times of Israel*, March 2, 2021, https://www.timesofisrael.com/trumps-3-billion-abraham-fund-may-be-tapped-out-before-staking-a-dime/.
4. Schneider.
5. "UAE Announces $10 Billion Fund for Investments in Israel," United Arab Emirates Ministry of Foreign Affairs and International Cooperation, March 14, 2021, https://www.mofaic.gov.ae/en/missions/tel-aviv/media-hub/embassy-news/uae-announces-$10-billion-fund-for-investments-in-israel.
6. Daniel Avis and Ben Bartenstein, "UAE Wealth Funds Behind $10 Billion Israel Plans Scout for Deals," *Bloomberg*, February 3, 2022, https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2022-02-03/uae-wealth-funds-behind-10-billion-israel-plans-scout-for-deals#xj4y7vzkg.
7. Lazar Berman, "Israel Approves Multimillion-Dollar Joint R&D Fund with UAE," *Times of Israel*, January 23, 2022, https://www.timesofisrael.com/israel-approves-multimillion-dollar-joint-rd-fund-with-uae/#.
8. "Israel, UAE Finalize 'Milestone' Free Trade Deal," Reuters, April 1, 2022, https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/israel-says-uae-free-trade-deal-reached-2022-04-01/.
9. Alexander Cornwall, "Israel, UAE Boost Ties with Free Trade Pact," Reuters, May 31, 2022, https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/israel-uae-sign-free-trade-deal-ambassador-2022-05-31/.
10. Ricky Ben-David, "UAE Seeks Staggering $1 Trillion in Economic Ties with Israel Over Next Decade," *Times of Israel*, September 15, 2021, https://www.timesofisrael.com/uae-seeks-1-trillion-in-economic-ties-with-israel-over-next-decade/.

11. Katherine Bauer, "Israel-UAE Economic Cooperation Has Deep Roots and Broad Dividends," Washington Institute for Near East Policy, March 8, 2022, https://www.washingtoninstitute.org/policy-analysis/israel-uae-economic-cooperation-has-deep-roots-and-broad-dividends.
12. "United Arab Emirates—Country Commercial Guide," International Trade Administration, July 26, 2022, https://www.trade.gov/knowledge-product/united-arab-emirates-market-overview.
13. Michael Fahy, "Dubai and Israel Diamond Exchanges Sign Collaboration Pact," *National*, September 17, 2020, https://www.thenationalnews.com/business/economy/dubai-and-israel-diamond-exchanges-sign-collaboration-pact-1.1079127.
14. "UAE Peace Breathes New Life Into Israeli Diamond Industry," *i24 News*, October 11, 2020, YouTube video, 2:47, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=y9u-B11V0R4.
15. "UAE Peace Breaths."
16. "Diamonds in UAE," *OEC*, accessed July 24, 2023, https://oec.world/en/profile/bilateral-product/diamonds/reporter/are.
17. "Dubai-Israel Diamond Trade Gets a Major Boost in 2022," Israel Diamond Industry, March 21, 2023, https://en.israelidiamond.co.il/news/israel/dubai-israel-diamond-trade/
18. Jerusalem Post Staff, "Israel's Diamond Sales Hit Record After Decade of Decline," *Jerusalem Post*, January 3, 2022, https://www.jpost.com/business-and-innovation/banking-and-finance/article-691410.
19. Deena Kamel, "UAE's First-Quarter Diamond Trade Rises 36% to $11bn," *National*, June 10, 2022, https://www.thenationalnews.com/business/2022/06/10/uaes-first-quarter-diamond-trade-rises-36-to-11bn/; and Melanie Swan, "Antwerp Loses Its Sparkle as Dubai Lures Diamond Trade," *Sunday Times* (London), August 1, 2021, https://www.thetimes.co.uk/article/antwerp-loses-sparkle-dubai-lures-diamond-trade-mpgq2wdvf.
20. "Dubai-Israel Diamond Trade."
21. Reuters Staff, "UAE, Israeli Companies Sign 'Strategic Commercial Agreement' on Coronavirus R&D," Reuters, August 16, 2020, https://www.reuters.com/article/us-israel-emirates-covid-idUSKCN25B0ZL.
22. Pluristem Therapeutics, "Pluristem and Abu Dhabi Stem Cells Center Sign MOU to Collaborate in the Development of Cell Therapies and Regenerative Medicines for the Treatment of Severe Diseases Including Covid-19,"

Global News Wire, August 17, 2020, https://www.globenewswire.com/en/news-release/2020/08/17/2079006/11974/en/Pluristem-and-Abu-Dhabi-Stem-Cells-Center-Sign-MOU-to-Collaborate-in-the-Development-of-Cell-Therapies-and-Regenerative-Medicines-for-the-Treatment-of-Severe-Diseases-Including-COV.html.

23. "Health Minister of Israel, UAE Talk Cooperation on Coronavirus Research," *Times of Israel*, August 24, 2020, https://www.timesofisrael.com/health-ministers-of-israel-uae-talk-cooperation-on-coronavirus-research/.
24. Sure Universal, "Israel's Innovative Technology Company SURE Universal Ltd Partners with United Arab Emirates (UAE) Firm HBK Department of Projects to Launch Healthcare Solution, HBKiCare," *PR Newswire*, September 22, 2020, https://www.prnewswire.com/il/news-releases/israels-innovative-technology-company-sure-universal-ltd-partners-with-united-arab-emirates-uae-firm-hbk-department-of-projects-to-launch-healthcare-solution-hbkicare-301135557.html.
25. Shoshanna Solomon, "MediWound Signs UAE Marketing Deal for Pineapple-Based Gel for Burns," *Times of Israel*, December 15, 2020, https://www.timesofisrael.com/mediwound-signs-uae-marketing-deal-for-pineapple-based-gel-for-burns/.
26. Suchita Chaudhary, "A New Frontier in Anti-ageing Healthcare, UAE-Israel Venture Aviv Clinics Opens in Dubai," *Gulf News*, April 7, 2021, https://gulfnews.com/uae/health/a-new-frontier-in-anti-ageing-health-care-uae-israel-venture-aviv-clincs-opens-in-dubai-1.78395245.
27. "Israel and UAE Medical Collaboration: Sheba Physicians Will Travel to Dubai, Treat Security Personnel and Train Medical Personnel," *Sheba Global*, October 22, 2021, https://www.shebaonline.org/israel-and-uae-medical-collaboration-continue-as-sheba-physicians-will-travel-to-the-uae-treat-security-personnel-and-train-medical-personnel/.
28. TOI Staff, "Israeli Firm Signs Deal to pipe UAE to Europe," *Times of Israel*, October 21, 2020. https://www.timesofisrael.com/israeli-firm-signs-deal-to-pipe-uae-oil-to-europe/.
29. "Israel's Environment Ministry Blocks Oil Pipeline Deal with UAE," *Al Arabiya News*, December 16, 2021, https://english.alarabiya.net/News/middle-east/2021/12/16/Israel-s-environment-ministry-blocks-oil-pipeline-deal-with-UAE.

30. Felicia Schwartz and Rory Jones, "Israeli, UAE Energy Firms Set Up Biggest Deal Since Diplomatic Agreement," *Wall Street Journal*, April 26, 2021, https://www.wsj.com/articles/israeli-u-a-e-energy-firms-set-up-biggest-deal-since-diplomatic-agreement-11619449804. See also Felicity Glover, "Mubadala Petroleum Finalizes $1 Billion Deal for 22% Stake in Israel's Tamar Gas Field," *National*, September 2, 2021, https://www.thenationalnews.com/business/2021/09/02/mubadala-petroleum-finalises-1bn-deal-for-22-stake-in-israels-tamar-gas-field/.
31. "Israel, Jordan, Sign Huge UAE-Brokered Deal to Swap Solar Energy and Water," *Times of Israel*, November 22, 2021, https://www.timesofisrael.com/israel-jordan-sign-uae-brokered-deal-to-swap-solar-energy-and-water/.
32. Danny Zaken, "Israel to Begin Exporting Gas to Egypt Via Jordan," *Globes*, February 16, 2022, https://en.globes.co.il/en/article-israel-to-begin-exporting-gas-to-egypt-via-jordan-1001402590.
33. Glover, "Mubadala Petroleum Finalizes."
34. "UAE Launches Plan to Achieve Net Zero Emissions by 2050," Reuters, October 7, 2021, https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/uae-launches-plan-achieve-net-zero-emissions-by-2050-2021-10-07/.
35. "Israel Electric, UAE's Energroup to Partner on Hydrogen Generation," Reuters, March 6, 2022, https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/israel-electric-uaes-energroup-partner-hydrogen-generation-2022-03-06/.
36. George Odhiambo, "Water Scarcity in the Arabian Peninsula and Socio-economic Implications," *Applied Water Science* 7 (2017): 2479–92, https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s13201-016-0440-1.
37. Stephen Leahy and Katherine Purvis, "Peak Salt: Is the Desalination Dream Over for the Gulf States?," *Guardian*, September 29, 2016, https://www.theguardian.com/global-development-professionals-network/2016/sep/29/peak-salt-is-the-desalination-dream-over-for-the-gulf-states.
38. For data on Pakistan, see Simeon Kerr and Farhan Bokhari, "UAE Investors Buy Pakistan Farmland," *Financial Times*, May 12, 2008, https://www.ft.com/content/c6536028-1f9b-11dd-9216-000077b07658. For data on Sudan and Philippines, see Joachim Von Braun and Ruth Meinzen-Dick, "Land Grabbing by Foreign Investors in Developing Countries: Risks and Opportunities," International Food Policy Research Institute, 2009, https://www.ifpri.org/publication/land-grabbing-foreign-investors-developing-countries. For data on Al-Dahra, see Michael Tanchum, "The UAE's

Food-Security Plans Have Made It a Global Market Player," *National*, May 6, 2022, https://www.thenationalnews.com/weekend/2022/05/06/the-uaes-food-security-strategy-has-made-it-a-global-market-player/.

39. Joanne Bladd, "Call for GCC Land Grab Policy to Stop—Experts," *Arabian Business*, September 7, 2009, https://www.arabianbusiness.com/politics-economics/call-for-gcc-land-grab-policy-stop-experts-13103.
40. Tanchum, "The UAE's Food-Security Plans."
41. Author's visit to Israel Pavilion, Dubai Expo 2020, February 2021.
42. "Israel's Fluence Foresees Wastewater Solutions for the UAE and Region," *Israel Gulf Report*, December 23, 2020, https://www.israelgulfreport.com/post/israel-s-fluence-foresees-wastewater-solutions-for-the-uae-and-region.
43. "Investments in New Desalination Plants in UAE Valued at $2.08 Billion, Minister Says," *National*, May 10, 2022, https://www.thenationalnews.com/business/energy/2022/05/10/investments-in-new-desalination-projects-in-uae-valued-at-208bn-minister-says/.
44. Luke Tress, "Israel's Vertical Field Inks Deal to Deploy Its Farming System in UAE," *Times of Israel*, January 20, 2021, https://www.timesofisrael.com/israels-vertical-field-inks-deal-to-deploy-its-farming-system-in-uae/.
45. "Al Dahra, Israel's Watergen Sign Strategic Partnership in Water Security," Emirates News Agency (WAM), November 26, 2020, https://wam.ae/en/details/1395302890325.
46. "Israel-UAE Water Research Institute to Open in Abu Dhabi," *Jerusalem Post*, June 1, 2021, https://www.jpost.com/health-science/israel-uae-water-research-institute-to-open-in-abu-dhabi-669808.
47. Israel Fisher and Michael Rochvarger, "Israel's State-Owned Water Company to Provide Consulting Services to Bahrain," *Haaretz*, March 29, 2021, https://www.haaretz.com/israel-news/business/.premium-israel-s-state-owned-water-company-to-provide-consulting-services-to-bahrain-1.9664546.
48. Khalej Times Staff Reporter, "UAE, Israel Universities Ink Agreement to Boost AI Collaboration," *Khaleej Times*, September 15, 2020, https://www.khaleejtimes.com/uae/uae-israel-universities-ink-agreement-to-boost-ai-collaboration.
49. "Israel, UAE Sign First Academic Cooperation Agreement," *Jerusalem Post*, March 14, 2022, https://www.jpost.com/middle-east/article-701194.

50. Media Line Staff, "UAE National Archives, Israel's National Library Sign Agreement," *Media Line*, November 4, 2022, https://themedialine.org/headlines/uae-national-archives-israels-national-library-sign-agreement/.
51. INSS, "The Atlantic Council, Emirates Policy Center, and Institute for National Security Studies Announce Strategic Partnership to Advance UAE-Israel Relations," Press Release, Institute for National Security Studies Press Release, October 15, 2021, https://www.inss.org.il/think-tanks-cooperation/.
52. "Memorandum of Understanding with the National Institute for Security Studies in Israel," *Derasat*, August 12, 2021, https://www.derasat.org.bh/memorandum-of-understanding-with-the-national-institute-for-security-studies-in-israel/.
53. "Israeli Settler Delegation in Dubai to Talk Business Cooperation with Emiratis," *Times of Israel*, November 11, 2020, https://www.timesofisrael.com/israeli-settler-delegation-in-dubai-to-talk-business-cooperation-with-emiratis/.
54. New Arab Staff, "Israel Forms First Council for Illegal Settlements Since 90s," *New Arab*, May 10, 2022, https://english.alaraby.co.uk/news/israel-forms-first-council-illegal-settlements-90s.
55. Tovah Lazaroff, "IDF Halts Attempt to Rebuild Homesh Settlement, First Razed in 2005," *Jerusalem Post*, April 28, 2021, https://www.jpost.com/israel-news/idf-halts-attempt-to-rebuild-homesh-settlement-first-razed-in-2005-666614.
56. Hagar Shezaf, "15 Years After Israeli Pullout, Many Palestinians Still Barred from Reaching Their Land," *Haaretz*, August 17, 2020, https://www.haaretz.com/israel-news/.premium-15-years-after-disengagement-from-gaza-many-barred-from-reaching-their-land-1.9070287.
57. "UN Experts Alarmed by Rise in Settler Violence in Occupied Palestinian Territory," United Nations Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights, November 10, 2021, https://www.ohchr.org/en/press-releases/2021/11/un-experts-alarmed-rise-settler-violence-occupied-palestinian-territory.
58. "Data Sheet, December 2019: Law Enforcement on Israeli Civilians in the West Bank," *Yesh Din*, January 30, 2020, https://www.yesh-din.org/en/data-sheet-december-2019-law-enforcement-on-israeli-civilians-in-the-west-bank/.

59. Givat Hahish, "West Bank Settlers Pressure Netanyahu Ahead of March Vote," *France 24*, January 28, 2021, https://www.france24.com/en/live-news/20210128-west-bank-settlers-pressure-netanyahu-ahead-of-march-vote.
60. "By Hook and Crook: Israeli Settlement Policy in the West Bank," B'Tselem, July 2010, https://www.btselem.org/publications/summaries/201007_by_hook_and_by_crook.
61. United Nations, "Israel's Settlements Have No Legal Validity, Constitute Flagrant Violation of International Law, Security Council Reaffirms," United Nations Meetings Coverage and Press Releases, December 23, 2016, https://www.un.org/press/en/2016/sc12657.doc.htm.
62. "Israel Approves West Bank Settlement Homes Ahead of Trump Exit," *DW News*, January 17, 2021, https://www.dw.com/en/israel-approves-west-bank-settlement-homes-ahead-of-trump-exit/a-56256384. See also "Return of the Outpost Method," *Peace Now*, July 22, 2019, https://peacenow.org.il/en/return-of-the-outpost-method; and Debora Patta and Agnes Reau, "Palestinians in the West Bank Say Israeli Settlers Attack Them, Seize Their Land Amid the War with Hamas," *CBS News*, November 16, 2023, https://www.cbsnews.com/news/israel-hamas-war-palestinians-in-west-bank-say-israeli-settlers-seizing-land/
63. Hahish, "West Bank Settlers."
64. Tovah Lazaroff, "West Bank Samaria Settler Olive Oil and Wine to Be Exported to Dubai," *Jerusalem Post*, December 8, 2020, https://www.jpost.com/middle-east/west-bank-samaria-settler-olive-oil-and-wine-to-be-exported-to-dubai-651424.
65. Raphael Ahren, "No Labels: Israel's New Gulf Partners Seem Happy to Do Business with Settlements," *Times of Israel*, December 9, 2020, https://www.timesofisrael.com/no-labels-israels-new-gulf-partners-seem-happy-to-do-business-with-settlements/.
66. Ahren.
67. Dan Williams, "Bahrain Open to Imports from Israeli Settlements, Palestinians Fume," Reuters, December 3, 2020, https://www.reuters.com/article/us-israel-bahrain-idUSKBN28D1O5.
68. "Bahrain Says It Won't Allow Imports from Israeli Settlements," Reuters, December 5, 2020.
69. "UAE Press: Palestinian Unity a Positive Signal," Emirates News Agency, October 4, 2017, http://wam.ae/en/details/1395302636225.

70. "Norway's Capital Oslo Is Banning Israeli Settlement Goods and Services," Palestinian BDS National Committee, October 28, 2019, https://bdsmovement.net/news/norways-capital-oslo-banning-israeli-settlement-goods-and-services. See also Gershom Gorenberg, "Opinion: Israel Just Showed Its Strategy on Settlement Boycotts: Gaslighting," *Washington Post*, December 14, 2021, https://www.washingtonpost.com/opinions/2021/12/14/israel-horizon-europe-deal-settlement-boycotts-gaslighting/; Oliver Holmes, "UN Publishes List of Companies with Ties to Israeli Settlements," *Guardian*, February 12, 2020, https://www.theguardian.com/weather/2020/feb/12/un-publishes-list-of-companies-with-ties-to-israeli-settlements.
71. David Rosenberg, "Israeli Settlers Want to Make Business Deals in Dubai. Pity They Have Nothing to Offer," *Haaretz*, November 13, 2020, https://www.haaretz.com/middle-east-news/.premium-israeli-settlers-want-to-make-deals-in-dubai-pity-they-have-nothing-to-offer-1.9306207.
72. "Kuwait Parliament Passes Bill Banning Dealings with Israel," *New Arab*, May 29, 2021, https://english.alaraby.co.uk/news/kuwait-jail-fine-anyone-who-deals-israel.
73. "Al Kuwait: Multazimoon bi-muqata'at Israel wa-muntajatiha," *Al-Jarida*, July 31, 2021, https://www.aljarida.com/articles/1659277841010387200.
74. "Oman Parliament Votes to Further Criminalise Israel Ties, Expansion on Boycott Law," *New Arab*, December 26, 2022, https://www.newarab.com/news/oman-parliament-votes-expand-israel-boycott-law.
75. "Saudi Arabia Amends Import Rules to Sideline Israel-Linked Products," *Times of Israel*, July 5, 2021, https://www.timesofisrael.com/saudi-arabia-amends-import-rules-to-sideline-israel-linked-products/. The decree primarily targets the Gulf's free trade zones that provide tax benefits to corporations setting up within them, a main source of competition from the UAE. See Abber Abu Omar, Salma El Wardany, and Reema Al Othman, "Saudi Arabia's Free Zone Tariff Exclusions Signal Widening Rift," *Bloomberg,* July 5, 2021, https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2021-07-05/saudi-arabia-excludes-imports-from-gulf-s-free-zones-and-israel#.
76. "In First, Israeli Athlete to Compete in Saudi Arabia Amid Thawing Ties," *Times of Israel*, October 25, 2022, https://www.timesofisrael.com/in-first-israeli-athlete-to-compete-in-saudi-arabia-amid-thawing-ties/.

77. "Netanyahu Forced to Cancel Trip to UAE Amid Dispute with Jordan," *Times of Israel*, March 11, 2021, https://www.timesofisrael.com/netanyahu-said-weighing-canceling-uae-trip-due-to-wifes-illness/.
78. "Israeli PM Cancels UAE Trip, Citing Disagreement with Jordan," *Arab News*, March 11, 2021, https://www.arabnews.com/node/1823636/middle-east.
79. Barak Ravid, "UAE Suspends Planned Summit to Protest Netanyahu's Electioneering," *Axios*, March 18, 2021, https://www.axios.com/uae-suspends-summit-netanyahu-electioneering-protest-306a37b6-56f6-451e-a2b3-faob2881bbee.html.
80. Anwar Gargash (@AnwarGargash), "From the UAE's perspective, the purpose of the Abrahamic Accords is to provide a robust strategic foundation to foster peace and prosperity with the State of Israel and in the wider region," Twitter, March 17, 2021, https://twitter.com/anwargargash/status/1372135281982246915?lang=en.
81. "Emiratis Said Angry at Netanyahu for Trying to Use Them in His Election Campaign," *Times of Israel*, March 17, 2021, https://www.timesofisrael.com/emiratis-said-furious-at-netanyahu-for-trying-to-use-them-in-reelection-campaign/.
82. Mostafa Salem, Andrew Carey, and Amir Tal. "Emiratis Accuse Netanyahu of Exploiting Normalization Deal for Election Gain," CNN, March 18, 2021, https://edition.cnn.com/2021/03/18/middleeast/uae-israel-normalization-deal-tensions-intl/index.html
83. Danny Zaken, "UAE Proceeding with Planned $10 b. Israel Investments," *Jerusalem Post*, February 2, 2022, https://www.jpost.com/business-and-innovation/all-news/article-695276.
84. Jonathan JLis, "Israeli PM Bennett Arrives in UAE for Historic Visit," *Haaretz*, December 12, 2021, https://www.haaretz.com/israel-news/bennett-departs-for-historic-uae-visit-sunday-1.10458721.
85. Stephen Farrell and Rami Ayyub, "Scored Injured in Jerusalem Clashes; Israeli Nationalists Chant Death to Arabs," Reuters, April 23, 2021, https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/police-arrest-dozens-jerusalem-clashes-israeli-nationalists-chant-death-arabs-2021-04-23/.
86. Aya Batrawy, "UAE Urges Israel to Stop Jerusalem Violence in Rare Rebuke," *AP News*, April 26, 2021, https://apnews.com/article/donald-trump-israel-united-arab-emirates-violence-dubai-4a48688bbe106ca7d931d148c205fdd3.

87. Stephen Farrell and Rami Ayyub, "Israeli Police, Palestinians Clash at Jerusalem's Al-Aqsa, Scores Injured," Reuters, May 7, 2021, https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/thousands-pack-al-aqsa-mosque-protest-palestinian-evictions-jerusalem-2021-05-07/.
88. Farrell and Ayyub.
89. "Bahrain Condemns Israeli Forces Attack on Worshippers at Al-Aqsa Mosque," Bahrain News Agency, May 8, 2021, https://www.bna.bh/en/BahraincondemnsIsraeliforcesattackonworshipersatAlAqsaMosque.aspx?cms=q8FmFJgiscL2fwIzON1%2BDiOudWAzaaIoSN9fOyDMf%2FI%3D.
90. Nidal Al-Mughrabi and Jeffrey Haller, "Jerusalem Violence Leads to Rockets, Air Strikes," Reuters, May 10, 2021, https://www.reuters.com/world/asia-pacific/violence-erupts-al-aqsa-mosque-israel-marks-jerusalem-day-2021-05-10/.
91. "Israel's Gaza Strikes May Constitute 'War Crimes': UN's Bachelet," *Al Jazeera English*, May 27, 2021, https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2021/5/27/israel-attacks-on-gaza-may-constitute-war-crimes-un-rights-chief.
92. Ilan Ben Zion, "Right Group Says Hamas Rockets at Israel a Clear War Crime," *AP News,* August 12, 2021, https://apnews.com/article/middle-east-business-israel-race-and-ethnicity-racial-injustice-1032a5117375ba8c0cdffbdd62ce02ad.
93. "UAE Urges Mideast Ceasefire, Offers Condolences to All Victims—WAM," Reuters, May 14, 2021, https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/uae-foreign-minister-calls-immediate-steps-ceasefire-amid-violence-israel-2021-05-14/.
94. "Muslim States Condemn Israel's 'Barbaric Attacks' Against Palestinians," Reuters, May 16, 2021, https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/saudi-arabia-condemns-israels-flagrant-violations-palestinian-rights-2021-05-16/.
95. "Muslim States Condemn."
96. Simon Mabon, "Israel-Palestine Conflict: Why Gulf Leaders Are Staying Quiet—for Now," *Conversation*, May 17, 2021, https://theconversation.com/israel-palestine-conflict-why-gulf-leaders-are-staying-quiet-for-now-160946. See also Sultan AlQassemi (@SultanAlQassemi), "The region's only democracy," Twitter, May 15, 2021, https://twitter.com/SultanAlQassemi/status/1393612890675032069.

97. Abdulkhaleq Abdulla (@Abdulkhaleq_UAE), "When it comes to 73 years of #ApartheidIsrael and its war crime against Palestinians, . . . " Twitter, May 19, 2021, https://twitter.com/Abdulkhaleq_UAE/status/1395037852745015300.
98. "Bahrainis Protest in Solidarity with Palestinians," *Jordan Times*, May 20, 2021, https://www.jordantimes.com/news/region/bahrainis-protest-solidarity-palestinians.
99. Yossi Mekelberg, an associate fellow at Chatham House, cautioned that "a prolonged war in Gaza with its devastating consequences could put an unbearable strain on the budding relations between Israel and some of its new friends in the region, which goes against the interests of all sides." See Yossi Mekelberg, "Gaza Deaths May End Israel's New Gulf Friendships," Royal Institute for International Affairs (Chatham House), May 13, 2021, https://www.chathamhouse.org/2021/05/gaza-deaths-may-end-israels-new-gulf-friendships.
100. Patrick Kingsley, "Shrinking the Conflict: What Does Israel's New Mantra Really Mean?" *New York Times*, September 30, 2021, https://www.nytimes.com/2021/09/30/world/middleeast/israel-bennett-palestinians-shrinking.html.
101. Zainab Fattah, "Israel's New Foreign Minister Gets Muted Reception on First UAE Visit," *Bloomberg*, June 29, 2021, https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2021-06-29/israeli-foreign-minister-gets-muted-reception-on-first-uae-visit.
102. "Israel Opens Embassy in UAE, Drawing US Applause," *Saudi Gazette*, June 29, 2021, https://www.saudigazette.com.sa/article/608281.
103. Chris Maxwell, "Yair Lapid Says Expo 2020 Dubai a Major Platform for Israel," *National*, June 30, 2021, https://www.thenationalnews.com/uae/government/2021/06/30/yair-lapid-says-expo-2020-dubai-a-chance-to-spread-israeli-culture/.
104. "Protests in Bahrain Over New Israeli Embassy," *France 24*, October 1, 2021, https://www.france24.com/en/live-news/20211001-protests-in-bahrain-over-new-israeli-embassy.
105. "The Pegasus Project: How Amnesty Tech Uncovered the Spyware Scandal," Amnesty International, March 23, 2022, https://www.amnesty.org/en/latest/news/2022/03/the-pegasus-project-how-amnesty-tech-uncovered-the-spyware-scandal-new-video/#.

106. Hamzeh Noami, "Pegasus Spyware Maker Ends Contract with UAE After UK High Court's Hacking Ruling," *CNN World*, October 7, 2021, https://edition.cnn.com/2021/10/07/middleeast/pegasus-uae-hacking-intl/index.html.
107. James Reinl, "Obama Aide: How We Got It Wrong in Yemen," *TRT World*, February 14, 2019, https://www.trtworld.com/magazine/obama-aide-how-we-got-it-wrong-in-yemen-24162.
108. "Gulf States: Nuclear Talks Should Address Iran Missile Program," Reuters, June 17, 2021, https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/gcc-foreign-ministers-iran-missile-programme-should-be-addressed-nuclear-talks-2021-06-16/.
109. Andrew Hanna, "Raisi: Role in 1988 Massacre," United States Institute of Peace, July 21, 2021, https://iranprimer.usip.org/blog/2021/jul/21/raisi-role-1988-massacre.
110. "Timeline of Diplomacy Under Biden," United States Institute of Peace, April 2, 2021, https://iranprimer.usip.org/blog/2021/apr/02/new-talks-timeline-diplomacy-under-biden.
111. Ali Kucokgocmen, "Erdogan Says Turkey, UAE Ties Improving After Rare Meeting," Reuters, August 19, 2021, https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/turkeys-erdogan-holds-rare-meeting-with-senior-uae-official-2021-08-18/. See also "UAE Foreign Minister Meets Syria's Assad, US Slams Visit to Dictator," *France 24*, November 10, 2021, https://www.france24.com/en/middle-east/20211110-uae-foreign-minister-meets-syria-s-assad-us-slams-visit-to-dictator.
112. Neri Zilber, "In Rejecting Iran Nuclear Deal, Israeli Rivals Are of One Mind," *New Lines Magazine*, September 7, 2022, https://newlinesmag.com/reportage/in-rejecting-iran-nuclear-deal-israeli-rivals-are-of-one-mind/. See also "Prime Minister Naftali Bennett: Do Not Give in to Iran's Nuclear Blackmail," November 29, 2021, https://www.gov.il/en/departments/news/spoke_iran291121; Linda Gradstein, "Israeli PM Bennett Makes Official Visit to UAE," *VOA News*, December 12, 2021, https://www.voanews.com/a/israeli-pm-to-pay-first-visit-to-uae-since-formalizing-ties/6350840.html.
113. Phil Stewart, "Exclusive: U.S., Israel, to Discuss Military Drills for Iran Scenario," Reuters, December 9, 2021, https://www.reuters.com/world/exclusive-diplomacy-stutters-us-israel-discuss-military-drills-iran-scenario-us-2021-12-09/.

114. Jonathan Lis, "Israel and UAE Discussed Iran on Bennett's Visit, but Neither Officially Acknowledged It," *Haaretz*, December 13, 2021, https://www.haaretz.com/israel-news/.premium-israel-and-uae-discussed-iran-on-bennett-s-visit-but-neither-officially-acknowledge-1.10462653.
115. "UAE Drastically Cut Funding for Palestinian Refugee Agency," *Al Jazeera*, February 6, 2021, https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2021/2/6/uae-drastically-cut-funding-for-palestinian-refugee-agency
116. Elham Fakhro, "Covid and Gulf Foreign Policy," in *The Covid-19 Pandemic in North Africa and the Middle East* (Washington, DC: Project on Middle East Political Science, 2020); Clive Jones, "Israel and the Gulf States: Regimes, Rivalry, and Regional Security," in *Israel in a Turbulent Region: Security and Foreign Policy*, ed. Tore T. Peterson (New York: Routledge, 2020).
117. "UAE Sends $10 Million Medical Supplies to Gaza," *Arab News*, December 2, 2022, https://www.arabnews.com/node/2209821/middle-east; and "UAE Announces $20 Million Contribution to UNRWA," *ANI*, June 3, 2023, https://www.aninews.in/news/world/middle-east/uae-announces-usd-20-million-contribution-to-un-relief-and-works-agency-for-palestine-refugees-in-near-east20230603224328/.
118. "Iran Warns Persian Gulf Countries About Security Ties with Israel," *Tehran Times*, June 11, 2022, https://www.tehrantimes.com/news/473523/Iran-warns-Persian-Gulf-countries-about-security-ties-with-Israel.
119. Zev Stub, "Dubai to Use Israeli Drones to Secure World Expo," *Jerusalem Post*, July 18, 2021, https://www.jpost.com/international/dubai-to-use-israeli-drones-to-secure-world-expo-673933.
120. Shoshanna Solomon, "IAI and UAE-Based EDGE Join Forces to Develop Anti-drone Tech," *Times of Israel*, March 11, 2021, https://www.timesofisrael.com/iai-and-uae-based-edge-join-forces-to-develop-anti-drone-tech/.
121. Solomon.
122. "EDGE Announces Strategic Deal with Israel Aerospace Industries to Develop Advanced Unmanned Surface Vessels," EDGE Group, November 18, 2021, https://edgegroup.ae/news/edge-announces-strategic-deal-israel-aerospace-industries-develop-advanced-unmanned-surface.
123. "UAE, Bahrain, Israel, and U.S. Forces in First Joint Naval Drill," Reuters, November 11, 2021, https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/uae-bahrain-israel-us-forces-conduct-red-sea-military-exercise-2021-11-11/.

124. Rina Bassist, "Arab States Make Up 24% of Israel's 2022 Arms Exports Including Drones," *Middle East Eye*, June 14, 2023, https://www.al-monitor.com/originals/2023/06/arab-states-make-24-israels-2022-arms-exports-including-drones.
125. Tuqa Khalid, "Israel Offers Security Intelligence Support to UAE After Houthi Attack on Abu Dhabi," *Al-Arabiya*, January 18, 2022, https://english.alarabiya.net/News/gulf/2022/01/18/Israel-offers-security-intelligence-support-to-UAE-after-Houthi-attack-on-Abu-Dhabi
126. Sune Rasmussen and Dion Nissenbaum, "Yemen's Houthi Rebels Claim Aerial Attack on UAE Capital," *Wall Street Journal*, January 17, 2022, https://www.wsj.com/articles/yemens-houthi-rebels-claim-suspected-drone-strikes-on-u-a-e-capital-11642416716.
127. "Timeline: UAE Under Drone, Missile Attacks," *Al Jazeera*, February 2, 2023, https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2022/2/3/timeline-uae-drone-missile-attacks-houthis-yemen&cd=5&hl=en&ct=clnk&gl=bh.
128. Gulf and Israeli officials, interview by author, Dubai, March 25, 2022.
129. "Israel Refuses to Sell the UAE 'Iron Dome' and 'David's Sling' Missile Defense Systems," *Defense Here*, February 1, 2022, https://www.defensehere.com/en/israel-refuses-to-sell-the-uae-iron-dome-and-davids-sling-missile-defense-systems#.
130. Barak Ravid, *Trump's Peace: The Abraham Accords and the Reshaping of the Middle East* (independently published, 2023), 530.
131. Ravid.
132. Barak Ravid, "Israel Offers to Help UAE Bolster Defenses After Houthi Attacks," *Axios,* February 2, 2022, https://www.axios.com/israel-uae-bolster-defenses-houthi-attacks-yemen-dbb1eae6-71fc-4a14-8fac-fe4046e43b61.html. See also Natasha Turak, "Drone and Missile Attacks on the UAE Shows Its Strengths More than Vulnerabilities, Security Analysts Say," *CNBC*, February 11, 2022, https://www.cnbc.com/2022/02/11/attacks-on-uae-shows-its-strengths-more-than-vulnerabilities-analysts.html.
133. New Arab Staff, "Blinken Reportedly Apologised to UAE for Slow Response to Houthi Attack," *New Arab*, April 14, 2022, https://www.newarab.com/news/us-apologised-uae-slow-response-houthi-attack.
134. Charles Forrester, "Israel, Bahrain Sign Defence Collaboration MOU," *Jane's Defence News*, February 7, 2022, https://www.janes.com/defence-news/news-detail/israel-bahrain-sign-defence-collaboration-mou.

135. "Bahrain Confirms Israeli Officer to Be Stationed in the Country," *Al Jazeera English*, February 12, 2022, https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2022/2/12/bahrain-confirms-israeli-officer-to-be-stationed-in-the-country.
136. "Mossad Is in Bahrain, Senior Bahraini Official Says at Security Conference," *Times of Israel*, February 21, 2022, https://www.timesofisrael.com/liveblog_entry/mossad-is-in-bahrain-senior-bahraini-official-says-at-security-conference/.
137. "Raees wuzara' Israel fi awal liqaa ma' saheefa khaleejiyya khus bi al-ayyam: nuqadir za'amat jalalat al-malik al-shuja'a," *Al-Ayam*, February 15, 2022, https://www.alayam.com/alayam/first/947514/News.html.
138. Bahraini activist, interview by author, Manama, June 15, 2022.
139. Lahav Harkov, "Negev Summit Gives Iran 'Something to Fear' Lapid Says," *Jerusalem Post*, March 28, 2022, https://www.jpost.com/israel-news/article-702513.
140. Lazar Berman and Aaron Boxerman, "Announcing Permanent Regional Forum, Israel, Arab States Laud Alliance, Decry Terror," *Times of Israel*, March 28, 2022, https://www.timesofisrael.com/announcing-permanent-regional-forum-israel-arab-states-laud-alliance-decry-terror/.
141. Amr Hamzawy, "The Negev Summit's Participants Had Wildly Different Goals," Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, April 6, 2022, https://carnegieendowment.org/2022/04/06/negev-summit-s-participants-had-wildly-different-goals-pub-86826.
142. Mishari Al-Thaidi, "Mu'tamar al-naqab sardiyya jadida li-amn al-arabi," *AlSharq AlAwsat,* March 30, 2022, https://aawsat.com/home/article/3561821/%D9%85%D8%B4%D8%A7%D8%B1%D9%8A-%D8%A7%D9%84%D8%B0%D8%A7%D9%8A%D8%AF%D9%8A/%D9%85%D8%A4%D8%AA%D9%85%D8%B1-%C2%AB%D8%A7%D9%84%D9%86%D9%82%D8%A8%C2%BB-%D8%B3%D8%B1%D8%AF%D9%8A%D8%A9-%D8%AC%D8%AF%D9%8A%D8%AF%D8%A9-%D9%84%D9%84%D8%A3%D9%85%D9%86-%D8%A7%D9%84%D8%B9%D8%B1%D8%A8%D9%8A.
143. "Abdullah bin Zayed Participates in 'Negev Summit' in Israel," Emirates News Agency (WAM), March 28, 2022, https://wam.ae/en/details/1395303034405.
144. Anwar Gargash (@AnwarGargash), "In our approach towards building bridges and promoting the agenda of stability and prosperity, the UAE distances itself from rhetoric of confrontation and polarization . . ."

[translated from Arabic], Twitter, May 30, 2022, https://twitter.com/anwargargash/status/1509201915422334983?s=21&t=pM8aQIsnCYbJyJJx3r6UFg.

145. "The First Regional Cyber Summit: Israel, Morocco, Bahrain, and the United Arab Emirates Gather in a First of Its Kind Meeting," Israel National Cyber Directorate, December 14, 2022, https://www.gov.il/en/departments/news/meeting_union.
146. Ashley Roque and Seth Frantzman, "How Israel's Shift to CENTCOM Is Paying Off During Gaza Conflict," *Breaking Defence*, November 21, 2023, https://breakingdefense.com/2023/11/how-israels-shift-to-centcom-is-paying-off-during-gaza-conflict/.
147. Jacob Magid, "US Lawmakers Aim to Integrate Defense Systems of Israel, 9 Arab States Against Iran," *Times of Israel*, June 10, 2022, https://www.timesofisrael.com/us-legislation-aims-to-integrate-israel-arab-states-defense-systems-against-iran/.
148. Aziz El Yaakoubi, Andrew Mills, and Matt Spetalnick, "US, Israel Push Arab Allies for Joint Defence Pact Amid Iran Tensions," Reuters, July 7, 2022, https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/us-israel-push-arab-allies-joint-defence-pact-amid-iran-tensions-2022-07-07/.
149. Dan Williams and Aziz El Yaacoubi, "Israel Says It's Building Regional Defence Alliance Under U.S.," Reuters, June 20, 2022, https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/israel-says-building-regional-air-defence-alliance-under-us-2022-06-20/
150. Ellen Knickmeyer and Josef Federman, "Biden Trip Promotes Budding Arab-Israeli Security Ties," Associated Press, July 7, 2022, https://apnews.com/article/nato-biden-iran-israel-saudi-arabia-bfb12ae6060cfda0003be0b35630aa5a.
151. Alexander Cornwell and Jon Irish, "Exclusive: Israel to Sell Air Defence System to United Arab Emirates," Reuters, September 22, 2022, https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/exclusive-israel-sell-air-defence-system-united-arab-emirates-sources-say-2022-09-22/.
152. Anna Ahronheim, "Satellite Images Show Israeli Missile System Deployed in UAE Against Iranian Threats," *Jerusalem Post*, October 29, 2022, https://www.jpost.com/middle-east/article-720935.
153. Matthew Lee, "US Approves Massive Arms Sale to Saudi, UAE to Counter Iran," Associated Press, August 3, 2022, https://apnews.com/article/biden

-iran-united-arab-emirates-saudi-arabia-yemen-2821c88775fe4eafd68b802676aa4eb6.

5. TOLERANCE-WASHING

1. Carol E. B. Choksy and Jamsheed K. Choksy, "The Saudi Connection: Wahhabism and Global Jihad," *World Affairs*, 178, no. 1 (2015).
2. Caryle Murphy, "Post-Sept 11 Saudi Arabia Modernizing, Slowly," NPR, September 7, 2011, https://www.npr.org/2011/09/07/140247658/post-sept-11-saudi-arabia-modernizing-slowly.
3. One of the structures—the Amir Mohammed Barbagi Mosque—was more than four hundred years old. See Bill Law, "Razed Mosque Symbol of Divided Bahrain," *BBC News*, March 27, 2014, https://www.bbc.com/news/world-middle-east-26721084.
4. Toby Jones, "Time to Disband the Bahrain-Based U.S. Fifth Fleet," *Atlantic*, June 10, 2011, https://www.theatlantic.com/international/archive/2011/06/time-to-disband-the-bahrain-based-us-fifth-fleet/240243/.
5. Gianluca Mezzofiore, "Bahrain Paid UK and US PR Companies $32m to Improve Image," *International Business Times*, July 2, 2014, https://www.ibtimes.co.uk/bahrain-pr-firms-bell-pottinger-m-c-377063.
6. "Bell Pottinger Collapses After South African Scandal," *BBC News*, September 12, 2017, https://www.bbc.com/news/business-41245719.
7. "US Partially Resumes Arms Sales to Bahrain," *Al Jazeera*, May 12, 2012, https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2012/5/12/us-partially-resumes-arms-sales-to-bahrain.
8. Erika Solomon, "Emiratis Petition Ruler for Democratic Elections," Reuters, March 9, 2011, https://www.reuters.com/article/uk-uae-petition-idUKTRE7281NN20110309.
9. "UAE: Nearly a Decade of Unjust Imprisonment for 'UAE-94' Dissidents," Amnesty International, July 2, 2021, https://www.amnesty.org/en/latest/news/2021/07/uae-nearly-a-decade-of-unjust-imprisonment-for-uae-94-dissidents-2/.
10. Kristian Ulrichsen, *The United Arab Emirates: Power, Politics, and Policy-Making* (London: Hurst, 2017).
11. Avi Davidi, "With Rare Israel Visit, Bahraini Delegation Seeks New Dialogue for Coexistence," *Times of Israel*, January 7, 2018, https://www

.timesofisrael.com/with-rare-israel-visit-bahraini-delegation-seeks-new-dialogue-for-coexistence/.

12. "Bahraini Delegation Greeted Warmly in Israel, While Angering Arab World," *Times of Israel*, December 13, 2017, https://www.timesofisrael.com/bahraini-delegation-greeted-warmly-in-israel-while-angering-arab-world/.
13. "Could Bahrain's Overtures to Israel End in Normalization?," *CGTN*, September 26, 2017, https://news.cgtn.com/news/7767544f77597a6333566d54/share_p.html.
14. Museum of Tolerance website, accessed July 22, 2023, https://www.museumoftolerance.com/.
15. See Cnaan Liphshiz, "EU Slams Simon Wiesenthal Center, Says Its Annual Antisemitism List Has Gone too Far," *Times of Israel*, January 11, 2022, https://www.timesofisrael.com/eu-slams-simon-wiesenthal-center-says-annual-antisemitism-list-has-gone-too-far/.
16. Benjamin Oreskes, "Amid Excitement and Suspicion, Bahrain Prince Visits Museum of Tolerance," *Los Angeles Times*, September 15, 2017, https://www.latimes.com/local/california/la-me-ln-bahrain-tolerance-museum-20170913-story.html.
17. Hamad bin Isa Al Khalifa, "Bahrain King Calls for Religious Tolerance," *Washington Times*, October 10, 2017, https://www.washingtontimes.com/news/2017/oct/10/bahrain-king-calls-for-religious-tolerance/.
18. Dov Lieber, "Bahrain's King Opposes Arab Boycott of Israel, Jewish Leader Says," *Times of Israel*, September 18, 2017, https://www.timesofisrael.com/bahrains-king-opposes-arab-boycott-of-israel-jewish-leader-says/.
19. Tamara Nassar, "Bahrain King Cozies Up to Israel," *Electronic Intifada*, September 19, 2017, https://electronicintifada.net/blogs/tamara-nassar/bahrain-king-cozies-israel.
20. Avi Davidi, "With Rare Israel Visit, Bahraini Delegation Seeks New Dialogue for Coexistence," *Times of Israel*, January 7, 2018, https://www.timesofisrael.com/with-rare-israel-visit-bahraini-delegation-seeks-new-dialogue-for-coexistence/.
21. Betsy B. Mathieson (@BetsyBBahrain), "I wish we had a credible healthy #Opposition in #Bahrain & not cowards terrorists racists murderers We could achieve so much with #Peace," Twitter, November 5, 2012, https://twitter.com/BetsyBBahrain/status/265337832111996928.

22. Betsy B. Mathieson (@BetsyBBahrain), "@tomcary_tel Tom I hope u will also talk 2 decent law abiding ppl in #Bahrain whose health safety & livelihoods r ruined by terror acts #F1," Twitter, April 17, 2012, https://twitter.com/BetsyBBahrain/status/192253488586162178.
23. Marc Owen Jones has documented the widespread proliferation of fake accounts during this period and their role in amplifying progovernment narratives.
24. Sally from Saar, "Why Progress in Bahrain Will Inevitably Happen," *Gulf Daily News*, accessed July 24, 2023.
25. Elizabeth Flock, "Bahrain Diplomat Brought Home Because of Threats, Ethnic Slurs," *Washington Post*, June 1, 2011, https://www.washingtonpost.com/blogs/blogpost/post/bahrain-diplomat-brought-home-because-of-threats-ethnic-slurs/2011/06/01/AGNdARGH_blog.html.
26. Sally from Saar, "Condemnation Baffling," *Gulf Daily News*, April 4, 2011.
27. Elliot Abrams, "Bahrain: Bad to Worse," Council on Foreign Relations, May 31, 2011, https://www.cfr.org/blog/bahrain-bad-worse.
28. Chris Noronha, "We All Share a Love for Bahrain," website of the Cathedral of Our Lady of Arabia, July 18, 2014, http://bahraincathedral.org/?p=1892.
29. Basma Mohamed, "Groups Honored for Their Support," *Gulf Daily News*, accessed July 24, 2023. See also "Bahrain a Beacon of Coexistence, Peace and Tolerance: HH Shaikh Nasser," *Daily Tribune*, April 8, 2022, https://www.newsofbahrain.com/bahrain/80200.html.
30. "Charm Offensive: This Is Bahrain Public Image Roadshow Hits the US," *Al Bawaba*, September 28, 2015, https://www.albawaba.com/business/charm-offensive-bahrain-public-image-roadshow-hits-us-748128.
31. "US Senators Submit Bill to Reinstate Arms Ban on Bahrain," *Middle East Eye*, August 11, 2015, https://www.middleeasteye.net/news/us-senators-submit-bill-reinstate-arms-ban-bahrain.
32. Alex MacDonald, "Bahrain Expat Group Seeks Israeli Help to Improve Kingdom's Image," *Middle East Eye*, September 29, 2015, https://www.middleeasteye.net/news/bahrain-expat-group-seeks-israeli-help-improve-kingdoms-image. See also Mohammed Al A'aali, "New Campaign to Promote Bahrain," *Gulf Daily News*, September 25, 2015, https://www.gdnonline.com/Details/25019/New-campaign-to-promote-Bahrain.

33. Brian Whitaker, "Selective Memri," *Guardian*, August 12, 2002, https://www.theguardian.com/world/2002/aug/12/worlddispatch.brianwhitaker. Whitaker's views were echoed by Ibrahim Hooper of the Council on American-Islamic Relations, who noted: "Memri's intent is to find the worst possible quotes from the Muslim world and disseminate them as widely as possible."
34. MacDonald, "Bahrain Expat Group."
35. Joshua Colangelo-Bryan, "How Bahrain Is Oppressing Its Shia Majority," *Guardian*, May 22, 2011, https://www.theguardian.com/commentisfree/2011/may/22/bahrain-change-view-human-rights.
36. "Bahrain: End Prison Ordeal for Nabeel Rajab Immediately," Amnesty International, November 27, 2013, https://www.amnesty.org/en/latest/news/2013/11/bahrain-end-prison-ordeal-nabeel-rajab-immediately/.
37. "Case History: Nabeel Rajab," Frontline Defenders, June 12, 2020, https://www.frontlinedefenders.org/en/case/case-history-nabeel-rajab.
38. "Al Wefaq Dissolved," *Gulf Daily News*, July 18, 2016, https://www.gdnonline.com/Details/101046.
39. Sami Aboudi, "Bahrain Court Shuts Down Main Shi'ite Opposition Group," Reuters, June 14, 2016, https://www.reuters.com/article/us-bahrain-rights-alwefaq-idUSKCN0Z01DU.
40. "The United States Is Deeply Concerned by Bahraini Court Decision to Dissolve the Opposition Al Wefaq Political," U.S. Mission to International Organizations in Geneva, July 18, 2016, https://geneva.usmission.gov/2016/07/18/the-united-states-is-deeply-concerned-by-bahraini-court-decision-to-dissolve-the-opposition-al-wefaq-political-society/.
41. "Bahrain Court Dissolves Main Secular Opposition Group," *BBC News*, May 31, 2017, https://www.bbc.com/news/world-middle-east-40104731
42. "Bahrain's Only Independent Newspaper Shut Down," Human Rights Watch, June 18, 2018, https://www.hrw.org/news/2017/06/18/bahrain-only-independent-newspaper-shut-down.
43. "Mansoor al-Jamri, Bahrain, International Press Freedom Awards," Committee to Protect Journalists, 2011, https://cpj.org/awards/mansoor-al-jamri-bahrain/.
44. "Message from Chairman of Board of Trustees," King Hamad Centre for Peaceful Coexistence, 2019, https://kinghamadglobalcentre.com/message-for-chairman/. See also "King Hamad Global Centre for Peaceful Coexistence Established," *Bahrain News Gazette*, March 2, 2018, https://www

.bahrainnewsgazette.com/king-hamad-global-centre-for-peaceful-co-existence-established/.

45. "Bahrain's History of Tolerance, Peaceful Co-existence Hailed," Bahrain News Agency, October 1, 2018, https://www.bna.bh/en/Bahrainshistoryoftolerancepeacefulcoexistencehailed.aspx?cms=q8FmFJgiscL2fwIzON1%2BDg73Cbi9wSLnoHd7T4bvoOQ%3D.
46. "Italy's Role in Whitewashing Religious Intolerance in Bahrain," Americans for Democracy and Human Rights in Bahrain, March 31, 2019, https://www.adhrb.org/2019/03/italys-role-in-whitewashing-religious-intolerance-in-bahrain/.
47. "King Hamad Chair in Interfaith Dialogue, Peaceful Coexistence Inauguration Held," Bahrain News Agency, November 5, 2018, https://www.bna.bh/en/KingHamadChairinInterfaithDialoguePeacefulCoexistenceinaugurationheld.aspx?cms=q8FmFJgiscL2fwIzON1%2BDgW0NhusGANC0NTAmTkaKis%3D.
48. "Kingdom of Bahrain Declaration Most Effective Weapon to Fight Extremism," Bahrain News Agency, November 23, 2018, https://www.bna.bh/en/KingdomofBahrainDeclarationmosteffectiveweapontofightextremism.aspx?cms=q8FmFJgiscL2fwIzON1%2BDud24f3I27lc%2BJXAwpt8MnU%3D.
49. "Bahrain Confers the King Hamad Order of the Renaissance to PM Narendra Modi," *India Today*, August 25, 2019, https://www.indiatoday.in/india/story/bahrain-confers-the-king-hamad-order-of-the-renaissance-to-narendramodi-1591389-2019-08-25.
50. "PM Modi Launches $4.2 Million Redevelopment Project of Hindu Temple in Bahrain," *Hindu*, August 25, 2019, https://www.thehindu.com/news/national/pm-modi-launches-42-mn-redevelopment-project-of-hindu-temple-in-bahrain/article29252060.ece.
51. Ruth Pollard, "Anti-Muslim Hatred Is Shaping India's Elections," Bloomberg, March 2, 2022, https://www.bloomberg.com/opinion/articles/2022-03-01/how-anti-muslim-hatred-is-shaping-india-s-elections.
52. "Hindu Leaders: Bahrain Role Model for Religious Freedom," Bahrain News Agency, August 25, 2019, https://www.bna.bh/en/HMKingissuesdecree46/HinduleadersBahrainrolemodelforreligiousfreedom.aspx?cms=q8FmFJgiscL2fwIzON1%2BDmBgBmRQOuJZn2rJQiby%2B1k%3D.
53. Emily Judd, "US, Bahrain's King Hamad Center Sign Deal to Fight Anti-Semitism, Promote Peace," *Al Arabiyya English*, October 24, 2020,

https://english.alarabiya.net/News/gulf/2020/10/24/US-Bahrain-s-King-Hamad-Center-sign-deal-to-fight-anti-Semitism-promote-peace.

54. "Bahrain Backs IHRA Definition of Anti-Semitism in Memorandum with US," *i24 News*, October 26, 2020, https://www.i24news.tv/en/news/international/1603701176-bahrain-backs-ihra-definition-of-anti-semitism-in-memorandum-with-us.
55. "Progressive Israel Network Groups Oppose Codification of IHRA Working Definition of Antisemitism, Citing Strong Potential for Misuse," Progressive Israel Network, January 12, 2021, https://www.progressiveisraelnetwork.org/progressive-israel-network-groups-oppose-codification-of-ihra-working-definition-of-antisemitism-citing-strong-potential-for-misuse/.
56. Cody Levine and Omri Nahimas, "Jewish Organizations Praise Israel-Bahrain Normalization Agreement," *Jerusalem Post*, September 15, 2020, https://www.jpost.com/diaspora/jewish-organizations-praise-israel-bahrain-normalization-agreement-641973. See also "European nations Welcome Bahrain Peace Deal with Israel," *National*, September 13, 2020, https://www.thenationalnews.com/world/mena/european-nations-welcome-bahrain-peace-deal-with-israel-1.1076927.
57. Reuven Rivlin (@PresidentRuvi), "An honor to welcome delegation from the King Hamad Global Center for Peaceful Coexistence," Twitter, November 26, 2020, https://twitter.com/presidentruvi/status/1331948947393433600. See also "Rivlin Hosts Delegation from Bahrain Led by Member of Royal Family," *Times of Israel*, November 27, 2020, https://www.timesofisrael.com/rivlin-hosts-delegation-from-bahrain-led-by-member-of-royal-family/.
58. Office of the President, "A Visit by the Delegation from the Kingdom of Bahrain from 'The King Hamad Global Center for Coexistence and Peace' and Signing of a Memorandum for Future Cooperation with the Hebrew University," Hebrew University of Jerusalem, November 25, 2020, https://en.president.huji.ac.il/news/visit-delegation-kingdom-bahrain-%E2%80%9C-king-hamad-global-center-coexistence-and-peace%E2%80%9D. See also Palestinian Boycott, Divestment and Sanctions National Committee (BNC), "Palestinians Write to ICRC: Conference in Partnership with Hebrew University Undermines Palestinian Human Rights," *BDS Movement*, November 5, 2018, https://bdsmovement.net/news/palestinians-write-icrc

-conference-partnership-hebrew-university-undermines-palestinian-human.

59. "US Senators Urge State Dept to Confront Bahrain's Repression," *Al Jazeera*, September 24, 2021, https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2021/9/24/us-senators-urge-state-dept-to-confront-bahrains-repression.
60. Ben Sales, "Bahrain Signed a Treaty with Israel. Now It Wants to Make Friends with American Jews," *Jewish Exponent*, October 6, 2021, https://www.jewishexponent.com/2021/10/06/bahrain-signed-a-treaty-with-israel-now-it-wants-to-make-friends-with-american-jews/.
61. Maria Lozano and John Pontifex, "Bahrain: King to Play Key Role as New Cathedral Opens in Arabia," Aid to the Church in Need, December 8, 2021, https://acnuk.org/news/bahrain-king-to-play-key-role-as-new-cathedral-opens-in-arabia/.
62. "Video Clip: The King of Bahrain Gives the Pope a Model of the Cathedral," website of Bahrain Cathedral, May 21, 2014, http://bahraincathedral.org/?p=1393.
63. Vatican Radio, "Bahrain King Presents Pope with Model of Largest Church in the Arabian Peninsula," *Vatican Radio Archivo*, May 20, 2014, http://www.archivioradiovaticana.va/storico/2014/05/20/bahrain_king_presents_pope_with_model_of_largest_church_in_the_arabian/in2-800781.
64. "Religious Leaders Meet in Bahrain," *Arkansas Online*, November 5, 2022, https://www.arkansasonline.com/news/2022/nov/05/religious-leaders-meet-in-bahrain/.
65. JTA, "Bahrain's King Holds Hanukkah Candle-lighting Ceremony," *Times of Israel*, December 9, 2015, https://www.timesofisrael.com/bahrains-king-holds-hanukkah-candlelighting/.
66. Sophia Smith Gater, "Bahrain Built a Massive Cathedral, but Still Won't Rebuild Shi'a Mosques," *Vice News*, December 13, 2021, https://www.vice.com/en/article/wxdn99/bahrain-built-a-massive-cathedral-but-still-wont-rebuild-shia-mosques.
67. Peter Beinart, "Has the Fight Against Anti-Semitism Lost Its Way?," *New York Times*, August 26, 2022, https://www.nytimes.com/2022/08/26/opinion/antisemitism-israel-uae-saudi.html.
68. AFP, "Bahrain's Jews Worship Openly for the First Time in Decades," *National*, September 14, 2021, https://www.thenationalnews.com/gulf-news/bahrain/2021/09/14/bahrains-jews-worship-openly-for-the-first-time-in

-decades/. See also Ismaeel Naar, "Bahrain's Jews to Commemorate Holocaust Remembrance Day at Revamped Synagogue," *National*, January 27, 2022, https://www.thenationalnews.com/gulf-news/bahrain/2022/01/27/bahrains-jews-to-commemorate-holocaust-remembrance-day-at-revamped-synagogue/.

69. "Revival of a Jewish Cemetery in Bahrain, the Only Synagogue in the Gulf," *Time News*, January 13, 2022, https://time.news/revival-of-a-jewish-cemetery-in-bahrain-the-only-synagogue-in-the-gulf.
70. Jeremy Sharon, "Gulf Rabbinical Court to Revive 'Golden Age' of Jewish-Muslim Cooperation," *Jerusalem Post*, February 22, 2021, https://www.jpost.com/middle-east/gulf-rabbinical-court-to-revive-golden-age-of-jewish-muslim-cooperation-659704. See also Lazar Berman, "Beth Din of Arabia: Jews in Gulf Countries Announce First Communal Organizations," *Times of Israel*, February 15, 2021, https://www.timesofisrael.com/beth-din-of-arabia-jews-in-gulf-countries-announce-first-communal-organizations/.
71. Jennifer Bell, "First-Ever Jewish Dating App Launches in the Gulf," *Al Arabiya News*, October 31, 2021, https://english.alarabiya.net/life-style/2021/10/31/First-ever-Jewish-dating-app-launches-in-Gulf.
72. Judit Neurink, "A New Association in Bahrain Throws Bahraini Jews a Lifeline," *Judit Eurink Personal Blog*, accessed July 24, 2023, https://juditneurink.eu/a-new-association-in-the-gulf-throws-bahraini-jews-a-lifeline/.
73. Emily Judd, "After Israel Deal, Bahrain's Jews Seek to Revive Community with New Rabbi, Synagogue," *Al Arabiya News*, September 14, 2020, https://english.alarabiya.net/features/2020/09/14/Close-to-extinction-Bahrain-s-Jews-say-Israel-deal-revives-their-community.
74. "Israel PM Meets Bahrain King, Jewish Community on Visit," *New Arab*, September 15, 2022, https://english.alaraby.co.uk/news/israel-pm-meets-bahrain-king-jewish-community-visit.
75. Other new historians include Avi Shlaim and Benny Morris.
76. Ilan Pappe, "Al-Fulistineyoon Al-Mansiyoon, Hikayat Arab 1948," YouTube video, 1:54:28, November 30, 2021, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=v4pEiPRK9ak.
77. Ilan Pappe, interview by author, Manama, December 1, 2021.
78. Fatemah Salari, "Heroic Bahraini Minister Sacked for Refusing to Shake Hands with Israeli Envoy," *Doha News*, July 24, 2022, https://dohanews.co

/heroic-bahraini-minister-sacked-for-refusing-to-shake-hands-with-israeli-envoy/.

79. Simon Arann (@simonarann), "The Ambassador of Israel to #Bahrain has gathered today in honor of Sheikh Khalifa bin Ahmed Al Khalifa, President of Bahrain's Organization for Culture and Heritage . . ." [translated from Arabic], Twitter, August 30, 2022, https://twitter.com/simonarann/status/1564617580618432516.
80. Stanley Szecowka, "King of Peace," *Gulf Daily News*, December 17, 2023, https://www.gdnonline.com/Details/1298524.
81. "Constitutional Lawyer Mohammad al-Roken Asked for Reform in the UAE but Got 10 Years in Prison Instead," *DAWN*, December 21, 2020, https://dawnmena.org/constitutional-lawyer-mohammad-al-roken-asked-for-reform-in-the-uae-but-got-10-years-in-prison-instead/.
82. ICFUAE, "Appeal for UAE to Release Prominent Emirati Lawyer Mohammed Al-Roken, After Serving 10 Year Prison Sentence," press release, International Campaign for Freedom in the United Arab Emirates, September 14, 2022, https://www.icfuae.org.uk/press-releases/appeal-uae-release-prominent-emirati-lawyer-mohammed-al-roken-after-serving-10-year.
83. "UAE Academic Facing Speech Charges," Human Rights Watch, February 16, 2017, https://www.hrw.org/news/2017/02/16/uae-academic-facing-speech-charges; "UAE: Activist Ahmed Mansoor Sentenced to 10 Years in Prison for Social Media Posts," Amnesty International, May 31, 2018, https://www.amnesty.org/en/latest/news/2018/05/uae-activist-ahmed-mansoor-sentenced-to-10-years-in-prison-for-social-media-posts/.
84. Mohammed Jamjoom and Frederik Pleitgen, "UAE Shuts Down Two Foreign NGOs," CNN, March 31, 2012, https://edition.cnn.com/2012/03/31/world/meast/uae-organizations/index.html.
85. "Counter Narrative Library," Hedayah Center, accessed July 22, 2023, https://hedayah.com/resources/counter-narrative-library/
86. "Hedaya and the EU Builds the Capacity of States and Non-State Actors to Effectively Challenge Radicalization—2023," Development Assistance Roadmap Portal in the Middle East, October 18, 2021, https://darpe.me/hedaya-and-eu-builds-the-capacity-of-state-and-non-state-actors-to-effectively-challenge-radicalization/.
87. "UAE Announces CVE-Based Curriculum to Curb Threat of Violent Extremism," *Arab Weekly*, July 19, 2019, https://thearabweekly.com/uae-announces-cve-based-curriculum-curb-threat-violent-extremism.

88. Usaama al-Azami, "UAE's Forum for Promoting Peace Is Another Cynical PR Initiative," *Middle East Eye*, December 10, 2018, https://www.middleeasteye.net/opinion/uaes-forum-promoting-peace-another-cynical-pr-initiative.
89. Samir Salama, "UAE Fatwa Council to Preach Islam's Moderate Values," *Gulf News*, July 25, 2018, https://gulfnews.com/uae/government/uae-fatwa-council-to-preach-islams-moderate-values-1.2242138.
90. Eleonora Ardemagni, "The Gulf Monarchies' Complex Fight Against Daesh," *NATO Review*, September 28, 2016, https://www.nato.int/docu/review/articles/2016/09/28/the-gulf-monarchies-complex-fight-against-daesh/index.html. See also Frederic Wehrey, "Gulf Participation in the Anti-Islamic State Coalition: Limitations and Costs," Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, September 23, 2014, https://carnegie-mec.org/diwan/56710?lang=en.
91. Joseph Bamat, "UAE Female Fighter Pilot Bombing IS Militants Wins Fans Online," *France24*, September 25, 2014, https://www.france24.com/en/20140925-uae-female-fighter-pilot-mariam-al-mansouri-airstrikes-islamic-state-is-isis-syria.
92. Ishan Tharoor, "U.A.E.'s First Female Fighter Pilot Dropped Bombs on the Islamic State," *Washington Post*, September 25, 2014, https://www.washingtonpost.com/news/worldviews/wp/2014/09/25/u-a-e-s-first-female-fighter-pilot-dropped-bombs-on-the-islamic-state/.
93. "UAE Lists Muslim Brotherhood as a Terrorist Group," Reuters, November 15, 2014, https://www.reuters.com/article/us-emirates-politics-brotherhood-idUSKCN0IZ0OM20141115.
94. "UAE Sentences Dr. Nasser bin Ghaith to Ten Years Prison," Americans for Democracy and Human Rights in Bahrain, April 18, 2017, https://www.adhrb.org/2017/03/uae-sentences-dr-nasser-bin-ghaith-10-years-prison/.
95. "UAE Fatwa Council Declares Muslim Brotherhood a Terrorist Organization," *Arab Weekly*, November 24, 2020, https://thearabweekly.com/uae-fatwa-council-declares-muslim-brotherhood-terrorist-organisation.
96. "United Arab Emirates: New Anti-Terror Law," International Commission of Jurists, accessed July 22, 2023, https://www.icj.org/ebulletin/united-arab-emirates-new-anti-terror-law/. See also "UAE: Terrorism Law Threatens Lives, Liberty," Human Rights Watch, December 3, 2014, https://www.hrw.org/news/2014/12/04/uae-terrorism-law-threatens-lives-liberty.
97. "UAE: Terrorism Law Threatens Lives, Liberty."

98. Israeli and Gulf officials, interviews by author, February 2020.
99. "UAE Cabinet Approves National Tolerance Program," United Arab Emirates Cabinet, June 9, 2016, https://uaecabinet.ae/en/details/news/uae-cabinet-approves-national-tolerance-program.
100. WAM, "International Institute for Tolerance Set Up in Dubai; Mohammed bin Rashid Lauded for Tolerance Law," *Gulf News*, June 22, 2017, https://gulfnews.com/uae/government/international-institute-for-tolerance-set-up-in-dubai-mohammad-bin-rashid-lauded-for-tolerance-law-1.2047606.
101. "Mary Mother of Jesus Is New Name for UAE Mosque," *Gulf News*, June 14, 2017, https://gulfnews.com/entertainment/arts-culture/mary-jesus-mother-is-new-name-for-uae-mosque-1.2043544.
102. "Year of Tolerance," UAE Government Portal, accessed July 23, 2023, https://u.ae/en/about-the-uae/culture/tolerance/tolerance-initiatives See also Sofia Barbarani, "Papal Visit: Pope Francis Lands in Abu Dhabi for Historic First Gulf Trip," *National*, February 3, 2019, https://www.thenationalnews.com/uae/pope-2019/papal-visit-pope-francis-lands-in-abu-dhabi-for-historic-first-gulf-trip-1.821388.
103. "Abrahamic Family House," Higher Committee for Human Fraternity, accessed July 23, 2023, https://www.forhumanfraternity.org/abrahamic-family-house/.
104. "Ambassador Yousef al-Otaiba Visits Museum of Tolerance in Los Angeles," *Pakistan Point*, March, 2019, https://www.pakistanpoint.com/en/story/579987/ambassador-yousef-al-otaiba-visits-museum-of-tolerance.html.
105. Miriam Herschlag, "For the first time, Dubai's Jewish Community Steps Hesitantly out of the Shadows," *Times of Israel*, December 5, 2018, https://www.timesofisrael.com/for-the-first-time-dubais-jewish-community-steps-hesitantly-out-of-the-shadows/.
106. Emirati and Bahraini diplomats, interviews by author, Manama, June 2022.
107. Yehuda Sarna, "How I Became Chief Rabbi of the UAE and Why That Matters to Global Jewry," *Times of Israel* (blog), August 21, 2020, https://blogs.timesofisrael.com/how-i-became-chief-rabbi-of-the-uae-and-why-that-matters-to-global-jewry/.
108. European diplomats, interview by author, Manama, June 2022.
109. UAE and Bahrain diplomats, interviews by author.
110. Herschlag, "For the First Time."

111. Raphael Ahren, "Muscling in on Dubai's Existing Jewish Community, a Chabad Rabbi Stirs Discord," *Times of Israel*, June 29, 2020, https://www.timesofisrael.com/muscling-in-on-dubais-existing-jewish-community-a-chabad-rabbi-stirs-discord/. The official website of Jewish UAE claims that the organization was set up in 2014, but individuals interviewed by the author say that it was not formally registered until 2018.
112. "Israel Cast Episode 102: Rabbi Levi Duchman, Rabbi of the UAE," Jewish National Fund USA, January 22, 2021, https://www.jnf.org/menu-3/news-media/israelcast/rabbi-levi-duchman.
113. Ahren, "Muscling in on Dubai's."
114. Steve Hendrix, "Package-Tour Diplomacy: Thousands of Israeli Tourists Flock to Dubai After Peace Deal," *Washington Post*, December 14, 2020, https://www.washingtonpost.com/world/middle_east/israel-dubai-uae-tourists-peace/2020/12/14/0d492838-3973-11eb-aad9-895922728oc4_story.html.
115. James Pearson, "Record-Breaking: Up to 14 Daily Flights from Israel to the UAE," *Simple Flying*, November 23, 2021, https://simpleflying.com/uae-israel-record-flights/.
116. "About US," *Jewish UAE*, accessed July 22, 2023, https://www.jewishuae.com.
117. "About US."
118. "About US."
119. "Kosher Food—Hotel Establishments," UAE Department of Culture and Tourism, *Circular No. 65/2020*, September 8, 2020, https://tcaabudhabi.ae/DataFolder//Circulars/Circular%2065_Kosher%20food%20-%20Hotel%20Establishments.pdf.
120. "Abu Dhabi Launches Kosher Food Certificates as It Chases More Jewish Tourists," *Arabian Business*, October 21, 2020, https://www.arabianbusiness.com/industries/travel-hospitality/453465-abu-dhabi-launches-kosher-food-certificates-for-hotels-to-attract-more-jewish-tourists.
121. Hendrix, "Package-Tour Diplomacy."
122. Gabe Friedman, "Over 50,000 Israelis Have Already Visited the UAE Since Peace Deal Signing," *Jerusalem Post*, December 18, 2020, https://www.jpost.com/arab-israeli-conflict/over-50000-israelis-have-already-visited-the-uae-since-peace-deal-signing-652528.
123. "Abu Dhabi Launches Kosher Food."

124. Asma Ali Zain, "Israeli Chief Rabbi Gives His Blessing to Institutions in UAE, Marking New Era of Religious Jewish Life in Dubai and Beyond," Jewish Telegraphic Agency, December 21, 2020, https://www.jta.org/2020/12/21/global/israeli-chief-rabbi-gives-his-blessing-to-institutions-in-uae-marking-new-era-of-religious-jewish-life-in-dubai-and-beyond.
125. "Largest Passover Seders in the Arab World Held in UAE," *Jerusalem Post*, April 15, 2022, https://www.jpost.com/middle-east/article-704305.
126. Kelly Clarke, "Inside the Dubai Community Centre Supporting the UAE's Growing Jewish Population," *National*, February 3, 2022, https://www.thenationalnews.com/uae/2022/02/03/inside-the-dubai-community-centre-supporting-the-uaes-growing-jewish-population/.
127. "Israel Cast Episode 102: Rabbi Levi Duchman, Rabbi of the UAE," Jewish National Fund USA, January 22, 2021, https://www.jnf.org/menu-3/news-media/israelcast/rabbi-levi-duchman. *Allah Yerhamo* is an Arabic phrase meaning "May God rest his soul."
128. Marcus Sheff, "The UAE Education System Is Pushing for Peace and Religious Tolerance. The Rest of the Region Should Follow Suit," Atlantic Council, March 2, 2022, https://www.atlanticcouncil.org/blogs/menasource/the-uae-education-system-is-pushing-for-peace-and-religious-tolerance-the-rest-of-the-region-should-follow-suit/.
129. Eldad Pardo and David Byer, "When Peace Goes to School: The Emirati Curriculum 2016- 2021," Institute for Monitoring Peace and Tolerance in School Education, January 20, 2022, https://www.impact-se.org/wp-content/uploads/When-Peace-Goes-to-School_The-Emirati-Curriculum-2016%E2%80%9321.pdf#page=6.
130. Describing the assessments of Palestinian textbooks made by the Center for Monitoring the Impact of Peace (later rebranded as IMPACT-se), Brown notes that "their method was to follow harsh criticisms with quotation after quotation purporting to prove a point," adding that "a close reading (of those textbooks) revealed that many quotations did not support the strong charges." Brown continues: "I realized from the research of Israeli academics (and also from my own children's experience in an Israeli school for a year) that a hostile and highly selective report on Israeli education might produce a similarly misleading result." See "What Do Palestinian Textbooks Really Say," in *Teaching About Terrorism*, Coalition for the Advancement of Jewish Education, 202, November 2002. Excerpt available

at Nathan J. Brown, "Untitled," http://www.geocities.ws/nathanbrown1/CAJE.htm.

131. In an interview, the owner of a private school in Manama noted that the Ministry of Education had forced the school to "black out" content in a textbook that mentioned historic collective Arab actions against Israel, on the basis that it did not fit with Bahrain's values.
132. "UAE Will Teach Holocaust Education in National School Curriculum," *Jerusalem Post*, January 9, 2023, https://www.jpost.com/diaspora/article-728016.
133. Zeena Saifi and Celine Alkhaldi, "This Is the First Ever Holocaust Exhibition to Open in the Arab World," CNN, June 8, 2021, https://edition.cnn.com/travel/article/crossroads-of-civilizations-museum-dubai/index.html.
134. "Thrilled to Have You: UAE Welcomes American Jewish Advocacy Group," Reuters, June 8, 2021, https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/thrilled-have-you-uae-welcomes-american-jewish-advocacy-group-2021-06-08/.
135. Lazar Berman, "In Meeting with UAE Jewish Leaders, Herzog Says He Draws Inspiration from MbZ," *Times of Israel*, January 30, 2022, https://www.timesofisrael.com/in-meeting-with-uae-jewish-leaders-herzog-says-he-draws-inspiration-from-mbz/.
136. Gulf and Israeli officials, interview by author, Abu Dhabi, February 2022.
137. The phrase originates with Prime Minister Ehud Barak of Israel, who gave a speech in from of Jewish leaders in the United States in 1996, noting: "The dreams and aspirations of many in the Arab world have not changed. We still live in a modern and prosperous villa in the middle of the jungle, a place where different laws prevail." It is widely quoted as embodying the thinking behind Israel's fortress mentality, and its role as a civilized outpost in a region dominated by extremism.
138. Corinne E. Blackmer, "Pinkwashing," *Israel Studies* 24, no. 2 (2019): 171–81.
139. Israel has also accelerated its enforcement of administrative detention measures, to hold more than a thousand Palestinian prisoners in indefinite detention, per figures released by B'TSelem in March 2023. Under this process, Israel allows for Palestinians to be held in legal limbo for periods ranging from several months to years, without charge and without the evidence disclosure requirements, based on classified information.
140. As the measure is intended to be preventative, it has no time limit and may be enforced on the basis of mere suspicion that the individual in question

may break the law in the future. See also Frank Bajak and Joseph Krauss, "Report: NSO Spyware Found on 6 Palestinian Activists' Phones," *AP News*, November 8, 2021, https://apnews.com/article/technology-business-israel-jamal-khashoggi-hacking-6bfc5bc992de7f33f5c8e969e69ce15c.

141. These organizations also included Bisan Center for Research and Development, Defense for Children International–Palestine and the Union of Agricultural Work Committees. See Rami Ayyub, "Israel Designates Palestinian Civil Society Groups as Terrorists, UN Alarmed," Reuters, October 22, 2021, https://www.reuters.com/business/aerospace-defense/israel-designates-six-palestinian-civil-society-groups-terrorists-2021-10-22/; and "In a Joint Submission to the UN Commission of Inquiry, Palestinian Organisations Highlight Israeli Policies to Entrench and Maintain Its Settler-Colonial and Apartheid Regime," *Al-Haq*, February 3, 2023, https://www.alhaq.org/advocacy/21199.html.

142. "Israel/OPT: Designation of Palestinian Civil Society Groups as Terrorists a Brazen Attack on Human Rights," *Amnesty International (AI) News*, October 22, 2021, https://www.amnesty.org/en/latest/news/2021/10/israel-opt-designation-of-palestinian-civil-society-groups-as-terrorists-a-brazen-attack-on-human-rights/.

143. IDF Editorial Team, "Brave, Fierce, and Strong: Meet the First Women to Guard in Nablus," Israel Defense Forces, August 3, 2015, https://www.idf.il/en/mini-sites/palestinian-terrorism/brave-fierce-and-strong-meet-the-first-women-to-guard-in-nablus/.

144. Kaamil Ahmed, "Palestinian Baby Dies After Treatment Delayed by Israeli Blockade of Gaza," *Guardian*, April 1, 2022, https://www.theguardian.com/world/2022/apr/01/palestinian-baby-dies-after-treatment-delayed-by-israeli-blockade-of-gaza.

145. "Checkpoints Compound the Risks of Childbirth for Palestinian Women," United Nations Population Fund, May 15, 2007, https://www.unfpa.org/news/checkpoints-compound-risks-childbirth-palestinian-women#.

146. "Pinkwashing: One of Israel's Many Strategies to Deflect from Crimes Against Palestinians," *Fanack Media*, June 28, 2022, https://fanack.com/politics-en/pinkwashing-one-of-israels-many-strategies-to-deflect-from-crimes-against-palestinians~233733/.

147. Emily Zak, "Pinkwashing Settler Colonialism: How Settler-Colonial States Co-opt Gay Rights to Legitimize Occupation," *Briar Patch*, June 21, 2016,

https://briarpatchmagazine.com/articles/view/pinkwashing-settler-colonialism.

148. Tovah Lazaroff, "Israel to Open 'There Is No Occupation' Campaign, New Minister Says," *Jerusalem Post*, January 16, 2023, https://www.jpost.com/israel-news/article-728719.

6. PEACE AND ITS DISCONTENTS

1. Ministry of Interior (@moi_bahrain), "Anti-cybercrime: Those who follow inciting accounts that promote sedition and circulate their posts will be held legally accountable," Twitter, May 30, 2019, https://twitter.com/moi_bahrain/status/1134148380312178689. See also "Bahrain Threatens Citizens Who Follow Banned Twitter Accounts," *Middle East Monitor*, June 3, 2019, https://www.middleeastmonitor.com/20190603-bahrain-threatens-citizens-who-follow-banned-twitter-accounts/.
2. Language Lover (@amlanguagelover), "Yes it is absolutely true! It is not even clear which account ppl must follow, which must not. Meaningless to dictate the rules in social media as ppl post what ever they want and we can just see. It seems the freedom is very limited in middle east . . .," Twitter, May 31, 2019, https://twitter.com/amlanguagelover/status/1134335387898449926.
3. "Israeli Delegation Cancels Visit to Bahrain After Outcry," Reuters, April 14, 2019, https://www.reuters.com/article/uk-bahrain-security-israel-idUKKCN1RQ099.
4. "Bahrain Shuts Down Event Criticizing Normalization with Israel," *Middle East Eye*, May 11, 2020, https://www.middleeasteye.net/news/bahrain-israel-bds-online-event-cancelled.
5. "Freedom of the New 2021: Bahrain," Freedom House, 2021, https://freedomhouse.org/country/bahrain/freedom-net/2021#footnote12_ghojohe. See also "Qarar raqqam (20) li-sannat 2020 bi-ta'deel ba'th ahkam al-la'iha altanfeethiya," Bahrain Civil Service Bureau, July 9, 2020, https://www.csb.gov.bh/ar/civil-service-legislation/decrees-resolutions/prime-minister-resolution/%D9%82%D8%B1%D8%A7%D8%B1-%D8%B1%D9%82%D9%85-20-%D9%84%D8%B3%D9%86%D8%A9-2020-%D8%A8%D8%AA%D8%B9%D8%AF%D9%8A%D9%84-%D8%A8%D8%B9%D8%B6-%D8%A3%D8%AD%D9%83%D8%A7%D9%85-%D8%A7%D9%84%D9%84%D8%A7%D8%A6.html.

6. "Bahrain Opposition Rejects Israel Normalisation, Calls for Resistance," Reuters, September 13, 2020, https://www.reuters.com/article/uk-israel-gulf-usa-bahrain-cleric-idUKKBN2640G8.
7. "Freedom of the New 2021."
8. "Bahrain Welcomes UAE, Israel Normalization Deal," *Anadolu Agency*, August 13, 2020, https://www.aa.com.tr/en/middle-east/bahrain-welcomes-uae-israel-normalization-deal/1941224.
9. "Oman Says It Supports UAE-Israel Normalization of Ties," *Al Monitor*, August 14, 2020, https://www.al-monitor.com/originals/2020/08/oman-israel-uae-agreement-normalize-ties-trump-us-deal.html.
10. Frank Jordans and Aya Batrawy, "Saudi Arabia Cautiously Welcomes UAE, Israel Normalization," *AP News*, August 19, 2020, https://apnews.com/article/middle-east-f8c04477 1b8d16406b90e1d72e2b8834.
11. "Kuwait Says It'll Be Last to Normalize with Israel, Will Stand by Palestinians," *Times of Israel*, August 16, 2020, https://www.timesofisrael.com/kuwaiti-officials-reject-israel-normalization-reaffirm-support-for-palestinians/.
12. "Qatar calls UAE and Bahrain's Normalization with Israel Sovereign Decision," *Al Monitor*, November 17, 2020, https://www.al-monitor.com/originals/2020/11/qatar-uae-bahrain-normalize-israel-global-security-forum.html.
13. "Al-mubadara al-wataniyya al-bahrainiyya limunahathat al-tatbee' tastankir al-harwala almashbooha lil-tatbee' ma al-adu al-sihyooni," Bahrain Democratic Youth Society, August 17, 2020, http://www.bdys.org/main/index.php/37-news/283-2020-08-17-10-20-40.
14. Ebrahim Sharif (@ebrahimsharif), "No one will believe this nonsense about 'preserving the rights,' because the trade-off has been made and it has become short play" [translated from Arabic], Twitter, August 14, 2020, https://twitter.com/ebrahimsharif/status/1294029116279267328?.
15. BDS Kuwait حركة (@BDS_Kuwait), "A statement of the forces of Kuwaiti civil society and public benefit associations that reject normalization with the usurper Zionist enemy," Twitter, August 16, 2020, https://twitter.com/BDS_Kuwait/status/1295021369160278025?.
16. BDS Kuwait ةكرح (@BDS_Kuwait), "37 deputies in the Kuwaiti National Assembly issue a statement regarding the crime of normalization with the Zionist enemy and they affirm Kuwait's firm position against normalization with the occupying Zionist entity" [translated from Arabic], Twitter,

August 20, 2020, https://twitter.com/BDS_Kuwait/status/1295686699113119747?.

17. Jadaliyya (@jadaliyya), "Omanis reject normalization with Israel and call on the Arab regimes to return to their senses and respect the will of their peoples https://jadaliyya.com/Details/41584 @jadaliyya" [translated from Arabic], Twitter, August 15, 2020, https://twitter.com/jadaliyya/status/1294686769843978267.
18. Asad Abu Khalil (@asadabukhalil), "The number one hashtag trending in Saudi Arabia is 'Normalization is Treason,'" Twitter, August 14, 2020, https://twitter.com/asadabukhalil/status/1294032457272979456. See also Elham Fakhro, "An Open Affair: As the UAE and Israel Normalize Ties, Gulf Actors Respond," *Jadaliyya*, August 20, 2020, https://www.jadaliyya.com/Details/41608.
19. Media Line Staff, "Twitter in Saudi Arabia," *Media Line*, January 2, 2021, https://themedialine.org/mideast-mindset/twitter-in-saudi-arabia/.
20. "Saudi Prince Strongly Criticizes Israel at Bahrain Summit," *Al Jazeera*, December 6, 2020, https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2020/12/6/saudi-prince-strongly-criticises-israel-at-bahrain-summit.
21. Jibreel Al-Obaidi, "Salam al-Emiraat Qarar Siyadi," *al-Sharq al-Awasat*, August 25, 2020, https://aawsat.com/home/article/2467676/%D8%AF-%D8%AC%D8%A8%D8%B1%D9%8A%D9%84-%D8%A7%D9%84%D8%B9%D8%A8%D9%8A%D8%AF%D9%8A/%D8%B3%D9%84%D8%A7%D9%85-%D8%A7%D9%84%D8%A5%D9%85%D8%A7%D8%B1%D8%A7%D8%AA-%D9%82%D8%B1%D8%A7%D8%B1-%D8%B3%D9%8A%D8%A7%D8%AF%D9%8A.
22. Fakhro, "An Open Affair."
23. See Twitter account of the Bahrain Society Against Normalization with the Zionist Enemy (@bsaz_bh); Bahrain Palestine Support Society home page, accessed July 22, 2023, https://www.pss-bh.org/ar/home; and Twitter account of the Youth League for al-Quds (@Y4Quds).
24. Rayhan Uddin, "Israel-UAE Deal: Emirati Influencers Criticized for Praising Normalization," *Middle East Eye*, August 14, 2020, https://www.middleeasteye.net/news/israel-uae-deal-emirati-influencers-criticised-praising-normalisation.
25. "UAE Detains Prominent Political Scientist Dr. Abdulkhaleq Abdulla," Americans for Democracy and Human Rights in Bahrain, February 1, 2017,

https://www.adhrb.org/2017/02/uae-detains-prominent-political-scientist-dr-abdulkhaleq-abdulla/.

26. "Bayan bi-sha'n tajawiz 'adad al-muwaq'een 'la mithaq filisteen hajiz al-milyon," *Al-rabita al emiratiyya li-moqawamat al-tatbee*, September 16, 2020, https://uae4palestine.com/posts/25.
27. Elham Fakhro, "Selling Normalization in the Gulf," Middle East Research and Information Project, June 23, 2021, https://merip.org/2021/06/selling-normalization-in-the-gulf/.
28. Saeed Al-Tunaiji, "Rasa'il fi-alwa'ee: Makhatir al-tatbi' ala al-Imarat w-al kathiyya al filistiniyya," *Al-rabita al-emiratiyya li-moqawamat al-tatbee*, September 23, 2020, https://uae4palestine.com/posts/27.
29. "Human Rights Defender and UAE94 Member Hamad Al Shamsi Labelled as Terrorist by UAE Authorities," MENA Rights Group, January 3, 2022, https://menarights.org/en/case/hamad-al-shamsi.
30. Hamad al-Shamsi (@Alshamsi789), "Emirati normalization with the Zionist entity would not have been a reality except after Abu Dhabi was able to shackle society with laws that criminalize expression of opinion and opposition to government policies and dealing with people of other opinion in a security manner, so that our society has become less than incapable of even rejecting this betrayal" [translated from Arabic], Twitter, August 13, 2020, https://twitter.com/ALshamsi789/status/1293973343973113856.
31. "Human Rights Defender."
32. Pollock and Katz, "Half of Emiratis Approve Domestic Policies."
33. The Arab Opinion Index is carried out by the Arab Center for Research and Policy Studies in Washington, DC. See Dana El Kurd, "What Do Ordinary Arabs Think About Normalizing Relations with Israel?," *Washington Post*, October 26, 2020, https://www.washingtonpost.com/politics/2020/10/26/what-do-ordinary-arabs-think-about-normalizing-relations-with-israel/.
34. See, for example, Rassd News (@RassdNewsN), "Angry demonstrations in #Bahrain, protesting the announcement of the normalization agreement with the #occupation, and the protesters assert that it does not represent the popular position on the Palestinian issue," Twitter, September 13, 2020, https://twitter.com/RassdNewsN/status/1305121588778545153; Al Jazeera Gulf (@AJA_Gulf), "Bahraini opposition media: Demonstrations in Bahrain

against normalization with Israel," Twitter, September 13, 2020, https://twitter.com/AJA_Gulf/status/1305047211257081856; and Al Jazeera Arabic (@AJArabic), "#Bahrain_refuses_the_Zionists tops the trending list in Bahrain, rejecting all forms of normalization with Israel, supporting yesterday's demonstrations rejecting normalization, and denouncing the visit of the Israeli Foreign Minister" [translated from Arabic], Twitter, October 3, 2021, https://twitter.com/AJArabic/status/1444527632188465152.

35. "143 Bahraini Clerics Reject Normalization, Stand with Palestinian People," *Bahrain Mirror*, September 17, 2020, mirrorbah.hopto.me/en/news/58573.html.
36. Aaron Boxerman, "Bahraini Opposition Denounces Normalization with Israel," *Times of Israel*, September 12, 2020, https://www.timesofisrael.com/bahraini-opposition-blasts-normalization-deal-with-israel/.
37. "24 Organizations Call on Bahrain Govt to Expel Zionist Enemy's Ambassador, End Normalization Agreement," *Bahrain Mirror*, May 13, 2021, http://bahrainmirror.com/en/news/59636.html.
38. See also Maryam al-Khawaja (@MARYAMALKHAWAJA), "I see a lot of tweeps in #Bahrain writing they're ashamed to be Bahraini today," Twitter, September 11, 2020, https://twitter.com/MARYAMALKHAWAJA/status/1304484890637934594.
39. "Palestinians Protest Arab Normalization Deals with Israel," *Al Jazeera*, September 15, 2020, https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2020/9/15/palestinians-protest-arab-normalisation-deals-with-israel.
40. Yousuf Al Jamri (@YousufAlJamri), "Urgent The flag of the Israeli occupation entity under the feet of a procession of senior Bahraini scholars in the capital, Manama" [translated from Arabic], Twitter, July 28, 2023, https://twitter.com/YusufAlJamri/status/1684994864495177728.
41. Fakhro, "An Open Affair."
42. Hassan Sajwani (@HSajwanization), "Finally we, Emiratis, will be able to pray at Al Aqsa Mosque," Twitter, August 14, 2020, https://twitter.com/HSajwanization/status/1293998192451817473.
43. Tamara Zieve, "The Arab Influencer Pushing the Abraham Accords from Abu Dhabi," *Jewish Insider*, January 19, 2022, https://jewishinsider.com/2022/01/loay-alshareef-saudi-arabia-influencer-uae-israel-jewish-muslim/.
44. "WJC Diplomatic Corps Builds Bridges in the UAE," World Jewish Congress, https://www.worldjewishcongress.org/en/uae-delegation.

45. Tara Kavaler, "Young Arab Influencers Find Common Ground with Israelis," June 25, 2021, https://www.ynetnews.com/magazine/article/SJCwpAZ2O.
46. Bahraini national, interview by author, Manama, December 7, 2021.
47. Greer Fay Cashman, "Rivlin Hosts Bahraini Delegation, Calls King Hamad bin Isa Al Khalifa," *Jersualem Post*, December 15, 2020, https://www.jpost.com/israel-news/israeli-academic-business-delegations-head-to-uae-alongside-tourists-652081.
48. "Special Programs," Sharaka NGO, accessed December 2023, https://www.sharakango.com/our-work/special-programs.
49. Fatima al-Harbi, "A New Chapter for Arabs and Jews—at Auschwitz," *Times of Israel Blog*, May 7, 2023, https://blogs.timesofisrael.com/a-new-chapter-for-arabs-and-jews-at-auschwitz/.
50. Marissa Newman, "Israel's Exigent Hires Ex-Head of Bahraini Sovereign Wealth Fund," *Bloomberg*, June 20 2023, https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2023-06-20/israel-s-exigent-hires-ex-head-of-bahraini-sovereign-wealth-fund#xj4y7vzkg.
51. Fakhro, "Selling Normalization in the Gulf."
52. "Joint Statement of the United States, the State of Israel, and the United Arab Emirates," White House: Statements and Releases, August 13, 2020, https://trumpwhitehouse.archives.gov/briefings-statements/joint-statement-united-states-state-israel-united-arab-emirates/.
53. Nidal Al-Mughrabi and Dan Williams, "Stop or Suspend West Bank Annexation? The Devil Is in the Detail for Israel-UAE Deal," Reuters, September 2, 2020, https://www.reuters.com/article/us-israel-emirates-usa-communique-idUSKBN25T2FE.
54. Al-Mughrabi and Williams.
55. Raphael Ahren, "Top UAE Official Laments PA's Ingratitude After Abbas Envoy Rants on Israel Ties," *Times of Israel*, October 13, 2020, https://www.timesofisrael.com/top-uae-official-laments-pas-ingratitude-after-envoys-rant-on-israel-ties/.
56. "Palestinians Protest Arab Normalization Deals with Israel," *Al Jazeera*, September 15, 2020, https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2020/9/15/palestinians-protest-arab-normalisation-deals-with-israel.
57. Jack Khoury, "Abbas Slams Normalization Deal as Palestinians Ignore Calls for Day of Rage," *Haaretz*, September 16, 2020, https://www.haaretz.com

/middle-east-news/palestinians/2020-09-16/ty-article/.premium/abbas-slams-normalization-deal-as-palestinians-ignore-calls-for-day-of-rage/0000017f-db0e-df9c-a17f-ff1ecb300000.

58. Rashid Khalidi, "What's Wrong with Peace?," *Mada Masr*, August 26, 2020, https://www.madamasr.com/en/2020/08/26/opinion/u/whats-wrong-with-peace/.
59. Mohammed Abu Rumman, "Asr al-sultawiyya al-jadeeda arabiyya," *Al-araby al-jadeed*, August 22, 2020, https://www.alaraby.co.uk/%D8%B9%D8%B5%D8%B1-%22%D8%A7%D9%84%D8%B3%D9%84%D8%B7%D9%88%D9%8A%D8%A9-%D8%A7%D9%84%D8%AC%D8%AF%D9%8A%D8%AF%D8%A9%22-%D8%B9%D8%B1%D8%A8%D9%8A%D8%A7%D9%8B.
60. "Palestine Recalls Its Ambassador to Bahrain," *TRT World*, September 11, 2020, https://www.trtworld.com/middle-east/palestine-recalls-its-ambassador-to-bahrain-39688.
61. "Arab League Refuses to Back Palestinians in Rebuke of Israel-UAE Deal," *Al Jazeera*, September 9, 2020, https://www.al-monitor.com/originals/2020/09/arab-league-palestinian-uae-israel-normalization-condemn.html.
62. "Palestinians Said to Quietly Return Their Ambassadors to the UAE and Bahrain," *Times of Israel*, November 19, 2020, https://www.timesofisrael.com/palestinians-said-to-quietly-return-their-ambassadors-to-uae-bahrain/. "Palestinians Cut Ties with Israel and US After Rejecting Trump Peace Plan," *Guardian*, February 1, 2020, https://www.theguardian.com/world/2020/feb/01/palestinians-cut-ties-israel-us-trump-peace-plan.
63. Yara Hawari, "Arab Normalization and the Palestinian Struggle for Liberation," al-shabaka, October 18, 2022, https://al-shabaka.org/commentaries/arab-normalization-and-the-palestinian-struggle-for-liberation/.
64. Leon T. Hadar, "The Friends of Bibi (FOBs) vs. 'The New Middle East,'" *Journal of Palestine Studies* 26, no. 1 (1996): 89–97.
65. Eran Etzion, "How Israel Has Embraced the New Middle East," *Manar Magazine*, October 3, 2022, https://manaramagazine.org/2022/10/how-israel-has-embraced-the-new-middle-east/.
66. Hudson Institute, "The Abraham Accords and the New Middle East," YouTube video, September 15, 2021, 52:10, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=q6aSX99VBBE.
67. Israeli anthropologist, interview by author, Tel Aviv, October 2021.

68. "Knesset Approves UAE Normalization 80–13; Mainly Arab Party Is Sole Opposition," *Times of Israel*, October 15, 2020, https://www.timesofisrael.com/knesset-approves-uae-normalization-with-huge-majority-only-joint-list-opposed/.
69. "Ma Wara' al-Khabar, Ma Rasa'il Netanyahu Ila Al'Arab W'AlIsraeliyeen," *Al Jazeera Arabic*, October 16, 2020, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=aNspRacVLZA. See also Sami Abu Shehada, "Israel's Pact with the UAE Is Not About Peace. It's a Business Deal," *Guardian*, October 14, 2020, https://www.theguardian.com/commentisfree/2020/oct/14/israel-pact-with-the-uae-peace-palestinian-settlements.
70. "Ma Wara' al-Khabar."
71. Aviv Tatarsky, "The Normalization with the Emirates: Not a Peace Agreement, but a Show of Strength," Regional Thinking Forum, August 20, 2020, https://www.regthink.org/uae-accords-aviv/.
72. Katie Waxberger, "The Agreement with the Emirates: Israel Strengthens the Authoritarian Regimes in the Middle East," Regional Thinking Forum, August 17, 2020, https://www.regthink.org/accord-with-uae/.
73. Public lecture by Dr. Ali Fakhro at al-Uruba Club, Manama, Bahrain, October 26, 2022.
74. Assaf David, interview by author, Van Leer Jerusalem Institute, February 2021.

CONCLUSION

1. Barak Ravid, "Saudi Crown Prince: Palestinians Should Take What the U.S. Offers," *Axios*, April 29, 2018, https://www.axios.com/2018/04/29/saudi-crown-prince-tells-jewish-leaders-palestinians-should-take-what-they-are-offered-or-stop-complaining-1525025098.
2. Saudi officials, interview by author, Riyadh, June 2022.
3. "In First, Israeli Athlete to Compete in Saudi Arabia Amid Thawing Ties," *Times of Israel*, October 25, 2022, https://www.timesofisrael.com/in-first-israeli-athlete-to-compete-in-saudi-arabia-amid-thawing-ties/.
4. David Schenker, "Getting to an Israeli-Saudi Deal on Tiran and Sanafir," Washington Institute for Near East Policy, July 7, 2022, https://www.washingtoninstitute.org/policy-analysis/getting-israeli-saudi-deal-tiran-and-sanafir.

5. Al Mayadeen English, "Saudi Arabia Plans to Open Red Sea Islands to Israeli Tourists," *Al Mayadeen*, January 23, 2023, https://english.almayadeen.net/news/politics/saudi-arabia-plans-to-open-red-sea-islands-to-israeli-touris.
6. Julian E. Barnes and Edward Wong, "Democratic Lawmakers Urge Biden to Ensure Saudi Ties Serve U.S.," *New York Times*, June 7, 2022, https://www.nytimes.com/2022/06/07/us/politics/biden-saudi-arabia-congress.html' and Zachary Cohen, "CNN Exclusive: U.S. Intel and Satellite Images Show Saudi Arabia Is Now Building Its Own Ballistic Missiles with Help of China," CNN, December 23, 2021, https://edition.cnn.com/2021/12/23/politics/saudi-ballistic-missiles-china/index.html.
7. Peter Suciu, "China's Stunning J-20 Stealth Fighter May Be a Flying Paper Tiger," *National Interest* (blog), November 15, 2023, https://nationalinterest.org/blog/buzz/chinas-stunning-j-20-stealth-fighter-might-be-flying-paper-tiger-207296.
8. David Myers and Daniel Sokatch, "Op-Ed: Palestinians in Israel Have New Cause to Fear for Their Future," *Los Angeles Times*, February 1, 2003, https://www.latimes.com/opinion/story/2023-02-01/israel-palestinians-netanyahu-nakba.
9. Peter Baker and Ronen Bergman, "Biden Presses Ahead with Effort to Broker Israeli-Saudi Rapprochement," *New York Times*, July 29, 2023, https://www.nytimes.com/2023/07/29/us/politics/biden-israel-saudi-arabia-negotiations.html.
10. Baker and Bergman.
11. See, for example, "Saudi Remains Committed to Arab Peace Initiative for Israel Peace, Foreign Minister Says," Reuters, August 19, 2020, https://www.reuters.com/article/us-israel-emirates-saudi-idUSKCN25F1TQ; and "Saudi Arabia Says a Palestinian State Is Key to Ties with Israel," *Bloomberg*, January 19, 2023, https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2023-01-19/saudi-arabia-says-a-palestinian-state-is-key-to-ties-with-israel.
12. Thomas Friedman, "Biden Is Weighing a Big Middle East Deal," *New York Times*, July 27, 2023, https://www.nytimes.com/2023/07/27/opinion/israel-saudi-arabia-biden.html.
13. Patrick Kingsley and Aaron Boxerman, "As Saudis Consider Deal with Israel, Palestinians Seek Sway in Talks," *New York Times*, September 5, 2023, https://www.nytimes.com/2023/09/05/world/middleeast/saudi-arabia-israel-talks-palestinians.html.

14. Summer Said and Stephen Kalin, "Saudi Arabia and UAE Clash Over Oil, Yemen, as Rift Grows," *Wall Street Journal*, March 3, 2023, https://www.wsj.com/articles/saudi-arabia-and-u-a-e-clash-over-oil-yemen-as-rift-grows-ff286ff9.
15. "Israel Social Security Data Reveals True Picture of Oct 7 Deaths," *France24*, December 15, 2023, https://www.france24.com/en/live-news/20231215-israel-social-security-data-reveals-true-picture-of-oct-7-deaths.
16. Dan Raviv and Yossi Melman, "Israel's Vow to 'Eliminate Hamas' is Unrealistic. Here's What Netanyahu Must Acknowledge," *Time*, October 28, 2023, https://time.com/6329637/israel-hamas-war-netanyahu-strategy/.
17. "Netanyahu Proposes Plan for Post-war Gaza with Israeli Army Having 'Freedom' to Operate," *France24*, February 23, 2024, https://www.france24.com/en/middle-east/20240223-netanyahu-proposes-plan-for-post-war-gaza-led-by-local-officials-without-links-to-hamas.
18. Ehud Olmert, "Netanyahu's Messianic Coalition Partners Want an all-Out Regional War. Gaza is Just the First Step," *Haaretz*, February 22, 2024, https://www.haaretz.com/opinion/2024-02-22/ty-article-opinion/.premium/netanyahus-messianic-coalition-partners-want-an-all-out-regional-war/0000018d-d237-d06c-abbd-daf733870000.
19. Jonathan Guyer, "Most of Israel's Weapons Imports Come from the US. Now Biden Is Rushing Even More Arms, *Vox Media*, November 18, 2023, https://www.vox.com/world-politics/2023/11/18/23966137/us-weapons-israel-biden-package-explained.
20. "Arab, Muslim Leaders Denounce Israel War on Gaza at Riyadh Summit," *New Arab*, November 11 2023, https://www.newarab.com/news/gaza-arab-muslim-leaders-denounce-israel-riyadh-summit.
21. "U.S. Forces Attacked 4 Times in Iraq, Syria Within Hours," Reuters, November 24, 2023, https://www.reuters.com/world/us-forces-attacked-4-times-iraq-syria-within-hours-2023-11-23/.
22. Credit card company representative, interview by author, Dubai, January 5, 2024.
23. "Bahrain F&B Group Takes Legal Action Against Pro-Israel Chef Susy Masetti," *Smashi Business*, March 20, 2024, https://www.instagram.com/p/C4yDp1opLZa/?igsh=ZHZmMWR1ZW5rdHA.
24. Vivian Nereim, "Saudis Overwhelmingly Oppose Ties with Israel, Poll Finds," *New York Times*, December 22, 2023, https://www.nytimes.com/2023/12/22/world/middleeast/saudi-arabia-poll-israel-gaza-war-hamas.html.

25. "Bahrain Leader Condemns Hamas Oct. 7 Onslaught, Calls for Release of Hostages," *Times of Israel*, November 20, 2023, https://www.timesofisrael.com/bahrain-leader-condemns-hamas-oct-7-onslaught-calls-for-release-of hostages/#; and Sahim Salim, "Israel-Hamas War: UAE Warns of Growing Tension in Region," *Khaleej Times*, October 24, 2023, https://www.khaleejtimes.com/uae/israel-hamas-war-uae-warns-of-growing-tension-in-region.
26. Stephen Kalin, "UAE Links Support for Rebuilding Gaza to Push for Two-State Solution," *Wall Street Journal*, December 12, 2023, https://www.wsj.com/world/middle-east/u-a-e-links-support-for-rebuilding-gaza-to-push-for-two-state-solution-b878b433; and "Bahrain Condemns Escalating Israeli War on Gaza," Ministry of Foreign Affairs, October 28, 2023, https://www.mofa.gov.bh/Default.aspx?tabid=7824&language=en-US&ItemId=22770.
27. "War on Gaza: Egyptian monthly exports to Israel double, UAE and Jordan exports also rise," *Middle East Eye*, June 20, 2024, https://www.middleeasteye.net/news/egypt-exports-israel-doubled-2024-official-report.
28. Michael Barnett, Nathan Brown, Marc Lynch, and Shibley Telhami, "Israel's One-State Reality," *Foreign Affairs*, April 14, 2023, https://www.foreignaffairs.com/middle-east/israel-palestine-one-state-solution.
29. Zaha Hassan, Daniel Levy, Hallaamal Keir, and Marwan Muasher, *Breaking the Israel-Palestine Status Quo*, vol. 19 (Washington, DC: Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, 2021).
30. Aluf Benn, "Israel's Self-Destruction: Netanyahu, the Palestinians, and the Price of Neglect," *Foreign Affairs*, https://www.foreignaffairs.com/israel/israels-netanyahu-self-destruction, February 7, 2024.

BIBLIOGRAPHY

Abdelaziz, Mohamed. "Arab Reactions to Trump's Peace Plan: An Analysis and Recommendation." Washington Institute for Near East Policy, January 31, 2020. https://www.washingtoninstitute.org/policy-analysis/arab-reactions-trumps-peace-plan-analysis-and-recommendation.

Abdelaziz, Mohamed, and David Pollock. "Half of Egyptians Value U.S. Ties, but Few Want Normalization with Israel." Washington Institute for Near East Policy, January 15, 2021. https://www.washingtoninstitute.org/policy-analysis/half-egyptians-value-us-ties-few-want-normalization-israel.

Abouzzohour, Yasmina. "Heavy Lies the Crown: The Survival of Arab Monarchies, 10 Years After the Arab Spring." Brookings Institution, March 8, 2021. https://www.brookings.edu/blog/order-from-chaos/2021/03/08/heavy-lies-the-crown-the-survival-of-arab-monarchies-10-years-after-the-arab-spring/.

Abrams, Elliot. "Bahrain: Bad to Worse." Council on Foreign Relations, May 31, 2011. https://www.cfr.org/blog/bahrain-bad-worse.

Adalah: The Legal Center for Arab Minority Rights in Israel. "Israel's Jewish Nation State Law." December 20, 2020. https://www.adalah.org/en/content/view/9569.

——. "Israel's 2016 Counter-Terrorism Law and 1945 Emergency Regulations Regarding the Outlawing of Six Palestinian Human Rights and Civil Society Groups." November 23, 2021. https://www.adalah.org/uploads/uploads/Adalah_Expert_Opinion_Palestinian6_Nov2021.pdf.

ADHRB Staff. "UAE Detains Prominent Political Scientist Dr. Abdulkhaleq Abdulla." Americans for Democracy & Human Rights in Bahrain, February 1,

2017. https://www.adhrb.org/2017/02/uae-detains-prominent-political-scientist-dr-abdulkhaleq-abdulla/.

Admoni, Ariel. "Same Reasons: Different Outcomes: Qatar's Policy on Israel Up to 1996." *Middle Eastern Studies* 58, no. 6 (2021): 830–42.

AIN Staff. "UAE Establishes Space Reconnaissance Center." *Ain Online*, December 11, 2006. https://www.ainonline.com/aviation-news/aerospace/2006-12-11/uae-establishes-space-reconnaissance-center.

Akkas, Erhan, and Suleyman Orhun Altiparmak. "The Reshaping Oil and Arms Trade Between the United States and GCC: Is the Theory of Complex Interdependence Still Prevailing?" *Journal of Asian and African Studies* 57, no. 7 (2022): 1430–45. https://doi.org/10.1177/00219096211058880.

Al-Ayam. "Raees wuzara' Israel fi awal liqaa ma' saheefa khaleejiyya khus bi al-ayyam: nuqadir za'amat jalalat al-malik al-shuja'a." February 15, 2022. https://www.alayam.com/alayam/first/947514/News.html.

Al-Haq. "In a Joint Submission to the UN Commission of Inquiry, Palestinian Organisations Highlight Israeli Policies to Entrench and Maintain Its Settler-Colonial and Apartheid Regime." February 3, 2023. https://www.alhaq.org/advocacy/21199.html.

Al Ittihad. "Mohammed Bin Zayed: Al-Istratijiyya il-amniyya tastajeeb li-mutatalibaat altanmiya al-shamila." March 5, 2008. https://bit.ly/3SfhkjR.

Al Monitor. "Israeli Journalist Barak Ravid Tells How the Abraham Accords Came About on Israel with Ben Caspit, Podcast Episode 72." December 20, 2021. https://www.al-monitor.com/podcasts/israeli-journalist-barak-ravid-tells-how-abraham-accords-came-about.

Alhinai, Sharifah. "The Jews of Bahrain and the Arabian Gulf's Only Synagogue." *Sekka Magazine*, October 1, 2017. https://sekkamag.com/2017/10/01/the-jews-of-bahrain-and-the-arabian-gulfs-only-synagogue/.

AlJughaifi, Saddam. "Al-Mamlaka al-arabiyya al-suoodiyya wa-alqadhiya alfilistineeya (1991–2001)." *Dar al-mutaz lilnashr wa-altawzee'*. Muscat, 2016.

Aly, Abdel Monem Said. "Essays: The Case for the One-State Solution." *Cairo Review of Global Affairs*, 2019. https://www.thecairoreview.com/essays/the-case-for-the-one-state-solution/.

Americans for Democracy and Human Rights in Bahrain. "Italy's Role in Whitewashing Religious Intolerance in Bahrain." March 31, 2019. https://www.adhrb.org/2019/03/italys-role-in-whitewashing-religious-intolerance-in-bahrain/.

——. "UAE Detains Prominent Political Scientist Dr. Abdulkhaleq Abdulla." February 1, 2017. https://www.adhrb.org/2017/02/uae-detains-prominent-political-scientist-dr-abdulkhaleq-abdulla/.

——. "UAE Sentences Dr. Nasser bin Ghaith to Ten Years Prison." April 18, 2017. https://www.adhrb.org/2017/03/uae-sentences-dr-nasser-bin-ghaith-10-years-prison/.

Amnesty International. "Bahrain: End Prison Ordeal for Nabeel Rajab Immediately." *Amnesty International (AI) News*, November 27, 2013. https://www.amnesty.org/en/latest/news/2013/11/bahrain-end-prison-ordeal-nabeel-rajab-immediately/.

——. "Gaza: Operation Protective Edge." July 9, 2015. https://www.amnesty.org.uk/gaza-operation-protective-edge.

——. "Israel/OPT: Designation of Palestinian Civil Society Groups as Terrorists a Brazen Attack on Human Rights."*Amnesty International (AI) News*, October 22, 2021. https://www.amnesty.org/en/latest/news/2021/10/israel-opt-designation-of-palestinian-civil-society-groups-as-terrorists-a-brazen-attack-on-human-rights/.

——. "The Pegasus Project: How Amnesty Tech Uncovered the Spyware Scandal." March 23, 2022. https://www.amnesty.org/en/latest/news/2022/03/the-pegasus-project-how-amnesty-tech-uncovered-the-spyware-scandal-new-video/#.

——. "UAE: Activist Ahmed Mansoor Sentenced to 10 years in Prison for Social Media Posts." May 31, 2018. https://www.amnesty.org/en/latest/news/2018/05/uae-activist-ahmed-mansoor-sentenced-to-10-years-in-prison-for-social-media-posts/.

——. "UAE: Nearly a Decade of Unjust Imprisonment for 'UAE-94' Dissidents." July 2, 2021. https://www.amnesty.org/en/latest/news/2021/07/uae-nearly-a-decade-of-unjust-imprisonment-for-uae-94-dissidents-2/.

Anadolu Agency. "Bahrain Welcomes UAE, Israel Normalization Deal." August 13, 2020. https://www.aa.com.tr/en/middle-east/bahrain-welcomes-uae-israel-normalization-deal/1941224.

Anziska, Seth. *Preventing Palestine: A Political History from Camp David to Oslo*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2018.

Arab Weekly. "UAE Announces CVE-Based Curriculum to Curb Threat of Violent Extremism." July 19, 2019. https://thearabweekly.com/uae-announces-cve-based-curriculum-curb-threat-violent-extremism.

——. "UAE Fatwa Council Declares Muslim Brotherhood a Terrorist Organization." November 24, 2020. https://thearabweekly.com/uae-fatwa-council-declares-muslim-brotherhood-terrorist-organisation.

Arabian Business. "Abu Dhabi Launches Kosher Food Certificates as It Chases More Jewish Tourists." October 21, 2020. https://www.arabianbusiness.com/industries/travel-hospitality/453465-abu-dhabi-launches-kosher-food-certificates-for-hotels-to-attract-more-jewish-tourists.

Ardemagni, Eleonora. "The Gulf Monarchies' Complex Fight Against Daesh." *NATO Review*, September 28, 2016. https://www.nato.int/docu/review/articles/2016/09/28/the-gulf-monarchies-complex-fight-against-daesh/index.html.

Arkansas Online. "Religious Leaders Meet in Bahrain." November 5, 2022. https://www.arkansasonline.com/news/2022/nov/05/religious-leaders-meet-in-bahrain/.

Arms Control Association. "Senate Failure to Block JCPOA Is a Victory for Nuclear Non-proliferation." Press release, September 10, 2015. https://www.armscontrol.org/pressroom/2015-09/senate-failure-block-jcpoa-victory-nuclear-nonproliferation.

——. "Understanding the JCPOA." August 2015. https://www.armscontrol.org/2015-08/section-3-understanding-jcpoa.

Arnaout, Abdel Ra'ouf. "Israel-UAE Visa Free Travel to Start October 10." *Anadolu Agency*, October 5, 2021. https://www.aa.com.tr/en/middle-east/israel-uae-visa-free-travel-to-start-oct-10/2383600.

Aronson, Geoffrey. "Trump's Decision on Settlements Opens the Way to Annexation." *Arab Weekly*, November 24, 2019. https://thearabweekly.com/trumps-decision-settlements-opens-way-annexation.

Aruri, Nasser, and Fouad Maghrabi. "The Reagan Middle East Initiative." *Journal of Palestine Studies* 12, no. 2 (1983): 10–30.

Associated Press Archive. "Qatar: Israel Trade Office Closed." November 9, 2000. http://www.aparchive.com/metadata/QATAR-ISRAEL-TRADE-OFFICE-CLOSED/3ea04bcb02b6e311f663638a71da0561?Assassinations:Subject.

Atlantic. "The Experiment Podcast: Evangelical Is Not a Religious Identity. It's a Political One." May 13, 2021. https://www.theatlantic.com/podcasts/archive/2021/05/evangelicals-republican-voters/618845/.

Azami, Usaama Al-. "UAE's Forum for Promoting Peace Is Another Cynical PR Initiative." *Middle East Eye*, December 10, 2018. https://www.middleeasteye.net/opinion/uaes-forum-promoting-peace-another-cynical-pr-initiative.

Azizi, Hamidreza. "The Concept of 'Forward Defence': How Has the Syrian Crisis Shaped the Evolution of Iran's Military Strategy?" Geneva Center for Security Policy, February 2021. https://dam.gcsp.ch/files/doc/iran-forward-defence-strategy-en.

Baconi, Tareq. *Hamas Contained: The Rise and Pacification of Palestinian Resistance*. Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2018.

Bahrain Cathedral. "Video Clip: The King of Bahrain Gives the Pope a Model of the Cathedral." May 21, 2014. http://bahraincathedral.org/?p=1393.

Bahrain Civil Service Bureau. "Qarar raqqam (20) li-sannat 2020 bi-ta'deel ba'th ahkam al-la'iha altanfeethiya." July 9, 2020. https://www.csb.gov.bh/ar/civil-service-legislation/decrees-resolutions/prime-minister-resolution/%D9%82%D8%B1%D8%A7%D8%B1-%D8%B1%D9%82%D9%85-20-%D9%84%D8%B3%D9%86%D8%A9-2020-%D8%A8%D8%AA%D8%B9%D8%AF%D9%8A%D9%84-%D8%A8%D8%B9%D8%B6-%D8%A3%D8%AD%D9%83%D8%A7%D9%85-%D8%A7%D9%84%D9%84%D8%A7%D8%A6.html.

Bahrain Democratic Youth Society. "Al-mubadara al-wataniyya al-bahrainiyya limunahathat al-tatbee' tastankir al-harwala almashbooha lil-tatbee' ma al-adu al-sihyooni." August 17, 2020. http://www.bdys.org/main/index.php/37-news/283-2020-08-17-10-20-40.

Bahrain News Gazette. "King Hamad Global Centre for Peaceful Co-existence Established." March 2, 2018. https://www.bahrainnewsgazette.com/king-hamad-global-centre-for-peaceful-co-existence-established/.

Balfour, Arthur James. "The Balfour Declaration." In *Speeches on Zionism by the Rt. Hon. The Earl of Balfour* (1917), 19–21.

Barnett, Michael Nathan Brown, Marc Lynch, and Shibley Telhami. "Israel's One-State Reality." *Foreign Affairs*, April 14, 2023, https://www.foreignaffairs.com/middle-east/israel-palestine-one-state-solution.

——, eds. *The One State Reality: What Is Israel/Palestine?* Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 2023.

Barr, James. *A Line in the Sand: Britain, France, and the Struggle for the Mastery of the Middle East*. London: Simon & Schuster, 2011.

Bauer, Katherine. "Israel-UAE Economic Cooperation Has Deep Roots and Broad Dividends." Washington Institute for Near East Policy, March 8, 2022. https://www.washingtoninstitute.org/policy-analysis/israel-uae-economic-cooperation-has-deep-roots-and-broad-dividends.

Baumgarten-Sharon, Naama. "No Minor Matter: Violation of the Rights of Palestinian Minors Arrested by Israel on Suspicion of Stone-Throwing." B'TSelem, July 2011. https://www.btselem.org/publications/summaries/2011-no-minor-matter.

Bawaba, *Al*. Charm Offensive: This Is Bahrain Public Image Roadshow Hits the US." September 28, 2015. https://www.albawaba.com/business/charm-offensive-bahrain-public-image-roadshow-hits-us-748128.

Bertoni, Steven. "Exclusive Interview: How Jared Kushner Won Trump the White House." *Forbes*, November 22, 2016. https://www.forbes.com/sites/stevenbertoni/2016/11/22/exclusive-interview-how-jared-kushner-won-trump-the-white-house/?sh=2bd87c23af68.

Blackmer, Corinne E. "Pinkwashing." *Israel Studies* 24, no. 2 (2019): 171–81.

Breaking Mazo. "The History of Jews in Bahrain." September 30, 2020. https://breakingmatzo.com/history-of-jews/the-history-of-jews-in-bahrain/.

B'Tselem. "By Hook and Crook: Israeli Settlement Policy in the West Bank." July 2010. https://www.btselem.org/publications/summaries/201007_by_hook_and_by_crook.

Butter, David. "Egypt and the Gulf: Allies and Rivals." Chatham House (Royal Institute for International Affairs), April 20, 2020. https://www.chathamhouse.org/2020/04/egypt-and-gulf/sisis-debt-his-gulf-arab-backers.

Caspit, Ben. "Episode 72." Produced by Ben Caspit, December 20, 2021. Al-Monitor podcast, MP3 audio, 40:30. https://www.al-monitor.com/podcasts/israeli-journalist-barak-ravid-tells-how-abraham-accords-came-about.

Choksy, Carol E. B., and Jamsheed K. Choksy. "The Saudi Connection: Wahhabism and Global Jihad." *World Affairs* 178, no. 1 (2015).

Chomsky, Noam. "The Oslo Accords: Their Context, Their Consequences." In *The Oslo Accords: 1993–2013: A Critical Assessment*, ed. Bauck Petter and Omer Mohammed. London: Tauris, 2013.

Coalition for the Advancement of Jewish Education. "What Do Palestinian Textbooks Really Say," in *Teaching About Terrorism*, November 2002. http://www.geocities.ws/nathanbrown1/CAJE.htm.

Committee to Protect Journalists. "Mansoor al-Jamri, Bahrain, International Press Freedom Awards." 2011. https://cpj.org/awards/mansoor-al-jamri-bahrain/.

Congressional Research Service. *Israel's Qualitative Military Edge and Possible U.S. Arms Sales to the United Arab Emirates*. CRS Report, October 26, 2020. https://sgp.fas.org/crs/mideast/R46580.pdf.

Dawisha, Adeed. "Saudi Arabia and the Arab-Israeli Conflict: The Ups and Downs of Pragmatic Moderation." *International Journal* 38, no. 4 (1983): 674–89.

DAWN. "Constitutional Lawyer Mohammad al-Roken Asked for Reform in the UAE but Got 10 Years in Prison Instead." December 21, 2020. https://dawnmena.org/constitutional-lawyer-mohammad-al-roken-asked-for-reform-in-the-uae-but-got-10-years-in-prison-instead/.

Delman, Edward. "Obama Promised to End America's Wars—Has He?" *Atlantic*, March 30, 2016. https://www.theatlantic.com/international/archive/2016/03/obama-doctrine-wars-numbers/474531/.

Derasat. "Memorandum of Understanding with the National Institute for Security Studies in Israel." August 12, 2021. https://www.derasat.org.bh/memorandum-of-understanding-with-the-national-institute-for-security-studies-in-israel/.

Dessi, Andrea. *Israel and the Palestinians After the Arab Spring: No Time for Peace*. Instituto Affari Internazionali, IAI Working Papers, 1216, May 2012. https://www.files.ethz.ch/isn/142706/iaiwp1216.pdf.

Development Assistance Roadmap Portal in the Middle East. "Hedaya and the EU Builds the Capacity of States and Non-State Actors to Effectively Challenge Radicalization—2023." October 18, 2021. https://darpe.me/hedaya-and-eu-builds-the-capacity-of-state-and-non-state-actors-to-effectively-challenge-radicalization/.

Diwan, Kristin Smith. "The Manama Workshop and the Course of Normalization in the Gulf." Arab Gulf States Institute in Washington, July 3, 2019. https://agsiw.org/the-manama-workshop-and-the-course-of-normalization-in-the-gulf/.

Dunstan, Simon. *The Yom Kippur War: The Arab-Israeli War of 1973*. Oxford: Osprey, 2007.

Embassy of Kingdom of Saudi Arabia, Washington, DC. "Kingdom of Saudi Arabia's Statement on the United States Withdrawal from the JCPOA." May 8, 2018. https://www.saudiembassy.net/news/kingdom-saudi-arabias-statement-united-states-withdrawal-jcpoa.

——. "Saudi Statement on Iran Nuclear Deal." July 14, 2015. https://www.saudiembassy.net/press-release/saudi-statement-iran-nuclear-dea.

Emirati Association to Resist Normalization. "Bayan bi-sha'n tajawiz 'adad al-muwaq'een 'la mithaq filisteen hajiz al-milyon." *Al-rabita al emiratiyya*

li-moqawamat al-tatbee, September 16, 2020. https://uae4palestine.com/posts/25.

Entous, Adam. "Donald Trump's New World Order." *New Yorker*, June 11, 2018. https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2018/06/18/donald-trumps-new-world-order.

Etsion, Udi. "Friendly Adversaries: How Israel Secretly Helped Build Up the UAE's Military Capabilities." *C Tech*, August 18, 2020. https://www.calcalistech.com/ctech/articles/0,7340,L-3845579,00.html.

Etzion, Eran. "How Israel Has Embraced the New Middle East." *Manar Magazine*, October 3, 2022. https://manaramagazine.org/2022/10/how-israel-has-embraced-the-new-middle-east/.

——. "Revolution and Counter-Revolution in Bahrain." In *Civil Resistance in the Arab Spring: Triumphs and Disasters*, ed. A. Roberts, M. Willis, R. McCarthy, and T. Garton-Ash. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2016.

Fakhro, Elham. "Selling Normalization in the Gulf." Middle East Research and Information Project, June 23, 2021. https://merip.org/2021/06/selling-normalization-in-the-gulf/.

Fanack Media. "Pinkwashing: One of Israel's Many Strategies to Deflect from Crimes Against Palestinians." June 28, 2022. https://fanack.com/politics-en/pinkwashing-one-of-israels-many-strategies-to-deflect-from-crimes-against-palestinians~233733/.

Fikra Forum. "TWI Interactive Polling Platform." Washington Institute, June 30, 2022. https://www.washingtoninstitute.org/policy-analysis/twi-interactive-polling-platform#main-content.

Freedom House. "Freedom of the New 2021: Bahrain." 2021. https://freedomhouse.org/country/bahrain/freedom-net/2021#footnote12_ghojohe.

Friedman, David. *Sledgehammer: How Breaking with the Past Brought Peace to the Middle East*. New York: Harper Collins, 2022.

Frontline Defenders. "Case History: Nabeel Rajab." June 12, 2020. https://www.frontlinedefenders.org/en/case/case-history-nabeel-rajab.

Goodman, Micah. *CATCH-67: The Left, the Right, and the Legacy of the Six-Day War*. New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2018.

Gordon, Neve. "Outsourcing the Occupation." In *Israel's Occupation*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2008. https://academic.oup.com/california-scholarship-online/book/19365/chapter-abstract/177960484.

Gottesman, Evan. "The Two-State Solution Is Dead: Long Live the Two-State Solution." Israel Policy Forum, July 7, 2020. https://israelpolicyforum.org

/2020/07/07/the-two-state-solution-is-dead-long-live-the-two-state-solution-3/.

Government of Abu Dhabi. Abu Dhabi Executive Council website. Accessed July 23, 2023. https://www.ecouncil.ae/en/ADGovernment/Pages/ExecutiveCouncil.aspx.

Government of Israel, Prime Minister's Office. "Prime Minister Naftali Bennett: Do Not Give in to Iran's Nuclear Blackmail." November 29, 2021. https://www.gov.il/en/departments/news/spoke_iran291121.

Hadar, Leon T. "The Friends of Bibi (FOBs) vs. 'The New Middle East.'" *Journal of Palestine Studies* 26, no. 1 (1996): 89–97.

Hakala, Pekka. "Opposition in the United Arab Emirates." European Parliament Directorate-General for External Policies, November 15, 2012. https://www.europarl.europa.eu/RegData/etudes/briefing_note/join/2012/491458/EXPO-AFET_SP%282012%29491458_EN.pdf.

Halevy, Efraim. "Israel's Hamas Portfolio." *Israel Journal of Foreign Affairs* 2, no. 3 (2008): 41–47.

Hamzawy, Amr. "The Negev Summit's Participants Had Wildly Different Goals." Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, April 6, 2022. https://carnegieendowment.org/2022/04/06/negev-summit-s-participants-had-wildly-different-goals-pub-86826.

Hanna, Andrew. "Raisi: Role in 1988 Massacre." Iran Primer, United States Institute of Peace, July 21, 2021. https://iranprimer.usip.org/blog/2021/jul/21/raisi-role-1988-massacre.

Hannah, John. "Iran-Backed Militias Are in Iraq to Stay." *Foreign Policy*, July 31, 2019. https://foreignpolicy.com/2019/07/31/iran-backed-militias-are-in-iraq-to-stay/.

Hasbani, Nadim. "The Geopolitics of Weapons Procurement in the Gulf States." *Defense & Security Analysis* 22, no. 1 (2006): 73–88.

Hassan, Zaha, Daniel Levy, Hallaamal Keir, and Marwan Muasher. *Breaking the Israel-Palestine Status Quo*. Vol. 19. Washington, DC: Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, 2021.

Hawari, Yara. "Arab Normalization and the Palestinian Struggle for Liberation." Al-shabaka, October 18, 2022. https://al-shabaka.org/commentaries/arab-normalization-and-the-palestinian-struggle-for-liberation/.

Hebrew University of Jerusalem, Office of the President. "A Visit by the Delegation from the Kingdom of Bahrain from 'The King Hamad Global Center for Coexistence and Peace' and Signing of a Memorandum for Future

Cooperation with the Hebrew University." November 25, 2020. https://en.president.huji.ac.il/news/visit-delegation-kingdom-bahrain-%E2%80%9C-king-hamad-global-center-coexistence-and-peace%E2%80%9D.

Hedayah Center. "Counter Narrative Library." Accessed July 22, 2023. https://hedayah.com/resources/counter-narrative-library/.

Herzl, Theodor. A *Jewish State: An Attempt at a Modern Solution of the Jewish Question*. New York: Maccabean, 1904.

Higher Committee for Human Fraternity. "Abrahamic Family House." Accessed July 23, 2023. https://www.forhumanfraternity.org/abrahamic-family-house/.

Hudson Institute. "The Abraham Accords and the New Middle East." YouTube video, September 15, 2021, 52:10. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=q6aSX99VBBE.

Human Rights Watch. "Bahrain's Only Independent Newspaper Shut Down." June 18, 2018. https://www.hrw.org/news/2017/06/18/bahrain-only-independent-newspaper-shut-down.

——. "Gaza: An Open-Air Prison." June 13, 2022. https://www.hrw.org/video-photos/video/2022/06/13/gaza-open-air-prison.

——. "Israel: New Peak in Arbitrary Razing of Palestinian Homes." August 19, 2010. https://www.hrw.org/news/2010/08/19/israel-new-peak-arbitrary-razing-palestinian-homes.

——. "Israel: Stop Discriminatory Home Demolitions." March 8, 2011. https://www.hrw.org/news/2011/03/08/israel-stop-discriminatory-home-demolitions.

——. "A Threshold Crossed: Israeli Authorities and the Crime of Apartheid and Persecution." April 27, 2021. https://www.hrw.org/report/2021/04/27/threshold-crossed/israeli-authorities-and-crimes-apartheid-and-persecution.

——. "UAE: Terrorism Law Threatens Lives, Liberty." December 3, 2014. https://www.hrw.org/news/2014/12/04/uae-terrorism-law-threatens-lives-liberty.

——. "UAE Academic Facing Speech Charges." February 16, 2017. https://www.hrw.org/news/2017/02/16/uae-academic-facing-speech-charges.

Huntington, Samuel. *The Clash of Civilizations and the Remaking of the World Order*. New York: Simon and Schuster, 1996.

Hussein, King. "The Madrid Peace Process." King Abdullah II website. 2001. http://www.kinghussein.gov.jo/his_peace2.html.

India Office Records. "Bahrain Intelligence Summary." IOR/L/PS/12/3769A, December 1–15, 1947. https://www.qdl.qa/en/archive/81055/vdc_100055736398.0x000014.

Institute for Middle East Understanding. "Quick Facts: Israel's West Bank Settlement Enterprise." June 22, 2020. https://imeu.org/article/quick-facts-israels-west-bank-settlement-enterprise.

Institute for National Security Studies (INSS). "The Atlantic Council, Emirates Policy Center, and Institute for National Security Studies Announce Strategic Partnership to Advance UAE-Israel Relations." Press release, October 15, 2021. https://www.inss.org.il/think-tanks-cooperation/.

International Campaign for Freedom in the United Arab Emirates. "Appeal for UAE to Release Prominent Emirati Lawyer Mohammed Al-Roken, After Serving 10-Year Prison Sentence." Press release, September 14, 2022. https://www.icfuae.org.uk/press-releases/appeal-uae-release-prominent-emirati-lawyer-mohammed-al-roken-after-serving-10-year.

International Commission of Jurists. "United Arab Emirates: New Anti-Terror Law." *icj*, accessed July 22, 2023. https://www.icj.org/ebulletin/united-arab-emirates-new-anti-terror-law/.

International Crisis Group. *Rethinking Peace in Yemen*. Report No. 216, Middle East and North Africa, July 2, 2020. https://www.crisisgroup.org/middle-east-north-africa/gulf-and-arabian-peninsula/yemen/216-rethinking-peace-yemen.

——. "The Shiite Question in Saudi Arabia." September 19, 2005. https://www.crisisgroup.org/middle-east-north-africa/gulf-and-arabian-peninsula/saudi-arabia/shiite-question-saudi-arabia.

——. *A Time for Talks: Toward Dialogue Between the Gulf States and Iran*. Report No. 226, Middle East and North Africa, August 24, 2021. https://www.crisisgroup.org/middle-east-north-africa/gulf-and-arabian-peninsula/226-time-talks-toward-dialogue-between-gulf-arab-states-and-iran.

Israel Defense Forces Editorial Team. "Brave, Fierce, and Strong: Meet the First Women to Guard in Nablus." August 3, 2015. https://www.idf.il/en/mini-sites/palestinian-terrorism/brave-fierce-and-strong-meet-the-first-women-to-guard-in-nablus/.

Israel Gulf Report. "Israel's Fluence Foresees Wastewater Solutions for the UAE and Region." December 23, 2020. https://www.israelgulfreport.com/post/israel-s-fluence-foresees-wastewater-solutions-for-the-uae-and-region.

Israel Ministry of Foreign Affairs. "Israel-Oman Agree to Open Trade Offices." January 28, 1996. https://www.mfa.gov.il/mfa/foreignpolicy/peace/guide/pages/israel-%20oman%20agree%20to%20open%20trade%20offices.aspx.

Israel National Cyber Directorate. "The First Regional Cyber Summit: Israel, Morocco, Bahrain, and the United Arab Emirates Gather in a First of Its Kind Meeting." December 14, 2022. https://www.gov.il/en/departments/news/meeting_union.

Israel21c Staff. "Abu Dhabi to Sign Deal with Israeli Satellite Service." *Israel 21c*, February 25, 2009. https://www.israel21c.org/abu-dhabi-to-sign-deal-with-israeli-satellite-service.

——. UAE Peace Breathes New Life Into Israeli Diamond Industry." October 11, 2020. YouTube video, 2:47. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=y9u-B11VoR4.

Jalal, Ibrahim. "UAE May Have Withdrawn from Yemen but Its Influence Remains Strong." Middle East Institute, February 25, 2020. https://www.mei.edu/publications/uae-may-have-withdrawn-yemen-its-influence-remains-strong.

Jewish Institute for National Security of America. "Israel Officially Moves to CENTCOM." September 2, 2021. https://jinsa.org/jinsa_report/israel-officially-moves-to-centcom/.

Jewish National Fund USA. "Israel Cast Episode 102: Rabbi Levi Duchman, Rabbi of the UAE." January 22, 2021. https://www.jnf.org/menu-3/news-media/israelcast/rabbi-levi-duchman.

Jewish UAE. "About US." Accessed July 22, 2023. https://www.jewishuae.com/templates/articlecco_cdo/aid/4922797/jewish/About-Us.htm.

Jones, Clive. "Israel and the Gulf States: Regimes, rivalry, and regional security." In *Israel in a Turbulent Region: Security and Foreign Policy*, ed. Tore T. Peterson. New York: Routledge, 2020.

——. "The Writing on the Wall: Israel, the Security Barrier and the Future of Zionism." *Mediterranean Politics* 14, no. 1 (March 2009): 3–20. https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/13629390902747335.

Jones, Clive, and and Yoel Guzansky. *Fraternal Enemies*. London: Hurst, 2019.

Jones, Toby. "Time to Disband the Bahrain-Based U.S. Fifth Fleet." *Atlantic*, June 10, 2011. https://www.theatlantic.com/international/archive/2011/06/time-to-disband-the-bahrain-based-us-fifth-fleet/240243/.

Kay, Linda. "Critical National Infrastructure Authority (CNIA), UAE Home Land Security Will Be at IDEX 2009." *Defense World*, February 20, 2009.

https://www.defenseworld.net/2009/05/20/critical-national-infrastructure-authoritycnia-uae-home-land-security-will-be-at-idex-2009.html.

Khalidi, Rashid. *The Iron Cage*. Boston: Beacon Press, 2006.

——. *Palestinian Identity: The Construction of Modern National Consciousness*. New York: Columbia University Press, 1997.

——. "What's Wrong with Peace?" *Mada Masr*, August 26, 2020. https://www.madamasr.com/en/2020/08/26/opinion/u/whats-wrong-with-peace/.

Khomeini, Ayatollah Ruhollah. *Governance of the Jurist: Velayat-e-Faqeeh*. London: Manor House Books, 1979.

Kimball, Daryl G. "Senate Failure to Block JCPOA Is a Victory for Nuclear Nonproliferation." Press release, Arms Control Association, September 10, 2015. https://www.armscontrol.org/pressroom/2015-09/senate-failure-block-jcpoa-victory-nuclear-nonproliferation.

——. "U.S. Reinterprets MTCR Rules." *Arms Control Today*, September 2020. https://www.armscontrol.org/act/2020-09/news/us-reinterprets-mtcr-rules.

Kincheloe, Joe, and Shirley R. Steinberg, eds. *The Miseducation of the West: How Schools and the Media Distort Our Understanding of the Islamic World*. Westport, CT: Greenwood, 2004.

King Hamad Centre for Peaceful Coexistence. "Message from Chairman of Board of Trustees." 2019. https://kinghamadglobalcentre.com/message-for-chairman/.

Koplewitz, ADI. "Palestinian Support for a One-State Solution Is Highest Since Last Year's Violence." Media Line, July 4, 2022. https://themedialine.org/by-region/palestinian-support-for-a-one-state-solution-is-highest-since-last-years-violence/.

Kushner, Jared. *Breaking History*. New York: Harper Collins, 2022.

LaCroix, Stephane. "Saudi Islamists and the Potential for Protest." *Foreign Policy*, June 2, 2011. https://foreignpolicy.com/2011/06/02/saudi-islamists-and-the-potential-for-protest/.

Lesch, David W., and Mark L. Haas. *The Middle East and the United States: History, Politics, and Ideologies*. New York: Routledge, 2019.

Levy, Daniel. "Is It Good for the Jews." *American Prospect*, June 18, 2006. https://prospect.org/features/good-jews/.

Lorimer, J. G. *Gazetteer of the Persian Gulf (1915) India Office Records*. London. IOR/L/PS/20 C91/1, 653.

Lozano, Maria, and John Pontifex. "Bahrain: King to Play Key Role as New Cathedral Opens in Arabia." Aid to the Church in Need, December 8, 2021.

https://acnuk.org/news/bahrain-king-to-play-key-role-as-new-cathedral-opens-in-arabia/.

Mabon, Simon. "Israel-Palestine Conflict: Why Gulf Leaders Are Staying Quiet—for Now." *Conversation*, May 17, 2021. https://theconversation.com/israel-palestine-conflict-why-gulf-leaders-are-staying-quiet-for-now-160946.

Marczack, Bill, and John Scott-Railton. "The Million Dollar Dissident: NSO Group's iPhone Zero-Days Used Against a UAE Human Rights Defender." *Citizen Lab*, August 24, 2016. https://citizenlab.ca/2016/08/million-dollar-dissident-iphone-zero-day-nso-group-uae/.

Mattar, Philip. "The PLO and the Gulf Crisis." *Middle East Journal* 48, no. 1 (1994): 31–36.

Mayer, Thomas. "Arab Unity of Action and the Question of Palestine." *Middle Eastern Studies* 22, no. 3 (1986): 331–49.

Mccaskill, Nolan D. "Trump Tells Wisconsin: Victory Was a Surprise." *Politico*, December 13, 2016. https://www.politico.com/story/2016/12/donald-trump-wisconsin-232605.

Media Line. "Palestinian Support for a One-State Solution Is Highest Since Last Year's Violence," July 4, 2022. https://themedialine.org/by-region/palestinian-support-for-a-one-state-solution-is-highest-since-last-years-violence/.

——. "Twitter in Saudi Arabia." Media Line, January 2, 2021. https://themedialine.org/mideast-mindset/twitter-in-saudi-arabia/.

——. "UAE National Archives, Israel's National Library Sign Agreement." Media Line, November 4, 2022. https://themedialine.org/headlines/uae-national-archives-israels-national-library-sign-agreement/.

Meir-Glitzenstein, Esther. "Turning Points in the Historiography of Jewish Immigration from Arab Countries to Israel." *Israel Studies* 23, no. 3 (2018): 114–22.

Mekelberg, Yossi. "Gaza Deaths May End Israel's New Gulf Friendships." Royal Institute for International Affairs (Chatham House), May 13, 2021. https://www.chathamhouse.org/2021/05/gaza-deaths-may-end-israels-new-gulf-friendships.

MENA Rights Group. "Human Rights Defender and UAE94 Member Hamad Al Shamsi Labelled as Terrorist by UAE Authorities." January 3, 2022. https://menarights.org/en/case/hamad-al-shamsi.

Metzer, Jacob. "Jewish Immigration to Palestine in the Long 1920s: An Exploratory Examination." *Journal of Israeli History* 27, no. 2 (2008).

Miller, Jade. "The Dubai Ports Controversy: An Uproar Heard Round the World." University of Southern California Center of Public Diplomacy, March, 2006. https://uscpublicdiplomacy.org/pdin_monitor_article/dubai-ports-controversy-uproar-heard-round-world.

Mobley, Richard. "The Tunbs and Abu Musa Islands: Britain's Perspective." *Middle East Journal* 57, no. 4 (2003).

Morris, Benny. *Righteous Victims: A History of the Zionist-Arab Conflict, 1881–2001*. New York: Vintage Books, 2001.

Mundy, Sam. "Gulf States and Israel Should Form a Rapid Response Force." *Foreign Policy*, September 5, 2022. https://foreignpolicy.com/2022/09/05/israel-gcc-uae-gulf-arab-states-iran-rapid-response-force-military-defense-nato-security/.

Murphy, Caryle. "Post-Sept 11 Saudi Arabia Modernizing, Slowly." NPR, September 7, 2011. https://www.npr.org/2011/09/07/140247658/post-sept-11-saudi-arabia-modernizing-slowly.

Nakib, Mai Al-. "'The People Are Missing': Palestinians in Kuwait." *Deleuze Studies* 8, no. 1 (2014): 23–44.

Nassar, Tamara. "Bahrain King Cozies Up to Israel." *Electronic Intifada*, September 19, 2017. https://electronicintifada.net/blogs/tamara-nassar/bahrain-king-cozies-israel.

Neubauer, Sigured. "Israel: A Strategic Partner for the UAE." *Gulf State Analytics*, November 9, 2017. https://gulfstateanalytics.com/israel-strategic-partner-uae/.

Neurink, Judit. "A New Association in Bahrain Throws Bahraini Jews a Lifeline." *Judit Eurink Personal Blog*, accessed July 24, 2023. https://juditneurink.eu/a-new-association-in-the-gulf-throws-bahraini-jews-a-lifeline/.

NPR. "Leader of the Palestinian U.S. Delegation Reacts to Trump's Jerusalem Decision." December 6, 2017. https://www.npr.org/2017/12/06/568920314/leader-of-the-palestinian-u-n-delegation-reacts-to-trumps-jerusalem-decision.

Obama White House Archives. "Fact-Sheet: Sanctions Related to Iran." July 31, 2012. https://obamawhitehouse.archives.gov/the-press-office/2012/07/31/fact-sheet-sanctions-related-iran.

——. "The Historic Deal That Will Prevent Iran from Acquiring a Nuclear Weapon." Accessed July 23, 2023. https://obamawhitehouse.archives.gov/issues/foreign-policy/iran-deal.

——. "Remarks by the President at Cairo University." June 4, 2009. https://obamawhitehouse.archives.gov/the-press-office/remarks-president-cairo-university-6-04-09.

Observatory of Economic Complexity (*OEC*). "Diamonds in UAE." Accessed July 24, 2023. https://oec.world/en/profile/bilateral-product/diamonds/reporter/are.

Odhiambo, George. "Water Scarcity in the Arabian Peninsula and Socio-economic Implications." *Applied Water Science* 7 (June 21, 2016): 2479–92. https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s13201-016-0440-1.

Omari, Ghaith Al-. "Oslo's Mangled Legacy." Washington Institute for Near East Policy, March 4, 2019.

Only, James. *The Arabian Frontier of the British Raj: Merchants, Rulers, and the British in the Nineteenth Century Gulf*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2007.

Orion, Assaf and Udi Dekel. "Winds of Change: Israel Joins the US Central Command Area." Institute for National Security Studies, January 20, 2021. https://www.inss.org.il/publication/centcom/.

Palestine Economic Portal. "Foreign Aid Management in Palestine." 2022. https://www.palestineeconomy.ps/donors/en.

Palestinian BDS National Committee. "Norway's Capital Oslo Is Banning Israeli Settlement Goods and Services." BDS Movement, October 28, 2019. https://bdsmovement.net/news/norways-capital-oslo-banning-israeli-settlement-goods-and-services.

——."Palestinians Write to ICRC: Conference in Partnership with Hebrew University Undermines Palestinian Human Rights." BDS Movement, November 5, 2018. https://bdsmovement.net/news/palestinians-write-icrc-conference-partnership-hebrew-university-undermines-palestinian-human.

Pappe, Ilan. "Al-Fulistineyoon Al-Mansiyoon, Hikayat Arab 1948." YouTube video, 1:54:28, November 30, 2021. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=v4pEiPRK9ak.

——. "The 1948 Ethnic Cleansing of Palestine." *Journal of Palestine Studies* 36, no. 1 (2006): 6–20.

——. "Revisiting 1967: The False Paradigm of Peace, Partition and Parity." *Settler Colonial Studies* 3, no. 3–4 (2013): 341–51.

Pardo, Eldad, and David Byer. "When Peace Goes to School: The Emirati Curriculum 2016- 2021." Institute for Monitoring Peace and Tolerance in School Education, January 20, 2022. https://www.impact-se.org/wp-content/uploads/When-Peace-Goes-to-School_The-Emirati-Curriculum-2016%E2%80%9321.pdf#page=6.

Peace Now. "Return of the Outpost Method." July 22, 2019. https://peacenow.org.il/en/return-of-the-outpost-method.

Pearson, James. "Record-Breaking: Up to 14 Daily Flights from Israel to the UAE." *Simple Flying*, November 23, 2021. https://simpleflying.com/uae-israel-record-flights/.

Pluristem Therapeutics. "Pluristem and Abu Dhabi Stem Cells Center Sign MOU to Collaborate in the Development of Cell Therapies and Regenerative Medicines for the Treatment of Severe Diseases Including Covid-19." *Global News Wire*, August 17, 2020. https://www.globenewswire.com/en/news-release/2020/08/17/2079006/11974/en/Pluristem-and-Abu-Dhabi-Stem-Cells-Center-Sign-MOU-to-Collaborate-in-the-Development-of-Cell-Therapies-and-Regenerative-Medicines-for-the-Treatment-of-Severe-Diseases-Including-COV.html.

Podeh, Elie. "The Drift Towards Neutrality: Egyptian Foreign Policy During the Early Nasserist Era, 1952–55." *Middle Eastern Studies* 32, no. 1 (1996): 159–78.

Pollack, Kenneth M. "Sizing up Little Sparta: Understanding UAE Military Effectiveness." American Enterprise Institute, October 27, 2020. https://www.aei.org/research-products/report/sizing-up-little-sparta-understanding-uae-military-effectiveness/.

Pollock, David. "Arab Public Opinion on Arab-Israeli Normalization and Abraham Accords." Washington Institute for Near East Policy, July 15, 2022. https://www.washingtoninstitute.org/policy-analysis/arab-public-opinion-arab-israeli-normalization-and-abraham-accords.

Pollock, David, and Shaina Katz. "Half of Emiratis Approve Domestic Policies, but Just 20% Want Israeli Ties." Washington Institute for Near East Policy, July 20, 2020, https://www.washingtoninstitute.org/policy-analysis/half-emiratis-approve-domestic-policies-just-20-want-israeli-ties.

Prados, Alfred, and and Christopher Blanchard. "Saudi Arabia: Terrorist Financing Issues." Congressional Research Service, December 8, 2004. https://www.hsdl.org/?view&did=450759.

Progressive Israel Network. "Progressive Israel Network Groups Oppose Codification of IHRA Working Definition of Antisemitism, Citing Strong Potential for Misuse." January 12, 2021. https://www.progressiveisraelnetwork.org/progressive-israel-network-groups-oppose-codification-of-ihra-working-definition-of-antisemitism-citing-strong-potential-for-misuse/.

Public Library of US Diplomacy. "A Long Hot Summer for UAE-Saudi Relations." WikiLeaks, October 15, 2009. https://wikileaks.org/plusd/cables/09ABUDHABI981_a.html.

——. "Acting A/S Feltman, Discussions with MFA Focus on Lebanon, Engagement with Syria, Israel's Relations with the Gulf States." WikiLeaks, March 12, 2009. http://wikileaks.org/plusd/cables/09TELAVIV605_a.html.

——. "Israel's Relations with the Gulf States Focus on Iran, Perception of Israeli Influence in Washington." WikiLeaks, March 19, 2009. https://wikileaks.org/plusd/cables/09TELAVIV654_a.html.

Rabi, Uzi. "Qatar's Relations with Israel: Challenging Arab and Gulf Norms." *Middle East Journal* 63, no. 3 (2009): 443–59.

Ravi, Meera. "Region's Oldest Synagogue Represents New Hope for Bahrain's Jews." *Majalla*, April 2, 2021. https://eng.majalla.com/node/128181/politicsregion%E2%80%99s-oldest-synagogue-represents-new-hope-bahrain%E2%80%99s-jews.

Ravid, Barak. "Exclusive: The Secret Drone Deal That Created an Israel-UAE Rift." *Axios*, February 11, 2019. https://www.axios.com/secret-drone-deal-israel-uae-iran-netanyahu-mbz-48caa235-1ed8-45fe-b691-b9bd41223ebb.html.

——. "Israel Offers to Help UAE Bolster Defenses After Houthi Attacks." *Axios*, February 2, 2022. https://www.axios.com/israel-uae-bolster-defenses-houthi-attacks-yemen-dbb1eae6-71fc-4a14-8fac-fe4046e43b61.html.

——. "Trump Blasts Netanyahu for Disloyalty: F**k Him." *Axios*, December 10, 2021. https://www.axios.com/trump-netanyahu-disloyalty-fuck-him-276ac6cc-3f70-4fba-b315-c82a59603e67.html.

——. "Trump's Big Deal Part I: May Your House Be Destroyed." Interview. *Axios,* December 13, 2021. Podcast. https://www.axios.com/how-it-happened-podcast-trump-netanyahu-59479101-dad6-4e3b-8461-a7e87ada6d73.html.

——. "Trump's Big Deal Part II: From Secret Alliance to the Abraham Accords." *Axios*, December 13, 2021. Podcast. https://www.axios.com/how-it-happened-podcast-abraham-accords-cea2e0c2-0661-49e6-a9ba-6f40602a050b.html.

——. *Trump's Peace: The Abraham Accords and the Reshaping of the Middle East.* Independently published, 2023.

——. "UAE Suspends Planned Summit to Protest Netanyahu's Electioneering." *Axios*, March 18, 2021. https://www.axios.com/uae-suspends-summit-netanyahu-electioneering-protest-306a37b6-56f6-451e-a2b3-fa0b2881bbee.html.

Reinl, James. "Obama aide: How We Got It Wrong in Yemen." *TRT World Magazine*, February 14, 2019. https://www.trtworld.com/magazine/obama-aide-how-we-got-it-wrong-in-yemen-24162.

Relief Web. "OPT: GCC Earmarks $1.6 Billion for Reconstruction of Gaza." March 2, 2009. https://reliefweb.int/report/occupied-palestinian-territory/opt-gcc-earmarks-16-bn-reconstruction-gaza.

Riedel, Bruce. "How the 1967 War Dramatically Reoriented Saudi Arabia's Foreign Policy." *Brookings* (blog), May 30, 2017. https://www.brookings.edu/blog/markaz/2017/05/30/how-the-1967-war-dramatically-re-oriented-saudi-arabias-foreign-policy/.

——. "9/11 and Iraq: The Making of a Tragedy." *Brookings* (blog), September 17, 2021. https://www.brookings.edu/blog/order-from-chaos/2021/09/17/9-11-and-iraq-the-making-of-a-tragedy/.

Rogin, Josh. "Why Did the Bahraini Crown Prince Snub the USA?" *Foreign Policy*, December 8, 2012. https://foreignpolicy.com/2012/12/08/why-did-the-bahraini-crown-prince-snub-the-usa/.

Rothschild Archive. "Walter Rothschild and the Balfour Declaration." London: Rothschild & Sons, 2002–2023. https://www.rothschildarchive.org/family/family_interests/walter_rothschild_and_the_balfour_declaration.

Rouleau, Eric. "Palestinian Diaspora of the Gulf." MERIP, May/June 1985. https://merip.org/1985/05/the-palestinian-diaspora-of-the-gulf/.

Said, Edward. "The Morning After." *London Review of Books* 15, no. 20 (October 21, 1993). https://www.lrb.co.uk/the-paper/v15/n20/edward-said/the-morning-after.

Saif, Salem. "When Consultants Rein." *Jacobin*, May 9 2016, https://jacobin.com/2016/05/saudi-arabia-aramco-salman-mckinsey-privatization/.

Sales, Ben. "Bahrain Signed a Treaty with Israel. Now It Wants to Make Friends with American Jews." *Jewish Exponent*, October 6, 2021. https://www.jewishexponent.com/2021/10/06/bahrain-signed-a-treaty-with-israel-now-it-wants-to-make-friends-with-american-jews/.

Salisbury, Peter. "Risk Perception and Appetite in UAE Foreign and National Security Policy." Chatham House, July 2020. https://www.chathamhouse.org/sites/default/files/2020-07-01-risk-in-uae-salisbury.pdf.

Saudi Gazette. "Israel Opens Embassy in UAE, Drawing US Applause." June 29, 2021. https://www.saudigazette.com.sa/article/608281.

Sawafta, Ali. "Palestinians Congratulate Biden, Indicate End to Boycott of U.S." Reuters, November 8, 2020. https://www.reuters.com/article/uk-usa-election-palestinians-idUKKBN27O0AF.

Sayigh, Yezid. "Reconstructing the Paradox: The Arab Nationalist Movement, Armed Struggle, and Palestine, 1951–1966." *Middle East Journal* 45, no. 4 (1991): 608–29.

Schenker, David. "Getting to an Israeli-Saudi Deal on Tiran and Sanafir." Washington Institute for Near East Policy, July 7, 2022. https://www.washingtoninstitute.org/policy-analysis/getting-israeli-saudi-deal-tiran-and-sanafir.

Schulze, Kristen. *The Arab-Israeli Conflict*. London: Routledge, 2008.

Shambrook, Peter "Contradictory Promises." Balfour Project, August 23, 2014. https://balfourproject.org/contradictory-promises/#_ftn5.

Sharif, Osama Al. "What Are Jordan's Options If Israel Annexes West Bank?" *Al Monitor*, May 25, 2020. https://www.al-monitor.com/originals/2020/05/jordan-king-threats-peace-treaty-israel-annexation-plans.html#ixzz7NEZhMlis.

Sheba Global. "Israel and UAE Medical Collaboration: Sheba Physicians Will Travel to Dubai, Treat Security Personnel and Train Medical Personnel." October 22, 2021. https://www.shebaonline.org/israel-and-uae-medical-collaboration-continue-as-sheba-physicians-will-travel-to-the-uae-treat-security-personnel-and-train-medical-personnel/.

Sheff, Marcus. "The UAE Education System Is Pushing for Peace and Religious Tolerance. The Rest of the Region Should Follow Suit." Atlantic Council, March 2, 2022. https://www.atlanticcouncil.org/blogs/menasource/the-uae-education-system-is-pushing-for-peace-and-religious-tolerance-the-rest-of-the-region-should-follow-suit/.

Shlaim, Avi. "The Balfour Declaration and Its Consequences." *Verso Books Blogs*, November 1, 2017. https://www.versobooks.com/blogs/3464-the-balfour-declaration-and-its-consequences.

——. *The Iron Wall: Israel and the Arab World*. New York: Norton, 2000.

——. "The Two-State Solution: Illusion and Reality." *Palestine-Israel Journal of Politics, Economics, and Culture* 26, no. 3 (2021).

Siniver, Asaf, ed. *The October 1973 War: Politics, Diplomacy, Legacy*. London: Hurst, 2013.

Stalinksy, Steven. "Palestinian Foreign Aid: Saudi Financial Aid." Jewish Virtual Library, July 2003. https://www.jewishvirtuallibrary.org/saudi-financial-aid-to-the-palestinian-authority.

Steinberg, Guido. "The Axis of Resistance: Iran's Expansion in the Middle East Is Hitting a Wall." German Institute of International and Security Affairs, August 12, 2021. https://www.swp-berlin.org/en/publications/irans-expansion-in-the-middle-east-is-hitting-a-wall#hd-d19467e644.

Tatarsky, Aviv. "The Normalization with the Emirates: Not a Peace Agreement, but a Show of Strength." Regional Thinking Forum, August 20, 2020. https://www.regthink.org/uae-accords-aviv/.

TBN Israel. "The Abraham Accords: How Israel Began Peace with the Middle East." November 6, 2021. YouTube video, Trinity Broadcasting Network Israel, 11:40. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wBwJww9zFRQ&t=623s.

——. "The Abraham Accords: The Beginning of Peace in the Middle East (Episode One)." YouTube video, Trinity Broadcasting Network Israel, November 6, 2021. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ubGRvpvBe7w&t=2s.

Trump White House Archives. "Joint Statement of the United States, the State of Israel, and the United Arab Emirates." August 13, 2020. https://trumpwhitehouse.archives.gov/briefings-statements/joint-statement-united-states-state-israel-united-arab-emirates/.

——. "President Trump Delivers Remarks at the Arab Islamic Summit." May 21, 2017. https://trumpwhitehouse.archives.gov/articles/president-trump-delivers-remarks-arab-islamic-american-summit/.

——. "Remarks by President Trump, Prime Minister Netanyahu, Minister Bin Zayed, and Minister Al Zayani at the Abraham Accords Signing Ceremony." September 15, 2020. https://trumpwhitehouse.archives.gov/briefings-statements/remarks-president-trump-prime-minister-netanyahu-minister-bin-zayed-minister-al-zayani-abraham-accords-signing-ceremony/.

——. "Statement by President Trump on Jerusalem." December 6, 2017. https://trumpwhitehouse.archives.gov/briefings-statements/statement-president-trump-jerusalem/.

Tunaiji, Saeed Al-. "Rasa'il fi-alwa'ee: Makhatir al-tatbi' ala al-Imarat w-al kathiyya al filistiniyya." *Al-rabita al-emiratiyya li-moqawamat al-tatbee*, September 23, 2020. https://uae4palestine.com/posts/27.

Ulrichsen, Kristian Coates. "Pegasus as a Case Study of Evolving Ties Between the UAE and Israel." *Gulf State Analytics*, June 9, 2022. https://gulfstateanalytics.com/pegasus-as-a-case-study-of-evolving-ties-between-the-united-arab-emirates-and-israel/.

——. *The United Arab Emirates: Power, Politics, and Policy-Making*. London: Hurst, 2017.

United Arab Emirates Cabinet. "UAE Cabinet Approves National Tolerance Program." June 9, 2016. https://uaecabinet.ae/en/details/news/uae-cabinet-approves-national-tolerance-program.

United Arab Emirates Department of Culture and Tourism. "Kosher Food—Hotel Establishments." Circular No. 65/2020, September 8, 2020. https://tcaabudhabi.ae/DataFolder//Circulars/Circular%2065_Kosher%20food%20-%20Hotel%20Establishments.pdf.

United Arab Emirates Government Portal. "Year of Tolerance." Accessed July 23, 2023. https://u.ae/en/about-the-uae/culture/tolerance/tolerance-initiatives.

United Arab Emirates Government Portal. "The UAE's Fourth Industrial Revolution Strategy." November 24, 2022. https://u.ae/en/about-the-uae/strategies-initiatives-and-awards/strategies-plans-and-visions/government-services-and-digital-transformation/the-uae-strategy-for-the-fourth-industrial-revolution#.

United Arab Emirates, International Trade Administration. "United Arab Emirates—Country Commercial Guide." July 26, 2022. https://www.trade.gov/knowledge-product/united-arab-emirates-market-overview.

United Arab Emirates, Ministry of Foreign Affairs and International Cooperation. "UAE announces $10 Billion Fund for Investments in Israel." March 14, 2021. https://www.mofaic.gov.ae/en/missions/tel-aviv/media-hub/embassy-news/uae-announces-$10-billion-fund-for-investments-in-israel.

United Nations. "Israel's Settlements Have No Legal Validity, Constitute Flagrant Violation of International Law, Security Council Reaffirms." *United Nations Meetings Coverage and Press Releases*, December 23, 2016. https://www.un.org/press/en/2016/sc12657.doc.htm.

——. "United Nations General Assembly Resolution 181." Adopted November 29, 1947. https://undocs.org/Home/Mobile?FinalSymbol=A%2FRES%2F181(II)&Language=E&DeviceType=Desktop&LangRequested=False.

——. "United Nations Security Council Resolution 242." Adopted November 22, 1967 (S/RES/242).

United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF). "Fifteen Years of the Blockade of the Gaza Strip: Brief by Stephane Dujarric, Spokesman for the Secretary-General." July 3, 2022. https://www.unicef.org/mena/press-releases/fifteen-years-blockade-gaza-strip#.

United Nations Digital Library. "Annual Report of the Director of the UNRWA (1 July 1959–30 June 1960)." https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/715794?ln=en.

——. "Report of the Director of the United Nations Relief and Works Agency (1 July 1967–30 June 1968)." https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/725068?ln=en.

United Nations News. "Living Conditions in Gaza More and More Wretched Over Past Decade, UN Finds," July 11 2017, https://news.un.org/en/story/2017/07/561302-living-conditions-gaza-more-and-more-wretched-over-past-decade-un-finds.

United Nations Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights. "UN Experts Alarmed by Rise in Settler Violence in Occupied Palestinian Territory." November 10, 2021. https://www.ohchr.org/en/press-releases/2021/11/un-experts-alarmed-rise-settler-violence-occupied-palestinian-territory.

United Nations Population Fund. "Checkpoints Compound the Risks of Childbirth for Palestinian Women." May 15, 2007. https://www.unfpa.org/news/checkpoints-compound-risks-childbirth-palestinian-women#.

United States Department of State, Office of the Historian. "Oil Embargo: 1973–1974." https://history.state.gov/milestones/1969-1976/oil-embargo.

United States Department of State, Office of the Spokesperson. "U.S. Relations with Israel." January 30, 2023. https://www.state.gov/u-s-relations-with-israel-2/.

United States Institute of Peace. "Timeline of Diplomacy Under Biden." April 2, 2021. https://iranprimer.usip.org/blog/2021/apr/02/new-talks-timeline-diplomacy-under-biden.

United States Mission to International Organizations in Geneva. "The United States Is Deeply Concerned by Bahraini Court Decision to Dissolve the Opposition Al Wefaq Political." July 18, 2016. https://geneva.usmission.gov/2016/07/18/the-united-states-is-deeply-concerned-by-bahraini-court-decision-to-dissolve-the-opposition-al-wefaq-political-society/.

Vatican Radio. "Bahrain King Presents Pope with Model of Largest Church in the Arabian Peninsula." *Vatican Radio Archivo*, May 20, 2014. http://www.archivioradiovaticana.va/storico/2014/05/20/bahrain_king_presents_pope_with_model_of_largest_church_in_the_arabian/in2-800781.

Verete, Mayir. "The Balfour Declaration and Its Makers," *Middle Eastern Studies* 6, no. 1 (1970): 48–76.

Von Braun, Joachim, and Ruth Meinzen-Dick. "Land Grabbing by Foreign Investors in Developing Countries: Risks and Opportunities." International Food Policy Research Institute, 2009. https://www.ifpri.org/publication/land-grabbing-foreign-investors-developing-countries.

Waage, Hilde. "Postscript to Oslo: The Mystery of Norway's Missing Files." *Journal of Palestine Studies* 38, no. 1 (2008): 54–65.

Waxberger, Katie. "The Agreement with the Emirates: Israel Strengthens the authoritarian Regimes in the Middle East." Regional Thinking Forum, August 17, 2020. https://www.regthink.org/accord-with-uae/.

Wehrey, Frederic. "Gulf Participation in the Anti-Islamic State Coalition: Limitations and Costs." Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, September 23, 2014. https://carnegie-mec.org/diwan/56710?lang=en.

Whitaker, Brian. "Selective Memri." *Guardian*, August 12, 2002. https://www.theguardian.com/world/2002/aug/12/worlddispatch.brianwhitaker.

WikiLeaks, "Bahraini Crown Prince's July 28 Meeting with CENTCOM Commander Petraeus, Special Envoy Mitchel, and NEA Acting Assistant Secretary Feltman," *Telegraph*, February 18, 2011, https://www.telegraph.co.uk/news/wikileaks-files/bahrain-wikileaks-cables/8334589/bahraini-crown-princes-july-28-meeting-with-centcom-commander-petraeus-special-envoy-mitchell-and-nea-acting-assistant-secretary-feltman.html.

——. "King Fahad Peace Initiative 1982." *Wikileaks: The Saudi Cables*. https://wikileaks.org/saudi-cables/docs/591cd409d616694ef9c72048aa91fce9_King%20Fahad%20peace%20Initiative%201982.doc.

Yesh Din. "Data Sheet, December 2019: Law Enforcement on Israeli Civilians in the West Bank." January 30, 2020. https://www.yesh-din.org/en/data-sheet-december-2019-law-enforcement-on-israeli-civilians-in-the-west-bank/.

Yossef, Amr. "Upgrading Iran's Military Doctrine: An Offensive Forward Defence." Middle East Institute, December 10, 2019. https://www.mei.edu/publications/upgrading-irans-military-doctrine-offensive-forward-defense.

Zahlan, Rosemarie Said. *Palestine and the Gulf States: The Presence at the Table*. New York: Routledge, 2009.

Zain, Asma Ali. "Israeli Chief Rabbi Gives His Blessing to Institutions in UAE, Marking New Era of Religious Jewish Life in Dubai and Beyond." Jewish Telegraphic Agency, December 21, 2020. https://www.jta.org/2020/12/21/global/israeli-chief-rabbi-gives-his-blessing-to-institutions-in-uae-marking-new-era-of-religious-jewish-life-in-dubai-and-beyond.

Zak, Emily. "Pinkwashing Settler Colonialism: How Settler-Colonial States Co-opt Gay Rights to Legitimize Occupation." *Briar Patch*, June 21, 2016. https://briarpatchmagazine.com/articles/view/pinkwashing-settler-colonialism.

Zaken, Danny. "Israel to Begin Exporting Gas to Egypt Via Jordan." *Globes*, February 16, 2022. https://en.globes.co.il/en/article-israel-to-begin-exporting-gas-to-egypt-via-jordan-1001402590.

Zilber, Neri. "Gulf Cyber Cooperation with Israel: Balancing Threats and Rights." Washington Institute for Near East Policy, January 17, 2019. https://www.washingtoninstitute.org/policy-analysis/gulf-cyber-cooperation-israel-balancing-threats-and-rights.

——. "In Rejecting Iran Nuclear Deal, Israeli Rivals Are of One Mind." *New Lines Magazine*, September 7, 2022. https://newlinesmag.com/reportage/in-rejecting-iran-nuclear-deal-israeli-rivals-are-of-one-mind/.

Zweiri, Mahjoob, and Farah Al Qawasmi, eds. *Contemporary Qatar: Examining State and Society*. Singapore: Springer Nature, 2021.

INDEX

Abbas, Mahmoud, 81–83, 86, 99, 200
Abraham Accords: areas of cooperation, 111–27, 145–48; evolution and impact, 3–5, 107–12, 127–129, 212, 215, 226; negotiations in lead-up to, 100, 103; perceptions of and responses to, 185–207, 209, 216, 222–23; signing ceremony, vii–viii, 105–6; justifications, 8, 106, 149, 152, 162, 177, 193; U.S. efforts at promotion and expansion, 6, 8, 88, 93–94, 140, 143–48, 211–16
Abrahamic Family House, 173
Abu Dhabi. *See* United Arab Emirates
Abu Dhabi Executive Council, 47
Advanced Integrated Systems (AIS), 46–47
Advanced Technological Solutions (AIT), 46–47
Air defense systems, 141, 146–47
Asia Global Technologies International (AGT), 46–47
Ahmadinejad, Mahmoud, 40
annexation, 71, 88–89, 96, 98–106, 123, 193, 199–200, 205
antisemitism, 11, 152–53, 162–63, 179–80
apartheid, 48, 132, 168, 181–82, 201, 224
Arab Higher Committee, 15
Arab-Israeli conflict: First Arab-Israeli War (1948), 18–19; Second Arab-Israeli War (1956), 19–21; Third Arab-Israeli War (1967), 21–23; Fourth Arab-Israeli War (1973), 23–25; Lebanon War (1982), 28; Lebanon War (2006), 7, 40–41
Arab League, 3, 15, 18, 20, 25, 29, 37–38, 99, 105, 143, 202, 220
Arab League resolutions, 38, 99, 105, 202
Arab Peace Initiative, 3, 36–37, 54, 128, 143, 187–88, 202, 216
Arab Spring, 1, 3–4, 7–9, 43, 57, 59–63, 106, 142, 150–51, 156, 160, 165, 186, 189, 221
Arafat, Yasser, 29–30
Aramco attacks (September 2019), 95

arms sales, 23, 26–27, 32, 62–66, 81–82, 106, 140–42, 147, 149, 151, 158, 201, 206, 213, 216, 218
Austin, Lloyd, 141

Bahrain: domestic opposition, 9, 58, 60–61, 64, 185–209, 236; generational shift in leadership, 43–44, 52–55; Jewish minority in, 7, 16–18; policies toward the Palestinians, 2, 14, 19; relations with Israel vii-ix, 3–5, 8, 36, 92, 94, 105–6, 109, 112–13, 121–28, 131–34, 140, 142, 144–49, 169, 201, 223; relations with the United States, 27, 62, 97, 99; tolerance narrative, 149–68, 174, 177, 179–80
Balfour Declaration, 11–12
Begin, Menachem, 24, 232
Beinart, Peter, 165–66
Ben Gurion airport, 81, 103–4, 143
Ben Gurion, David, 14, 18, 215
Ben Gvir, Itamar, 215
Bennett, Naftali, 133, 137, 140, 142, 167
Berkowitz, Avi, 76, 82, 98, 102–6
Biden, Joe, 6, 9–10, 108, 112, 128, 135–36, 141, 143–44, 165, 202, 212–19
Blinken, Antony, 143–144, 164, 212
boycott of Israel: Arab states', 11, 15, 16, 18, 52–53, 154; Arab grassroots, 191, 198, 200, 222–23; Gulf states', after the Abraham Accords, 127–28, 154; Boycott, Divestment, Sanctions movement, 74, 126–27, 186; Palestinian boycott of Trump administration: 86, 93, 97
boycott of Qatar, 80–83, 87, 136, 173, 188
Brody, Elliot, 79–80
Bush, George W., 38, 53, 85, 90

Camp David Accords, 2, 24, 36, 59, 198
Carter, Jimmy, 24, 100
China, 5–6, 63, 69, 83, 107, 120, 213–15
Clinton, Bill, 34–36, 52, 77, 79, 85
Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (Israel-UAE), 113
Comprehensive Security Integration and Prosperity Agreement (Bahrain-U.S.), 147
COVID-19 pandemic, 101, 103, 115, 188, 193, 198, 204
Critical National Infrastructure Authority (UAE), 46–47
cyber-technology, 7, 63, 145, 206

Dahiya doctrine, 41
Dermer, Ron, 76, 100, 103
Deterring Enemy Forces and Enabling National Defenses Act (United States), 146
diplomacy: Arab-Iranian: 26, 67, 137–38, 214; Arab-Israeli, 11, 28, 86, 92, 103, 144, 196, 199–200, 233; Arab regional: 3, 27, 168; U.S.-led, 5, 24, 226
Dubai, 1, 9, 26, 44, 51, 56, 90, 114–25, 133–35, 139, 149, 170, 173–78, 205
Duchman, Levi, 176–79

Eisenhower, Dwight D., 20
Erakat, Saeb, 85

Europe, 11–13, 64–65, 84, 93, 117, 135, 150, 157, 163–64, 174
European Union, 65, 157, 164
Expo2020, 117–18, 120, 139

Fahad Plan, 27–29
Falcon Eye Project (UAE), 47
Fatah (the Palestinian National Liberation Movement), 21, 30
fighter jets, 34, 63, 68, 82, 106–7,141, 213–14
Friedman, David, 72–76, 81–85, 88, 95–98, 101–2, 107, 125, 199

Gargash, Anwar, 129, 144, 200
Gaza: aid to, 37, 138; Israeli strikes on (May 2021),109, 130–34, 185, 197; jurisdiction and Israeli control over: 1–3, 31, 39–40, 59, 93–94, 97, 123, 182, 202; rise of Hamas in: 3, 40. *See also* Gaza War (2023)
Gaza War (2023), 7, 9–10, 185, 198, 218–27
Gantz, Benny, 88, 96–97, 100, 137, 142, 147
genocide: claims in Gaza, 218; Nazi Holocaust, 15, 153, 163, 179–80
Greenblatt, Jason, 73–74, 78, 82, 87, 94–95
Golan Heights, 1, 21, 24, 87–88, 89, 123
Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC), 8, 27, 50–51, 55, 61, 81, 111, 121, 127–28, 167, 187, 217
Gulf of Oman Attacks (UAE), 94, 138–39

Hamas, 3, 7, 9, 26, 39–40, 54–56, 59, 94, 109, 131, 141, 150, 200, 219–23, 226–27
Hezbollah, 26, 40–41, 59, 84
Hook, Brian, 82
Hussein, Saddam, 29, 38
Huthi rebels, 64–65, 84, 108, 136, 140–44, 220–22

International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA), 40, 51, 65
Ibn Saud. *See* Saud, Abdel Aziz bin Abdul Rahman Al-
International Court of Justice, 26, 218
International Renewable Energy Agency (IRENA), 51, 67
Intifada, 2, 27–29, 36–39, 191
Iran: accusations of interference in Gulf states, 26, 58, 60, 105, 192; proxies, 38, 40–41, 147; relations with Arab states, 27, 37–38, 45, 49–50, 54, 57, 65, 83, 87, 91–95, 111, 138–45, 155, 195, 207, 211–16; relations with the United States, 5, 70, 81, 108, 136–37, 147; rise of, 7, 40, 43
Iran's nuclear program, 3–4, 46, 136–38
Iran Nuclear Deal, 3, 64–67, 70, 74, 84, 89, 94, 135–36, 203
Iranian revolution, 25, 27, 61
Iraq: 12, 16, 21–22, 27–29, 38–39, 53, 66, 78, 91, 95, 137, 140, 146, 171, 214, 220
Iron Dome: 141, 225
Islah, al-. *See* Reform and Social Guidance Association (UAE)
Islamic State of Iraq and Syria (ISIS): 68, 91, 171–72

Israel: Arab engagement with, iix–ix, 1–11, 27–30, 37–38, 45–58, 63–68, 87, 111–66, 174–83; Arab-Israeli wars, 20–32; Arab perceptions of, 1, 49–53, 167–69, 185–88, 191–202, 210; establishment of, 11, 17–18; internal criticism of, 203–10. *See also* Netanyahu, Benjamin; United States: policies toward Israel
Israeli-Palestinian conflict, 6–7, 11, 53, 75, 87, 94, 99
Israel-Hamas War (2023). *See* Gaza War (2023)
Israel Defence Forces (IDF), 41, 46, 137, 181–82, 219
Israeli defense systems and technology: Airobotics, 139; Barak air defense system, 141, 147; David's Sling 141; Iron Dome, 141; NSO Group, 63–64, 135; SPYDER, 141; spyware; 63–64, 134–35
Israeli strikes on Gaza 2021, 109, 130–34, 185, 197

Jerusalem: claims over, 37–38, 130–31, 194; institutions in, 122, 153, 155, 163, 207; legal status, 16, 22, 30, 33, 84, 206; settlements in, 125, 163; U.S. policy regarding, 74–76, 85, 89, 96–97, 101–2, 152
Jerusalem Embassy Act, 84
Jewish Agency for Palestine, 13–14
Jewish Associations in the Gulf: Association of Gulf Jewish Communities,167; Jewish Council of the Emirates, 176; Jewish Community of the UAE, 176
Jewish exodus from Arab states, 7, 15–18
Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA), 3, 64–67, 70, 74, 84, 89, 94, 135–36, 203
Jordan: relations with Arab states, 22, 28; relations with Israel, 1–2, 21, 29–32, 99–100, 117–18, 146, 198, 204, 220–21; relations with United States, 83, 97, 146, 171
Jordan River: 224–25
Jordan Valley, 98

Khalidi, Rashid, 21, 200
Khalifa, Hamad bin Isa Al-, 54–55, 92, 106, 151, 154, 158, 161, 164, 169
Khalifa, Salman bin Hamad Al-, 52–55, 62
Khalifa, Khalid bin Ahmed Al-, 93, 189
Khalifa, Mai bint Ebrahim Al-, 168–69
Khalifa, Nasser bin Hamad Al-, 153–54, 158, 174
Khartoum Declaration, 1, 21
Khashoggi, Jamal, 136, 218
Khomeini, Ayatollah Ruhollah, 25
King Fahad Plan, 27–29
King Hamad Global Center for Peaceful Co-Existence, 161–63
Kushner, Jared, 72, 74–77, 80–84, 87–94, 98, 100–106
Kuwait, 2, 8, 13–14, 19, 22–25, 27–29, 58, 111, 127, 146, 186, 188–93, 222

land for peace, 2, 25, 48
Lapid, Yair, 133–34, 143

Lebanon, 7, 18, 26, 29, 40, 220
League of Nations, 12
Levy, Daniel, 225
Livni, Tzipi, 55
Logic Industries, 46–47

Madrid Peace Conference, 2, 29, 31, 32, 199
Maktoum, Mohammed Bin Rashid Al-, 135, 139, 173, 190
Malley, Rob, 136
Ministry of Tolerance (UAE), 173
Missile defense systems. *See* air defense systems
Modi, Narendra, 162
Morocco, 107, 142–45, 198, 258
Morsi, Mohammed, 59
Mossad, 32, 35, 56–57, 106, 140, 142
Muasher, Marwan, 225

Nader, George, 77–79
Nahyan, Khalifa bin Zayed Al-, 44, 46, 50, 116, 176
Nahyan, Mohammed bin Zayed Al-: domestic policies, 43–45, 47–50, 90, 135; relations with Arab states, 199; relations with Iran, 44–45, 78, 137; relations with Israel, 34–35, 57, 64, 91, 106, 112, 129–130, 140, 180; relations with United States, 77–79, 83, 104, 141
Nahyan, Tahnoun bin Zayed Al-, 47, 137
Nahyan, Zayed bin Sultan Al-, 21, 26, 35, 37, 43–44, 50, 90, 174, 179
Nakba. *See* First Arab-Israeli War
Nasser, Gamal Abdel, 19–20, 22
Nation-state Law (Israel), 85
National Democratic Action Society (Bahrain), 160
Negev Summit, 143
Netanyahu, Benjamin: criticisms of, 201, 203–8; domestic politics, 44, 47, 91, 125, 132–33, 185, 215; policies toward Iran, 66–67, 84, 137; policies toward the Palestinians, 40, 48, 83–89, 108–9, 200, 219, 225; relations with Arab states: 56, 61, 111–12, 126–30, 212, 216; relations with the United States, 74, 81, 95–105, 124
Nixon, Richard, 23
normalization: Arab-Israeli, 6–9, 88, 93–94, 102, 128; Bahrain-Israel, 106, 153, 185; perceptions of, 3, 187–99, 205; UAE-Israel, ix, 8, 68, 71, 91, 103; U.S. involvement in: 88, 93–94, 102, 207, 221–22; Saudi-Israel, 10, 128, 148, 212–20
NSO Group, 63–64, 135
nuclear weapon, 40, 65–66

Obama administration, 48, 62, 65–66, 76, 151, 156
Obama, Barak, 50, 53, 62–63, 65–67, 74–77, 80–85, 124, 136, 156, 158
October 7 attacks, 9, 218, 225
oil embargo, 24, 220
Oman: as a regional mediator, 137, 214; civil society, 191, 128, policies toward Israel, viii, 2, 8, 32–33, 51, 86, 111, 114, 128; policies toward Iran and Arab states, 7, 47, 49, 97, 99, 113, 187

Oslo Accords / Oslo Peace Process, 2, 7, 30–36, 73, 126
Oslo II (Taba Agreement), 30, 33
Otaiba, Yousef al-, 8, 50, 89–91, 101–4, 107, 174, 176

Palestinian Authority, 6, 18, 30, 38–40, 81, 168, 202, 208, 216, 220, 224, 226
Palestinian boycott of Trump administration, 86, 93, 97
Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO), 20–22, 25, 28–30, 224
Palestinian leadership, 86, 93, 105, 211
Palestinian territories, 20, 39–40, 104, 118, 150, 185, 200, 215, 219
Palestinians: Arab aid to, 37, 44, 138; Arab grassroots support for, 2, 14, 16, 143, 190, 194; Britain's policies toward, 15, 18; conflict with Israel, 7–10, 48, 98, 120, 124, 130–33, 168, 182, 218, 224–26; diplomacy with Israel, 28, 31–34; impact of Arab normalization, viii, 5–8, 25, 109, 134; in Kuwait, 19, 29; leadership dynamics, 36, 93, 105, 211, 226; mobilization, 13–14; Netanyahu policies toward, 61, 48, 87, 129; United States' policies toward, 6, 71–73, 83, 86–92, 94, 97, 100, 144, 219; views on Abraham Accords, 105, 185, 196–211. *See also* United Nations resolutions
Palestinian refugees, 3, 19, 27, 29–30, 73
Palestinian state, 2–3, 9–10, 15, 28, 30–31, 38, 40, 89, 97–98, 217
Pan-Arab, 19, 132, 190, 201, 212, 215
Pappe, Ilan, 31, 168, 231
Patriot Missile Defense Systems. *See* air defense systems
Peace to Prosperity Workshop, 202, 254
peace for peace, 48
Pegasus spyware, 63, 134
Peel Commission, 14
Peninsula Shield Forces, 61
polling data, 3, 99, 193, 197, 222
Pompeo, Mike, 76, 88, 96, 98, 102, 212
Popular Committee for Assisting the Palestinian Mujahedeen (Saudi Arabia), 22, 217

Qatar: boycott of Israel, 2, 22; foreign policy, 60, 119; mediation, 220; pre-independence, 13; relations with Gulf states, 27, 44, 79, 81–82, 87, 136, 173; relations with Hamas, 26, 40; relations with Iran, 49, 54; relations with Israel, viii, 32–33, 37, 51, 146; relations with the United States, 80, 83; relations with the Palestinians, 2, 19; response to the Abraham Accords, 128, 188, 191

Raisi, Ebrahim, 136–137
Rajab, Nabeel, 159–160
Ramadan War. *See* Fourth Arab-Israeli War
Reagan, Ronald, 28
Reform and Social Guidance Association (UAE), 152, 169, 170, 192

resolutions: Arab League, 38, 99, 105, 202; of Israeli-Palestinian conflict, 3, 6, 11, 33, 34, 226–27; United Nations', 2, 20, 22, 65, 76–77, 124, 141
Rothschild, Jacob, 12, 157
Russia, 16, 69, 78, 141, 144, 214, 215

Sabah, Ahmad al-Jaber Al-, 14
Sadat, Anwar, 23–24
Said, Edward, 31
Said, Qaboos Al-, 32, 87
Saud, Mohammed bin Salman Al- (MbS), 65, 79–80, 83, 106, 136, 211–14, 217, 220
Saud, Abdel-Aziz bin Abdel Rahman Al-, 13, 15
Saud, Fahad bin Abdel-Aziz Al-, 27–29
Saud, Salman bin Abdel-Aziz Al-, 22, 80, 217
Saudi Arabia: Arab Spring response, 58, 60–61; attacks on, 95; Britain's policies toward, 12–15; diplomatic initiatives to resolve Arab-Israeli conflict, 3, 11, 22, 27, 28, 37, 187–88, 220; domestic developments, 59–60; grassroots support for Palestinians, 2, 26, 190, 197; normalization with Israel, viii, ix, 10, 64, 112, 114, 128, 211–20; regional relations, 27, 121, 172–73; relations with Iran, 25, 48, 65, 95, 137; relations with the United States, 6, 9, 77–87, 99, 136, 147–48, role in Arab-Israeli conflict, 18, 19, 21–25, 37; reputational drive, 150, 165; role in Yemen conflict, 65, 108, 160
security architecture, 5, 8, 10, 111, 143, 145, 212
settlements, 8, 13, 28, 30, 72–74, 76, 96–97, 100, 109, 111, 123–27, 133, 206, 215
Sharif, Ebrahim, 158, 160, 189, 222
Sharon, Ariel, 36, 39, 123
Shi'a, 25–26, 38, 45, 58, 60–61, 147, 149–50, 153–54, 159–60, 165, 194–95
Shin Bet, 46, 137
Shamir, Yitzhak, 48
Sinai Peninsula, 20–21, 25
Six-Day War. *See* Arab-Israeli conflict
Smotrich, Bezalel, 40, 215
Soviet Union, 2, 20, 23–24, 28, 234
Space Reconnaissance Center (UAE), 45
spyware, 63–64, 134–35
Straits of Tiran, 20
Sudan, 107, 119, 172, 198, 258
Suez Crisis: *See* Arab-Israeli conflict
Sunni, 4–5, 7, 25–26, 43, 45, 58, 60, 147, 153–54, 158, 160, 173, 189, 194, 238, 244
Sunni Islamist, 4, 7, 43, 58, 194
synagogue, 16–17, 154, 156, 166–67, 173–78
Syria: conflict with Israel, 18, 21–24, 28–29, 33, 204; civil war, 195; Israeli attacks on, 66; Israeli occupation of, 1, 88; Iranian groups in, 220; Islamic state (ISIS) in, 91, 171; relations with the UAE, 137; U.S. policy toward, 146, 213

tanker attacks 2019 (UAE). *See* Gulf of Oman attacks
technology: Chinese, 69, 107, 213–14; Israeli, 32, 45–46, 48, 56, 112, 114–15, 119–21, 135, 139, 148–49, 197, 209; missile and drone, 62, 67, 141, 146; nuclear, 216; UAE investments in Israeli, 8, 113, 130; U.S. policies on transfer of, 6, 62–63, 213
Tiran and Sanafir islands, 212
tolerance, 8–9, 106, 112, 144, 150–83, 197
Trump administration, 72–109, 146, 201, 212
Trump campaign, 76, 78, 85
Trump, Donald, 82, 86, 95, 104, 106, 112, 136, 152, 187, 205, 211
two-state solution, 3, 6, 36, 48, 74, 89, 203, 216, 219–20, 223–25

Ula Declaration, al-, 136
United Arab Emirates (UAE): attacks on, 94, 138–39; covert ties with Israel, 34–36, 46–48, 51, 56–57, 60–68, 87, 134; domestic politics, 44, 58–61, 90, 135, 151–52, 209, 223; foreign policy under Zayed: 21–22, 26–27; Jewish outreach, 176–80; relations with Arab states, 50, 82, 86, 127–28 140–41, 187, 217; relations with Iran, 137, 49–50, 65–67, 137, 227; relations with global powers: 69, 83, 107, 214–15; relations with Israel, vii-ix, 7–8, 85, 91, 101–9, 129–34, 139–45, 182; relations with Palestinians, 2, 21–22, 25, 35–37, 103–4, 130–32, 138, 220; relations with United States, 34, 77–81, 89–91, 97, 99, 136, 147–48, 214; rise of MbZ, 43–45; threat perceptions, 3, 5, 49, 59–60; tolerance narrative, 9, 149, 170–75; perceptions of Abraham Accords, 187–207, 222; trade ties with Israel, 112–27
United Nations Relief and Works Agency (UNRWA), 19, 22, 73, 86, 138, 202, 219
United Nations resolutions, 2, 22, 65, 124, 141, 230
United Nations Security Council, 22, 28, 76, 88, 124, 141, 219
United States: Arab Spring policies, 151, 156–60; Cold war policies, 20; containment of China, 5, 107, 213–14; diplomacy, 2, 24; efforts by Arab states to influence, 23, 33, 35, 48–50, 69–69, 78–83, 106, 154, 158–59, 165, 214; efforts to draw Saudi Arabia into Abraham Accords, 6, 211, 216; retrenchment from Middle East, 63, 212; peace to prosperity workshop, 192–93; policies to deepen Arab-Israeli cooperation, 8, 11, 68, 122, 140, 143–47, 212–13, 216, policies toward Iran, 40, 83, 95, 136–37; policies toward Israel, 6, 24, 34, 63, 66, 76, 84, 89, 94–96, 101–2, 152, 219, 221; policies toward Palestinians, 85–86, 96, 125, 198–200; relationship with Bahrain, 52–55, 62, 154; relationship

with the UAE, 34, 77–81, 89–91, 97, 99, 136, 147–48, 214; sale of military equipment, 27, 35, 63, 68–69, 107; security role in Persian Gulf, 27, 63, 68, 81–83, 101
United States Central Command (CENTCOM), 44, 54, 108, 146
United States European Command (EUCOM), 80, 146, 212
United States Fifth Fleet, 27, 146, 221
United States Naval Forces Central Command (NAVCENT), 27

velayat-e-faqih, 25
Vision 2030, 112, 213

Wadi Araba agreement, 31
Washington, DC. *See* United States
Washington Institute for Near East Policy, 193, 197, 222
Wefaq National Islamic Society Bahrain, al-, 55, 160, 194–95
West Bank: diplomatic initiatives related to, 28, 30, 93, 217; Israeli disengagement from, 39; Israeli occupation of, 1–2, 22, 31, 37, 133, 181–82, 202, 215, 219, 225; Jordanian control over, 21; Palestinian protests in, 99, 205; as seat of the Palestinian Authority, 103; settlements in, 3, 36, 72, 76, 97–98, 109, 124–25, 224; threats of annexation, 8, 71, 89, 100; UAE trade with settlements in, 123, 126–27; UN resolution on settlements in, 76; U.S. policies on settlements in, 76, 96
White House, 85, 96–98, 105–6, 211
Wikileaks, 49–50, 54, 55

Yemen, 18, 64–65, 84, 108, 136, 138, 140, 160, 216–17, 221
Yom Kippur War. *See* Arab-Israeli conflict

Zarif, Javad, 136
Zionism: Britain's endorsement of, 12; conspiracies related to, 156–57; criticism of, 16, 206; endorsement of, 163, 196; as ideology, 4, 18, 32, 143, 163, 196, 208, 229, 299; references to Israel as "Zionist entity," 139, 188, 191–94, 221; as related to Israel's establishment, 11, 13–14, 16, 18
Zionist. *See* Zionism